Bloody Kisses

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/38400742.

Rating:
Explicit

Archive Warning:
No Archive Warnings Apply

Category:
F/F

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationship:
Adora/Catra (She-Ra), Bow/Glimmer (She-Ra), Catra & Glimmer (She-Ra)

Character:
Adora (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra), Bow (She-Ra), Glimmer (She-Ra), Micah (She-Ra)

Additional Tags:
Alternate Universe - Vampire, Blood, Blood Drinking, Vampire Adora (She-Ra), Vampire Hunters, Alternate Universe - Modern with Magic, Happy Ending, Human/Vampire Relationship, Alternate Universe - Role Reversal, Established Relationship, Light Dom/sub, Spiders

Language:
English

Series:
Part 4 of Blood, Lust, and the Order of the Gray Skull

Stats:
Published: 2022-04-15 Completed: 2023-11-13 Words: 114,064 Chapters: 22/22

Bloody Kisses

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/38400742.

Rating:
Explicit

Archive Warning:
No Archive Warnings Apply

Category:
F/F

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationship:
Adora/Catra (She-Ra), Bow/Glimmer (She-Ra), Catra & Glimmer (She-Ra)

Character:
Adora (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra), Bow (She-Ra), Glimmer (She-Ra), Micah (She-Ra)

Additional Tags:
Alternate Universe - Vampire, Blood, Blood Drinking, Vampire Adora (She-Ra), Vampire Hunters, Alternate Universe - Modern with Magic, Happy Ending, Human/Vampire Relationship, Alternate Universe - Role Reversal, Established Relationship, Light Dom/sub, Spiders

Language:
English

Series:
Part 4 of Blood, Lust, and the Order of the Gray Skull

Stats:

Published: 2022-04-15 Completed: 2023-11-13 Words: 114,064
Chapters: 22/22

Bloody Kisses

by pencilxpaper

Summary

Adora is the Lord of the Vampire Horde and struggling to hold on to power to save humanity. Thankfully, she has Catra by her side. As long as they are together, nothing really bad can happen, right?

Catra is in love. She's thinking about marriage. The only problem is her girlfriend is a two hundred-year-old vampire that apparently everyone wants dead.

//\(;;)/\\

-or-

A fic with sappy in love chaotic Catra and sexy Vampire Horde Lord Adora learning how to dom her girlfriend (on purpose) while dealing with vampire politics.

Notes

I am going to try to make this as easy to read as possible without reading the other parts, but if you want the full back story and thus the full emotional effect, please do read Parts 1 through 3. The rating is for sex, not violence.

See the end of the work for more notes

The Garden

Catra stood in the cold, without a jacket, because Adora didn't give her enough time to really think about it before they were out the door and in the car, which was odd because... usually, Catra was the impulsive one.

"I just have to get out of the house," Adora had said in a rush as she pulled Catra out the door.

She said it with such urgency that Catra thought she had a plan.

Standing there in the dead of night at the gate, while Adora cussed in Dutch wishing the lock would get typhoid over the fact that she kept dropping her lock picking tools... Catra started to wonder if Adora had any idea what she was doing.

The wind picked up, whistling through the bare trees that stood like hands against the moonlight. The same trees normally would make the Botanical Gardens a magical place to walk through during any other season. At the moment, they made the place seem more like a scene from a gothic novel than a cheap date idea.

Adora cursed again as her lock pick broke inside the mechanism. She got up and grabbed one of the boulders next to the sign that declared that the Botanical Gardens were closed for the winter. She turned, raising the rock over her head, and threw it against the lock. The gate rattled with clanking in the night and if there had been a guard on duty, they would have come running. But, the rock cracked on the base of one of the bolts that held the lock together.

Adora got a triumphant look on her face as she scrambled to rip it off the chain.

Catra wasn't judging, but she was cognizant that this was odd behavior for Adora. Then again, Adora had been odd for a while,

and Catra couldn’t blame her. After what Adora had been through, throwing heavy rocks against chains and locks was practically therapy.

Adora pulled the gate open, turned to her, and bowed lowly with an exaggerated sweep of her arm. “You first, my lady.”

Catra’s face heated up against the cold, which was stupid. They had been dating for four months now. She should be over that shit. Yet, she still found herself smiling, and acting demure as she took Adora’s hand. She still got giddy as Adora led her into the gardens.

They both took a brisk pace. There was no question as to where they were going. There was, after all, only one place Adora liked to go to when she broke into the Gardens. The real question was why. Curiosity ate at Catra, and it wasn’t just this weird outing, but other ways that Adora had been different lately.

First of all, Adora had gone from a literal virgin to an insatiable sex fiend. Catra wasn’t complaining about that. It seemed like, for the first time in her life, someone was on the same page about how often and when to fuck. All the time, and anywhere they could get away with it. The odd thing... and the thing that Catra didn’t understand, is why they had left the apartment in the first place. Bow and Glimmer were gone to the big city with Bow’s dads to look through the archive. They wouldn’t be back till morning... till after sunset.

Catra thought, with all the desperate horniness that Adora had gained in the last week, and after all the sneaking out of the house, fucking in the car, and in various shadowy places around town, that she’d want to fuck on the couch... In the kitchen... In the bath. She thought Adora would want to try something different, but oh no, the moment they were left alone, Adora had gotten nervous. Fucking nervous. Which was... frustrating. Catra had gotten all revved up to be ravaged and got all excited about committing every possible act of sexual transgression on every

piece of furniture, and at the first hint that anything would happen, Adora had stood up and declared they needed to go.

Glimmer warned her that after what happened, Adora would probably need time to recover. Grieve. Get through some trauma. It's one thing to be haunted by the spirits of your past, and quite a different thing to have them literally resurrected to torment and control you. Catra understood that maybe that was a bit fucked up, and everyone had their own way of dealing with it.

Catra also, as always, wanted nothing more than to satisfy Adora's whims. Indulge her in her fantasies. Give her the things she needed. Willingly and happily give her the things she wanted. She just... wanted to be told what that thing was, and she got the feeling that there was something that was being left unsaid between them.

Adora walked with her shoulders back, her chest out. Her chin up, with Catra on her arm. She seemed to be in better spirits at the surroundings, despite the garden being mostly dead from the last cold snap. She smiled right up until they reached the alcove.

The moment they stepped in, Adora's face fell.

Catra looked up at her. "Are you ok?" She couldn't help the tone in her voice. She was now solidly confused.

Adora struggled for a moment to say anything before she muttered, "I just... I thought the flowers would still be here."

"Babe... It's winter."

Adora's shoulders fell. All the confidence was gone.

Glimmer had warned Catra to be gentle. Be gentle. She winced and changed tactics. "Do you... need the flowers?" Catra was winging it. Taking shots in the dark... in the actual dark, at what could possibly be wrong.

Adora, absentmindedly, half not even there, muttered, “They calm me.”

Catra caught the unspoken meaning. Adora needed calming. Catra moved to be in front of her, put her hands on Adora’s face. “What are you nervous about?”

Adora looked at her, but she was looking right through her. “It’s nothing. Nothing that can be helped. Don’t worry about it, my sweet.” And then she closed her eyes, turned her head, and kissed Catra’s palm.

Not fair. That wasn’t fair. It made Catra’s heart start beating hard. It made warmth pool in her chest, and made her lose her fucking words.

With a calmness Catra didn’t expect, Adora stepped forward into the alcove where once there had been a thousand white trumpet-shaped flowers that only opened in the moonlight.

Adora pulled her slowly, somberly, to a bench stationed in the middle of the alcove.

As Catra sat down, Adora sat down next to her.

Adora turned her face to the moon. She looked sad. Mournful. Longing. And, Catra thought, she looked gorgeous. Statuesque. A Greek goddess carved out of marble and given flesh and bone.

Adora didn’t see her reaction. She was staring inexplicably at the moon. In a voice more to herself than to Catra, she uttered, “Waxing gibbous.”

Catra blanked at that. What the hell did the moon phase have to do with anything? Catra had to reach back into her education to remember even what the moon phases were. She was about to ask why it mattered. About to ask if Adora was having a stroke, or some kind of dissociative spell... And instead, she was struck mute when Adora turned to her.

Adora’s eyes had gone blood red. The moonlight glinted off them almost making them glow. Below her top lip, the tips of her fangs protruded. Vulgar. Sexy. Predatory.

Catra’s heart beat hard against her chest. Her brain released a lot of feel-good chemicals that made her thinking hazy. Catra fell under Adora’s spell and completely forgot that there was anything to ask about. Forgot there was anything odd to Adora’s behavior. All she could think was... she knew what that look meant, and it made her insides pulse with need. It made her crave to be devoured in any way Adora chose.

Adora, red eyes half-lidded, with the dead calm of her species, leaned forward. She brought her hand to Catra’s chin. “My pretty thing. I don’t need the flowers when I have you in the moonlight.”

Catra could have turned into a puddle. Melted away right then and there. No one had ever been so fucking romantic with her, and she was horrified to find out she liked it. How mundane to find out you had some of the cheesiest romantic kinks known to humankind.

When Adora closed her eyes and put her lips on Catra’s, Catra closed her eyes and whimpered like a heart-sick puppy. Lost, like a schoolgirl with her first crush sneaking a kiss between classes. She was helpless and utterly devastated.

This was Adora’s magic. Every kiss felt like the first time. Every fuck felt like it was a revelation. The smallest things felt big. The simplest gestures felt like grand romantic moments. Catra had, quite literally, been swept off her feet.

Adora leaned in further, never taking her lips off Catra’s. She started to push Catra back against the bench.

Catra’s arms went around Adora’s neck as she was laid down.

Adora’s breath was heavy, ragged like she was just barely holding herself back from what she wanted.

Catra gave her every indication to take it. Take everything. She laid down willingly. She arched her back. She moaned. She turned her head and bared her neck.

"Not yet, my pet," Adora whispered, barely able to hide the sudden gruffness in her voice. "I want to savor you first."

That alone nearly sent Catra over the edge. None of her girlfriends ever talked to her like that. No one even came close.

Adora loomed over her, breathing like a tiger watching a deer. Bearing her teeth, her jaw worked to fight back the urge to bite. Instead, her hand started going up Catra's shirt.

Catra's eyes rolled back. Every inch that Adora's fingers touched her burned like fire. She felt like a furnace against the cold. All of the sudden, her clothes seemed too much. She felt too hot. She'd catch fire and burn burn burn for Adora.

Adora's hand stopped.

Catra groaned.

Adora's breathing changed. Hitched.

Catra opened her eyes, less ecstasy and more curiosity fueling her.

Adora still loomed above her, but her shoulders were tight, and her face was turned up. She stared at a corner of the garden like a deer about to get hit by a car.

That was not a look Catra liked to see on her girlfriend, and she turned her head to see what the hell she was looking at.

In the bushes, staring straight at them were a pair of red eyes not unlike Adora's. The creature was barely bigger than a baby. It had gray skin, clawed hands, and a pointy tail. And... little wings? If Glimmer had seen that, she would have screamed bloody murder and ran like a bat out of hell, but Catra just looked at it, confused.

Adora hadn’t screamed. She hadn’t run off. That spoke volumes before Adora ever said a word. She swallowed before she pushed herself up and addressed it. “Hey there... little guy. What... What are you up to?”

Adora flinched when it opened its mouth. That flinch spoke volumes too.

A voice came out of it’s mouth male, deep, and heavy as if it came out of a body many times its size. “Horde Lord Adora, apologies for interrupting.” The words came out without the thing moving its lips.

It took Catra’s brain a moment to register but it was... a recording? Some kind of magic recording?

Adora abandoned her position above Catra. She turned to face the thing, leaning forward to listen.

“There is an urgent matter that I must speak with you about alone, post haste. Do not let yourself be followed. I will wait for you on the roof of the place your tribute to Prime compelled you to go.” The imp clapped its mouth shut and ran surrying like a demon out into the night with a childish laugh.

Catra, still laying on the bench, still waiting to be ravaged, looked at her girlfriend, and frowned.

Adora was staring at where the imp had disappeared. All her calmness was gone, replaced by a gut-wrenching look of pure horror. “I thought I had more time.”

Catra closed her eyes and rubbed her face with her hands. She had to accept that... whatever was going to happen the mood had been broken. Adora looked scared, and she hated when Adora looked scared. She had to stifle her own sexual response. She had to swallow down her horniness and find out what the hell had happened. She sat up.

In a dazed voice, Adora repeated, “The place where my tribute compelled me?” Her brow furrowed for a moment in thought.

Catra moved her legs around Adora, so she could sit up. Without Adora’s hands on her, the cold hit her extra hard. The wind blew and stole all the warmth right away. She had gone from feeling like a furnace about to explode to feeling like the dark damp part of the refrigerator where the light never touched.

Adora’s face took on a look of pain. “The laundromat. He’s waiting for me at the laundromat.”

“Who's waiting for you?”

“A friend... At least I hope he’s still a friend.” For the first time since the interruption, Adora turned to Catra. Her fangs had retreated. Her eyes returned to their normal gray-blue. “I’m sorry. I have to go take care of this.”

Catra sighed. She wasn’t angry, just disappointed. A week of fucking in the car. Fucking outside. Fucking in abandoned buildings, and the one night they had a chance to fuck on the fucking couch... She could handle it. It was Adora’s job to take care of this kind of shit. It was the only instructions the Order had given her. Stay alive. Stay in power, and keep this peace. Catra could handle disappointment. She could handle frustration. She could support her girlfriend. “It’s ok. I get it.”

Adora stood up abruptly. “I’ll take you back home first.”

Catra stood up next to her. “Like hell you are. I”m supposed to be guarding you, remember?”

“He’s a friend.”

“I don’t care. It’s my job.”

“I think it’s better if you don’t. Just let me take you home where it’s safe.” Adora had reached forward to put her hand on Catra’s shoulder.

Catra deflected the hand and took a step back. “So, you admit it’s not safe, so I’m definitely going with you.”

Adora got a pained look on her face. She hesitated as if evaluating her options before her shoulders lowered.

Something about Adora’s body language screamed an alarm in Catra’s head. This wasn’t grief. This wasn’t dealing with trauma. This was... avoidance. Things clicked into her head. Adora’s behavior falling into place for the last week. “You're hiding something from me.”

Adora winced. Still not looking her in the eye.

Catra stared at her, reeling for a moment. “All this time, you’ve been fucking me like crazy to what? To keep from having to talk to me? Keep me from asking questions?”

Adora let out a long breath. “It’s not like that...”

Catra stepped in. “What’s going on? Tell me right now.”

Adora took a deep breath, and said, flatly, “I’m probably going to be assassinated in seven nights.” She closed her eyes, her head hanging low. “On the first night of the full moon, normally, the Horde Lord takes tributes. Everyone gets together. The Horde Lord appears in front of... In front of the heads of the vampire families.” Her hands were shaking, and she tried to stuff them in her black leather jacket to hide them. “I’m supposed to go. I’m supposed to show up and act like I know what the hell I’m doing, and if I don’t, they’ll just kill me.” She looked up, tears in her eyes glistening in the moonlight. “I was such a prolific hunter before I was turned... I don’t think there’s a single family that doesn’t have a vendetta against me, and I’m the youngest vampire in the Horde... So I’m the weakest.” She took a breath. “I’m stuck. If I don’t go, then I forfeit my position and everything goes back to the way it was. They all start feeding on people again, and the hunters go back to hunting... If I do go... What do you say in English? I am a duck on the water?”

“A sitting duck,” Catra filled in.

Adora nodded. “Yeah. A sitting duck.”

Catra raised an eyebrow. “It’s also, a Catch twenty-two.”

“A Catch twenty-two,” Adora repeated with a nod that showed she had no idea what that idiom meant.

Catra thought about explaining, but figured now wasn’t the time. She was more struck by this sudden revelation. Adora had been scared. Catra hadn’t seen it, because she was filtering all the weird behavior through other lenses, lenses Glimmer told her to look through. This fear Adora had was the undercurrent to every interaction they had since they got back, and she hadn’t noticed until now. She had been careless and it made her sick to her stomach. “Adora, come here.” She held out her hands.

Adora, broken, took a step into those hands and leaned her head on Catra’s shoulder while Catra engulfed her in a hug. “You’re an idiot, you know that?”

“I know,” Adora whimpered.

Catra took a big breath, and declared, “I’m going with you.”

Adora’s body stiffened.

“I’m going with you to this meeting with your... friend... and I’m going with you to this full moon Horde thing.”

Adora leaned harder against her. “I want to keep you safe. The safest place to be is as far away from that meeting as possible.”

Catra managed a smile. She held Adora tighter. “I’m going to be by your side and I’ll stab anyone that tries to hurt you.”

Adora pulled her hands out of her pockets and balled them up in the bottom of Catra’s shirt. She took in a long slow breath. “Ok. Ok... We can do it together,” she mumbled into Catra’s shoulder.

Catra waited, holding Adora there until Adora decided to move again.

Catra took her hand, and they started the long walk out of the garden, back to the car in silence.

A strong wind blew, knocking Catra into Adora, and making her shiver for the lack of a coat.

Adora put her arm around Catra, and Catra nuzzled up into Adora's arm, her hands going under her leather jacket. The wind caused a cloud to cover the moon, and they were draped in oppressive darkness. Catra wondered if they'd get through the night before the next cold front hit in full.

They reached the car. Adora started the engine, cranked up the heat, and drove toward the place where it all started for them... the only 24-hour laundromat in the area.

Pet

Bow read off his tablet, his face lit by the screen in the dark, heedless of the motion of the car on the road. “They moved the headquarters here in eighteen ninety when the city was just established. It’s easier to buy land and do all the necessary warding before the place is heavily populated.” He put the tablet down and looked out the window.

Glimmer tried to focus on the road. Focus on the instructions for how to get there. In true secret society fashion, the headquarters was deep into a wooded area. A place where the trees wouldn’t have been so big just a few generations ago, but they were planted with plenty of optimism. The trees had already lost their leaves, reaching out to them like witches' hands and fingers. The moon and its light kept appearing and disappearing as clouds rolled in. It felt like driving into one of Bow’s favorite horror movies.

Bow shut off the tablet and smiled. “My dads helped move and organize the archive... their library, and I think Lance was the person to type out their card catalog.”

Glimmer turned the wheel to take them down a lonesome path that had warning signs, caution signs, keep out signs, and kept going. “Please don’t tell me we’ll be thumbing through miles of cards.”

Bow made a noise deep in his chest. Noncommittal.

Glimmer’s shoulders fell as she slowed the car, taking more careful turns now. She had built up this trip in her head as maybe a week-long commute into the city, to the headquarters and the archive, before they found what they needed and could go home. Now, she wondered if it would take multiple weeks.

She only agreed to go because, apparently, even among the secretive society of vampire hunters, someone who could read

Latin was rare. Bow begged her to come to speed up their research. What she had to look forward to were piles of the personal journals of Adora's uncle, a budding necromancer for his time, who finally bloomed into a full-blown worker of dark magic about a week ago.

His palm-sized book of spells stolen from the archive's forbidden wing sat in Glimmer's jacket pocket. She promised Catra she wouldn't mess with it until she got answers about herself and her apparently magical natural pink and purple hair, so she hadn't opened it, but she figured she had to bring it tonight. What if it held some kind of key? Some missing puzzle piece of the mystery? And maybe she was fucking curious. So sue her.

A wrought-iron gate appeared out of the tunnel of trees that loomed over the road.

To both of their surprise, the name scrawled across the gate, in dark iron letters, was "Van Helsing."

Bow sat back in his chair. "When Adora and Adam died, their father and uncle came here to claim them and got themselves killed." He hesitated. "Adora's mother didn't last long after that. I don't know the story there, but the family fortune was bequeathed to the Order, so they built their headquarters on the money of the tragedy of a family wiped out."

Glimmer felt a tremor go down her back, causing her arms and neck hairs to stand up on end. "Sounds like the beginning of a gothic novel." She looked at Bow in the dark. "Two love birds show up to a scary mansion in the woods, built on sketchy money?"

Bow smiled. "It's intentionally scary. They try to keep people away."

The gate shuddered and moved.

Glimmer startled and then gripped the steering wheel to get ahold of herself and drove the car forward into the round driveway of a

massive building. It was three stories high and with branching wings, like an old mansion plucked from right out of old Europe and placed haphazardly in the middle of the American west. It must have been even more shocking when it was first built before the trees were really overgrown enough to hide it.

She parked. They got out. Their new boss Juliet, a stern woman with the facial scar of someone who had been an active field agent before being promoted, waited for them on the steps. She had a military precision to the way she stood. Stiff back. Shoulders straight. "I'm glad you made it. Most people make a wrong turn at least once."

"The address isn't on any navigation apps," Glimmer said as she followed Juliet in.

The woman smiled slightly to herself as she looked over her shoulder. "You can guess why. Secrecy is our first line of defense."

Bow was hanging on her every word with an eager smile. Glimmer found the whole thing exhausting.

Juliet went on without needing encouragement. "Normally, you'd already have visited this place the moment you were hired. Usually, all hunters stay here when not on an active hunt. You see, it's the only place we can guarantee their safety." She shrugged. "But Adora can't stay here, so you're not required to either."

The inside of the building was lavishly decorated like a king's castle, a five-star hotel, or some mix of the two. They were getting paid good money, but the apartment still cost something. They could have stayed here and saved their money for more fun things. Glimmer sighed at the lost opportunity.

"Right now, we're at eighty percent capacity. The agreement with Adora has been so effective that we've had to pull most of the hunters home. A full sixty percent reduction in attacks. Unheard of in the history of our organization." As she said that, they passed a

group of chairs where a rough group of field agents quickly stopped their discussion and watched the newcomers.

Glimmer noted they didn't exactly look happy.

Bow flashed them a polite smile and a wave.

A few scowled back. No one waved.

Juliet walked them past, and the group started talking amongst themselves again. In a quieter voice, she offered, "The whole workforce is suspicious of the quietness. I'll tell you now, they don't trust Adora. She might have been one of them at one point, but in their minds, she's still a bloodsucker." Her voice got quieter still. "I haven't told anyone you're living with her or affiliated with her at all... for your protection."

Glimmer watched the woman's body language carefully. "But Catra-"

The woman sighed, big and heavy like there was a great weight on her shoulders. "Catra is Adora's official bodyguard... And her application made her... relationship with Adora too obvious. I never told anyone, but the records keeper talks to the mail carrier and..." She hesitated. Stopped her walk.

Bow and Glimmer just barely stopped behind her without running into her.

Juliet looked around, then focused her eyes on the two of them. "She's your friend, right? Practically family?"

Glimmer nodded.

"So I won't sugar coat it." She grabbed Glimmer and Bow's shoulders pulled them into a nook of carved oak, and whispered, "The general consensus among the field agents is that they think your friend is a thrall, someone held under vampire influence and control, and if not a thrall, then something worse. A vampire's pet. A bearer of a vampire's bloody kiss. A willing servant of the dark."

Glimmer scoffed. “Catra’s not under anyone’s influence, and she’s no one’s pet.”

Juliet shrugged. “I know that, but the rest of the Order is hard to convince.” She put a hand on Glimmer’s shoulder. “We’re talking about hunters who have fought tooth and nail against vampires their whole lives. Sometimes for generations.” She leaned back against the wall, pulling her hand away. “Once it was made widely known that Adora was one of them, there were calls to wipe the Van Helsing name from the gate of this building. Some wanted all honors for the whole family stripped, especially after what happened last week.” She shrugged. “Some wanted to strip Adam and Adora, posthumously, of their hunter records, which is unheard of, but that’s how they feel about a hunter who failed to uphold their Oath of Death.” She looked around, one more time, paranoid. “If I have my way, neither of them will ever even know where this building is, for everyone’s safety.”

Bow and Glimmer both looked to the floor at that news. Glimmer understood now why Catra had been given the task of full-time, Order Approved, Horde Lord bodyguard. She was not welcome to do any other job here. That thought didn’t sit well in Glimmer’s mind. Catra, out of all of them, deserved a chance to prove herself. Bow’s dads had been training them all during the week leading up to this, and they said she was a natural. A once-in-a-generation hunting marvel on the level of what Adam and Adora were in their time. Catra, after years of barely being able to hold down minimum wage jobs, had finally found her calling. Her purpose. A job she was naturally good at and paid well... All that potential and no one here but their boss could see it.

Juliet pulled them back out into the hall, walking briskly. “It will take time, and building trust. Don’t be discouraged. I have full faith that we will win them over.” She reached a set of large double doors, and with military efficiency, she threw them open. “This is the archive.”

Bow and Glimmer walked into a room that was two stories tall and full of books. Two large staircases went up on either side. On each

wall, there was an archway to another wing.

Lance was on the second floor, grabbing books and piling them in George's arms, when he looked up. "Bow! Glimmer! You made it!"

Nothing could have stopped him from running down the staircase and pulling them into a hug that was just a tad too tight.

George followed after, stopping at a large table in the center of the room to deposit his cargo on the table already piled high with old tombs before joining in on the hug.

Juliet stood up straight. "I'll leave them in your care. If you need anything, you know where to find me." She turned and walked with a clip back down the hall.

Lance was bubbling with excitement as he leaned back. "We've been pulling everything we can think of. Everything on the Van Helsing family."

George added, "We have friends picking up additional volumes from the family home in the Netherlands."

Bow's eyebrows went up.

George gave them a tense smile. "The family home was converted to a training ground for the Order. Adora's father had already outfitted the grounds with everything needed. Some of the historical family documents were stored there."

Glimmer felt a weirdness worming around in her brain at that. A glance between her and Bow said it all. They just wouldn't mention the state of the Van Helsing home to Adora. It would bring up bad memories. There was a fairly good chance she'd never be able to visit anyway if this place was any indication.

They all sat down to their relative piles of books. Lance put his hand on pile after pile. "This is Adam's hunter reports." Another pile. "These are his private journals. All in Dutch. You might have to take those home for Adora to read for us." He moved on to

another shorter pile. “Everything we could find that matched your description of this Shadow Weaver person, going back to fourteen twenty. Infrequent but consistent run-ins before she dropped off the face of the earth when Adora disappeared. All in English, so we’ll tackle those.”

George pushed a pile toward Glimmer. Leather-bound books with tattered edges. “And these are the private journals of Adora’s uncle. Your reading.”

Glimmer pulled the pile near her and couldn’t help a small smile. This wasn’t so bad. She might be able to skim through them in a few weeks.

Lance put his arms out wide. “This is everything,” He declared loudly before adding, “From the first floor anyway.”

Glimmer’s smile was gone. She grabbed the first journal and opened it to page one with a sigh. Months... Months of reading... she decided.

Bow happily grabbed the first of Adam’s reports, attacking reading them like it was his new life’s mission.

Glimmer turned her eyes down to hastily written Latin. The first words in the book she picked up were a declaration, “ *I believe my brother is infertile.* ” She stopped at those words and blinked. Adora’s father...hadn’t been infertile, right? That’s what being a father meant. This was not the story she expected. She read on, wondering if this was going to be more interesting than she thought.

***

The laundromat glowed in the dark like a beacon.

Adora got out of the car and stared at the building with the vague unfocused stare of someone who had seen some shit.

Catra got out and slammed the door. “No sense being sentimental,” she muttered as she headed to the back where the built-in stairs to the roof were.

Adora rushed to follow her. “Sorry. This place doesn't exactly have positive memories for me... Outside of meeting you.”

Catra smiled over her shoulder while she pulled Angella’s half-borrowed, half-stolen silver rings out of the small pocket of her jeans and slipped them on. “I know. Which is why there's no use in being sentimental. Let’s get this over with.”

A few moments later, they were shivering on the roof, leaning against the bricks.

Maybe they had both been aware of the wind before and how cold it was, but being even slightly high up where the wind wasn’t blocked by low trees, they couldn’t deny the fact that they were both underdressed for the cold front that was heading toward them in the clouds that now blotted out the moon’s light.

Catra felt the shivers start in her core and fought them. This would be over soon enough. She resolved to be the stoic, quiet, bodyguard that the Order was paying her to be.

A fog crept onto the roof despite the wind, swirling about, blanketing it in mist.

Adora sighed and breathed, “He’s here.”

Catra stuck her hands in her pockets to hide her rings.

At that moment, as they got ready, Catra watched Adora as something took over her. It was, perhaps, a lingering residue of her upbringing, but when she got it in her head she was going to do something particularly dangerous, it was like she became someone else, like a shell cased over her normal Adora. Her face was a mask, hiding any turmoil in her brain. The Adora that stood before her was not the woman who had been scared of death for

the past week. Not the woman who was too nervous to fuck on the couch. This was hero Adora. Savior Adora.

Catra's nipples stiffened against her shirt just thinking about it. This Adora was hot as fuck.

Catra forced herself to look away just as the fog billowed and rolled onto the roof, and through it, someone walked toward them. At first, it was just a shadow, but the shadow morphed into a man stepping out of the mist in a trench coat and a hat that would have been stylish in the forties. He had pointed ears. Slightly gray skin. Permanently red eyes.

He stopped short of them, and his red eyes slid over Catra, then to Adora. He bowed shallowly. "My lord."

Adora took a small step forward, her hands up. "Hordak, you don't have to call me lord. Not here. Not after what you did to help me."

Catra raised an eyebrow and looked him over, appraising him. The name was familiar. She had only seen it written out on a letter. This guy made Adora's flight from Shadow Weaver's grip possible. Catra owed her current domestic bliss to this man.

He came up sharply from the bow, and his eyes landed on Catra.

Adora took a half step to put herself between them.

He raised an eyebrow. "Is this the human you killed Shadow Weaver over?"

A question Adora wasn't expecting. It took her a moment to get out, "I guess... She's my... she's a..."

Her girlfriend, Catra thought, but she said nothing. The less everyone knew, the better.

"A hunter," he added flatly.

Catra raised an eyebrow at him. Observant fellow. What had given her away, she wondered.

Adora winced. “She’s not a danger to you.”

“I guess it’s to be expected.” He tilted his head and turned away to look out off the roof. He stuck his claw-like hands in his pockets. “I called you here to warn you.” He shifted his coat on his shoulders. “The heads of the families don’t think you’ll show up to your first meeting as Horde Lord. They are preparing to fight each other for the title after you've abandoned it. Many want things to return to normal. They think this whole experiment is madness.”

Adora stood firm. “I’ll be there. I’m not giving up.”

“Good.” The friend smiled at Adora. “They don’t know you like I know you.” His eye drifted to Catra again, and his smile faded. He turned back to look out. “There are rumors that you’ve rejoined the Order. Which, I assume, is true based on her being here.”

Catra glared back at him, unflinching. Unmoving. She and Adora had talked about this on the way over. This man was a friend, but everyone had their limits, and she didn’t know where his limits were. Best not say anything that didn’t need to be said.

Adora squared her shoulders. Stood up straight. Hero Adora spilled out the half-truth that she and Catra agreed on in the car. “I’m working with the Order of the Gray Skull towards this peace. I need time. They need results.” She added, “No doubt the Horde has noticed they’re not being pursued. The hunters have backed off. That’s because of my agreement with them. They are only investigating murders. Not hunting vampires in general. I need the Horde, and ideally everyone else, to realize that this alliance is in their best interest.”

He raised an eyebrow at her. “In that case, I have advice.”

Adora turned to him, jaw set. Her look unwavering. Again, very hot. Very distracting. Catra had to look away and pretend to be distracted by something else.

“Come to the meeting with full force. Bring the sword.”

Catra was mildly surprised that Adora didn’t flinch. Didn’t break the shell at all even though she knew that the Sword of Protection, the Order’s mythical, magical vampire hunting weapon that held the destructive power of the sun, the same sword that had chosen Adora once as a child and again as a vampire, and had twice been their salvation, was in two pieces in their closet behind Catra’s box of sex toys. The magic in it gone. Whatever magical creature Adora’s ancestors had captured in the blade vanished without a trace.

He nodded toward Catra. “Bring some hunters with you. Fully armed. Festooned in silver.”

Catra’s mind went to Angella’s silverware stored in the buffet in the formal dining room of their house. It had enough silver to practically make a fucking suit of armor.

He folded his arms and hesitated for a moment. “Mark them as your pets for their protection. There’s a taboo against feeding on or killing a vampire’s marked pets.”

Adora’s brows furrowed in confusion. “Mark them?”

He unfolded himself toward her and tilted his head. He pointed two sharp fingers mid-way up his neck. “A light bite. Use just the fangs. Not a feeding bite. Make two small puncture wounds where they are visible above the collar.” He put his hands down and looked away. He smiled to himself. “If you show up with the hunters as your support, it will make up for your youth. Between the sword to deter direct attacks and the idea that the hunters will be after them if they defy you, you should have enough time to have them at least listen to you... hear your argument.”

Catra could imagine the bite on her neck. Could imagine Adora breathing on her skin, holding her close, and then... giving her a claiming mark. It was with superhuman levels of impulse control that she managed not to touch her own neck while they were

talking about it. The idea of being marked was hot. Catra's body was already covered in permanent ink of her various obsessions and flings, and the idea of a mark to denote her as Adora's made her bite her lip. Adora had once said that vampires were all about loyalty and ownership. *Yeah* , Catra thought with growing arousal, *so the fuck am I.*

Adora nodded, a little too fast. A little too eager. Adrenaline was taking over. "Ok. We can do that. Thank you for this. I appreciate it."

It was entirely possible that Adora could also smell Catra's arousal, and it was throwing her off. Catra silently apologized. She had very little control over her body's reaction to this shit.

Hordak smiled at Adora before tipping his hat and starting to walk back into the mist.

"Wait!" Adora's voice cracked as she called out.

He stopped and looked over his shoulder.

Some of the hardshell exterior she presented softened. "How is your human friend?" She hesitated. "Are you two doing ok?"

That made Catra's eyebrows lift. So this 'friend' of hers had a human friend. Interesting.

His look softened. "We are well. We are... studying my condition from a scientific perspective." He paused and looked Adora in the eye. "Did you know UV light doesn't hurt us?"

Adora stood up straight at his declaration.

He continued. "Actually, no kind of artificial light hurts us. We've recreated the closest thing to sunlight in our lab, and it does nothing. We even double-checked to make sure my skin still reacts to natural sunlight... and it does." He looked away. "My partner speculates there must be some quality of natural sunlight that is as of yet unknown to science. She's... ecstatic."

“What about you? Are you happy?”

A small smile crossed his face. “A question I’ve often asked myself in the last month of being experimented on.” He breathed in. “Yes...I am happy, finally.” He paused. “I have you to thank for that, so you have my loyalty.” He turned away.

Adora’s body relaxed. “That’s what I want. I want the whole Horde to be happy like I am... like you are.”

He nodded. “I hope you succeed. Good luck, young Horde Lord.” He walked away swiftly until he reached the shadows, and then he fully disappeared back into the fog.

Catra waited a good long moment, eyes on Adora, waiting for the sign that he was gone and it was ok to talk.

The fog faded away, and Adora turned to her. Her eyes glanced over Catra, taking in her body.

Catra felt studied. Adora had to see how horny she was. There wasn’t a good way to hide it. She exuded it.

Adora’s eyes dragged across Catra. Down her body, and lingered at Catra’s chest with her nipples standing at ready attention. Her eyes were wide with understanding. With a voice slightly shaking Adora asked, “Do you want to go back to the garden and fuck?”

Catra took note of the tone. The shaking voice. The hardshell exterior... brave Adora... Hero Adora... was gone. She was paler than usual. Her hands were shaking, and probably not from the cold.

Catra’s thinking flipped. Adora wasn’t reacting to her being turned on. She was looking for a distraction... A release. She was... in her head again. She was spiraling. *Shit* .

Catra ripped off the silver rings on her fingers, stuffing them back into the small pocket of her jeans, before stepping in and putting her hands on Adora’s face and forcing her to look her in the eye.

“We’ve got this. We’ll make a scabbard for the sword. No one will know as long as you don’t draw it. I’ve got an idea for where to get silver. And, you’ll fucking mark me, right?” She couldn't help the way her voice shook with desire as she said that last bit.

Adora’s shaking subsided, and she nodded. She looked ok before something crept into her face. Insecurity. “You don’t have to go with me. I’d almost rather you didn’t.”

Catra couldn’t help but smile. “Oh, Adora, you still don’t get it? You’re one of my people now. We are ride or die.”

Adora closed her eyes as if that were painful to hear.

“Hey, I don’t need you to try to protect me. I’m here to protect you. We’re doing this together, baby.” She watched Adora’s face tighten. Catra’s jaw set before she demanded, “Promise me you won’t pull any of that self-sacrificing bullshit you did last time.”

Adora opened her eyes. The shell was back. Hero Adora looked at her with a firm gaze. “I promise.”

Catra believed that. She closed her eyes, moved her hand around to the back of Adora’s neck and pulled their foreheads together. “Good.”

After a long moment of standing there, breathing the same warm air recycled between them, Catra pulled away. A chill ran through her. “Ok. I’m freezing my ass off here, so we’re going back home and fucking on the couch.”

Adora’s face went from pale to flush instantly.

Catra smiled that her girlfriend could still be embarrassed about this stuff.

Adora shook her head a little. “But the couch... It's a communal space. Wouldn’t it be... disrespectful?”

That made Catra’s chest buzz with an eagerness that she couldn't hide. “Yeah, won’t it be interesting?”

Adora’s eyes blew out into deep dark pools as her embarrassment was replaced with lust.

Catra grabbed her hand and practically dragged her off the roof to the car.

***

Glimmer leaned into the book, now years into the apparent infertility of Adora’s father. Adora’s uncle described the Van Helsing family home as growing increasingly tense every month there wasn’t a baby.

There were external pressures from the Order. It was, they insisted, of vital importance that there was an heir to the legacy. Adora’s uncle mused on why the order was so insistent. Maybe it was to keep the sword in play, for it was bound to the bloodline. He suspected he could find the answer if he could convince the Order to let him into the forbidden archive. He thought they could trust him. He was a Van Helsing, after all.

Glimmer thought that was terribly ironic. That name was now synonymous with vampires and necromancers.

The journal kept mentioning how the lack of an heir was dragging Adora’s father down to ruin and what they would have called at the time melancholy, but it was obviously depression.

Glimmer glanced at the dates, did some quick math, and realized that the announcement must be close. She flipped pages, sure that any moment there would be a happy reveal of Adora’s mother’s pregnancy.

Finally, a single-day entry stated in Latin, *“I cannot watch my brother fade away. I must do something.”*

That was... not what she was expecting. Glimmer read a month's worth of daily reports until she got to the page that made her put the book down. A single entry, " *The physician says she is pregnant. My brother's condition has improved significantly* ."

Glimmer looked up at the room around her as if that written statement was so loud that anyone else could have heard it. Bow, George, and Lance seemed deep in their reading.

She blinked. It could be, even at this early stage, that Adora's *uncle* had done something magical... but what was far more likely was something far less fantastical and more base. That the uncle wasn't an uncle at all... She instinctively reached for the spellbook in her pocket. She could check. She could see if there was some kind of... super-fertility spell or something.

She did it without thinking. She did it because the alternative was too much. The answer had to be in the spellbook.

She was breaking her promise to Catra. But Catra, if she were here, would understand. Would even agree.

She opened the spellbook and started reading the small tight writing where the man had tried desperately to quickly copy as many spells as he could fit into that small book. A desperate man. A man who had gotten his hands on arcane knowledge and wanted to grab all of it.

She immediately found the building blocks of the hell they had gone through last week. Spells to open doors to other worlds... life force binding spells... A spell for partial temporary resurrection with a drop of blood on the corner of the page. She could guess whose blood that was. There was lots of blood magic... dark magic. But there was also light-hearted stuff. A love potion that was marked "doesn't work." A spell for summoning light from the fingertips marked "doesn't work," with a note that "it is a shame. It would have been useful fighting vampires." Glimmer rolled her eyes. Was hunting vampires all this family thought of? Even the necromancer uncle?

The next spell was a teleportation spell. Next to it was also written, “doesn’t work.”

Glimmer was thinking of Adora. Would Adora want to know if her father... wasn’t her father? Glimmer paused to think that one over. If it were her... she would want to know, but she wouldn’t care. Micah was her dad, her father, regardless of blood. Maybe Adora would feel the same. There was also the chance that this information... especially if she couldn’t prove or disprove it... would just be cruel.

With Adora on her mind, she glanced over the teleportation spell. It called on Hermes and another spirit of light she didn’t immediately recognize, but the Latin felt familiar somehow. She didn’t even read it out loud, just sounded the words in her inner thoughts, and then looked up as she was engulfed in sparkling purple light.

The Mark

Chapter Summary

> Catra goes through a range of emotions, the major one being that she is love-sick over her vampire girlfriend. Oxytocin for everyone!

Catra knew she was being stupid. Something about this relationship had fucked up a large part of her brain chemistry. In a word, she was obsessed.

A mix of dopamine, norepinephrine, and serotonin made her crave boring domestic sex. For the first time in her life, she craved the intimacy of being fully naked with each other without the threat of being interrupted. Just... to take it slow and enjoy it. It was stupid, but it's what she wanted. She wanted to be warm, and she wanted Adora not to worry about being caught.

Adora drove the car down a long fast road that stretched between towns and pushed through the darkness that surrounded them on both sides. The kind of road that already has a high speed limit that everyone ignores. That road cut through the hundreds of cattle farms and goat farms that spread between the towns.

Catra kept glancing at Adora and feeling a buzz in her chest at the little signs that Adora was thinking about what they would do. A bite of her lip. A little flush on her cheeks.

Catra was lost at these little signs of her girlfriend being flustered.

A sparkling purple light burst in the car like a firework with no sound.

Catra shut her eyes against it like you would a sudden headlight in the dark.

The wheels hit gravel, rumbling, meaning they were going off the road.

Adora jerked the wheel and made a noise that was surprise and horror all in one.

Catra opened her eyes as Adora jerked the car back onto the road, overcorrecting.

Catra tasted copper in her mouth. Adrenaline was hitting her system, even though she couldn't feel it.

She turned her head to see, of all people, Glimmer in Adora's lap, straddling her. Her eyes were wide with confusion and fear. Her body blocked Adora's ability to use the wheel.

Adora had the blank stare of someone whose eyes were still recovering from a flash.

Catra felt the car starting to lose control from Adora's overcorrection. The wheels squealed against the pavement.

No problem.

Catra leaned forward, grabbing the side of the wheel with her left hand and grasping the emergency brake with her right.

While Glimmer and Adora's brains caught up with their senses and started screaming, Catra turned the wheel into the skid and worked the break-in tandem.

Adora caught up to her, stopped screaming, grabbed Glimmer tight around the body with one hand grabbing the back of her head to protect her neck, and threw her foot on the clutch.

That stopped the drive forward, cutting the engine from the gears.

Catra steered out of the skid and gently guided the wheel to land the beast safe and sound on the side of the road.

Catra smiled big. “That was fun. You two ok?”

Adora sat, still gripping Glimmer. Glimmer’s face was buried in Adora’s neck. Her shoulders started bouncing up and down with barely controlled sobs.

Adora sat frozen, face pale. A sheen of fear sweat on her face. She slowly turned to look at Catra, still gripping the girl in her lap as if her life depended on it.

“Let me guess. You did exactly what you promised me you wouldn’t do, and you looked at that spellbook, didn’t you?” Catra’s tone was casual. Almost chiding.

Adora pulled Glimmer in tighter. Her voice was shaky. “Give her a moment... please.”

The unspoken message, Adora needed a moment too.

Catra backed off.

Glimmer was shaking in Adora’s arms. A good sign that the adrenaline was wearing off, and her body was recovering from system shock.

Catra watched with slight amazement as her girlfriend comforted her best friend in a way... Catra had always not been able to. Warmth bloomed in her chest at the idea. Oxytocin.

Her shaky voice slowly fading, Adora stroked Glimmer’s hair and whispered calming things to her, telling her she was ok. That they were alive and that Catra had saved them.

That made Catra get a lopsided smile. Yeah. She did save them. That was badass.

***

“I didn’t even read it. I just looked at it, and... and... Poof.” Glimmer sat between the chairs, unbuckled and now desperately

trying to make up for her earlier display of weakness.

Adora drove, silent and a little shell shocked, following Glimmer's directions back to the headquarters.

Glimmer's phone kept pinging, meaning she was getting spammed by texts... probably Bow asking what the hell happened. Glimmer ignored them.

"The solution here is to talk to your dad and figure out what is going on," Catra said casually.

Glimmer gave one big sigh. "I've tried. He's been avoiding me."

Catra's eyebrows raised. She turned back. "What?"

Glimmer shook her head. "He won't answer my calls. I tried showing up to his work during the day yesterday, and he saw me and ran to the back where I couldn't get to him and told the other pharmacists to tell me he had 'just stepped out, but I literally saw him go back there."

Catra chewed on that for a moment. Not what she was expecting from Micah. The only response was to escalate. "I need to borrow your mother's silverware for a thing with Adora, and you need to talk to your dad. Sounds like we need to give them a surprise visit tomorrow night."

Glimmer shifted uncomfortably between the seats.

"If we catch them while they're sleeping, your dad can't run away. Adora and I will distract Angella with the silverware borrowing. We'll give her a story about providing dinner for some acquaintances, which is true if things go badly. And you can get your dad alone and demand answers."

Glimmer bit her lip before closing her eyes for a moment. She was making a decision. "Ok. I hate to admit it, but I don't have a better plan." She tapped on Adora's shoulder and pointed toward a dirt road into a wooded area.

Adora slowed down the car and looked at the fork in the road between the trees. “It says no trespassing.”

“Yeah. Keep going. Follow the warning signs. They will take you right there.”

Adora turned.

A moment later, Glimmer conceded. “I’ll tell Bow I can’t come to the archive tomorrow after I... figure out what to tell him about this.”

Her phone pinged again. Almost angrily this time.

They all focused on the road ahead, with the warning signs passing by. Adora’s shoulders were getting tighter and tighter as they went. She slowed down the car with each passing sign.

A gate appeared in the distance in her headlights. Adora immediately shut off the lights and stopped the car.

The fast-moving clouds above parted so the moon could illuminate Adora’s family name, wrought in iron.

Adora’s shoulders fell.

Glimmer shifted uncomfortably. “Oh, I forgot. Your family fortune was used to build the headquarters here. I’m sorry, Adora.”

Adora shook her head and, despite her face, acted like she was dismissing it. “Just like my father to sign away the whole thing and not give any stipulations.” Despite her sincerest attempt to act like she didn’t care, it was obvious to Catra that she cared greatly. That would have to be unpacked later.

Catra got out, pulled the seat forward, and offered a hand to help Glimmer climb out.

Glimmer still looked rattled. Her hair had the slightest hint at the roots of changing color. The slightest hint of her father’s dark hair

peeking out from her mother's pink and purple hair.

Catra pulled Glimmer to her once she was out of the car and touched her face, forcing her to look her in the eyes. She moved Glimmer's face from side to side, checking her for any indication of what they had all affectionately called magic sickness.

Glimmer submitted herself to this investigation with a satisfied little smile.

Catra let her go. "You look ok, but let me walk you in just in case."

Glimmer's satisfied smile was gone. "I don't think that's such a good idea."

Adora opened her door and stood up, leaning on the car to watch them. "Catra's right. Let her escort you in, just as a precaution."

Glimmer pulled away and winced.

In that wince, Catra read between the lines. Glimmer would have been fine with Catra walking her in, but someone else wasn't. She smiled wider, if only for Glimmer's sake. "We'll just stay out here and wait till we're sure you're in."

Glimmer relaxed a little, but not fully. She reached forward, pulling Catra into a hug.

Catra had, long ago, cataloged all of Glimmer's various hugs. This was a conciliatory hug. An apology. That meant the reason Catra was barred from entering was a bad one. One Glimmer didn't agree with.

Glimmer let go and walked fast toward the gates. They opened for her automatically. As they shut, she turned and waved goodbye in the dark.

Catra waved back, and then Glimmer was gone.

She turned back to Adora.

Adora had settled on leaning on the car, her chin on her arms.

Catra shrugged. “I guess my conditional employment status means I don’t get to join the club yet.”

Adora was not looking at her but at the building and the gate. “They don’t trust you because of me.” Her jaw worked, and she kicked at the ground. “My name is on that gate, and they dare to keep you out?” Adora looked away, shaking her head. “This isn’t fair. This isn’t right. You’re a hunter. You should be allowed into the headquarters like everyone else.”

“It’s not-” Catra meant to say it wasn’t important, but Adora cut her off.

“They deserve a good old-fashioned thrashing.” She said it with a bite to her tone.

Catra lost all thoughts and instead focused on Adora’s reaction with a growing warmth in her chest. Oxytocin again. “Thrashing?”

Adora continued to look at the building. “Once, when I was first admitted to the Order, my brother and I went to the headquarters to finish the paperwork. A group of four hunters made comments about me.” She glanced at Catra. “You know. Sexist stuff. Saying that a woman wasn’t fit to be a hunter.”

“Yes. They were assholes.”

Adora smiled slightly at that. “Well, Adam got angry at them. I told him not to worry about it. That it didn’t bother me.” She shrugged. “I had stuff like that said to me all my life... anyway...”

Catra leaned up against the car, mirroring the way Adora was leaning. Putting her chin on her arms in rapt attention.

“Anyway, he didn’t often get riled up. He was usually the more level-headed of the two of us, but this time he was furious, so he challenged all four of them for my honor. Pulled off a glove, threw it on the ground and everything.”

“Did he kick their asses?”

Adora let out a small nostalgic laugh and shook her head. “He hurt some of them, but he was the one who left that fight the worst for it. He was bruised and bloody for weeks. We had to delay our first hunting tour to wait for him to get better and stop pissing blood.”

Catra couldn’t help a smile, feeding off Adora’s energy. “So the lesson here is?”

Adora shrugged. “Well, those four guys never bothered us again. In fact, we all became good friends afterward. They were some of the first to actually accept me.” She shook her head. “A *thrashing.* It’s about showing people you’re willing to fight.” She adjusted her position and pointed to the building. “If I weren’t a vampire, and if I wasn’t barred from the building apparently built with my family’s money...“ She paused to give that weight. “-every hunter who doesn’t trust you would get a chance to see how hard I’m willing to punch for you. How many hits I was willing to take for you. I’d take them all.” Her stance was firm. She looked confident.

Before Catra stood hero Adora again. Hot sexy hero Adora. That got her mind going, which got her body going again. Her nipples stood to attention against her shirt.

Glimmer’s surprise appearance had ruined her plans for the night. This little trip to the city's outskirts had destroyed Catra’s window for lazy domestic sex at the apartment. They basically had enough time to get home and get a quickie in before the sun rose, and Adora was lulled into day-sleep. So, since painfully domestic sex wasn’t an option anymore, she practically vibrated as she said, “Wanna get back at them by having defiant sex instead?”

Adora turned to her, eyebrows high. Eyes wide. “What?”

“Fuck outside the hunters' headquarters. Do that marking thing to me right under their noses.”

Adora turned away before saying, “I don’t think that is a good idea.”

“That’s the point, right? It’s a bad idea. It makes it more fun.”

Adora bit her lip.

Catra’s body got revved up, seeing her girlfriend start to lose the internal battle.

Adora smiled a little. “If we did, I’d have to keep my fangs in for as long as possible.”

That wasn’t a no, and that little smile meant Adora was considering it.

Catra leaned in a bit further. “Are you saying you’ll have to hold yourself back as you fuck me? You poor thing.” She leaned back suddenly, gripping the car to keep her from falling back. “Not like I’m into that or anything.” Teasing.

Adora’s smile turned into a knowing smirk. “You are ridiculous.”

Catra squirmed, her body getting ready for what was going to come. “It would be *sacrilegious* to do something like give me a vampire’s claiming mark on the hallowed land of the vampire hunter headquarters, don’t you think?”

That got Adora’s attention. That stroked that long-hidden suppressed spark in Adora’s soul that cried out for mischief. When she turned her eyes on Catra, she looked... hungry.

Catra couldn’t suppress a smile on her lips. She pulled away from the car.

Adora shifted. “Catra... You shouldn’t.” She couldn’t regulate her tone. It was more playful than warning.

Catra glanced to her side. The side facing the woods.

Adora, unconsciously, glanced the same way.

That's all Catra needed. Conscious or unconscious, a sign that Adora would follow.

Catra smiled big, tapped the top of the car, and burst into a run.

Adora followed because she couldn't help but follow.

Catra laughed, pumping her legs hard. Running like she hadn't run in years to lure Adora into a mock hunt. Utilizing Adora's trained behavior, except, using it to play.

Catra laughed openly as Adora threw herself into her, wrapping her arms around Catra's waist like a football tackle into the soft, slightly wet earth covered in old leaves.

They fell together, entangled, with Catra on the bottom, writhing to get the upper hand.

Adora's hands groped her helplessly. Her smile went away as desperation took over. She grabbed the loops in Catra's pants and used them to flip her onto her back, face up.

Catra lost her breath at the motion, at the act of being caught, and at the look on Adora's face.

Adora looked taken by surprise. She looked focused. She looked, above all, hungry for more than just blood. Her jaw worked to hold her fangs in.

Catra smiled and started wiggling, pretending to get away, but trying to tempt Adora even further.

Two hundred years of operant conditioning was working its way through Adora's brain.

Catra bit her lip. "What's wrong? Distracted trying not to pop a fang?"

Adora growled at her.

Catra felt a flush of delight at being growled at. Actually growled at! Catra was being a jerk, and she knew it, and she thought Adora might like it, so she did the asshole thing and tilted her head back and to the side, revealing her neck to the moonlight.

Adora closed her eyes and leaned in close, practically burying her head in Catra's shirt. "Not fair."

"All's fair in love and war, baby."

Adora waited for a moment before moving her hands but not her head.

Catra eagerly awaited Adora's counterstrike.

Adora, unceremoniously, stripped Catra of her pants. Pulled them down, lifted her, and manhandled her till the pants were on Catra's ankles, and her ankles were under Adora's legs. Catra was trapped, open, and exposed. Trapped and thrilled.

Adora buried her head back into Catra's shirt to avoid looking.

Catra grabbed Adora's head, her fingernails running through Adora's hair. "What are you going to do, princess? Eat me?"

Adora grunted.

It was an animal-like grunt. A grunt of frustration, and yet Adora wasn't calling things off. They were still playing. Catra continued to squirm on the surface to make Adora hot and bothered but accidentally did it to herself.

With one hand, Adora grabbed Catra's to pull it off her head, and with the other, she attacked Catra at her weakest point. Right between the legs. The most intimate of places flayed open and made exposed.

Catra fucking melted. This was her problem. Her real problem. She should have spent the last week teaching Adora the ropes (literally and maybe figuratively) about being intimate. It would have been an investment in the future. However, once Adora actually touched her, Catra lost all her resolve. She also lost all her ability to toy with Adora. Adora's unskilled touch struck a nerve straight to Catra's brain and shut it right off. Catra's eyes rolled back, and she moaned.

Adora's grip on Catra's hand tightened at the moan. She pressed her face harder into her shirt. These were signs that she had to fight her instincts. Her counterattack to that moan was to insert a finger in.

That was new, at least for Adora. Because of that, it was unexpected, and something about it being unexpected made it a thousand times more intense than it was supposed to be. Catra whimpered. It was so stupid. So simple. No one had any right to mess her up like this, and there not be any gymnastics involved. No toys. It was highway robbery.

Catra opened her eyes, growing in her helplessness.

Adora lifted her head off Catra's shirt and gave her a knowing confident cocky little shit-eating grin.

Catra whimpered and closed her eyes again, throwing her head back, as Adora got two fingers in and curved them upward.

Fuck. FUCK. Catra had to admit, Adora hit the spot of nerves on her inside pelvis perfectly.

Catra's brain went awash. She moaned and grunted in hopeless abandon.

Adora's breathing got ragged.

In the back of Catra's mind, she was so fucking proud. Adora was holding herself back so well. Managing to do what she thought was impossible and have an intimate moment without having to

be a vampire about it. Without having to feed. She would have said something, but Adora's fingers curled harder, and Catra lost her fucking mind.

Adora leaned in, nipping at Catra's stiff nipple through her shirt.

Catra huffed and grabbed Adora's head with her free hand.

"Just a minute," Adora breathed against Catra's shirt. "Just a minute, just a-"

Catra knew what was happening before Adora could say anything. She heard the slightly wet *snikt* sound of fangs sliding out on their own and Adora cursing under her breath.

The night rang out with the sound of a bell. Big, deep, and resonant.

Ba-blang .

Adora moved up, bringing her face closer to Catra's neck, but kept her hand moving. Moved harder, faster.

The *ba-blang ba-blang* of the bell grew louder and faster.

Catra lost sense of time and place. The ringing of the bell only made things more urgent. More exciting. She was being played like an instrument, all coming to a crescendo.

Adora gasped as Catra, in one massive moment, grunted and tightened around Adora's fingers in shaking pulses.

Adora shot up to her neck, first lingering around her favorite feeding spot.

Ba-blang .

Adora cursed and forced herself to move up the neck.

Catra gasped as Adora nipped at the delicate skin of her upper neck. A quick, shallow bite. Just a mark.

Her hand was pulled out of Catra with no ceremony or delicacy. It only highlighted the sense of being used that made Catra happily submissive.

Catra was limp. Numb with feeling. Her hearing started to go out, and the sound of the bell faded.

Adora grabbed Catra by the hips, threw her over her shoulder in a fireman's carry, and ran.

As Catra hung off Adora's back limply, her hearing started to come back in the sound of fuzz. Of TV static.

She heard the grand building next to them open up and the sound of voices as people shouted orders. Catra's bare ass was open to the cold and the elements, and she didn't fucking care.

Catra's shirt had soaked through on the back from the frigid dampness of the forest floor leaves. Running through the forest only made it colder, but she found it hard to give a damn. She was smiling. She was happy.

Adora wrenched the door open, dropped Catra in, slammed the door shut, and slid over the hood to get to the driver's side.

Catra gawked at her in open awe as she saw a reckless smile on Adora's face as she passed the windshield.

Breathing hard, Adora jumped in the car, got it going with a roar, but didn't turn on the lights.

Catra, with what was left of her sanity, turned to look at Adora in the dark.

Adora's fangs were still out. Her eyes were still red. With a monster's focus and night vision, she had the car turned around and drove back out faster than they could even open the gates.

Adora shivered and started laughing as they got further and further away from the building.

Catra laughed with her, her bare ass on the leather of the seat. It thrilled her that Adora was less worried about keeping the leather clean than getting out in a hurry.

Adora drove fast and breathed deeply, and maybe she even relaxed a little.

Catra watched her in awe. Adora looked happy. She looked alive. Her cheeks were red from the exertion and excitement.

Catra stopped laughing. She was struck by the sight. She was stupid. Her brain chemistry was fucked up. Adora was beautiful. The most beautiful creature in the world. Catra wanted to stop time. She wanted this moment to last forever. "I love you," she uttered. It was all she could do to avoid saying, "Will you marry me?" in Dutch.

***

The next night, Micah sat down on the bed he usually shared with his wife. For the first time in a long time, the other half of the bed was empty.

His phone was pinched between his cheek and shoulder as he took off his socks. "I'll be fine. You focus on enjoying yourself."

Angella gushed at him from the other side of the receiver. She was so happy. So surprised. He had never given her anything like this before, and she feared she couldn't repay him.

"Don't worry about catching up with me. I'll just give you something nicer next time." He laid back in bed, like a teenager on the phone with a crush. He had the same buzzing in his heart the first time he ever talked to Angella. "You enjoy the spa with your friends. Drink and eat all you want. It's an all-expenses-paid trip, and I don't want you to worry about me."

She kissed him over the phone in a rapid-fire of small kisses into the microphone.

He kissed her back, in the same way, feeling foolish but not caring.

After too many “I love you” s, and too many goodbyes, she finally hung up when one of her friends called her to join them at the bar.

He sighed and put the phone on his chest. The buzz of talking to her was replaced with weariness. He got her out of that house, far away, and in just enough time. He turned his head to look at the clock. In his best estimate, he would probably get only a few hours of sleep.

He knew his girls better than anyone. After the incident at the pharmacy, Glimmer would be put out. Catra would escalate things, and soon.

He expected an ambush. He dressed in full pajamas to avoid any embarrassment because his girls were forces of nature, and neither cared if they caught him in his boxers or not.

That was ok. He could relax knowing Angella was too far away for any of their discussion to hurt her. She was safe, and that’s what mattered. He could have the space to be honest with his daughter. Tell her the whole story. She deserved to know. He had just been putting it off because... well... she had shown no aptitude to magic before, so there was no reason to mention it. But now?

He sighed again.

He got up, plugged in his phone on the nightstand, and went to the bell that hung from the wall near the window. There was a similar bell next to every window in the house. They were all small. You’d barely notice them unless you were looking.

He closed his eyes and started reciting the vampire sensing ward in Latin. He could imagine the bells stretching down past the foundation into the ground and the soil. He relaxed in a way he

could only relax after the wards were uttered once the sun went down.

He laid back down on the bed and covered himself in the blankets. He closed his eyes. The wards would keep *that* woman from coming in through his window in a haze of fog, tempting him with her fangs and promises of power and knowledge, but they couldn’t stop the nightmares. Those he had to endure on his own.

The old marks high on his neck throbbed. He put a hand over them just to prove to himself they were gone. Healed over for decades. The woman that made them hadn’t shown her face in as long.

The only thing that could still hurt him was the memory, and he wasn’t afraid of memories.

Sins of the Father

Catra woke up to the soft sound of the alarm growing in intensity twenty minutes before sunset.

Her head was on Adora's shoulder, the warmth between them staving off the cold that seeped into the apartment. Their window was covered in thick sun-blocking curtains and the glass covered in a layer of aluminum foil, but the cold got in anyway. It would only get colder now that the sun was going down.

Adora's eyes flitted open for a second before they closed again. She settled back into a deep sleep, her face falling back into the pool of drool on her pillow.

Catra reached over and turned off the alarm and came back to her spot at Adora's side. She breathed her in, wallowing in the warmth. Some part of her brain wanted to just put it off until later. There would always be another morning, right? On a night as cold as this one, she could just stay in bed and enjoy the creature comfort of her girlfriend's bare skin.

Despite herself, Catra got up. She had to do it tonight because tonight was all she was sure she had. She crawled over her girlfriend slowly.

Catra stepped into the cold floor and went to her sock drawer. She pulled out a thin paper band with marks and numbers on it. She turned back to her girlfriend slumbering in their bed.

Adora looked like a fucking dork drooling on her pillow with her eyes rolled back, but Catra's brain made that fucking dork into the most beautiful creature in the world.

With reverence that she had never felt for another girlfriend, Catra sat back on the bed and pulled Adora's left hand out from under the covers.

Asleep like that, Adora looked like a renaissance painting. Pale skin. Bare chest, with perfectly shaped breasts and small pink nipples. She was also buff as hell. Her hands weren't soft, but they were beautifully shaped and capable. Her hair, fair and long and straight, splayed out on the pillow like a fucking saint. A drooling, conked-out saint.

Catra wrapped the strip around Adora's ring finger. This was the next step in making that conked-out saint her wife. She made a mental note of the size.

She had already avoided proposing ringless this last week. She just needed to... order the ring and... somehow manage to keep her girlfriend alive and manage not to propose for another six months while she paid the damn thing off.

She lifted Adora's hand to her mouth. She placed a kiss so gently on Adora's palm that she was unsure she was the same person she had been before Halloween. She guessed this was the transformative nature of love that Razz kept trying to get her to understand during their sessions. Razz had a hell of a time trying to explain it, and to Catra's brain it just sounded like romantic love made you stupid, and she didn't want to be stupid. "I understand now," she whispered. She let her lips linger on the base of Adora's ring finger, closed her eyes, and said with more finality, "I finally understand."

She had a sudden urge to give. She felt a pang that she had been selfish for a few days and wanted to show her love to Adora by being selfless. By doing whatever she wanted, however she wanted it.

Too bad they had to get up and get ready quickly tonight.

***

Glimmer went through the morning in a daze.

She and Bow talked before they fell asleep the night before. He had been so understanding. He covered for her instantly when he

noticed she was gone from their table at the headquarters. He told his dads the flash was his phone, that he was taking pictures of the books, and that she had just stepped out. Then he started texting her.

She told him everything. The accidental spell casting. The near car wreck. How it was Adora outside that set off the ward that everyone freaked out about.

He was a good boyfriend. He took it all so well. He was worried for her. So worried that he absolutely supported her waking up her dad in the middle of the night the next night to get some answers.

That's how they had gone to sleep. Everything on the table, and no secrets between them.

When they woke up, Bow turned to her in bed, touched her face, and looked at her with worried eyes. "I can be there with you when you talk to your dad."

Glimmer flinched.

"I'll tell my dads I'll be late."

She shook her head. "No. You go on to the headquarters. What you're doing there is far more important."

His face changed, but to what, she wasn't sure. His brow creased like he was thinking. He closed his eyes for a moment and breathed in slowly before saying, "If you feel like you want to do this alone-"

"Catra and Adora will be there getting silverware. I won't be alone."

"-then I support you. I'll do whatever you need." He withdrew his hand from her face.

She felt so cold when he pulled away. The lingering feel of his hand on her cheek only made the sickness in the pit of her stomach worse.

She didn't try to change his mind. She didn't want him there with her. She didn't want anyone there with her because she didn't know what her dad was going to say... how it might change things.

She got up, got dressed early to help him make breakfast and coffee and get out the door right as his dads pulled up.

He hugged her tight and bent over to kiss her.

That kiss was so soft. So careful. It devastated her.

She waved feebly as he disappeared down the stairs and into his dads' van.

Glimmer didn't remember what else happened that morning. Theoretically, Catra and Adora got up. Catra ate something, and they all got into the car bundled against the frigid cold.

Glimmer didn't remember specifics, though. She vaguely remembered getting her keys. She guessed she had to have gotten in the car and turned on the engine. But honestly, the whole morning was a blur. She drove on autopilot.

The thing that distracted her was the ease with which Bow accepted this arrangement. There was no debate. No second-guessing. It meant he thought it was important. Potentially... earth-shattering for her. It meant he thought there was a real concern.

Her brain did nothing but run over worst-case scenarios with him gone. Of course, it wouldn't give her normal explanations. Wouldn't do feasible stuff. No no. It was all, "What if I'm an alien?" and "Oh no, what if I'm a succubus?"

A week and a day ago, she would have dismissed both those options as absolutely impossible. But then she had been sucked into another dimension by a half-dead necromancer and made to believe it was 1890. She got to see the partial resurrection of Adora's sire and brother, and... you know... after that, almost anything felt possible.

What if she wasn't human? What if that meant Bow and her couldn't have kids? *No problem,* she thought. *We'll just adopt like his dads did.*

Of course, that is if Bow was still ok dating someone who wasn't human. She felt sick to her stomach at the idea that once he found out what she was, he'd be overwhelmed with disgust and very politely and kindly leave her.

Someone tapped her on the shoulder. She glanced back.

Catra had unbuckled from the back seat, moved forward, and poked her in the forehead with a finger. "You're panicking. Stop it."

Glimmer blinked. "I'm not panicking. I don't panic."

Catra pointed to the steering wheel. "You reached your parents' house, and we have been sitting in the car for two minutes with the engine running."

The autopilot snapped away, and Glimmer realized that yeah, Catra was right. She shut off the engine and uttered, "Sorry," then unbuckled.

Catra leaned in, face close to Glimmer's ear. "I know you didn't want Bow there, but Adora and I are more than willing to be by your side during this if you want."

This offer was somehow worse than Bow accepting not being there. With everyone acting like this was such a big deal, how the hell was she supposed to pretend it wasn't? "You get the silverware, and then... I don't know... Say you got something to

get in your room and then... you know... stay gone until I text you." She winced, knowing it was a lot to ask for. "Ok?"

Catra didn't accept that immediately. She stared at her as if evaluating the validity of the ask before finally saying, "Fine, but you text or yell for us if you need us. Remember, we got your back."

Glimmer felt a pang in her chest. Catra always had her back, and normally she'd absolutely have Catra there, but... not this time. She couldn't even really pinpoint why. It was just a worry.

She steeled herself against the worry as they walked toward the door. The cold front stung their eyes and attacked their cheeks.

She could do this. It was just her dad. It was just a conversation with her dad about what the hell was going on. It was just like having the "puberty" talk with her mom when she was eleven. That thought did not make her feel better. In fact, that thought made everything so much worse that when the door opened, she felt her resolve leave her.

Her father answered in his pajamas, meaning he expected them. He had bags under red and weary eyes, meaning he wasn't looking forward to this. And... Her mother wasn't there.

"I sent her on a vacation for a few days," He said, with a slight tremor in his voice, his hand gripping his pajama pant legs nervously. He didn't look away from her.

On any other occasion, he would have noticed Adora. He would have asked to be introduced to Catra's girlfriend, whom he had heard so much about. He would have gone full dad mode for Catra. He would have smiled, teased her, and asked a bunch of awkward questions. He would have told the new girlfriend embarrassing stories about Catra's younger years. They would have all fallen flat because Catra was incapable of feeling embarrassed. Glimmer would have been embarrassed enough on her behalf.

That’s what would have normally happened.

Instead, he hardly noticed her.

He made a positive grunt when Catra asked to borrow the silverware. He looked at her, and his eyes fell instantly on her neck. “What are those?”

Catra tucked her neck further into her thick coat. “Mosquito bites.”

His brow furrowed. “In this weather?”

She shrugged. “Climate change, I guess.” She pushed by him and headed toward the dining room.

He watched her, concerned.

Adora had not moved forward. Wouldn’t even dare to go in without being invited, so Glimmer stayed by her side. “Hey dad, it’s cold,” Glimmer said while pushing her hands further into her coat pockets.

That seemed to snap him out of it. “Oh, please, come in out of the cold.”

Adora breathed out as she stepped in. Glimmer wished, suddenly, that she had asked about the whole invitation thing before now. She thought Adora already had an invitation from her mom, or did it renew if a different owner was there? Or was it Adora just being... polite... the way she asked to be invited into rooms sometimes?

They all stood, quiet and awkward in the hallway while Catra came back with the box full of silverware and went back outside to put it in the car.

Her dad winced. “Was... was that all you girls needed?”

Glimmer shook her head so that her hair hit her face. “There’s something else I want to talk to you about.”

He wiped his palms on his pajamas. “Ok.” He glanced at Adora, unsure.

Adora was stiff-backed. At attention. An old habit. She was also not really paying attention and had completely missed out on the subtle clue to scram.

Glimmer couldn’t stand the awkwardness. “Catra has... something else she needs to get from her room with Adora.”

For a brief moment, his eyes lit up. “Adora?” He turned to her, a small smile on his lips. “So you're the new girlfriend.”

Adora smiled awkwardly. “Yes sir. Mr. Angella sir.”

That got a good smile out of him.

Catra came back in, took one look at Adora’s face, and Micah’s and declared, “Nope. Not this. Not now. You and Glim talk first.” She grabbed Adora’s hand and did her duty. She dragged Adora down the hall to her room and disappeared.

Leaving Glimmer with her father.

His smile faded, and he looked worried.

Seeing that hurt more than she thought it would, but it also strengthened her resolve. She clenched her fists. She straightened her back. Held her chin up. “Dad... Am I a succubus?”

His face, for a moment, went blank. “What?”

The words fell out of her mouth so fast. “I mean, I know everyone finds me very attractive and I always thought I had some kind of thing with that and maybe this would explain it and I think I might be ok with that I just need to know if you can have babies when you’re a demonic thing like that or-”

She was cut off by her father laughing. Big, and deep.

Glimmer's shoulders fell, but she did find herself smiling a little. "Ok, so not a succubus."

He pulled her into a hug, struggling to stop laughing.

Feeling his laugh was the only thing that relieved her tension.

He pulled away, wiping away his tears, a smile still on his face. "No, you're not a succubus. I don't know if they exist. I've never run across one, but..." His face got deathly serious. He had his hands on her shoulders, and they tightened. "But that doesn't mean there aren't dangerous things out there. Vampires are real. I know that."

Glimmer had been smiling. Now she forced her face to go blank.

He went on, either unaware of her reaction or not understanding it. "They are real. And of all the magical creatures out there, they're the vilest."

Glimmer worked hard to make her face impassive. Her brain was reeling. This was... not what she was expecting to talk about.

"Sure, they come at you with sweet sugared words, make you feel like there's respect or even love, and then use your trust to..." He froze. The blood drained from his face.

Glimmer didn't understand why at first until she heard it. The *ting-a-ling* of a bell. Like a little Christmas bell you'd get at a craft store.

Her father's pupils constricted to points. "Dear god... now? But..." He looked up like he had forgotten about her. He blinked, looking down the hallway as the lone bell was joined by a cacophony of small bells around the house. The noise grew in intensity.

He had the look of a man staring a ghost in the face. "The girlfriend?" His hand went from her shoulder to his own neck, covering a spot that Glimmer instantly understood. His look turned hard. Determined. Fear shifted to determination.

Glimmer felt his hand tighten on her shoulder before pushing her toward the front door. “Run! I’ll save Catra!” he bellowed.

There was a cracking of electricity in the air. Shadows pulled from the room around them toward her father, and he started glowing with a faint dark purple as he turned toward Catra’s door.

Glimmer didn’t have to think. The facts fell through her like a sieve because there was no logic to them. She didn’t have time to wonder how her father knew about vampires or why he apparently had vampire wards around the house. She had never thought once about why there was a bell on each window, and now she felt really dumb for not questioning it before. She didn’t have time to even wonder how it was that he pulled shadows the way Shadow Weaver did, the way he made the air crackle like her magic.

Instead, Glimmer’s brain went instantly to the memory of the teleportation spell, and she absorbed the page mentally, wordlessly, all at once on instinct fueled by a sudden fear that her dad would kill Adora or vice versa.

She disappeared out of time and space in a flash of pink and purple sparkles.

***

A few moments earlier, Catra heard the low deep belly laugh of Micah as she shut the door to her room after pulling Adora in. The laughter was good. It meant maybe this wasn’t going to be so bad for Glim.

Adora smiled as she came in, looking about the room. Having been saved from awkward conversation, she went past the guitar, the music stand, and all the strewn pieces of music notation paper with really shitty lyrics on them. She went straight for the dresser with all the pictures in small frames. “I’m glad I get to see all this again with my memories.” She reached for one of the photos.

“Now I can imagine how things would have been if I could have met you when I was a teenager.”

Catra blushed. Fucking blushed. She looked away from Adora to her death metal posters on the wall with skulls, crows, and band names written in red ink. “I was angsty.”

Adora tilted her head. “You don’t say.”

Catra watched her with a twinge in her heart. Adora had now been in her old room twice, two more times than any other girlfriend. Many of them refused to come to the house in the first place, not seeing their relationship as worthy of *meeting the parents* . If they did make it to the house, they never actually made it to the room.

Adora had no idea how rare of a position she was in. Kind of like someone seeing Superman’s Fortress of Solitude. Catra was now laying her young angst teenage self out bare for Adora’s inspection for a second time, and Adora seemed delighted by it. That fact alone was kind of hot.

Adora’s fingers touched the picture frame. Within it, there Catra was with thick eyeliner. She had spent hours on her hair with hair gel and a hairdryer to get that big spiky 80s style just right. Leather jacket and big combat boots, making a rock-on sign with her hand and sticking out her tongue. Angella took that picture right before dropping her and Glimmer off at a concert.

Glimmer agreed to go so that her parents wouldn't worry about Catra getting into any more trouble than they would have gotten into if they stayed home.

Adora smiled. A flush came to her cheeks. “You look adorable.”

Catra moved forward, propelled by the beat of her own heart and the swelling of her own happiness. She took the picture away from Adora and set it back down on the dresser, closed her eyes, and kissed her.

Adora leaned back against the edge, knocking down a few other pictures.

Catra didn't care. She pressed in, wanting more than anything for her body to be as close to Adora's as possible.

Adora's hands reached up to her face. Touched her on the jaw.

For Catra, this was a kiss that silently begged, pleading with Adora to not leave like the other girls did. *Stay. Stay with me,* her mind screamed while her mouth did its best to convey that through touching lips.

She moved Adora toward the bed.

The back of Adora's knees hit the edge, and she giggled against Catra's lips as she sat back.

Catra sank to her knees before her girlfriend.

Catra could have died at that giggle. It was cute, light, and good. Catra's mind raced. Had she ever heard Adora giggle before? She finally let the kiss break, let her lips fall away from Adora's, but looked at her with a burning need. "Tell me what you want," she said, her voice gruffer, needier than she intended.

Adora's smile flickered for a moment. "What?"

Catra closed her eyes and put her hand to her own chest. "I want to do something for you. Tell me what you want."

"Whatever *you* want, my love." Her hands traced Catra's face, unsure.

Catra shook her head. It was hard to express in words. She wanted to serve. She wanted to give. She wanted to make Adora feel good, and... damn it, she wanted Adora to demand it. She wanted hero Adora to make an appearance just to tell her exactly how she wanted to be pleased. The thought made Catra whimper.

“Are you ok?”

She was ok and not. It was so hard to communicate this. “Command me,” she begged.

Adora was a little flustered. “Ok. So, kiss me again. That was good.”

Catra did kiss her. She poured her heart into it. She grabbed Adora’s knees and pushed in. She pulled back, eyes still closed. “What else?” She opened her eyes to see Adora frowning.

Catra frowned in response. “What’s wrong?”

“I don’t know what to do. We’re at your parents' house-”

“Not my parents.”

“Ok, guardians, but still... I don’t know what’s ok to ask for.”

Catra’s skin goosebumped. “Ask for whatever you want. This is about what you enjoy. It could be anything. Baby, I’d lick your boots if that’s what you wanted.”

“Eww.” Her face scrunched up in a way completely adolescent and absolutely adorable.

Catra bit her lip. This was the result of her not spending the last week doing some basic sex ed with Adora. She could have just read out the right Wikipedia pages to her for light reading before bedtime these last few days instead of fucking. If she had done that, this wouldn’t have been so hard.

Catra considered trying to explain everything. Trying to translate all the words into words Adora would understand, and... given the impossibility of doing that quickly, she fell on what had satiated this desire in the past. “Are you hungry?”

Adora bit her lip.

She knew Adora hadn't eaten in a few nights. Knew by heart that the hunger would just now be pricking at her stomach. That was something Catra could do for her without having to explain it. It would give her the same high. The same feeling. It would be a decent replacement.

The tension in Catra's body released. This was something she could do. And yeah, it wasn't Hero Adora commanding her to do it, but it would work. With reverence, she pulled back, moved her hair out of the way, and bared her neck. She picked the side of her neck that didn't have the mark. No sense wrecking the work they had done the previous night.

She had Adora's full, undivided attention. Adora looked at her with desperation. With hunger. Because she wasn't holding them back, her fangs made no sound as they slowly extended. Her eyes shifted from blue gray to predatory red.

Catra shivered in anticipation and as Adora leaned forward, Catra heard something. A small little racket that sounded like the *ting-a-ling* of a small Christmas bell.

Adora froze. Her red eyes went wide. She looked up at the window.

Catra looked there too, and in the corner was a little bell jiggling like it was being played at by twelve different cats. "What the hell?"

The color, which had been so pink and so cute, drained out of Adora's face. "Vampire ward." They heard the faint sound of bells starting to ring around the house as she said it. "Wards," she corrected, emphasizing the 's'. She put her hand over her mouth, covering her fangs in sudden abject horror.

Catra would have done anything to get that look off Adora's face. It wasn't just fear, but shame. A self-hate that Catra had known was there, but it had been a while since it had surfaced. She

opened her mouth to say something to make Adora feel better. To let her know she wouldn't let anything bad happen.

She heard Micah yelling down the hall, and before she could say or do anything, the room burst into blinding sparkling purple light, and she felt Glimmer grab her shoulder.

More sparkles, more blinding light, and Catra was in a tight space. Her stomach felt like shit. Adora was on top of her, and on top of *her* , Glimmer scrambled.

It took Catra a moment to get oriented before she smelled the familiar scent of the upholstery. They were in the footwell in the back seat of Glimmer's car.

"No time to explain!" Glimmer said as she pulled herself into the driver's seat and fished her keys out.

Adora and Catra tried to get up and were thrown off balance while Glimmer peeled off out of the driveway and down the road.

Catra got up and struggled to get Adora out of her way, so she could see out the back window.

The front door of the house burst open. A darkness appeared, swirling with shadows, glowing purple. It took Catra a moment to recognize Micah among the darkness.

Glimmer, gulping breaths, said, "Apparently, dad has some vampire-related trauma."

Micah looked around for the car, then, not finding it, fell to his knees. The shadows dissipated from around him.

Glimmer turned the car hard to one side, making the silverware in the trunk rattle.

Right before Catra lost sight of him, Micah bowed his head and covered it with his hands. She wasn't sure, but it looked like his shoulders had started shaking up and down like he was weeping.

Catra sat back, brow furrowed and mind racing. “Well shit.” Catra turned to look at Adora and found her scooted down in the seat, to stay out of the sight of the window, arms wrapped around herself. Her fangs were still out. They wouldn’t go back until she calmed down, and that might take a while.

Catra’s only thought then was getting Adora somewhere safe. Some place she wouldn’t be scared out of her mind. She turned around, resting her chin on the shoulder of Glimmer’s seat. “Glim, where are you going?”

Glimmer startled, and said, automatically, “Home.”

Catra shook her head. “We can’t take her home. You know your dad. He might be stunned now, but he’s as tenacious as you are.”

Glimmer frowned but didn’t fight her on that. “Bow’s dads’ house?”

“First problem is they’re not at their house right now, and the second problem is they’re not allowed to let her in. It’s against protocol for hunters.”

Glimmer’s brow furrowed. “Where else is there?”

There was a long quiet pause before Catra lifted a finger and tapped the seat. “Razz’s ranch.”

Glimmer shook her head. “She’s still on retainer, with instructions to call if you ever show up. You go there, he’ll know exactly where you are.”

Catra sneered. “Wait, so they knew every time I ran away-”

“They knew exactly where you had gone and that you were safe, so they didn’t worry and they gave you some space.”

Catra’s jaw worked with that. “Well fuck... then I’m out of ideas.”

“There’s Prime’s lair,” Adora said from the back seat.

Catra lifted an eyebrow and looked back.

Adora took a deep breath, then looked away. “It’s a place that no one else knows about but us. It’s not perfect, but there’s enough stuff there to keep us comfortable for a while.”

Catra sat back, away from Glimmer, and into Adora’s side. She rubbed Adora’s arm. “I’m willing to camp out for a few nights if you are.”

Adora reached out and put her hand over Catra’s. “I should ask to stay there alone. Let you talk to your father.”

“Not my father.”

At that, Adora looked frustrated. “Talk to him. I’ll be at the cave and safe.”

Catra shrugged. “You can’t tell me to leave you alone. It’s my job to protect you.”

Glimmer cut in. “I’ll talk to him. I still have unanswered questions.”

Adora looked back out the window. Her fangs slid back in.

Catra took that as acceptance. “Ok. Cave it is.”

Touch of The Divine

Chapter Summary

> Micah reveals what Glimmer really is, Catra and Adora camp out, and a new furry creature enters the picture.

The building's heater worked hard against the rapid cooling of the night. It made the apartment smell like burning dust. It dried out the air. The constant flow made the room too warm.

Glimmer sat at a chair at the window in their entryway, looking at the parking lot through a slit in the curtains. Frost started to cover every surface outside. It made the asphalt and stairs glitter in the light of the moon.

She leaned against the window sill because... well... she was exhausted and it was all Catra's fault. Well, it was partially Catra's fault.

She had driven Adora and Catra to the cave about an hour away. When they got there, Catra started listing off things she needed from home. Clothes. Adora's broken sword, both pieces. Non-perishable food. Her box of "toys".

Glimmer had stared at her for a moment, calculating. It was a full hour of driving back to the apartment, and a full hour back to the cave. Another full hour to drive back home. Her whole night would be used up driving, and what if in all that driving she missed her dad trying to reach the apartment? So she did the only reasonable thing and just... kind of... teleported.

Catra saw it happening. Tried to stop her, but she wasn't fast enough. The process had gotten so instantaneous that Glimmer only needed to think of where she wanted to go. It was like flexing a muscle. *Pop!* and she would be there.

In an instant, she was back at the apartment grabbing everything Catra wanted but leaving the box of toys. It would be too

awkward to carry anyway. She teleported back, easy peasy.

Catra was mad when she didn't see the box, but she pretended she wasn't. She folded her arms and got a challenging look on her face like she was just daring Glimmer to do it again. "Hey, I also need you to go buy some wood, and leather for us to make a scabbard for the sword."

Glimmer groaned and dropped everything she was holding on to the floor, but *poof! Flash!* She was in the only 24-hour hardware store in the area. She scared one guy, obviously high and browsing the plumbing, but he ran away after she showed up, so, not a problem! After a few minutes of shopping, she paid, and *poof! Flash!* She was back at the cave, dropping the supplies to the floor.

Catra moved forward, grabbed her face, and inspected her. She was all furrowed brow and clenched jaw. Satisfied, she finally pulled back and asked, "How do you feel?"

The truth was, she felt like shit. Her stomach was messed up. Her hands were shaky, but that was something she could ignore, so she said, "Fine."

Catra raised an eyebrow.

"I'm fine." She had said it so loudly, so emphatically, that she almost believed it. It was only on the drive back that she realized how hard it was to focus on the road. How tired she felt. How shaky her hands were.

So, she sat in the apartment, leaning against the window, waiting for her dad to show up and hoping he had answers. Doing magic like this... it took something out of her, and what if taking too much killed her? That thought hadn't entered her head until that moment sitting there exhausted and unable to recover, waiting for her dad.

A car roared into the parking lot, parked askew, and Glimmer sat up to see it better.

In a rush, someone in a trench coat got out and then reached back in to grab something.

It was her dad. She knew it. It was his white sedan. His graying dark hair. His salt and pepper beard.

He climbed the stairs, trying to be quiet. In one hand, a hastily made wooden crucifix that she could just barely see in the dark. In his other hand, a hastily sharpened wooden gardening stake. There were fifty bulbs of garlic in a ring around his neck, freshly purchased from a 24-hour grocery, she was sure of it. Held between his pinky finger and his ring finger was a small bottle of what she could only imagine to be holy water. Did he steal that from a church in the middle of the night?

The sight of him, all decked out to kill a movie vampire but not a real one, calmed her down. Unless he knew some crazy anti-vampire magic, Adora had very little to worry about, and Glimmer certainly wasn't going to correct him on it.

What worried her more was the look on his face as he got closer to the apartment. He was visibly shaken. He had to stop and gather some courage as he stood at the door, preparing to try to barge in.

Glimmer forced herself to get up and opened the door before he could do anything drastic.

He startled when the door opened, holding both the cross and the stake up, and on viewing her, his hands fell to his sides. "She's... she's not here is she," he asked in defeat.

Glimmer shook her head, no.

For a moment, he tapped the holy water with his wedding ring. "I... don't suppose you'd tell me where they are."

She shook her head slowly.

He frowned. “Look, I know you don’t believe me but... you girls have gotten involved in something you don’t understand. That girl is dangerous.”

Glimmer folded her arms and leaned against the door frame. Maybe it looked like she was exasperated, but the truth was she felt like she couldn’t stand much longer. “What the hell is this all about, dad?”

He looked at her, really looked at her. His determination turned to worry. “Are you ok? Did she feed on you?”

Glimmer rolled her eyes. “No, she didn’t feed on me. She never has.”

His brows furrowed in disbelief.

“I’ve just... been... well...” Her arms fell to her sides. “Teleporting?”

He went still.

She kicked at the edge of the carpet against the threshold. “I read a spell book, and, well, it seems that I’ve just... absorbed a spell and I can do it really easily and...” Oh, this was the worst. The absolute worst part. Having to admit she was being reckless unnecessarily. “And... sometimes it’s easier to teleport than it is to drive.”

His face relaxed. “You can teleport?”

She nodded.

“That’s amazing.” He put the crucifix, stake, and holy water down on the ground next to the door. He ducked out of the necklace of garlic, dropped it alongside all the other stuff, and stood up to offer her his hand. “Can you show me? Take us to the roof or are you too weak?”

She resented being called weak. She took his hand and let herself go.

A moment later, in a shower of purple and pink sparks, Glimmer stood on the roof of their apartment with her dad. From the dry heat of the apartment, the cold was almost refreshing.

Her dad turned to look at where they were. He had a father's prideful smile on his face, like the first time he found out she beat up a bully. He turned to her and squeezed her hand. "That was amazing. It would have taken me two months to prepare a spell like that!"

She should have felt excited. She would have been ecstatic, but she felt sick to her stomach. "Dad, I feel bad."

He waved his hand dismissively. "You are fine. You just need to recharge. You did it once, but..." He stopped and turned his attention fully on her. "It's moonlight. You charge in direct moonlight."

"Oh, thank god," Glimmer said as she, kind of sat down, kind of collapsed. The point was, she was now on her back looking up at a starry sky, with a moon shining bright above them. Whether it was true that it recharged her, or it was just placebo, she didn't care. Looking at it made her stomach feel better.

Her father got down and laid next to her on his back looking up at the same sky. The same moon.

"How long does it take?"

He shrugged. "I don't know."

"Why moonlight?"

At that, her father went quiet for a moment. He took a deep breath and said, flatly, "Your mother is a moon goddess."

Glimmer had to work to process those words. Moon. Goddess. Goddess? Her mother was a goddess? “How?”

His hand reached out to find hers again.

She felt his fingers and held on tight.

He seemed to gain some resolve with that hold. “Magic can be... chaotic.” It took him a moment to continue. “I learned dark magic when I was young, from a bad mentor, and that kind of magic... it hurts you and can easily hurt others. So I stopped practicing until I got to college.” He seemed to gain some strength. “I found a club of sorcerers who practiced all kinds of magic, and I kind of... you know... reclaimed magic for myself. I studied magic harder than my actual classes. I was a natural.”

He shifted, but still held her hand. “There was this spell no one in the club could figure out, and I looked at it and I knew the answer. My dark magic mentor explained this problem to me. Some spells have a session ID.”

Glimmer’s brain came to a halt. “A what?”

He shrugged. “Some spells exist independently of reality and need to be fixed in time and space or else they won’t work. The best analogy I have is the way databases and websites have a session ID. Anyway, I took one look at this spell and realized it was fine, it just had a session ID from the 1400s, so that’s why it wouldn’t work.”

He let that linger for a bit before adding, “And so I updated the session ID.” He squeezed her hand harder. “You have to understand, I was sure it wouldn’t work. No one had gotten it to work in over a thousand years. I thought I was safe.”

Glimmer squeezed his hand harder. “Dad, what happened?”

He put his other hand on his chest. “The simple answer is, I banished myself to another realm... And I met your mother... and

we fell in love." That last word was said wistfully like it hurt his heart to say it.

"So the whole story about you and mom meeting at orientation?"

"Complete hogwash. But, that's the story because that's what your mother remembers."

"Mom doesn't know?"

He shook his head and took a breath. "Your mom can't know. If she does... well... Glimmer, your mother and I ran away together. We ran here. And goddesses can't live here, not in their normal form and she had people trying to find her. So, she cast a spell on herself. She became, in every way, human, except she wasn't." He paused, looking up into the moonlight. "The spell only works as long as she thinks she's human. If she ever remembers who she really is, she'll lose her form and... and we'll lose her." He was fighting back tears. "I only found her by accident the first time. I don't think I could find her again. If she goes back, her court won't let her leave." His grip on her hand got tighter. "So, she asked me... begged me... to not tell her. To keep it a secret from her, and let her live out a life she always wanted."

Tears obstructed Glimmer's vision of the moon. "Dad... that's horrible."

"I didn't even think we could have children. I don't know if we're the same species, but she's still a goddess, and, I guess if a goddess wants to be pregnant, she can be pregnant." He turned to her. His eyes were glittering with their own tears in the moonlight. "Glimmer, you're a demigoddess. I don't know exactly what that means for you, but it seems like it gives you a store of magical power that you can dip into. Magic will be easier for you and..." His face got grim. "And that's a blessing and a curse. Because, like I said, magic can be chaotic." He settled back, looking at the moon. "If you want, I'll teach you, because I know I can't stop you from practicing it but..." He clenched his jaw so tight, she heard him grind his teeth, before he said, "Catra has

made a huge mistake. I need your help getting her away from Adora, for her own good, before she does something she can't take back."

Glimmer frowned. "Dad..."

"She has no idea what she's done, what that mark on her neck *means* , or what they'll make her do. Please. I need you to help me find that vampire and save Catra from her."

She glared at him. "Dad... What are you going to do? Kill her?"

He flinched at that. "If I have to."

She let go of his hand. "Where is this coming from? What happened to you?"

He turned away from her, putting his other hand on his chest. "There are things in my past I'm not proud of. Please let it be enough to say... I don't want Catra repeating my mistakes." He got up and walked away toward the stairs.

Glimmer knew she should go after him. Knew she should pressure him to figure out what in the world was going on. She tried to get up and follow him, but her limbs were too tired. She gave up, and let her father have his secrets for the moment. She'd text Catra and let her know that the dad situation with Adora wasn't resolved.

She relaxed against the roof, soaking moonlight, and staring at the orb in the sky with a new and sudden reverence.

***

The moment they arrived, while Catra was dealing with Glimmer, Adora focused on the cave.

Adora had no idea where anything was. She couldn't turn on the magical torches that Prime could command with a snap. That was ok because Glimmer brought a flashlight.

So Catra sat on a random rock, with their things piled up next to her. She shined the light on Adora while Adora tore open a few bags of “clean” vampire laundry. "We can use these to make a makeshift mattress,” she said, almost cheery.

They were in the throne room, right at the foot of the stairs. The cave wasn’t as cold as the world outside, but it was still chilly. The ash of Prime’s body, and the smaller bit of ash that was his severed skull, hadn’t moved. It hadn’t been disturbed, which meant the wind didn’t get down here at all.

For a moment, Catra wondered if there was anything to be gained from the ash. Maybe find a reason for why Prime’s skull turned to ash instead of doing what all the others apparently did. Then again, Shadow Weaver’s had turned to ash too, so probably, it was fucking magic. Some dark magic to keep them both from falling into the hands of the hunters and having their skulls added to the catacombs, and their souls held in limbo.

Catra kicked the pile and looked around at the cave. The space was bigger than she remembered. The stairs were more massive. The ceiling was so high up that the flashlight wouldn’t reach into the dark. She settled on looking at the throne. It was carved out of stone, just like the stairs. A massive regal thing. She could imagine Adora sitting on it and commanding a world of vampires. Her brain went immediately to straddling Adora on that throne... meeting her every wish. Her every command. She filed that thought away for later when Adora was more in the mood.

She turned to the opposite wall, the one where the Sword of Protection had been hanging for two hundred years with Prime’s other trophies. The wall was empty now, leaving various hooks and shelves without their cargo. It was as if the place had been looted, but when she looked at the floor, there were no footprints except theirs. There were bug tracks in the dust, but that was it. She wondered if Adora was scared of bugs. She decided not to mention it, in case she was.

Adora wasn't paying attention anyway. She seemed focused. Happy. "Adam and I would camp a lot of the time. It's cheaper than getting a room at an inn, and sometimes we didn't have a choice. It was fun. I developed a taste for it, you know? Waking up outside, with the smell of the evening. It was refreshing."

That explained Adora's exuberance. A rare opportunity to dip into memories of happier times. Catra couldn't help but feel a sympathetic happiness for her girlfriend.

Adora had a slight reminiscing smile on her face. "Adam and I would trade off who was making the shelter, and who was foraging or hunting for dinner. I was really good at identifying mushrooms. He was better at fishing." Adora pulled some shirts tight, making part of a bundle for the mattress. "One time we went to this village in the alps. Beautiful. Old-" She went quiet while she tied another few bundles tight. "A very remote village, where they didn't like our habits of sleeping all day and moving around at night, so we camped out in the mountains."

Catra spent the last week learning everything there was about vampire hunting, and this was possibly the worst of it. The curse of vampire hunters, it seemed, to be mistaken for their prey as often as they were considered heroes.

Catra moved the light on the floor because she thought she saw something move. Once the light was on it, it was just a spider. It scurried away.

Adora didn't notice. "Anyway, at this particular village, we took out a brood of like seven vampires, and before we could even get cleaned up from the battle, the villagers showed up, saw the blood, and... well, we had to run for our lives." She paused, sitting back on her heels, looking over the mattress. "It turns out we were more in danger from the people than the vampires." She smiled awkwardly to herself before her smile disappeared as she looked over her work, as the context of where they were and why came back. "Story of my life I guess..."

Catra's shoulders dropped, and she looked back at Adora. "This will blow over. Just wait till Glimmer has her chance to talk to him."

Adora looked up, squinted, kneeling on the floor with her hands on her knees. "Why won't you call him father, or dad?"

Catra rolled her eyes. "I'll call you *daddy* if you want."

Adora blushed and looked back at her work. "That... that's not what I mean."

Catra smiled to herself at how easy that was. They'd get there, eventually. "Then what do you mean?"

"I mean... he is your father."

Catra opened her mouth to protest, but Adora stopped her with a hand up.

"I don't mean biologically. I mean, just now, he was about to go toe-to-toe with the Horde Lord to protect you."

Catra smiled. It was the first time she had heard Adora refer to herself as the Horde Lord in an *I'm kind of a badass* kind of way. She liked that.

Adora stood up and motioned toward the makeshift bed. "The sun will be up soon. What side do you want?"

Catra said nothing as she got up, and crawled into one side of the bed.

Adora crawled into the other. She pulled some clothes she had tied together over them. A makeshift blanket against the cold. Catra made that warmer by putting their coats over it.

Settling down into the weird clothing folds, Adora added, "I just don't understand why you wouldn't honor him by giving him the title."

Catra rolled over to face Adora, shutting off the flashlight right as they made eye contact. She didn't have to dig deep to understand what was going on. Adora had an obsessed father who was more likely to throw his daughter to the lions than he was to risk his life to save her. He trained her hard, and while he showed Adora his approval and praise, he also never let up on the iron fist that he used to... in his own words, temper his children to the rough treatment of daily life as hunters of the undead. He would have called his actions necessary. Modern people would have called it child abuse.

A father who sought to protect his children? Yeah, Catra could see how Adora might be a little jealous of that. How badly she would have wanted that experience. A thought bubbled up in Catra's brain.

If you marry me, he could be your father-in-law, and you could call him dad, or father, or whatever the fuck you want. He'd love it.

She avoided saying that by saying, instead, "I learned for the first ten years of my life not to get attached to parental figures." She shrugged up against Adora's side, thankful for the body heat. "Sure he was nice, but shit like that- it doesn't last. No one's love is unconditional. I'm not going to pretend like it is."

Adora, her arm around Catra, made a disgruntled noise deep in her chest. "That's very cynical."

"It's been right more often than it's not."

Adora was quiet for a long time before she took Catra's hand in hers. "And us? Do you think we are temporary too?"

There was a tone of hurt in Adora's voice that made Catra angry at herself. "That's not what I'm talking about."

"It's not that dissimilar."

"It's different."

"It really isn't."

Catra clenched her jaw. It *was* dissimilar. Catra knew that, because she had Adora's ring size burned into her brain. It was *dissimilar* because she was trying to figure out how best to propose, and trying desperately to avoid doing it too early. *It* was dissimilar because... because they were in love and that was different. If Micah hadn't provided for her, he would have had CPS called on him and gone to jail. Catra would have made sure of that. His "love" was one of obligation. Adora... Adora was here by choice. At least, Catra hoped she was there by choice.

By then, Catra realized she had gone too long without answering, which made her even angrier at herself. She snapped, "Right now, I'm pretty sure that man is looking to kill you."

Adora took a deep breath before saying, in almost a whisper, "It's not like I'm not worthy of his scorn or his distrust. Maybe I hunted someone he loved, or Shadow Weaver did. Maybe one of the vampires who I just saved by making this agreement with the hunters did something to him." She paused.

Catra gripped her tighter.

"My love, I'm not innocent, and that man loves you as a father should." The last few words were faint, as the weight of the rising sun settled on her, and drove her brain to day-sleep.

Catra heard her fall asleep with the subtle change in breathing. Just like Adora to plan to say that just as she fell asleep so that Catra had no chance to retort with something clever. It was just as well. She was angry, and she never came up with good clever retorts when she was angry.

She rolled to face out, to give herself a moment to think, but before she could do that she saw... a cat.

In the darkness, a sleek black cat was sitting looking at her only a foot away. It had a small frame and thin limbs. It looked back at

her with one blue, one gold eye. Both glowed in the dark like beacons.

The impossibility of those eyes struck Catra. What were the odds of finding a cat with a mirror image of her own heterochromia? One in a million? One in ten million? Catra wondered if she had fallen asleep and was dreaming.

The cat stood up on all four legs, arched its back with the hair standing on end, put back its ears, and hissed.

Catra, already in a bad mood, hissed back.

In the blink of an eye, it wasn't a cat, but a lioness, massive and looming over her. Hunched muscled shoulders. Huge ripping claws gripping the cave floor. Same heterochromatic eyes in the dark but set in a massive lioness face.

And that... that snapped Catra out of her anger and right on into curiosity. Even as it pulled its black-rimmed lips back, and bared its massive teeth, mouth dripping and the moist breath hot on Catra's face, Catra just watched. "What the hell are you?" She asked out loud, calmly, her question echoing off the edges of the cave.

And in a moment, it was a cat again. Small, and surprised. It hissed again and ran away.

The moment it turned, and those glowing eyes were gone, the cave became pitch black again.

Catra blinked in the dark. She... didn't remember consuming any hallucinogens, so she probably wasn't seeing things that weren't there.

She knew somewhere in the back of her mind that if Glimmer had seen that, she'd have freaked out and demanded to leave. Catra considered this course of action but decided it was pointless. She was probably just asleep and having a nightmare. Nightmares

didn’t bother her, so she rolled back over, snuggled up to Adora, and forgot about it entirely.

Communication

Chapter Summary

> Adora has a dream. Catra gets jealous. Glimmer just wants to be worshiped.

It twisted her gut, but it felt familiar.

The light of the fire in the room and how it made all the shadows dance like they were alive. The slight sulfur scent of whatever was brewing in the pot. The pain in her bones... her sire's influence holding her there.

Shadow Weaver sat in her reading chair. She was distracted. Distant.

"You might think I'm harsh," Shadow Weaver's low dark voice echoed in the small living room of their house. "But these are the lessons you must learn to survive. We don't play with our food because you are young, and when you are young it's too easy to become obsessed." She settled her eyes on the fire burning in their hearth. "You can have a pet when you're older. When the obsession is easier to deal with. When you won't feel it so *sharply* ."

Adora didn't know how long she had been there on the floor. Her knees screamed at her. Her neck hurt. She could feel the sun rising outside but couldn't sleep. Her body shook.

Shadow Weaver ignored her and kept lecturing. "We could get you a pet right now, and you'd become obsessed. Then, you'd realize they were mortal, and you can't imagine living without them, so what do you do? You go to the Horde Lord and beg for permission to turn them. What if it's denied? What if he asks of you something you can't provide? Then you're left watching the thing you love die and rot." She shivered and shifted in her chair. "Better to just abandon them, leave the country and never see

them again. Even better, not to get attached in the first place." There was a long pause. "I speak from experience. Best not to repeat my mistakes, child." Her fingers drummed on the arm of the chair.

Adora flinched as Shadow Weaver stood up. After the flinch came hope. Maybe she'd be released.

Shadow Weaver turned to her, boring into her soul with those cracked red eyes. "I am going to bed. Meditate on my warning."

Adora focused on the floor, her insides churning. She realized, with abject horror, that she was to spend the whole day like this.

Shadow Weaver walked past her to her room and shut the door.

Adora jolted out of sleep at the sound of that door slamming, her heart racing. Sweat covering her.

It took her a moment to realize the sound hadn't been Shadow Weaver's door but Catra's phone, thrown into the wall.

She rolled over to find Catra, her face stuffed into the makeshift pillow, screaming into it like an angry teenage girl.

"My love," Adora said quietly as she reached out. "What happened?"

Catra moved fast. Turned to her and latched on, ducking her head into Adora's neck and shoulder. She wasn't crying, but her body was stiff.

"He called," was all Catra could say. Her voice gruff with anger. Her body tight.

Adora relaxed. She put her arms around her girlfriend and held her while she fought the pressure from the sun to go back to sleep.

For a moment, Adora let herself calm down from her dream. Shadow Weaver was dead and couldn't hurt her anymore. She was the Horde Lord, so, if it came down to it... she shook that thought out of her head. Best not indulge in thoughts like that. Besides, more than likely, there wouldn't be time to deal with obsession.

Catra breathed in through her teeth and curled up in the bed before saying, "I told him we were in love."

"You did?" Adora couldn't help the surprise in her voice. They had often enough whispered sweet nothings to each other, proclaiming their love in private. It was something else to declare it to a parent.

"He said it feels a lot like love, but it's not. It's something else." She hesitated for a moment, then added, "He knows better than to say I don't know what love feels like."

"Is that why you threw the phone?"

Catra nodded.

Adora breathed in, taking in all Catra's anger and frustration, and said, "Is it broken?"

Catra froze, then groaned against Adora's chest.

Adora ran her fingers through Catra's hair. "It's ok if it is, love. It's just... we're out here in the middle of nowhere, and we need our phones."

Catra pulled away from her but didn't look her in the eye. She got up, went to the wall, picked up her phone, and flipped it over. She stood for a moment, looking at her screen. "What the hell?" She turned, looked Adora in the eye, and held up the phone.

The screen wasn't even scratched. A genuine smile bloomed on Adora's face.

That’s when they both heard the meow.

Catra and Adora turned to look at the source. Adora had little time to respond before she felt something warm and furry in her arms. It jumped to her like it knew her and started purring.

The smile on Adora’s face got bigger. “A cat?” Her hands clasped around the soft furry warm thing on her. The weight of it felt pleasant.

Catra’s look soured. “Oh, I get it. You were just waiting for me to get out of the way so you could weasel into my territory. Is that it?”

It took Adora way too long to realize Catra was staring at the cat in her arms. Catra, jealous over a cat? The purring was too much. Too relaxing. Adora’s eyelids started to get heavy again. “Don’t be mad,” was all she could say. With the crisis averted, and her girlfriend not stressing out anymore, Adora lost the fight she had with the day, laid back on the mattress, and slipped right back into dreaming. Her dreams were more pleasant. All about cats. She had always wanted a cat.

***

“This cat is going to drive me mad,” Catra said with a sigh.

“Wait? A cat? What does a cat have to do with anything?” Glimmer said over the phone.

Catra’s battery was hovering at a dangerous three percent. She didn’t care. She rolled over in bed, watching Adora giggling as she played with the cat. “It is, officially, cuter than I am, so Adora is spending all her time with it.”

Adora stuck out her tongue at Catra.

Catra stuck her tongue in response, then rolled on her back and looked at the impossibly high ceiling. “Did you talk to your dad?”

Glimmer grunted.

“And?”

“I can’t tell you. Or, I could, but... If mom ever finds out, she’ll be in some kind of danger, so if it’s all the same to you-”

Catra cut her off. “Hey, don’t worry about me. I only care that you know what’s going on.” She paused for a moment. “Is it cool?”

Glimmer made a noise deep in her throat before muttering, “Oh hell yes, it’s cool.”

Catra smiled big. “You gonna tell Bow?”

Silence at the end of the line. Glimmer’s awkward twisting silence. She got quiet and said, “I should, but- the more people know, the more danger mom is in.”

Catra sat up. “Are you human?”

Glimmer whimpered. “Partially.”

“Then you have to tell him.”

Glimmer groaned.

“I can’t believe I’m the one arguing for reason here.”

Glimmer whispered but sounded like she had gotten closer to the phone. “What am I supposed to do? Disclose it before I start dating? Put it on my Tinder profile?”

“Tell Bow.”

“I want to. It’s just...”

Catra waited, ignoring the purrs and meows of the new animal that had come between her and her girlfriend as Adora ran her fingers through its fur. “Just what, Glim?”

“What if I only tell him if he wants to get married?”

“Is he there with you?”

“He’s making coffee in the kitchen.”

Catra’s heart leapt at that. “Can I get a cup?”

“Hold on.” Glimmer hung up.

Catra hung up too. She turned to look at Adora scratching the cat’s neck with both hands, a smile plastered on her face. Catra rested her arms on her knees and watched with a subtle frustration. As much as she liked seeing Adora happy, she wanted to be where the cat was, in Adora’s lap, and the space had been occupied since they woke up. *Stupid cat.*

When the sparkles came, neither she nor Adora flinched, but the cat jumped three feet into the air, did a flip, and landed running.

Glimmer handed Catra a battery pack and a steaming mug of coffee. She didn’t look tired. She looked refreshed but worried. “How are you two holding up?”

Adora’s smile was gone as her hands settled back onto her lap with nothing to busy them.

Catra plugged her phone into the battery pack, and took the first sip of coffee before declaring, “I’ve been replaced.”

Adora playfully hit her in the shoulder, spilling some coffee out of Catra’s cup.

Catra smiled at the contact.

Glimmer didn’t notice the playfulness. Her mind was somewhere else. “So... You think I should tell him?”

Adora perked up.

Catra shrugged, drinking more coffee. She swallowed, turned to Adora, and asked, “If I were only partially human, would you want to know?”

“Oh, yes,” Adora said without hesitation, then narrowed her eyes at Glimmer.

Glimmer’s brow furrowed. “Adora, don’t try to guess it. Don’t even try. Just trust me. It’s very cool, and you should absolutely never say anything to my mother.”

Adora’s look got serious, like a soldier taking orders. She nodded.

Catra finished her coffee in a gulp and handed the cup back to Glimmer.

Glimmer took the cup mindlessly, her hands holding it as if she didn’t know what to do with it. Her face scrunched up in thought before falling. “I guess you two are right... I’ll tell Bow tonight.”

Then, without another word, she was gone in a flash.

With the slight buzz of caffeine in her stomach starting to seep into her bloodstream, Catra looked back at Adora and gave her a crooked smile.

Adora blushed instantly. “What are you doing?”

Catra pouted and started tipping over till she lay her head down on Adora’s lap and exaggerated a swoon. A dramatic arm draped over her forehead. “You reject Catra. You replace her with a new pet. Shame, shame on Adora for a thousand years!”

Adora smiled in utter delight and giggled as the fingers of one hand ran through Catra’s hair.

Catra could die to hear that giggle. With a contented smile, she pulled her arm down and looked up at her girlfriend's flushed, bright face. She felt warm. The buzz in her chest... was that the caffeine or was it... Happiness?

She stared, transfixed, as Adora tried to cover her mouth because she was still laughing.

Catra's smile faded as she felt a sense of wonder flow over her. She was the luckiest girl in the world. She wanted this, whatever it was, to last forever.

Adora looked at her lovingly, and then her look changed. Her smile faded, and her fingers slowed in their playing with Catra's hair. "I have a really stupid question."

Catra looked at her, full force, with nothing but seriousness. "There are no stupid questions."

Adora looked away as if looking around to see if anyone was there before she turned back and leaned in, "Do... Do people like licking boots?" She leaned in further and whispered, "Is that something people like... sexually?"

Catra licked her lips and lifted her hand to trace Adora's face. "It depends."

Adora blushed at the face touching and moved away. "Be serious."

"I am being serious." She pulled her hand away, laid it on her chest, and looked Adora over like she was sizing up a meal. Judging Adora for how far she'd take this information. How hard would she go? And she had to admit that she didn't care how far Adora took it. That was the problem with having no limit. This was the thing that caused her and Scorpia to break up. That caused her to pause.

She had always assumed that her lack of boundaries and limits was a plus. Any girl she dated could get their kinks out, whatever they might be, but this had backfired. Scorpia got scared. Scared at what Catra would let her do and how far she would let her go. That fear that Catra never understood destroyed Scorpia's peace and was the seed that caused their falling out. Many people assumed they broke up over the nightclub fiasco, but they only

publicly pretended to break up to save Scorpia's reputation. The real breakup was later and much more mundane. More sad.

Catra looked at Adora, knowing the quantity of what was to be lost. Heaven. Also known as this domestic bliss that she had only recently discovered.

She licked her lips, closed her eyes, and chose her words carefully. "It's not the boot licking itself that gets people off. It's being told to do it."

Adora made a confused face.

Catra's heart fluttered in her chest. "You know the old saying, everything is about sex, except sex. Sex is about control."

Adora frowned.

"What?"

"Are you always so cynical? Why can't sex be about showing love?"

Catra frowned. "I'm not saying it's not about that." She struggled up off Adora's lap to sit next to her on the bed and look her in the eye.

Once she had those blue-gray eyes on her, waiting for an explanation, Catra found her words had left her. She didn't want to fuck this up. She didn't want to scare Adora away. She looked somewhere else besides Adora's eyes and found her words. "Control and... domination can be about love too."

Innocently, Adora repeated, "Domination?"

Catra winced. Her hands reached out, and Adora took them. That little bit of physical contact made her feel like this wasn't a complete loss. "It's about trust; that kind of trust can make a relationship deeper." She hesitated. "Does that make sense?"

Adora said nothing but instead let go of Catra's hand and threw her arms around Catra.

Catra let herself be pulled in. Relaxed as she was engulfed in Adora's arms.

Adora pulled Catra back onto the bed, holding her. Adora waited before taking a breath and saying, "I don't know. Maybe?"

Catra pushed herself up to look Adora in the eye. "I'm not asking you to do anything you don't want to do. Remember? That's one of our rules." She held up her hand.

Adora reached out to her and entwined their fingers. Adora blushed. She swallowed. "Ok. I need... I need time to think about that and... maybe plan some stuff."

Catra leaned in, closing her eyes and placing a chased kiss on Adora's bottom lip before whispering, "We have time. Don't rush, ok, babe?"

Adora's brain sent off warning signals. *Don't rush? Do we have time?* The number of nights she felt like she had to live were ticking down in the back of her mind. With the Sword of Damocles dangling above them, she had a schedule lined out. Make the scabbard tonight. Make sure Catra has her silverware figured out. They'd go exploring in the cave. She had not planned on having time alone to fumble through verbal searches and listen out of earshot of Catra so she could... plan a super important kind of sex she had no idea even existed until this moment. Should she ask for search terms? Should she rely on the few she had heard already and just go from there? Terrifyingly, she considered asking Glimmer for search term advice, which felt like a whole other horror. The relative peace she had found, distracted by Catra's complete lack of fear, faded in a horrible heart-sinking minute. It felt like she had no time left. Precious few moments, and too many things to do.

Catra laid down, putting her head on Adora's chest, and heard the other girl's heart pounding. Catra assumed it was arousal, and got pleased with herself. Look at her communicating her needs and wants to a long-term partner. Razz would be so proud.

***

Glimmer managed to make a plan to tell Bow. Managed to very nearly tell him in the car on the drive over, but he was distracted.

"Two nights, and we haven't found anything about the catacombs. I was hoping Adora's uncle's journal would have something, so I'm glad to have you back to look through them." He shot her a warm smile in the relative dark of the car.

And see, Glimmer got distracted by falling back into a memory of her query before she had accidentally nearly killed her and Catra and Adora in one misplaced teleport into Adora's lap in the car. And *then* she got distracted by the fact that she somehow teleported into a moving car. How had she done it? She was just thinking about Adora.

When they got to the headquarters, she texted her dad, asking him how teleportation works. A moment later, he sent back:

(Dad) Not until you help me save Catra from the pure evil of a vampire master.

Glimmer groned

(Glimmer) She's not like that. She's literally trying to save people.

A long pause.

(Dad) They are very good liars.

Glimmer put up her phone out of anger. She didn't need him. She'd figure it out on her own. She'd just find Adora's uncle's notes.

Sitting looking at the next ten years of bound paper, Glimmer realized that Adora's uncle never wrote about magic in his journal. This was, she realized, probably a self-defense tactic so that the Order wouldn't know about his actions. So, she turned to the little leather spell book that she now kept on her person at all times.

She glanced over the spells, making sure not to actually read the Latin, but focusing on the notes in the margins. Now that she actually thought of it, the uncle never got the teleportation to work, so he wouldn't have notes on it... But whoever he got the spell from would have. She closed the book in front of her. "Where's the forbidden archive?"

Lance and George both looked up at once, their expressions unreadable. George furrowed his brow, then went back to his reading. Lance put his book down, leaned forward, and looked her right in the eye. "Why do you ask?"

Glimmer closed the spell book. "We know he saw the forbidden archive. He didn't write about it in his journal, so... the information we need is in there."

Lance was about to say something, but he was cut off by George standing up and slamming his knuckles onto the table. "The archive is forbidden for a reason. The fact that we are here is because someone let a bad actor into that archive."

Bow put his reading down. "Dad, Glimmer's right."

Glimmer nearly fell out of her chair.

Bow continued. "The reports about Shadow Weaver are... unhelpful. Adam's reports are all very accurate details about the hunts, but he never talks about the family." He turned to Glimmer. "And what have Adora's uncle's journals been about?"

Glimmer felt a warm flush on her cheeks. She could have said the truth, that they were about nothing much but the daily happenings of the Van Helsing family. Nearly contemptuous descriptions of Adora and Adam growing up, almost as if he

resented them in some way. The subtext that... something had to be done for their conception, but she didn't know what. She had gotten to the account of the Sword of Protection choosing Adora, and all he had written was, *"It chose her while my brother still lived. How strange. I wonder if it had ever in its creation been touched by the weaker sex?"* Which she thought was misogynistic. What a douche. She settled on saying out loud, "Nothing useful. Nothing about the catacombs."

Bow folded his hands together and leaned forward, addressing his dads. "That necromancer had to find out about the dimension we were banished to somehow. If it's not in any of these documents, it must be in the archive."

Lance opened his mouth, but stopped as George stood up straight.

George folded his hands behind his back, and in a very military fashion declared, "Not on my watch." For a moment, he relaxed, looked back at Lance, and added, "It's not that I don't trust the two of you. It's just that... Magic can be..."

Lance finished, sitting forward. "-Chaotic. Look, you have to understand that over the centuries, the Order has gathered those documents from necromancers, vampire sorcerers, and... less than savory characters from our own Order. Some of those people meant to do harm. Some didn't and were just really unlucky when a spell didn't go the way they wanted."

Glimmer heard what she needed to hear. That forbidden archive was full of spells. Maybe a spell that created the catacombs and the dimension that all those soles were in. Maybe it really did hold a clue. Maybe it had notes about teleportation and how it worked. And, a small part of her wondered if it had something on moon goddesses. "Ok," the word fell out of her mouth. She turned to Lance and George and, with the straight face she had learned to lie to her mother, said, "I understand your concern. Can you at least show us where it is? I don't know, maybe to just get a sense of what this guy was thinking?"

George looked at Lance.

Lance shrugged. “What’s the harm?”

And that was how she and Bow ended up walking down three flights of steps with flashlights, following George and Lance down into... the catacombs themselves.

As they entered the space, the sound of their feet on the ground was magnified in the small corridor. Damp walls, dusty rocks. Really, it was like descending any dark and secretive passage right up until they reached the skulls. Glimmer’s breath hitched, and she threw her hand over her mouth as the rows and rows of vampire skulls stretched out before them in a seemingly never-ending tunnel.

They had all been carefully placed to settle one on top of the other, fangs used to balance, before setting them against the next one in line. Each one represented a soul caught in purgatory, forced to play out an existence that seemingly never ended. In short, it was torture, which was why they were there in the first place. The vampire hunting counsel had, annoyingly, cited Chesterton’s fence, and stated that the catacombs couldn’t be undone without finding out why they were made in the first place. Doing otherwise, they claimed, was reckless.

So, it was the four of them, reading as fast as they could, trying to end that torment. Ending it faster... didn’t it justify any means necessary? Wasn’t she under a moral obligation to end this as fast as possible?

Bow gave a visible shiver.

Glimmer turned her light to see one closer and groaned as spiders scurried away from them. Spiders. She hated spiders. Her skin goosebumped, and shivers went through her, and she turned away from it to follow Bow’s dads. The shivers felt slightly electric, and a memory sparked in her brain. It felt like Shadow Weaver’s touch, only weaker. It all clicked in, suddenly, that what she felt

wasn’t fear but magic. A low-level current of flowing magic. At that realization, she unconsciously reached out to touch one of the nearest skulls in child-like wonder.

“We’re here,” George boomed, his voice loud and deep in the small space.

Glimmer flinched and pulled her hand away. She wiped her hand on her shirt and turned to the others.

Before Lance was a massive door. Made of iron. No door knob or handle, just a keyhole. George stopped in front of it and put a hand out to touch it. “They moved the whole archive here when they moved headquarters. They considered burning it.”

Glimmer suppressed a scoff. What was it with hunters and burning spells?

Lance clapped his hands together and looked at them cheerfully. “But, they decided that burning it was permanent, and locking it up wasn’t, and just in case it needed to get used, it would be here.”

George added with a clenched fist. “But it’s the last resort.”

Glimmer, then tuned it all out. She looked at the door, imagining what was on the other side. The answers to all her questions. The solution to all her problems. The secret to her independence.

They all climbed back up the stairs, and Glimmer’s eyes were on Bow.

They all settled down to read again, and after a requisite amount of time, Bow put his reading down, looked straight at her, and said, “Hey, Glim. Are you hungry?”

Glimmer put her book down. “Starving.”

“Feel like getting food?”

“Absolutely.”

Bow led her out of the building, and when the door shut behind them, she grabbed him. It was in these moments that she felt insatiable. She wanted his lips on hers. She wanted his body. She wanted him as a person.

He kissed her, pressing soft, warm lips against hers, held her, and pulled back with a smile. “I was thinking we could teleport in, but if you want, we can do this too.”

He might never understand how attractive she found him at that moment. How he was better than all her other dates. How baffling it was to her that he seemed to understand her on a fundamental level. Glimmer felt like he was on her wavelength. That their brains were riding the same electrons. She was really, really glad she wasn’t a succubus.

She forced herself to pull back away from him. She looked deep into his rich brown eyes and said firmly, “Bow, I’m a demigoddess.”

He blinked, and his voice cracked as he said, “What?”

She grabbed his shoulders. “Worship me, baby,” and teleported them both into the forbidden archive.

Kneel

Chapter Summary

> Adora and Glimmer make some bad choices, and we meet a lot of new vampires!

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

It was the night before the full moon.

Glimmer had woken up each night and driven Bow to the headquarters while staring at the moon whenever it peeked through the trees. She was now fully aware of the moon's phase and its place in the sky at all times.

Tonight the moon was almost full and was going to set late into the night. It would be a perfect night for galavanting across town, showing Bow all the different places she could teleport. Instead, she used her amazing awesome power to secretly teleport them both into the forbidden archive again.

Glimmer turned to the next book on the shelf. Forbidden things were supposed to be fun, at least exciting, but the forbidden archive was just like the normal archive, except they didn't have anyone to curate their reading. It was just a big room with lots of shelves and books upon books upon books.

It had been nights since they first dropped in here, and she had only gotten through one shelf. It didn't help that they could only reasonably be away from Lance and George when they had an excuse during their lunch and dinner breaks. If they wanted to actually eat, it cut into their time. Glimmer looked down the line at all the books on the shelves and said aloud, "This is going to take years."

Bow smiled at her from the other side of the shelves between the books. “Lance always says, if you’re lucky, it takes a whole lifetime.” He grabbed his next book.

Glimmer groaned. Maybe there was a seeking spell to help her find the information they needed. Maybe there was a shortcut. Maybe there was something that would keep her from dying of boredom.

Her phone buzzed in her pocket. A glance to know it was Adora calling, and she picked it up. “Are you guys ok?”

Adora made a distracted noise on the other end of the phone before ignoring the question altogether and saying, in the most awkward fashion, “Glimmer, I need... I need you to help me grab some things.”

Bow looked up, and Glimmer gave him the “all ok” sign, and he returned to reading. She turned away to focus on the phone. “Like what?”

Adora’s voice got quiet. Conspiratorial. “Can you... come get me so I can get my car? Just make sure your dad isn't at the apartment first. I have to get something there too.”

Glimmer raised an eyebrow. “Sure. I’ll come get you two in a few minutes.”

In a whisper, Adora let out a breath and said, “Just get me. Catra’s busy.”

“Ok. Give me a second. I’ll be there in a flash.” She looked up at Bow between the books. “Hey, I’m popping out for a moment.”

Bow looked up just as she popped out.

She checked the apartment, the area around, and then popped in to grab Adora.

A while later, she watched Adora stuff the box of toys into the trunk of her car.

Glimmer folded her arms and leaned on the car. “I should have known it was about sex.”

Adora’s cheeks flushed. “I’m sorry?”

Glimmer shook her head and waved a hand in dismissal. “No, it’s fine. Probably a sign you two are comfortable and safe, right?”

Adora stared back at Glimmer with a frozen expression, like she was trying very hard not to reveal anything.

Glimmer’s heart sank. “Are you ok? Is the cave dangerous?”

“We’re fine. The cave is fine.” The act crumbled as she turned around and leaned against the car next to Glimmer. “Ok, it’s not fine. I mean, the cave is fine, but the situation...” Adora looked tired.

Glimmer sighed. Catra had told her everything about this upcoming meeting. Told her that Adora was doing a bad job of hiding the fact that she was scared shitless. “Do you want Bow and me there? We can be there too.”

Adora’s body got stiff. “Oh no. Absolutely not.” She turned to look Glimmer in the eye. Her eyes flickered from Glimmer’s neck, then back to her face for a moment. “You’re very delicious looking.”

Glimmer felt her face heat up. “Gee. Thanks.”

“I mean your hair, the fact that you’re different. It’s very... Alluring.”

Damn Adora. Way to make a girl’s heart flutter. “Again, thank you.”

Adora closed her eyes and looked away, letting out a long breath. “No, I mean... I don’t know who will be there, and the last thing I

want is for them to take one look at you, realize what you are, whatever that is, and- and...” She shook her head and clenched a fist. “No. I want you as far away from this meeting as possible.”

“Bow could go.”

Adora’s shoulders dropped. “Two problems with that. First, I’d have to mark him and... I don’t think that would go over well with the Order. And second...” She took a deep breath. “If anything happened to him... I don’t know if I could live with myself.”

Glimmer put a hand on Adora’s shoulder. “How about this, you keep me on speed dial. If anything goes wrong, I pop in and take you and Catra away.”

A smile bloomed on Adora’s face. “I like it. Like a failsafe.”

Glimmer smiled. “Exactly like a failsafe.”

Adora’s smile got big and dumb, like all the worry instantly fell off her. She reached forward and pulled Glimmer into a hug. “Thank you.”

Glimmer hugged her back, thinking about what Adora had said. Thinking about Adora calling her alluring. Thinking about what it would be like to be “marked”. *Hm...*

Adora pulled back and clenched her jaw. A strained smile on her face.

“You’re holding yourself back from biting, aren’t you?”

Adora squeaked, “Yeah.”

Glimmer pulled back the rest of the way, feeling guilty. “Sorry.”

“It’s ok. If I couldn't hold myself back, where would I be, right?” She laughed nervously.

Glimmer smiled softly at her. She couldn't imagine how her dad thought this was a monster. This Adora, who was so careful. This Adora, who was so worried about doing the wrong thing. This Adora, who was willing to face death to hold on to a position she didn't want in order to save humanity. If she could find a way of introducing her dad to *this* Adora, he'd understand.

"How's the research going?"

Glimmer sighed and collapsed against the car. "Oh. Well... Good and bad. Regular searching hasn't come up with anything. Bow and I don't think it ever will, so I've teleported us into the forbidden archive."

Adora's body went stiff. "You what?"

Glimmer shrugged. "It makes sense. If your uncle came up with that whole plot, then the information to do it was probably in the one place he had access to that no one else did."

Adora shook her head. "I don't like this."

Glimmer frowned. "I don't either. I thought it'd be faster, but- without a guide, it's-" Her brain came to a complete halt. What she and Bow needed was a guide. Someone who knew a way around the *forbidden* archive. They just so happen to know a dead necromancer who had found all this information once before. Temporary partial resurrection was possible. The necromancer himself proved that. Oh, Bow would think this was a dangerous idea, taking a necromancer that tried to kill them and putting him back in a forbidden archive. But... there were ways to make it safer. If that man could manage an illusion spell while nearly dead, then she could do it fully powered. She just needed a drop of Adora's blood to make it all possible.

"Glimmer?" Adora's voice was small. Worried.

Glimmer snapped back to reality. "What?"

"You... went quiet there for a moment."

Glimmer turned her attention to Adora. “I need a favor.”

Adora stared at her.

Glimmer pushed off the car, pulled out the spell book tucked into her bra.

Adora frowned.

Glimmer flipped the book open to the resurrection spell and the dried-up used-up blood in the corner of the page. “I need... a drop of your blood.”

Adora whimpered. “Why?”

Glimmer looked up, meeting Adora’s eye. “I’m going to temporarily resurrect your uncle and put him under an illusion to help us find this information.”

Adora winced.

“It’s the only way to do this in any length of time that matters. He had decades to do what we’re trying to do in weeks. I know this is a big ask. I just... I need to ask you to trust me.”

Adora looked at her with those steel gray-blue eyes and pleaded silently.

“Let me practice resurrection on your horrible uncle so I can get it right when we try to bring back your brother.”

That was low. Glimmer knew that was low, but it was true.

Adora took a deep breath. Her eyes shifted red, and she opened her mouth to reveal a fang. She brought up the heel of her hand and nicked it.

Glimmer held out the page to catch the fresh blood on the spot where the old drop had been. Adora’s blood was thick. Dark.

Glimmer felt a buzzing in her chest of barely contained exuberance. “Thank you.”

Adora licked her wound and put her lips around it. She leveled her red eyes on Glimmer, unblinking.

Glimmer crumpled under that look. The eyes on her were hungry. Desperate. It was thrilling. But she felt something else that was thrilling. She felt electricity that wasn’t unlike what was flowing through the catacombs. Now that she was attuned to it, she felt it radiating off Adora. “Oh, wow. Are all vampires magic like this?”

Adora pulled her hand away from her mouth. “Like what?”

How to put something like that in words? It was impossible. It didn’t help that Glimmer felt curiosity digging into her brain. She wanted to dissect that power. She wanted to play with it. Feel it. The feeling overwhelmed her. She shook her head. “Nevermind. Good luck with the meeting. Tell Catra I said hi.” And she teleported out.

***

Catra walked with a grim determination while her chest burned with rage. She had texted Adora’s phone. No response. She had called. Gone to voicemail. She called Adora’s name through the cave, using her flashlight to look in every fucking nook and cranny Adora could fit in. Her Horde Lord, the one she was tasked with protecting, was fucking gone. “Adora!” She yelled, “Show your fucking face! Prove to me you’re alive because I fucking love you, and losing you would make me go on a rampage that the world does not want to see!”

The cat was following behind her. Never getting too close, but also never getting too far away.

Catra huffed as the thing started meowing. It was a high-pitched sound. Needy. Like a cat trying to get into a bathroom when its owner had disappeared from sight. “Yeah, I’m sorry! I lost your little cat crush! Ok!” She rounded on the thing.

The air cracked, and the worried cat turned into a lioness. The lioness's eyes were wide. It was growling, with bared teeth.

Catra was done with this shit. She leaned forward, offering her head. "Go ahead. Rip my head off if you're going to."

The lioness flinched, cutting off the growl suddenly.

Catra sneered and stood back up. "I thought so. All show, no bite." She looked the lioness over. "Why haven't you done this in front of Adora?"

The lioness took a step back. Head lowering. Unsure of itself.

Catra raised an eyebrow. The thing was cautious of her, which wasn't helping anyone. Maybe this thing could sniff Adora out. Maybe it could be an ally. She took a breath and tried to calm herself down. She looked at the ground, just next to the lioness's feet, and held out her hand the same way Razz had taught her to introduce herself to a new horse.

The lioness made a noise deep in her throat that reverberated around the cave as she moved in and gently got her nose near Catra's hand. After a moment, the animal gave her a cautious lick.

Catra knew exactly what she felt. Serotonin. Sero-fucking-tonin. She got the same feeling when the first horse had come to her for the first time.

The animal cautiously pushed a cheek into Catra's palm, and Catra obliged by curling her fingers to scratch. Catra smiled as the thing started purring as it leaned in harder. She smiled because lionesses couldn't purr. This thing was a cat pretending to be a lioness. "See, I'm not so bad. A little angry sometimes, but I'm only violent to bullies." More scratches. Deeper purring. "Maybe now that we're friends, you'll stop hitting on my girlfriend."

The animal made a huff and pulled away.

Catra's smile was gone. "Wait... Did you understand me?"

They were both interrupted by the sound of the engine of a car driving up outside the cave. Catra *knew* the sound of that engine. She *knew* the sound of that door slamming. Catra felt the hot anger well up in her again and turned to walk toward the cave entrance, down the long passage that went to the outside. When she glanced back to see if the lioness was following, it was a cat trotting alongside her, tail up, making happy cat noises like it was about to be fed.

They reached the entrance just as Adora approached, her arms full of the missing toy box and a few shopping bags hanging off her arm.

Catra was going to be angry. Going to be furious, but those shopping bags got her attention. They were generic. The kind you get from a small independent store, and there was only one that she knew of that used these black opaque bags, specifically so they wouldn't show what was inside them. Her insides turned to jelly. “Where the fuck have you been?” Her voice ended up sounding way softer than she intended.

The cat went straight up to Adora, purring and rubbing against her legs, marking her scent all over, claiming her.

Adora flashed Catra a smile. “I was hungry. I asked Glimmer to help me get the car, and I got the toys, and then I drove around till I could find a farm.” She walked past them.

Catra, now helplessly interested in what was in the bags, followed.

As she walked, the cat tried its best to get in Adora’s way.

“It took a lot longer than it normally does to find a farm with cows in it.” Adora sounded cheerful.

“You didn’t answer my texts or calls.”

“Oh! Yeah. My phone died while I was driving back.”

“A likely story.” Catra’s eyes were on the bags.

Adora put everything down and then faced her with a confident lopsided smile that weakened Catra’s knees. Adora raised an eyebrow and revealed a riding crop in her hand. “And, I got some new toys.”

Catra felt warm all over. Without looking at the cat, she waved at it and said, “Scram, kitty cat. Mama's got some disciplining to do.”

The cat hissed.

Catra, furious, turned to it, ready to hiss back when she realized it wasn’t looking at her. Its back was arched. Hair on end. Its tail was poofed out, making it four times its normal size.

Adora and Catra looked at the front of the cave, where the animal was hissing.

There was a group of people walking toward them.

Adora dropped the bags and bent down to draw up the broken sword in the new scabbard they had made the last few days. It would do nothing, but its threat was more than enough to get results. She turned back, fangs out, eyes burning red.

Catra threw herself in front of Adora, reaching into her coat and pulling out a stake in one hand. Angella’s silver rings slid onto the fingers in the other with practiced efficiency. She squared her shoulders and demanded, “Who goes there?”

The answering call was laughter. Deep, maniacal, and amused laughter.

With a forcefulness Catra had never experienced before, Adora growled, “Who are you, and what do you want?”

The group stopped moving forward as soon as she addressed them.

The laughter died down. “Oh, no. I’m sorry. The laundry on the floor for a bed was too much.”

Catra brought up her flashlight to reveal a woman stepping from between the gathered crowd. The woman had long, straight white hair that fell over big 80s shoulder pads. Her dress was short and purple, with a black belt. The woman curtseyed. “Oh, gracious Horde Lord. Forgive me for surprising you, but I thought you’d want your clan to help you prepare for tomorrow's meeting.”

“Clan?” Catra said as she glanced back at Adora.

Adora’s fear had faded into surprise. She looked back at Catra and shook her head. Shrugged, then regarded the group. “I don’t have a Clan.”

The woman came out of the deep curtsey. “Oh, but you do.” She put one hand on her hip, and another she held out to gesture toward the others. “We kicked out your sire, but you were always one of us.” She put her hand down, and her smile faded. “Also, I figured you’d either be here, and we could help, or you’d have skipped town, and we could clean the place up and maybe set up an imposter.”

Catra smiled, wide and knowing. “Adora, I think I like them.”

Adora stepped forward, the scabbard held ready. “Why go through the trouble?”

The woman shrugged and folded her arms. “You’re too young to have experienced the civil war last time the position was vacated without a clear heir. It’s best to avoid all that.”

Catra added, “I’m sure it doesn’t hurt to have someone from your clan in power either.”

The woman gave a slight smile back. “Well, there are perks.”

Adora frowned. “No need for imposters. I’m no coward.”

The woman stepped forward, one of those too tense to be genuine smiles on her face. “Then we will move on to plan B, making you act like a proper Horde Lord before the meeting tomorrow.”

Catra pulled back and turned to Adora to whisper into her ear. “I say we give them a chance. You keep your sword on you at all times, and- we both keep an eye on them.”

“Are you sure?” Adora asked under her breath.

“You and I are at a severe lack of allies. It would be nice to have someone who knows how things work.”

Adora agreed with a slight nod. Catra stepped back.

The woman took a single step forward, offering her hand to her Horde Lord. “I am Lyn. At your service.”

Adora, cautiously, let go of the scabbard with one hand and held it out to take the woman’s hand and shake it. Before she could do anything about it, the woman turned her hand to kiss Adora's knuckles. Which... caused Adora’s cheeks to flush.

The woman added, “You may know me better by the name the hunters gave me. Evil-Lyn.”

Adora made a noise, deep in her chest, of deep and abiding discomfort as she pulled her hand away as if she had touched something unclean.

Evil-Lyn smiled at her with deep red lipstick and overdone eighties makeup. “Don’t worry. I don’t bite. Not anymore.”

***

The rest of the night was a flurry of activity. Clan members cleared away the laundry mattress, swept up Prime’s ashes, and cleaned up the place. Others went out to buy things, while Lyn

herself focused on Adora. Lyn gave Adora a rundown of dos and don’ts.

Lyn said a lot of shit Catra didn’t care to listen to because the damn cat was hanging around her now. Lingering at her feet. Shying away from the vampires, hissing at them and ducking behind Catra’s legs. Catra was on cat babysitting duty while Adora, like the good little soldier she was, learned how to be a commander. Or, at least, how to act like one.

Eventually, Lyn’s attention turned to Catra. “A hunter pet will surely raise some eyebrows.” She walked around Catra, the cat hissing at her the whole way. “I suspect Shadow Weaver never taught you what being a vampire’s pet really means?”

Catra sneered at the name.

The woman smiled at that. “Then, let me enlighten you. A pet’s purpose is to serve the whims of its owner. To follow orders. To be devoted and loyal. And yes, to protect your vampire master.”

“No problem. Already there,” Catra said.

“You are Adora’s eyes and ears. Her hands. Her feet. An extension of her and her power. Your blood is hers. Pets are expected to give themselves up willingly if their owners are starving, assuming that they will be turned afterward, but that doesn’t always happen.” She gave a coy smile. “A good enough incentive for pets to help their owner get meals.” She turned away before she could see Catra’s reaction. “You can not act on your own without her directing you. If she says kill, you must kill. If she says stay, you must stay. If you are insubordinate in any way, she will be a laughing stock for not being able to even keep her pets in line.”

A laughing stock. Those words reverberated in Catra’s brain. After everything they’d been through, she didn’t want to be the weak link in this relationship.

Lyn showed them that up the stairs and behind the throne was a hidden suite of rooms. They had been Prime’s private quarters

(for him and his own pets), and when Lyn and the others left, Adora and Catra were able to lock the door and relax.

As the sun started rising, Adora and Catra stripped to get in bed and lay on freshly cleaned silk sheets.

The cat jumped up, landing between them, kneaded the blanket, and settled at Adora's hips.

Adora bit her lip in the faint light of the room. "Glimmer offered to pop in and save us if things went bad."

Catra smiled back. "Of course she did."

Adora took Catra's hand and pulled it to her lips. She placed a delicate kiss on Catra's palm before saying, "I feel better about tomorrow."

"We're going to kick this meeting's ass."

Adora smiled genuinely at that. "Yeah." The word was faint as the sun rose, and Adora slipped into day-sleep.

The cat purred between them. The box of toys was discreetly pushed into a corner along with the bags. Catra forced herself to close her eyes. Things better go well tomorrow because she would have a hell of a time convincing Glimmer to come back and get that shit for her.

***

Adora was hugging the cat because it was the only thing that calmed her down. The cat rubbed itself against Adora's bosom.

Catra watched that cat rub its scent all over her girlfriend's chest, and... and... at this point, she didn't care. Whatever Adora needed to calm down, she'd take it. "Did you charge your phone?"

"Yes."

“You got Glim on speed dial?”

“Yes.”

Catra smiled, wide and genuine. “Don’t worry. We got this.”

Adora took a breath and looked back toward the door. “How many are there?”

“The cave is getting full. I didn’t realize vampires could climb on the walls, but babe, they’re climbing all over the walls to get a better view.”

Adora frowned.

“You’ll be fine. You got the sword. No one will dare come against you with that. Just don’t accidentally draw it.”

Adora nodded. Her frown fading as the hard shell of Hero Adora started to take over. She put the cat down, let it run away from her, and stood up. “Ok. Let's go.”

The sound of the throng amassed outside the door grew as they went toward the entrance.

Adora’s shell hardened as she walked, her sword in her hand.

Catra shut the door behind them, gently pushing the cat back as it tried to follow.

Adora stepped out first and walked with something faking confidence out onto the landing that led to the throne. Catra followed, and as they walked, the room went deadly silent. The only sounds that could be heard were their footsteps and the various pieces of silverware that Catra had sewed to her jacket, hung around her neck, and stuffed in every pocket.

The silence wasn’t reverence but shock. The greatest vampire hunter to ever live was there in the flesh as Lord of the Vampire

Horde. She didn't run away. She came and stood before them, ready for anything.

And then all eyes went to that fucking sword.

In that silence, Adora took her throne and draped the sword on her lap with one hand on the scabbard and one hand on the hilt. The room filled with gasps as she touched the metal of that hilt like they all expected her to burst into flames.

Catra took her place at Adora's right side.

Below them, at the foot of the stairs, thirteen people stood apart from the rest. The heads of the families, Catra guessed since one of them was Lyn. On the other side, Hordak stood stoic. Next to him was a vampire with fangs on both the top and bottom. He was covered in hair, to the point that he looked like a caveman vampire. He looked nervous, anxious, or angry. Maybe all three. *How old must he be* , Catra thought. *Ancient? Older than ancient?* With that kind of age came power that she couldn't even imagine. Catra's eyes slid to the back wall past him. For her, the caveman vampire and the crowd faded. Right there were all of Prime's trophies all in their places, on shelves and pegs as if they never moved. She didn't remember Lyn talking about them. She didn't see anyone putting them back. She was distracted by this mystery as Adora addressed the crowd.

Adora took a breath and said the words that Lyn told her to say. "I convene the first meeting of my reign."

And the hairy dude next to Hordak took a step forward and held an accusatory finger toward Adora. "Not so fast! We have not accepted you yet."

So early, and Catra was already thankful she had armored herself in silver. The first sign of trouble, she'd just have to get in the way and be a burning wall of 'fuck you'. Angella's care and protection extended through dinnerware.

Adora's shell didn't crack as she turned her eyes to him.

The man was shaking as he spoke, either out of fear or anger, but his accusation seemed to break the spell of quietness around them. The room erupted into noise of objections and anger.

Hordak raised his hand, and some of the people quieted down. He spoke loudly to talk over those who weren't. "By every right, she has a chance to earn our loyalty."

The hairy man turned on him. "Oh, interesting that you would come out to support the woman who killed your sire and master!"

Hordak's fangs bared. His eyes burned red. "My sire was a tyrant!" He turned to those assembled. "We are all the better for his death, and I will be the first to say it." He then turned his full attention to Adora. "I knew Adora before her ascension. She has proven to my clan and me that she is worthy. I believe in her vision, so I pledge the loyalty of my clan."

People turned around to people they knew and whispered. People gasping in shock.

Catra revised her opinion of this guy. As much as she considered him a coward for not helping out more, this was more than she expected.

Hordak turned to the other leaders. They wouldn't meet his gaze.

Hairy dude stepped forward, trying to glare everyone down. "I will not pledge my or my clan's loyalty. Not till I am satisfied." He turned to Adora, his body rippling with adrenaline.

Catra took a half step between him and Adora. Not enough to block him, but enough to show him she was going to stop anything he was planning.

He got right up to the steps. His eyes never left Adora. "The horde has lost forty percent of its membership after your ascension."

At that, Adora stood up, and the room flinched. Adora took a breath. "A temporary problem. Once they see how safe being in

the Horde is, how they can feed safely off livestock- they will return, and I will accept them with open arms."

The room filled with murmurs.

Harry dude scoffed and turned toward the gathered Horde. "Open arms! Arms that are currently occupied by a hunter's weapon! A weapon she dares to bring in this sanctum as a threat to us all."

At this, Lyn cut in. "Oh, shut up, Grizzlor. Everyone expected her to bring the sword. If she didn't, half of you would have been disappointed."

A few of those gathered laughed.

Grizzlor turned toward the laughter and growled. He then turned to address Adora again. "I raise that your edict will cause us all to either die or break your law."

Adora's shell cracked. "What do you mean?" The words came out in a tone that showed she was genuinely confused.

Shit.

He snarled a smile, showing off his teeth, catching the fact that he caught her off guard and reveling in it. "The weather turns cold, and I don't know how they handle cattle, horses, and pigs in the Netherlands, but here, as the weather gets cold, farmers put their animals in barns at night."

Adora blinked.

He turned to the rest of the assembly. "Fantastic trick for a vampire hunter, to become Horde Lord, ban feeding on anything but livestock right before they are put up. You will all have to break into buildings to get your fill. Video cameras. Security systems. Fancy for the hunters to let the police do the hunting for them."

The room erupted into yelling. Shouts of anger. Frustration.

Catra breathed in through her nose, as her jaw clenched. She was tensing up, ready to fight the whole fucking room before they reached Adora. How many vampires were there? Three hundred? Four hundred? Didn't fucking matter. They were all dead if they came up those steps. If this dude put one foot on the step in front of him, it was all over. She didn't care about propriety. She didn't care about what it would look like. She'd murder the asshole.

With a smile that revealed all too much, he turned back to Adora in the chaos and pointed at her. "You, with your hunter's weapon. You, who pretend to come here with a hunter pet. You are not their master but their puppet! That pet controls you!"

That made the gathered crowd erupt. The noise in the room was deafening.

Catra sneered. She felt the heat of the furnace of a fire in her gut. She could have attacked him right there and then, caused an international incident, and... made Adora into a laughing stock.

You can't think when you're angry , she thought. *Angry makes you stupid.*

She ran her fingers through her hair to ground her, stopping her from rashly doing anything. Instead of murdering the head of one of the clans, she turned to look at Adora, expecting either a command to kill or a command to stay. She desperately wanted the command to kill. Every inch of her begged for it. What would be best but a show of strength? Sicking your pet on one of the older more powerful assholes who thinks he's above reproach? She looked back to Adora begging, pleading. She needed something, baby.

Hero Adora was cracking. The look on Adora's face was starting to seep into panic as she lost control of the room. Then, her eyes fell on Catra. Locked on.

Catra saw something in Adora's face. A hardening. A resolution of will. She saw the years of hunter training dragging itself out of

Adora's fear, planting itself, and making the woman look like a goddamn goddess.

Adora clenched her jaw and squared her shoulders. In a low controlled voice that made Catra's insides quiver, she commanded, "Kneel."

Catra forgot her anger. She forgot her sense of self. Catra felt the wave of that command hit her, and she uttered, "Mommy," before falling to her knees before her girlfriend... and heard everyone else do it too.

The clan leaders obeyed. For all their bluster, they still knew their place, knew the danger of that sword in Adora's hands. They were still scared of her and they revealed it in an instant of impulsive reaction.

Catra kept her eyes on Adora and felt her heart flutter as her girlfriend gained a smirk as she realized what had happened. She kept Catra's eye and said, in quiet sweet buttery tones, "Good girl."

Catra nearly came in front of all those people. She felt lightning strike down her spine, straight to her cunt. In the sudden quiet of that cave, she whimpered and knew that every ear heard her do it. She didn't care.

Adora looked away from her. Hero Adora was back. Her chin was high. Her confidence was dripping off her. "I understand the concern. By the full moon next month, I will find a solution to the winter feeding problem, or I will release the ban." Her look bore down on Grizzlor. "If I can do that, will you pledge you and your clan's loyalty to me?"

He struggled to speak under that gaze on his knees like everyone else but eventually let out a soft, "Yes..."

Adora turned to the other leaders. "Does this satisfy the rest of you as well?"

They nodded.

Adora smirked and looked down at them. “Good. Then I adjourn this meeting. I will see the Clan leaders next month for your loyalty pledges.”

Catra squeezed her knees together, because that fucking line, delivered with such confidence, was too much. She wanted friction. She wanted release, and she fucking wanted Adora to fucking tell her what she wanted already.

She didn’t have to wait long.

The meeting was over, just like that. People started leaving, as fast as possible. Maybe it was to get out of the sight of the sword. Maybe it was because they were all ashamed of kneeling so easily. It didn’t fucking matter. Within a few minutes, everyone, even Adora’s clan, were gone.

Adora held that smirk until everyone had left, guided Catra into their rooms, and gently put the cat out.

Catra was in a daze. Her self-control was already gone. Her libido already taking over.

Adora turned on her, fangs out. Eyes red.

Catra’s heart pounded in her chest. Her skin crawled to be bit. Her blood screamed to be given. She was a mess. An absolute mess and she rushed to pull off all the silver into a pile far away from her Horde Lord. She was no longer a weapon. She had to disarm. She was, instead, a toy, and that thought made her soak her pants.

Adora watched her, hungry. Longing. Loving. She shut the door to the rooms securely, and behind her back, ticked the lock before wiping her drooling mouth. Her voice deep and husky, dripping with desire, she commanded, “Kneel for me again, kitten.”

Catra whimpered as her body reacted with throbbing tingling joy. “Yes, Princess.” She fell to her knees, helplessly. Whimpering. Wanting nothing but to give. To please.

Adora moved forward, touching Catra’s jaw gently, and possessively. “Oh kitten, you were so good for me.” She was already out of breath as her thumb moved across Catra’s lips. “ You deserve a reward.”

Catra could have died happy, finally, as she opened her mouth to accept Adora’s probing thumb.

Chapter End Notes

> Next chapter, we will get some smut. If that’s not your thing, I’ll make it easily skippable.

Applesauce

Chapter Summary

> Adora finally allows herself to want. Catra has a bootlicking good time. Micah does not. Glimmer uses her feminine wiles and project management to get what she wants.

Chapter Notes

> The first scene is smut. If that's not your thing, skip to "Catra grunted into the warmth of that hold."

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Catra felt like she was afloat in warm water. Her brain was a soup of chemicals. The prodding of Adora's thumb was invasive and deep, making her want to gag, and she loved every second of it.

For all her bluster in the meeting before, Adora looked like she was coming apart at the seams with desire. Her fangs seemed to strain in her mouth. Her red eyes had exploded into dark, dilated pools. "Baby," she whimpered.

Catra forced her eyes to open wide and looked at her Horde Lord with rapt attention. As hot as it was to see Hero Adora command a whole room of vampires, watching that same woman fall apart at Catra's sublimation was the most erotic thing Catra had ever witnessed.

"I need your word," Adora said in a rush. Her breathing erratic. Her hands slightly trembling. "Your safe word."

Catra had one that was her go-to. One that she had never once uttered during a scene. Around Adora's thumb, she said, "Applesauce."

Adora swallowed. She nodded. Her thumb pulled out as she closed her eyes and caressed Catra's face. "I want to use you,

baby...” She said, helpless. “...But not hurt you. Use it if I go too far.”

Catra’s eyes closed. That’s what she wanted. To be used. Shit, consensually used. She opened her eyes as Adora lost her fight with holding herself back.

Adora’s breathing was ragged. “But first...” Her thumb went back aggressively, pressing down on Catra’s tongue. “My boots are dirty.”

Catra couldn’t suppress a smile. She immediately dropped so that her face was on Adora’s boots. Adora’s boots were so clean you could eat off them. She looked up, making eye contact, before sticking out her tongue, and making one long swipe from toe to laces.

Adora shuddered. Her cheeks flushed. She frantically started trying to undo her own pants. Her hands were shaking. Her whole body was shaking. Quivering.

Yes, they had fucked constantly for the last week. Yes, it consisted of only a few sex acts that Adora had researched and felt comfortable with. Adora was always servicing. She wanted it that way. Said it made her more comfortable. Which was fine. Catra was fine with whatever.

But Adora pulled her jeans down to mid-thigh and let out a gasp as she let herself open to the air in front of Catra. She was coming apart at the seams as she motioned for Catra to come back up.

All of a sudden, Catra understood what this past week had been about. Adora had been afraid to want. Afraid to desire, with the threat of impending doom. Adora had dedicated herself to pleasing Catra and lived off the residual high of that, afraid to want anything more. She had been, ultimately, the same repressed pre-victorian lesbian, just patching a wound, thinking she deserved nothing more.

Adora closed her eyes, gritting her teeth, with tears starting to stream down her cheeks, as her hand moved from Catra's face to her neck and pulled Catra's face forward.

Catra, happily, willingly, obliged by offering her tongue, lips, and her whole face. As she found Adora's clit, Adora gasped, shuddered, nearly collapsed, and started rolling her hips.

"Fuck," Adora groaned out loud. "Oh, Fuck!" Her hand gripped the back of Catra's head, holding her there, grinding against her tongue with wanton abandon.

And Catra's heart soared. How long had she waited for "wanton abandon" in her girlfriend? It felt like forever. It was only a few months, but it felt like forever.

Catra had already done this once, but not like this. It had been fast. Adora, she was sure, hadn't been fully prepared for it. It was Adora's first orgasm in her fucking life, and it caught her by surprise.

This... This Adora was prepared for. Wanted. Desperately. Her eyes closed as she rutted, grunted, and edged for friction.

This... this was a world away from that rushed moment outside the hotel. Adora's whole body was into it.

Adora threw her head back. Her mouth open and gasping. Her whole self on edge. Her hand gripped Catra's hair.

A fire consumed Catra, culminating in a throbbing aching in her own body, and all from watching her girlfriend use her.

"Catra?" Adora whimpered.

It wasn't a question but a warning. Adora manages to look down, her eyes silently asking Catra if this is ok because... Catra can feel Adora's clit reacting to her. Can feel the muscles down there tightening and clenching. Her girl is gonna fucking cum, and hard.

Catra is not only ok with it, she's fucking drooling for this. She shows her approval by clamping her lips around Adora's nub and giving it a good, solid suck.

Adora whimpers, and her hand grips Catra's hair harder as she yells. Fucking screams as her body shakes.

Catra keeps going, pushing Adora through her climax till it's over, and Adora lets go of her head.

Adora slumped against the door, pulled away, threw her head back, and cursed in Dutch as if it was a prayer.

Catra, chin dripping with Adora's desire, smiled while looking at the wreck she made of her lover.

Adora took a moment, but her eyes, dark as they are, turned on Catra with that same intense hunger that had been there before.

Catra's insides turned to jelly.

Adora, with an inhuman focus, started shedding her leather jacket. "Kitten," She purrs. "Let me..." She never finished that sentence.

Instead, she picked Catra up by the armpits and tossed her onto the bed.

Catra is weightless for a moment before landing back first on the mattress. The soft silk. She sinks into it. Lavishes against it.

Desperate and hungry, Adora grabbed Catra's boots, socks, and pants.

It's a moment before Catra got the message and saved her favorite Slayer concert shirt from being ripped off her fucking body. She pulled that off on her own before Adora ripped her bra off.

In seconds, Catra is completely naked, open, and exposed, and Adora is heaving to hold herself back.

She crawled onto the bed, forcing Catra's knees open.

Catra looked up.

Adora stopped. She was heaving. Her fangs were stark against her lips. Her eyes were wild. Half in a desire-fueled craze and half-aware of what the fuck she was doing.

Maybe she expected Catra to utter her word. No fucking chance. "Do I please you, Princess?" Catra said instead, her voice breathy.

The words hit Adora like magic, making her eyes roll up and flutter as she opened her mouth and bared her fangs.

Catra has never seen this. Never actually seen Adora's mouth open, her fangs allowed to protrude and exist without her trying to hide them or stuff them into her neck.

It's aggressive, like watching a caged animal drool over food and Catra's fucking into it.

Catra watched, understanding what this meant. What Adora wanted. Her fucking cunt throbbed to give it. "Shit," she said, throwing her head back, closing her eyes.

Adora leaned forward, breathing hot breath into Catra's exposed, sensitive lower lips. That only made Catra's heart jump.

Why did they need a box full of toys when Adora had two perfectly good ones right in her mouth? Catra wanted those fangs in her most intimate of spots. "Fuck yes!"

Adora had never once touched her with her mouth. Not like this. Adora was so cautious of her fangs. She was scared of hurting her girlfriend. Scared that if she let herself go... of what she would do. Catra's heart fluttered. Her fucking self-denying little shit of a lover. Her absolute useless lesbian of a vampire. She could think

of nothing to cure this but saying, “My love, take what you want from me,” and shimmying her hips to get the message across.

Adora, as she was, was more BDSM than most people could handle. Maybe all this time, Adora needed the freedom of knowing that her girlfriend had a safe word. The freedom of limitations.

Adora closed her eyes and leaned in. She fucking whimpered as she tasted her girlfriend’s pussy for the first time. Her whole body eased into it, relaxing into the bed. What Catra felt was surprisingly gentle.

Catra fucking lost it. Adora was so fucking light and delicate. She used only the sides of her fangs to move in ways her lips and tongue couldn’t.

On the best of nights, Catra could last a respectable amount of time with Adora. Not today. Not fucking today. After what happened in front of everyone and what just happened in private... she didn’t last two fucking minutes. Her body let out a grunt as her muscles tightened. Adora gripped her hips and kept pressing, doing for her what she had just done. Pushing her through the shakes, quivers, and grunts that Catra couldn’t hold back.

Catra, sweating and heaving, collapsed onto the bed. Spent. Used up. “Fucking bite me, baby,” she let out in a sigh.

Adora, still breathing heavy, turned her face to Catra’s inner thigh. She opened her mouth.

Catra fucking came again as Adora’s fangs bit the soft, tender skin. Grunting, Catra forced herself to stay still, despite internally everything going nuts. Her insides clamping and shuddering.

Adora made a small bite and sucked on it, savoring the taste.

Catra relaxed, drained from two consecutive world-shattering orgasms. She closed her eyes.

Adora detached and licked the spot to help the bleeding stop. “My good kitten,” she cooed as she suckled the bite. “You did so good.”

Catra felt a bloom in her chest. How did Adora guess she was so weak for praise?

Adora moved up on the bed, wiped her mouth, and started shedding her own clothes before curling up against Catra’s side.

Catra grunted into the warmth of that hold. Of the pleasant feeling of Adora’s slightly sticky skin against hers. Of the sweet and musky scent of their lovemaking.

Adora leaned her head on Catra’s arm and whispered, “Was that ok?”

“Fucking hell, princess. That was more than ok. It was heaven.”

Adora’s hand traced Catra’s face. Her fangs were still out. At this point, it might be hours before they’d go back. But her look was less hungry.

It was a moment before Catra realized tears were dripping out of the corner of Adora’s eyes.

Adora must have seen the look on Catra’s face because she smiled. “I’m sorry. I’m so sorry. I just... I don’t deserve this.”

Catra’s heart leapt back into the game. She turned over to face her lover. “Why?”

Adora closed her eyes and leaned into the pillow. “This whole time, I thought I was going to die tonight.”

“Yeah, idiot. Like I’d let that happen.”

Adora smiled through the tears, and her hand absentmindedly traced Catra’s bare body. “I thought it was the fate I deserved.” Her smile was gone.

Catra moved in, kissing every inch of Adora's skin that she could reach with her mouth. Soft little assuring pecks.

Adora closed her eyes tight. "I've never talked about what it was like when I was first turned." She paused, swallowing. Still not opening her eyes and accepting the kisses even though she flinched like everyone was undeserved. "I was a blank slate. My memories were gone. I didn't know any better."

Catra moved her body close, putting her hands on her girlfriend's skin. She knew what was coming. Or, at least, she had a really good guess.

Adora pulled her in. "For the first hundred years... I enjoyed it. Hunting. Feeding. It was exhilarating. Even fun..." She winced and pulled Catra in so tight that Catra couldn't kiss any longer. "I still dream about it..." She breathed raggedly. "And this... felt... similar." It was hard for her to get those words out. Hard for her to admit this.

Ah, there it was. The underlying cause of Adora's self-doubt and fears. For Adora, as a vampire, desiring another woman was a violent act. Her brain mixed up her body's signals for hunger and physical pleasure because they had been the same thing for two hundred years. Now, she equated those feelings to shame. Catra relaxed into the hold. "The thing that got me in juvie... I enjoyed that too. It was bad. My worst moment, and I fucking loved every second of it. I dream about it too."

Adora opened her eyes and pulled back to look Catra in the eye, her hand tracing Catra's cheek. She looked... interested.

Catra smiled warmly. Maybe there was an incredible age difference between them, but they weren't all that different when it came down to it. "I would do it again, given the same circumstances." She reached up, holding Adora's wrist. She closed her eyes. "You were manipulated, abused, and lied to. What you did, baby, it wasn't your fault. Having enjoyed it doesn't make you a bad person. It makes you shockingly human."

Adora relaxed. Her fingers played with Catra's hair. "You really believe all that?"

"Yes."

Adora shifted in the bed. Either uncomfortable with the position or with herself.

Catra moved in. "I don't know what you researched, but sometimes this can make people emotional. Lots of shit you've been holding back comes back in a flood because you're uninhibited. That's cool. That's good. That's a part of the whole thing." Catra pressed her body against Adora's. Legs to legs. Stomach to stomach. Chest to chest. Her head tucked into Adora's shoulder. What her girl needed was aftercare. "Whatever is going on in your head right now, just remind yourself that you deserve to feel good. You are allowed to want and have fun. It's ok."

She felt Adora's body relax. Adora's arm reached around her waist and pulled her further in. "I want to believe you."

"You will."

They felt something small jump onto the bed. Catra opened her eyes as the thing started to purr and push itself between them.

Adora visibly relaxed as she touched its fur and scratched its neck.

Catra's body went stiff. She frowned. "How the hell did you get in?" She sat up to check that the door was still closed. It was. "There's probably a vent or something." She then looked at the animal that had come between them. "Look, kitty cat, you've got to let us have some alone time." She stopped as she looked at the thing. There was something on its paw. She moved closer to check. She reached out to touch it. She knew what that was. That texture. Blood. The animal let her touch its paw and rub her thumb on the spot, smearing the blood around. "What did you do? Get into a fight?"

***

A few moments earlier...

Micah was on the floor on his knees in the master bathroom at his house.

It was the night of the full moon. He had only set his wife's vacation to last through tonight in the hope that she would stay out late in the full moonlight and get something from it. He had intended for all this nasty business with the girls to be cleared up before she came back, and he was running out of time.

The last few days, he had barely slept. Glimmer had not come through in helping him stop Adora. The only explanation he could come up with was that she must be under the monster's influence. Maybe it was true that the beast had never fed on her... or... the fiend had merely put her under before feeding so that his little girl, his sweet little girl, wouldn't remember it. Both of his girls were under that bitch's thumb, and it ate at him. He knew all too well the tactics those monsters did to get close.

He had spent these last few days gathering the reagents he needed. Driving for miles to find the right kind of store to get a rare herb or a specific flower. Days of preparation, and if he couldn't get his hands to stop shaking, it will have been all for nothing.

He fought how blurry his vision was getting. He needed to sleep, but... he needed Catra to be safe first.

With bags under his eyes and a body that screamed for rest, he used his dry concoction to make a sigil on the stone tile floor. At least here, in the bathroom, there was little that could go wrong. The fire wouldn't catch on anything. No one would see him.

He spoke a mix of Korean and Latin, substituting the phrases he knew how to do in either language. His own mix for a seeking spell without the normal limiters. He lit a match with his thumb and looked at it. With this flame, he would find the vampire that

had latched on to his girls. There was nowhere to hide. Nowhere to run.

He forced himself to set the flame to the sigil.

It fizzed and popped. As the flame spread through the symbol, it started glowing a faint blue.

Micah, heedless of the smoke, heedless of anything, leaned in and squinted to see what the seeking spell would show him.

He blinked. A vision coalesced.

What stood before him was a lioness. Wild-eyed. Crazed. It growled, bared its teeth, and threw a massive clawed paw at his face.

Micah's lizard brain reacted faster than he ever could. One hand shot out to put out the flame and scatter the dust, and his body threw him back hard against the wall to avoid the claws. The air was knocked out of his lungs, and his body screamed for oxygen.

He was aware of the coldness of the floor under him. It's hardness. The smoke of his extinguished flame stung his nostrils. He was hyper-aware because, for the first time in decades, he was scared again.

It took him a long moment to feel the sting on his cheek. To reach up, and touch it, and find blood. He held his hand out and stared at the red dripping on his fingers. The lioness was no illusion. That thing had hijacked his spell, had used it to travel. It was here, physically, before he cut off the channel.

He put his hand down, and for a moment, he stared off into space as those facts filtered into his mind. The vampire that had its fangs on his adopted daughter... was strong enough... influential enough, to have that thing on her side, protecting her from magic.

He couldn’t fight that. He clenched his fist. He couldn’t fight that and her. Not alone. His jaw set. He would find help. He didn’t care what it took. How much it cost. There had to be vampire hunters out there somewhere.

He was going to save Catra, come hell or high water.

***

The sun was starting to set.

“I know it sounds crazy... But doesn’t everything sound crazy?”

Bow’s shoulders tensed up as he put his hands under his armpits, making a noise of discomfort.

Glimmer pulled back and looked down at the spell book open between them on the bed at the apartment. “It could go bad, but... I could learn the illusion spell. I could practice. I could get it down really well and learn how to cut off the magic.” That was something she was picking up from the spell book in the last few reads. “The moment anything starts to be weird, I can just- cut off the flow, and he’ll be gone.”

Bow sank into the bed, pulling the blanket over his bare and muscled torso. “It’s bad enough that we’re in there at all.”

“You came up with the idea to go in there!”

Bow winced.

Glimmer backed off. Well, she backed off a little bit. She did put a hand on his beefy thigh under the blanket.

He didn’t flinch.

She was careful with her tone. “At the current rate, it will take us decades to recreate what he did.”

Bow pulled the blanket over his head and groaned.

She thought he would say no again, but instead, she felt his hand cover hers and squeeze.

That little motion was enough. He understood. He agreed, at least a little bit. He just needed... assurances. “I won’t do it if I can’t absolutely master the illusion spell.”

He squeezed her fingers again.

She felt her heart race. “Maybe I could try resurrecting something else temporarily. Like an animal or something... just to get experience.”

Another squeeze.

“I have his notes. I’ll go through the same experiments, except I’ll just skip the ones that didn’t work. I won’t do any of it till I’ve mastered all of it.”

At that, Bow pushed the blanket off his face and looked at her. He took a slow, steady breath and said, “The illusion will have to be really good. As good as it was with us.”

“Yes. Sure.”

“You’ll have to come up with a scenario he would actually believe.”

She squeezed his hand, feeling her heartbeat pick up in her chest. “I will. I’ll run it by you first. You’ll get veto power on everything!”

Bow looked at her with soft puppy dog eyes and smiled. “You really believe this is the right thing to do?”

“It’s the only thing. We’ll get the catacombs thing cleared off, and all those souls will be released, and our conscience will be clear.” She looked away. “And... and you and I will be able to join Catra in her bodyguard duties and just... hang out with our friends for our job for the rest of our lives, and in so doing save humanity.”

A bigger smile bloomed on Bow's face, and he pulled her hand to his bare chest. "It might be the sex appeal, but you're really starting to sell this to me."

Glimmer grabbed the book and put it on the side table before rolling over and engulfing Bow in kisses. He laughed.

When she stopped to look at him, to gauge his level of concern, he settled down.

For a moment, his smile faded, and he looked at her. He looked down and played with the frays of her purple, overly large shirt. "I want you to make an iron-clad risk management plan. I want to see the actual document. I want you to think about every possible way this could go bad and plan for it."

She smiled big and put her hand on his cheek. "You're so sexy when you talk about project management."

She pulled him into a kiss, and he relaxed. She knew then that she had won.

Chapter End Notes

> For those who skipped: The only plot thing you need to know about the smut is that Catra's safe word is "applesauce."

Absolute Power.... Something Something

Chapter Summary

> Catra finds out some of what Adora bought and gets overwhelmed. Adora makes a choice out of fear and desire.

Chapter Notes

> "Dog", Fetch- A natal spirit that was believed to follow and aid a Sabbatarian, a person born on a Saturday, throughout his or her life, empowering them to cure disease and to have great success in fighting the undead... It's name was derived from the preferred shape that the spirit (fetch) adopted, although the Icelandic Fetch (the fylgja) could also appear as a bird, horse, wolf, bear, or dragon.- The Vampire Encyclopedia by Mathew Bunson

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Catra had the haziness she always had when she woke up after a hot night. Like her system had used up too much dopamine and needed time to recover. It could have been called dullness, but she knew the feeling as contentment. Contentment was often destroyed by having to rush out as whatever girl she was with had to prepare themselves for the day ahead.

No, but this morning was different because it was Adora she was next to, and they didn't have to rush anywhere. Sure, it wasn't slow, sensuous sex on the couch in a warm apartment, but it was a lazy morning where nothing much was expected of them, so they could wake up slow.

Except...

Slurp. Slurp. Slurp.

It took Catra a moment to identify the sound. She opened her eyes and found the cat, pressed between her and Adora, licking

the fine new hairs on Adora's forehead like it was cleaning its kitten.

Catra sighed. They weren't exactly alone. She could kick the cat out, but something about the scene made her not want to.

Adora leaned into the licks, still half asleep, like a stray kitten desperately seeking a replacement mother. The cat purred softly.

It was adorable. So adorable that it made her chest ache. What she wouldn't give to wake up like this, with Adora peaceful and happy, for the rest of her life.

She got up and started digging through the extra clothes Glimmer brought her to find something to wear.

The moment her back was turned, Adora's phone went off.

Adora startled awake and earned a chastising slap to the head with an unopened paw. She laid back down for the cat to continue cleaning, reaching for the phone. "It's Bow," she said, sleep still in her voice.

"Put him on speaker phone," Catra said as she pulled on one of her many soft concert shirts. Something black with skulls and ravens on it.

A moment later, Bow's insanely cheery voice broke through the laziness of the morning. "Oh, hey! You're alive and ok!"

Adora closed her eyes. "I'm so sorry. I should have called you both and let you know that the meeting went well."

"It's ok. When you didn't call Glimmer, we assumed you were fine."

Catra pulled on a new pair of old comfortable jeans and offered, "Adora pulled it off perfectly. You wouldn't have believed it. She said 'kneel' and made the whole room go to their knees." Just

remembering it made Catra's insides twitch. That feeling made her turn her attention to the bags in the corner.

"Wow. Pretty impressive!" There was no hint of sarcasm in his voice. In fact, he sounded proud. They heard him start the coffee machine before he asked, "So, anything we need to tell Juliet today?"

Catra's hand, digging through the first bag, landed on something leather. It was thin and had adjustable buckles. Her heart sped up in her chest as she pulled it out. A full-body leather harness. Adjustable. She held it up, desperately interested in which of their bodies would fit better before she realized there was a ring at the crotch. She lost all sense of reason and logic.

Adora responded to Bow. "I'm still in charge. I have a month to solve a problem and... I need help."

"Cool. What with?"

Catra, her head dizzy, carried the harness to Adora on the bed. She sat down and held up the thing she had found. With every ounce of restraint she could manage, she pointed to the ring and mouthed, "Who is this for?"

Adora motioned between them and mouthed "both of us" before turning back to Bow's question.

Catra bit her knuckle as she shook the harness before whispering, "Adora, who's going to be in it?" She needed to know desperately. It wasn't even that it mattered. She could take as much as give, but damn... damn, she had a preference and hoped Adora was thinking the same.

Adora's face got stern, and she pointed to the phone before talking loudly to Bow, "In the winter, the livestock get put up. The Horde is worried about how they're supposed to feed. Worried that they'll be in danger if they break into barns."

Catra turned away, her body producing a shocking desire for just having woken up. She decided it could wait, so she went to the bags again. There were three of them. What else could Adora have gotten? The possibilities were dizzying.

The cat meowed and hit Adora in the head to make her still.

Adora laid back stiff as death for the animal.

"Aw! Is that the cat Glimmer was telling me about?" Bow's voice went up an octave.

Catra smiled to herself. Her roommates, all of them, were the type to go nuts over a little fluffy animal. Of course, Bow loved the cat and hadn't even met it. Of course, Glimmer told him about it immediately.

Adora replied, a little frustrated, "Yes, it's the cat."

"I'm glad it's adopted the two of you. Seems like a good comfort in the middle of all this. Have you named it yet?"

Catra's hand reached something else, but her mind and ears were on Adora.

Adora responded too fast. "Oh, yes. I've been giving this lots of thought, and I've decided its name is *Melig* ." She then gave the cat above her direct eye contact, like she was making a point. "It's Dutch for mealy, but also corny. Like someone laughing for a really long time about something stupid."

Catra looked back to the bags and smiled wide. Yes, her stupid girlfriend was making a sarcastic comment to a cat about how it was "not funny," but this was how names happened. You make a funny comment once, and the name sticks, and there's no changing it after that.

"Melig. I like it," Bow said with a smile. "You know, I wonder... Do you think that cat could be your fetch?"

Catra felt the distinct sensation of latex under her fingertips, and she pulled out a full-body black latex suit. Her brain was swamped with the dizzying effects of imagining Adora in that suit. *What the hell?*

"What's a fetch?" Adora asked as she reached up to the cat and started scratching it.

"Kind of like a familiar. A spirit guide for hunters. It protected them from magic and gave them a boost against the undead. They were popular before the order fell out of love with magic. Anyway, all the important families had one. It's usually a dog, or a bird or something. I'm sure your family would have had one. In fact, it would be shocking if they didn't. Maybe... I don't know... maybe something about the sword made it go away, and now that the sword is..." Bow stopped himself and let that part linger unsaid. "Just, real quick, have you ever seen this cat eat? It could be magical."

Catra stood up and looked at the damn cat. The damn magical cat that she had seen on at least two occasions turn into a lioness. A damn cat that seemed to hate all vampires, except Adora.

Adora gave a long, tired, exasperated sigh. "Bow, it's just a cat. It's very cute, but it hasn't done anything anyone would describe as magical."

Like hell it was just a cat. Catra glared at it and found its knowing mismatched eyes looking back at her. Looking straight back at her, with a warning behind them, as if it was just waiting for her to snitch. Its claws stretched in and out of its paws, just waiting to be used. Was that a threat? Was she being threatened by a magical cat? Well, fuck that. Catra wasn't a snitch. If the damn thing wanted to keep this a secret from Adora, then it could, but damn... that's quite a secret.

"Maybe just keep an eye out for anything weird about it," Bow added.

“Sure.” Adora kept scratching the animal's fur, unaware of the death stare it gave her girlfriend. “Back to the point. I need everything the hunters have on the problem of winter feeding. Surely, Juliet has some resources she can pull or... I don’t know... get a group of hunters together to brainstorm.”

“Will do. What about a time frame?”

“I need something that will work by the next full moon.”

“No problem. We’ll all get right on it.” They could hear the smile in Bow’s voice. “You and Catra, be careful. Just because the meeting went well doesn’t mean you’re out of danger.”

“No kidding,” Catra said, staring straight back at the cat before it went back to licking Adora’s forehead like nothing happened.

Adora thanked Bow, said her goodbye, and hung up.

Catra pulled up the latex suit and held it out like a scarecrow. “A fucking latex suit? Goddamn Adora, what has gotten into you, and can it be me?”

Adora’s eyes brightened up. She developed a smile that would have slain millions. “You like it?”

Catra’s mouth went dry. “Like it? Hell no, I don’t like it.”

Adora started to frown.

“I fucking love it!” Catra pulled the thing to her chest and looked Adora over. “But I’m serious. How the hell did you go from where you were to this?”

Adora’s look shifted to a cocky smile. “I’ve been researching, and that’s all you need to know. A girl’s gotta have her secrets. Makes me more... *mysterious* .”

Catra knew the look that was on her own face. A soft smile. A soft, vulnerable, and loving look. “You asked the woman at the

counter for recommendations, didn't you?”

Adora’s confidence dropped.

“Big buff woman with long white hair in a ponytail and purple tattoos all over.”

Adora’s eyes went wide with recognition and shock.

Adora didn’t know it, but she had just met one of Catra’s many exes. Huntara. The best dom Catra had ever had. The woman who showed Catra the ropes, as it were. But Adora didn’t need to know that. Didn’t need to have the wind stolen from her sails like that. The idea that Huntara, of all people, gave Adora tips... The idea was maddening. Sexy. It was the best thing she had heard all week. No wonder her girlfriend fucking hit it out of the park last night. She threw the latex suit aside and fell forward, laying down on Adora’s body and stuffing her face into her girlfriend’s breasts. “I’m in heaven,” she mumbled into Adora’s hard stomach, intentionally tickling her with her lips.

Adora giggled and reached to stop her.

This was how half their love-making started. A tease, a push, a giggle, and suddenly they were rolling over each other and playing wrestling till someone got fucked. That’s how it would have gone if someone hadn’t interrupted them by knocking on the door.

The giggling stopped instantly. The cat stopped licking.

Catra got up to get her stake. Adora got up to get her sword.

The cat got up too. The hairs on its back stood up.

“Who is it?” Adora called out once the scabbard was in her hands.

“It’s Lyn. We have urgent business to attend to.”

Adora and Catra exchanged glances.

Adora’s face looked painfully sad.

Catra wanted to wipe that sadness off her face with everything she had, so she whispered, “Later, princess. We can play later.”

Adora’s cheeks flushed red, and she turned to the door. “We'll be out in a minute.”

***

The cave had taken on a cold but damp atmosphere since last night as if the world were driving home the fact that the cold snap of winter was on its way. Similarly, Lyn seemed cold and distant. Maybe she didn’t want Adora to fail, but there seemed to be a sense in the woman’s demeanor that she accepted she was stuck with the Horde Lord she had, and it wasn’t the best of situations.

With no fanfare, Lyn motioned them both to follow her without giving much reason why.

The cat jumped onto Adora, scaling her like a scratching post, before settling on her shoulders. Its tail flicked back and forth, hitting Adora’s leather jacket. She absentmindedly reached up a hand and petted the thing. “It’s ok. We’re going to be fine.”

They followed Lyn till she reached a stone, tapped it, and the stone moved away to reveal a glowing green passageway carved out of the rock. A spiraling staircase appeared into the mountain’s depths. Adora stopped at that entrance, scratching into the cat’s fur and saying again, this time quieter, “We’re going to be fine,” before taking the step to move forward.

Catra followed, only to be stopped by the cat jumping off Adora’s shoulders and hissing.

Adora turned around, face wracked with worry and confusion. “Melig, what’s wrong?”

Catra sighed and bent down to pet the animal. “Yeah, Melig. Nothing to worry about here. Is it that you don't want to go down

there?”

The animal tipped its head back to look up at Catra with a pleading expression and meowed helplessly.

Poor thing. Well, if it could understand her then... “Don’t worry. You can stay here. I’ll take care of Adora for you.”

The cat mewed quickly. A soft little thankful chirp.

Adora stood back a moment, leaning on the edge of the passageway. “That’s odd. It’s like it understood you or something.”

Catra stood back up, looked Adora dead in the eye, and lied. “Nah. It’s just a cat, but they can hear and understand your tone.”

Adora nodded uneasily at that. “Ok. Sure.” She turned to the animal and said, in a tone attempting to be calming, “I’ll be fine. Just wait here for us.”

Catra put her hand on Adora’s hip and moved her out of the door, down the passageway. She went intending, with every ounce of her, to keep the promise to the cat. She looked back as they disappeared and found the cat leaning around the edge to watch them. As worried as a cat could look, it looked worried. Catra winked at it, and it slowly blinked back at her.

Catra turned back to the path forward, that slow blink on her mind. It seemed like a thank you.

Lyn walked ahead, not stopping for their little interaction with their new pet.

Adora rushed through the steps to catch up, so they both exited the passageway faster than expected.

The room they entered was a massive cavern surrounded on all sides by rock. Stalactites, looking like dripping candle wax, hung from the craggy ceiling and dripped into cones of stalagmites on

the floor. It was all bathed in a faint green light that faded into darkness as the tunnel went on.

More shocking than the cave was the statue of a tall woman in blue robes that stood among the rocks in front of them.

Lyn stopped short of the statue and looked up at it. “She doesn’t look real, does she?”

Adora and Catra said nothing.

Lyn rubbed her hands together and turned to Adora. “It’s not a statue. She’s a vampire. A very old one. One of the first ones, actually. She’ll only respond to the Horde Lord, so really, you’re not the Horde Lord until she acknowledges you.”

Adora swallowed reflexively before standing straight and walking toward the statuesque woman.

The woman looked, for all the world, like she was made of marble. White smooth pale skin. Eyes that seemed impossibly still. She stared off into nothingness beyond them.

“How do I-” Before Adora could get the words out, the statue woman turned to look at her. It was a sharp, almost mechanical motion.

Adora jumped back, fists up, ready for a fight, before regaining her composure and clearing her throat. “Hey, hi! I’m Adora, the new Horde Lord.”

“Just a moment, you are being scanned,” the woman said in a soulless, mechanical voice. Mouth unmoving. Catra was not sure where that voice came from.

Lyn sighed. “The stories are that she was the first vampire to figure out how to turn into spiders, and- well- When you turn into an animal, it’s hard to come back. You have to... remember. And it’s easy enough when you’re just one thing, but when you turn into... lots of things... It’s hard to get thousands of spiders to

remember what it's like to be a woman, so... she's never really come back from that."

From the statue, from every nook and cranny, poured gobs of spiders. They came off her in waves. The robes deflated.

Adora pulled back as the horror reached for her.

Lyn continued on. "The other first ones made the mask and the robes so that she could look normal if she wanted to." Lyn turned her attention to Adora as the wave of spiders headed for her. "Whatever you do, don't move."

Adora froze on the spot, eyes wide with sudden terror but forcing herself to stay where she was.

Catra watched the little bugs swarm her. They didn't seem to be trying to get into anything. Adora didn't act like she was being bit, so Catra let whatever this was happen.

A moment later, they crawled off her. Adora let loose with a shiver that reverberated through her whole body as if trying to shake off the feeling. She made faces before finally getting over it. "That... was not pleasant."

The spiders all crowded back into their shell, and the woman "looked" at Adora. "Administrator detected. Welcome, Horde Lord Adora. How may I serve you?"

Lyn's padded shoulders relaxed. "Oh, thank god!" She started laughing, light-hearted as if she had been tensed up, and all the tension was suddenly released. She ran her hands through her hair. "Oh my. I'll admit, there was a part of me that was terrified that you hadn't actually killed Prime and that this was going to turn into a bloodbath, but whoa! Thank goodness, you're not a lier."

Adora's jaw clenched as she turned back to the thing before them. "I didn't realize there'd be a test."

Lyn ignored her and waved a hand. “Ok, ok, ok. Ask her... her name is Light Hope, because she always desired to walk in the sun again... anyway. Ask her for object number fifty-eight.”

Adora turned on Lyn. “What?”

“Ask her to retrieve object number fifty-eight. She won’t listen to me.”

Adora turned back to the statue spider woman. “Um- Light Hope? Can you get object number fifty-eight for me?”

“Affirmative.” At that, the spiders all evacuated again, this time crawling as a mass into the darkness of the cave behind her.

Lyn, light-hearted, leaned over to Adora, “She lives off the small lives of flies and bugs and other things that spiders eat. I dare say she’s probably the vampire who has gone the longest without actually consuming human blood. Amazing, isn’t it?”

Adora’s face was pale. Her eyes were wide. Her body was stiff. “Yeah. Real, impressive. A real achievement.”

Catra turned to look at the empty shell the spiders left behind. “I can’t imagine living long enough to turn into this. Forget your humanity this hard.”

Lyn’s lightheartedness faded. “Yeah, well, it's the fate of any of us who live this long. I don’t remember the exact details, but I think she was a priestess in ancient Egypt. That was like, what? Thirty centuries ago? Honestly, she looks fantastic, and she’s even learned English. Did you know we didn’t even have to teach it to her? She learned it by observing people after Prime brought her to this country. Amazing.”

Catra shook her head and found Adora looking at her.

There was real fear in Adora’s eyes as if she was faced with the real possibility of immortality and its consequences for the first time in her life.

Lyn prattled on. “She was never strong enough to make a bid for Horde Lord. I doubt she’d ever want to run anything, so she dedicated herself to supporting the position, acting as caretaker of the treasures.”

Adora looked away from Catra at the unmistakable sound of thousands of spiders coming back toward them in the cave. It sounded like rain coming toward them, amplified by the cave.

Catra leaned against the cave wall, done already with the theatrics.

Adora, however, looked like she was going to jump out of her skin.

The spiders mounded up before Adora in a column, and the ones on top moved aside to reveal... a three-pointed green crystal.

Catra moved to Adora’s side to get a good look. “Ok, so what is it?”

Lyn’s high heel shoes clacked against the stone as she walked over. “Prime stole this treasure, long ago, from our clan. He had it but couldn’t use it because our sire prime made it so that it would only respond to the blood of one of her progeny.”

Adora cleared her throat. “Sire prime?”

Lyn seemed to be enjoying this. “Oh, Shadow Weaver told you nothing, did she? Well, no matter. I can fill in. The oldest known member of a clan is called our sire prime. Prime, of course, chose the name to imply that he was the only sire prime that mattered to us. I think his name was Eric before. Eric just doesn’t have the same gravitas as Prime, does it?”

Adora shook her head and focused back on the crystal. “What... does it do?”

Lyn straightened her back, her hand hovering above the crystal. “It’s power. Pure power. Enough to make a young vampire strong

enough to defeat an ancient vampire."

Adora turned to her. Fear evaporated into sudden interest.

Lyn smirked. "Your sire was banished for trying to take this power for herself while it was still under Prime's control. That attempt ruined her. She couldn't retract her fangs, so she had to wear a mask for the rest of her short life, and she still never forgot about the taste of a power she got for the briefest moments. Her asking to turn you, and everything she did to you, was to get back to this. Back to the possibility of binding herself to it and ruling the Horde herself."

Adora blinked. "What?"

Lyn's smirk turned into a knowing smile. "Ah, yes. Your sire was a bitch. She would invest all that time in bringing you up, helping you kill Prime, making you Horde Lord, just so she could get to this, kill you with its power, and take your place." She moved back. "Vile woman. Absolutely vile."

Adora turned back to the glowing green thing before her. "So, if I use this-"

"You will no longer have to worry about someone catching you without that blade. How did Shadow Weaver get you away from it again?" Lyn pulled her hands in, tapping her own jaw. "Ah yes. She killed your brother, didn't she? And you left your sword in the saddle. Classic killing a Van Helsing trick."

Adora's jaws clenched.

Lyn's eyes flicked to Catra, then back to Adora. "Would be a shame if someone tried to pull something like that now."

Adora's face fell. She understood without having to be shown.

Catra winced. Maybe she understood Adora's brother a little more at that moment. Being used as a tool against the one person you love more than anyone else... kind of sucked.

Adora stood up and looked down at the thing, her brow furrowing. “Ok, how does it work?”

Catra moved forward, grabbing Adora’s arm and smiling a wide fake smile at Lyn. “Can you give us a moment?”

Lyn rolled her eyes and gave a disinterested shrug.

Catra pulled Adora away, off to a corner.

Adora looked her dead in the eye. “You think I shouldn’t use it.”

Catra, eyes firm, looked at her unflinching. “Babe, you don’t need this.”

Adora’s eyes searched her. She looked stubborn, and then, for a moment, she looked lost. “Catra... I wish that were true.”

“You have the sword.” Catra raised her eyebrows to Adora, a silent reminder that the sword was broken. However, its threat still meant something to everyone else. Her hand reached out, tracing Adora’s jaw. “You have me, and I’m more deadly than a blade.”

Adora closed her eyes and leaned into Catra’s hand.

“We have Glimmer and Bow. And... your *deal* with the hunters.” She added inflection to remind Adora that it wasn’t just a deal. It was a contract. They were invested.

Adora’s brow furrowed.

Catra felt her slipping away. “You’re enough, just as you are. You’ve got a good plan. We solve this whole feeding thing, and you’re the hero for them too.” She rubbed her thumb over Adora’s lips gently. “I don’t think you’re in as much danger as you think.” Her mind was on the cat. Adora didn’t know what it was. Didn’t know what she had.

Adora dropped her head, eyes still closed, and moved to touch their foreheads together. “Easy for you to say. You have no fear.”

“That doesn’t mean I’m a fool.”

Adora breathed in. A moment passed. “This thing we’re doing... It's big. It’s unprecedented. It’s important. Saving people on both sides. It's... ending a war.” Adora grabbed her hand.

Catra finally closed her eyes as she felt Adora’s hand shaking.

Adora’s voice shook ever so slightly. “I thought... I thought I was ready to die. That I deserved it.”

Catra’s whole body hurt at that.

Adora pressed on. “You showed me I can live, and now I want to.” Her hand gripped Catra’s. Adora’s jaw worked. The rest came out of her in a hurried rush of intensity. “Goddamn it, Catra, I want to live so I can be with you. I don’t want to worry about dying anymore. I don’t want to die a hero. I want... I want to end this war, survive it, and spend the rest of my life with... you.”

That was it. Catra saw the vastness of the fear in front of her. The overwhelming monster was Adora’s fear of losing what she had and failing at her life’s mission. There was nothing Catra could say, nothing she could show Adora to prove that she would live through this. There was no assurance she could give that would calm Adora down. She would be afraid for the rest of her life, which hurt more than any wound Catra had ever received. The words fell out of her mouth, defeated. “Do what you gotta do, then.”

The shaking in Adora’s hand slowed. She took a breath, as if breathing in the release of getting permission, and kissed Catra on the cheek before whispering, “Thank you for understanding.”

Catra opened her eyes. “I understand. You don’t believe me.”

Adora gave her another kiss. An apology before turning away from her toward Lyn. The moment she turned around, her shoulders straightened. Her shaking faded. Hero Adora walked back to the writhing, wriggling column of spiders and the object of vast

vampiric power that they held. “Ok. Let's do this.” She paused, turning to Lyn. “How exactly do we do this?”

Lyn looked at her. “Give me your hand.”

Adora put her hand in Lyn’s.

Lyn flipped it over, palm up, and ran her sharp fingernails over Adora’s veins. “I do an incantation, and you give it your blood. Simple as that. Mara made it easy for us, impossible for others.”

Adora took a breath and nodded.

Lyn started chanting in Latin and dug a nail into a blue vein.

Adora didn’t flinch at the pain. Didn’t move as her vein opened up, and the thick dark blood of her kind started dripping down her arm.

Lyn’s chanting grew in volume, and she moved Adora’s arm over the crystal.

Then the first drop of blood hit and landed. The blood was absorbed into the crystal, and it turned red. The room lit up with red light pushing against the green, like Christmas.

Adora gasped, and her body tried to pull back. Lyn gripped her arm harder, holding it where it was, still chanting as more drops of blood fell.

Catra watched her girlfriend’s shell crack and the briefest moment of terror flash across her face.

Catra watched, stone cold. Every choice has consequences. If Adora didn’t do this, she might have died within the week. Maybe she would have lived forever and turned into a nearly inhuman amalgam of vampire spiders. Catra breathed it all in and decided that no matter what happened, she’d be there.

Lyn left after it was over, saying something about sending the clan to take care of them the next night. She rattled off to Catra a list of things. Adora needed to feed soon. She'd likely feel fine, just some dizziness. Catra half listened. She was watching Adora as Adora sat on the steps. Her eyes were unfocused. She didn't look like she was in pain. In fact, she looked just fine. Maybe tired.

Lyn left soon after. She stomped up the stairs, and they heard the cat hiss and heard Lyn hiss right back at it, then call it something derogatory, before leaving.

Catra leaned on the cave next to Adora. "You ok?"

Adora tilted her head up. Her eyes were soft. "I feel great."

"Did it hurt?"

"Yeah."

"But you feel ok now?"

Adora nodded and looked past her to the statue spider woman. "Is it ok if we... put a raincheck on those toys?"

Catra let out a long sigh. She waited for Adora twice. She could wait again. "Sure." She reached down and got her arms under Adora's armpits.

Despite feeling "great," Adora could barely put weight on her feet. She leaned heavily on Catra's shoulder. Her body was... wiggly.

"Alright... well, Miss Horde Lord, let's get you something to eat."

Chapter End Notes

> Spiders: Predatory insects often compared to the vampire because of their method of luring their prey, entrapping it, and then sucking the life out of it, leaving only an empty shell of a carcass. Vampires can supposedly transform themselves

into spiders...” - The Vampire Encyclopedia by Mathew Bunson

The Diner

Chapter Summary

Adora is a little out of it. Micah hires some experts.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Catra drove because Adora was too floppy to even consider her taking the wheel. As she drove by empty field after empty field, Adora leaned against the window. Melig stood in the back seat, its front paws on the glass, looking at the world passing by.

Catra parked the car on the side of the road the moment she saw the dark, hulking masses in the corner of a field under a clump of trees. Their collective breath fogged in the chill air above them like a cloud. They looked like black holes set against the silvery grass glittering in the moon's waning light. She turned to tell Adora they were there, only to get a whiff of fresh chill air and find the door open and the girl already gone.

Catra sighed, pulled the door closed, and sat back to face forward.

Melig chattered from the back seat and scratched at the window, begging to follow.

Catra winced as she heard an uncharacteristic wet noise of feeding muffled through the car windows and said to the cat, “You know, things would be a lot easier if you’d just... I don’t know... let Adora know what you are.”

The cat ignored her and kept pining.

Catra got out and opened the door for the cat.

The animal hopped out, sat down, stuck up a leg with splayed toes, and started cleaning itself with its tongue.

Catra leaned on the car to watch her girlfriend feed.

Adora latched onto one of the dark hulks before detaching and moving to another.

Catra's eyebrows went straight up as she watched Adora drink from another, then another, and another. *Well... that's interesting.*

Minutes later, Adora slumped against the car's front left wheel, blood smeared on her face. The sanguine stuff dripped down her chin in thick in congealing globs. Adora reeked with iron gaminess. She heaved breath like she had run a mile at a sprint.

Melig stopped licking itself to investigate. It came right up to Adora's side, tail flicking back and forth, ears forward.

Catra knelt down in front of Adora.

Adora's eyes were open yet completely blown out into unfocused dark pools. Her eyes were still red, though her fangs still peaked above the rest of her teeth, like they couldn't quite go all the way back in. Adora couldn't keep still. Even sitting there on the ground, she was pushing the heels of her boots against the gravel. Her hands were messing with her pant legs as if she was too aware of the fabric against her skin.

"You... ok?" Catra drawled.

Adora focused on her with difficulty. "Great. I'm great." She went still for a moment before saying, "I feel like I could eat god."

It was going to be one of *those* nights. Catra pulled her dedicated blood-cleaning handkerchief out of her jacket pocket and started dabbing it at Adora's messy face.

Adora blinked at that like her brain caught up with what her mouth had said. "It feels... it feels like when I was first turned. Just... so much all at once. I feel everything. I feel the universe."

"Yeah. You're high as fuck."

Adora did nothing but blink, and she blinked too much, too fast.

Melig chirped.

Catra, with the dull tone of someone who had seen too many girlfriends like this, offered, “Magic or drugs, whatever the catalyst, the mechanism is the same.” She settled down to look Adora in the eye. “Something is blocking the dopamine receptors in your brain, flooding your system with the stuff. Probably because whatever you just went through would have been traumatic as fuck without it. The good news is, this can’t last forever. Lyn said it would be over by tomorrow night.”

Adora’s blinking slowed. She struggled to focus again, but she developed a smile. “This feels really good. Everything feels good.”

Catra smiled. “I hope so.” Whatever was going on in Adora’s brain could be fun or catastrophic, depending on the level of stress she was experiencing, and... and Adora didn’t do stress well. “We just have to keep you in a calming environment till it passes.”

Adora’s phone rang. After a short delay, she flinched at the sound, and her smile was gone.

Catra frowned at the loss of that smile. “Remember, you need to keep *calm* .” She accentuated the last word toward the cat.

In response, Melig snapped into action, moving forward and rubbing up against Adora’s side. Adora’s hand found its fur and started the meditative motion of scratching and petting, making the animal purr. That movement and its consequences stole Adora’s full undivided attention. She calmed down. The smile returned, even as the phone kept ringing.

Catra glanced at Melig and offered a quick “Thanks,” before taking the phone out of Adora’s jacket pocket. She stood up to answer. It was Bow. “What’s up?”

No hello. No pleasantries. He didn’t even ask why she was answering instead of Adora. Bow got straight to the point. “We

talked to Juliet. There's a problem... She wants to talk to you both in person."

Catra looked at the tweaked-out vampire on the ground before her. "I say this in all honesty, now is not a good time."

"She says it's urgent. Can you two meet us for lunch with her?"

Doing anything else would have been better. Anything other than having lunch while her vampire girlfriend was tweaked out on pure vampire power with their vampire hunter of a boss. "Bow, I'm serious. Now is not a good time. Can this wait till tomorrow?"

"Juliet is leaving the country later tonight. She wants to talk to you two before she leaves. She said it's important."

"And she can't do it over the phone?"

"She says phones aren't secure."

Well then, that was it. They had no choice. Catra sighed.

Bow took the sigh as agreement. "I'll text you the address. It's a 24-hour diner about an hour away from the headquarters. Very private. No one goes there. The food is terrible."

The moment he hung up, she got the ping of the address on the phone in her back pocket. She turned to Adora. "How do you feel about seeing your boss?"

Adora's face bloomed into a smile. "I wonder how she tastes."

"No eating."

Adora's smile didn't go away.

Catra knelt back down and licked her lips as she considered her approach. She reached out to run her thumb on Adora's chin before saying, "Are you going to be a good girl for me? No biting anyone?" She said it in buttery tones. Sultry.

Adora melted at it. Completely at a loss at the onslaught of that tone. Her eyes flicked up to Catra's face and then flickered closed as she leaned into the touch. "Yes, mistress," she breathed.

Catra's eyebrows went up for the second time that night.

Adora moved to suck Catra's thumb into her mouth.

Catra frowned as she got a taste of what she was missing. *Fuck.*

***

The diner was a lonely place situated at the intersection of two major highways. It sat atop the artificial hill of the overpass. It had bright neon lights that shouted that it was open 24 hours in eye-popping impossible yellows and reds.

Catra parked with Adora and the cat in the front seat, faces plastered against the glass, ogling the bright sign.

Bow and Glimmer were already there, snuggled up against the cold under the awning of the building.

Adora didn't see them as they waved. Instead, she breathed on the glass, then got distracted by the fog her breath made. She started drawing two circles next to each other. Smiling, she tapped a dot with her index finger in the center of the two circles. She erupted into laughter before leaning in and... licking the dots off the window by swirling her tongue on them.

On the other side of the window, Bow and Glimmer's faces fell as they both realized exactly why this had been a bad time for Adora to meet with her boss.

"What were you thinking?" Glimmer whispered once they got in and sat down in a booth that had gone too long without maintenance. The bench stuffing was coming out of cracks in its surface.

Catra pushed Adora in and all the way to the wall in a vain attempt at control. She whistled at the cat following them and motioned to Adora's lap under the table.

The cat jumped up and purred. Adora, her filters down, moaned and started petting and scratching fur. The cat fucking loved it and leaned in with a cat-ish smile, licking its chops in pure heaven.

With that out of the way, Catra turned to Glimmer. "I was told there wasn't a choice."

"You didn't tell me she was high!" Bow whispered and yelled at the same time, which was impressive.

Glimmer's eyes burned on Catra. "What the hell did you two do?"

Bow added, "Is she dangerous?"

Catra said, "Horde business." She glanced up at Bow. "And no, she's not dangerous. She's very full, and she hasn't tried to eat me- and look at me! I'm a fucking snack! So relax and act normal. Boss incoming."

Glimmer and Bow both startled. They were so focused on Adora, they missed the stern woman with a gigantic scar across her face entering the building.

Juliet strode in, face impassive. She took one look at the seating arrangement and grabbed a freestanding chair. Bow and Glimmer flinched at the sound the bare metal made on the red and white checkered linoleum.

Juliet plopped down, and her eyes landed on Adora.

Adora leaned forward and waved. "Hey there, Chief. Boss man. Big wig. My sovereign."

Juliet's brows knit. "What's up with her?"

Catra answered with aplomb. "She's high as fuck."

Bow winced. Glimmer rolled her eyes.

Juliet's lips pressed to a thin line before she declared, "This is going to get written up in her evaluation. She needs to stay vigilant."

Adora shifted her attention to the salt shaker. She turned it over, spilling salt all over the table and acting surprised.

Catra leaned forward, cutting off Juliet's access to the sight. "I'm vigilant enough for both of us, which is what you're paying me for. So, what couldn't you say on the phone?"

Juliet pinched the bridge of her nose, right above her scar, and said, "The order can't help with the winter feeding problem."

The salt shaker landed on the table in a sound that made everyone flinch except Catra. Eyes turned on Adora, who had gone very still and very focused on Juliet. She opened her mouth to say something, but nothing came out.

Catra filled in. "Why the hell not?"

Juliet shrugged. "We don't have the money this season to do anything at that scale. All our funding is tied up in human resources, silver protection, and real estate. The only flex money we have is the travel budget, and it's not enough. I'm telling you this now so you have more time to come up with a solution."

Catra's nails scratched the table. "You could have told us that over the phone."

Juliet shook her head. "No, I can't. I've got the head of every secret service agency in the world breathing down my neck and tapping my phones. I can't send a text without an international incident." She leaned back in her chair. "I'm sorry, but the most I can offer is support for whatever you can manage to come up with." She shook her head. "You will have to come up with something on your own, and if you don't... I order you to give me

full warning as early as possible so we can ramp back up production.”

Catra grit her teeth.

While Bow and Glimmer sat in stunned silence, Catra turned to her girlfriend.

Adora’s eyes were still red and wide, and she strained to focus them. She had a faint hint of herself like she was cutting through the dopamine with a tremendous effort. She was trying to put on a brave face. Trying to hide a tempest that Catra could see in the way she was scratching Melig. “Ok. We’ll come up with a solution... I just need... time to... think.” Her focus was gone. Her body shivered.

The window Adora was sitting next to was cloudy. Catra thought that Adora had breathed on it to fog it up, but then she realized, no, it was outside.

A thick fog had rolled in, and none of them had noticed. The neon sign gave everything an unnatural yellow and red tent.

Melig hissed and growled, pulling away from Adora and pressing its face to the window.

Catra stood up to see what the cat was looking at. Bow and Glimmer did the same.

Outside, things were moving toward them. They looked like little black shadows through the mist. As they got closer, their beady eyes reflected in the light, and their little round ears stood out against the gravel. Melig hit both paws on the window, growling and spitting.

“Rats?” Bow said in confusion. “A swarm of-”

He was cut off by a scream. Everyone looked up toward the entrance except Juliet.

The swarm of rats piled up at the door, pressing the closest ones against the glass. The waitress was still screaming, body shaking, as if her worst fear had manifested.

Juliet stared at Adora, which made Catra look at Adora too.

Adora was still. Deadly still, as if the whole scene wouldn't affect her. But her pupils were now constricted. She was starting down the path of having a bad trip. Catra's heart broke as she watched. She heard the sound of broken glass in the background and was immune to the chaos that followed.

Bow and Glimmer pulled their feet up into the booth and huddled together. Melig jumped out of Adora's lap, growling, excited, happy, and started chasing the first rat that came close.

Juliet didn't budge, even as rats started running over her leather boots.

The other patrons screamed, scrambled, and ran for the exits.

Catra turned to Juliet.

She didn't know what to expect from the head of the Order of the Gray Skull. Maybe some sign of panic. Some fear, but there was none. There was, instead, a battle-worn weariness.

The rats swarmed the countertop, breaking into the display of pies, even as the cook tried to swat a spatula at them. They ignored him and started gorging themselves on buttered crusts and sugared fruit filling. Melig darted through the scene, chasing any rat it thought it could catch.

Juliet leaned forward on the table, kicked a rat off her leg, looked at Adora, and said, in measured tones, "I assume you've done something to level up."

Adora finally moved. Her pinprick eyes, red as the blood she drank, locked onto Juliet with a laser focus.

The corner of Juliet's lip twitched. "In any other circumstance, I'd consider this a breach of your contract."

Adora blinked and refocused.

Bow squeezed his eyes shut while Glimmer started kicking at the things crawling around them on the floor.

Juliet went on, "Dipping into dark magic is forbidden in the Order. But... in this case, I'm going to conveniently forget what I've witnessed here because right now, your only goal is to survive. I don't much care how you do it." She stood up.

Adora's whole body flinched.

Juliet kicked more rats away from her before adding, "But, you're going to have to learn to keep your emotions in check, or else you'll be a danger to others. If that happens, I can't vouch for your safety from the people who make up my organization. Goodbye, Adora, and good luck." She turned abruptly and waded through the mess, stopping once to avoid the cat as it chased a particularly large rat. She stepped around the broken glass to leave through the front door.

"Fuck her," Catra snapped as the woman disappeared from sight.

Bow whimpered, "Can we teleport out now?"

"Hell yes, we can," Glimmer said between kicks. She then looked up at Catra. "Do you two need-"

Catra grit her teeth and shook her head no. "We'll be fine. Go on."

In a flash, Glimmer and Bow were gone.

Catra turned back to the table, gripping her hands into fists, ready to be angry.

Undulating gray-brown fur, red eyes, and sharp teeth covered the floor. Melig was getting surrounded in a corner hissing and

swatting.

Adora reached out and touched her. “Catra, I have a confession.”

Anger melted away as she turned to her lover, ready for anything.

“I just hallucinated that we met Juliet here.” She squeezed Catra’s hand. “And I summoned a swarm of rats and some fog and- Bow and Glimmer were here, and it scared them and- I think I’m ready to go back to the lair.” Her face was vacant. Lost. “Also, if I stop concentrating, I’ll cease to exist.” She squeezed harder. “This doesn’t feel good anymore.”

Catra noticed that Adora said “summoned”... past-tense, despite the rat next to them chewing on the seat cover. Catra squeezed Adora’s hand. She’d clear things up in the morning when Adora wasn’t high. Till then... the only goal was to help Adora calm down. She got up from the table and held out her hand to her lover.

Adora’s face flushed with interest as she watched.

Catra couldn’t help but smile wide. “We’re going to go back, and I’m going to turn on some of your favorite music, and we will dance the night away. Dance till all this has passed us by. How does that sound?”

Adora’s eyes dilated as she reached to take Catra’s hand.

Catra’s chest buzzed at that sight, and she pulled her girlfriend out of the booth.

The fog started to dissipate into a clear night again. The rats disappeared.

The cat mewled with disappointment at the loss.

***

Micah hadn't slept. His wife got home and was immediately worried about him. He told her it was just some craziness at work and not to worry about it. He decided not to tell her about Catra and the vampire until he had something to show for it. If he had his deepest wish, she would never know. He stayed up all night and threw himself into the dark web to find anyone and everyone who claimed they were vampire hunters. He lucked out in finding a duo nearby. Vetting someone who claimed they were a hunter was *almost* impossible. Almost.

"You've come to the right people," the woman said, leaning on the table in front of him. She had white hair done up in a wave, dark brown skin, and a bright blue faux leather jacket. All and all, a very noticeable outfit for someone who claimed they were a hunter. That was one strike against.

Micah picked up his coffee and drank it like it was the elixir of life. His other hand messed with a thin layer of salt grit left on the table.

The woman looked down at the salt and huffed. "This is exactly why we meet clients here. No one comes here. It's the most private meeting place because they don't clean the tables between guests. They rely on desperate traffic from the highway. The food is atrocious."

Her pink-haired wife added, with a quieter voice, "I heard there was a rat infestation here last night. The whole place was swarming with them."

Micah started to notice the signs that the place had experienced some drama. The hastily taped-up front door. The display had empty pedestals where there should be pies. Instead, there were only crumbs. The waitress was busy cleaning something behind the counter with a look of pure weariness.

The white-haired woman leaned back, looking away, and folded her hands together. "Look, I get how scary it can be when a vamp locks their fangs on your kid."

They didn’t seem to notice the marks he made into the salt with his finger as she talked.

The woman continued. “Which is why I will absolutely do this for a discount, because you’re desperate, and desperation does not cost more. In fact, it costs less.”

“I can pay this much,” he said before pulling the little slip of paper he had prepared out of his pocket with the hand that wasn’t making a spell in the salt.

Both the women leaned forward to see the amount. He saw their eyes dilate a fraction.

He was genuine about the amount. Saving Catra was worth everything to him. But it was also a good distraction. He finished the sigil.

The sporty white-haired girl leaned back, crossed her legs, but kept a finger on the paper and lied. “You know, this isn’t much, but like I said, desperation costs less, so I think it’s a fair amount for a charity case.”

Her wife rolled her eyes, brought the straw of her drink to her mouth, and looked away. She was already tired of this.

His moment came when the waitress screeched as something broke away from her and ran in a mad dash to the back. They all heard the cook howl and bellow obscenities. Both women turned to see what was going on. He focused on the marks on the table. He spoke the incantation under his breath, pulled up the magic with a gesture, glittering and smoky, and flung it toward both of them.

They turned back from the commotion as the magic hit them square in the face. The white-haired woman’s eyes twitched. The other woman looked... surprised. She looked at the table, then at him, in utter astonishment.

Micah smiled. “Are you two really vampire hunters?”

The white-haired one didn't miss a beat. "Yeah. We're part of a secret organization that's been hunting vampires for thousands of years. They pay us a lot of money, so we're not supposed to charge anything, but now they're trying to tell us that there's been some kind of peace, and everyone is worried we will all be downsized. Laid off." She seemed to be getting angry. "Peace? As if anyone could believe that. I know vamps, and this peace is all a setup for something big. They're luring the Order into a false sense of security."

The pink-haired woman looked at her wife in astonishment but said nothing.

Micah frowned a bit. "Do you think... my adopted daughter might be caught up in this bigger plan?"

"Absolutely. It sounds like she's gotten herself entangled in a very powerful vampire's orbit, and they'll use her when the time comes. Pets are immune to vampire influence, so everything they do is willing, but that doesn't mean they can't be brainwashed." She shook her head. "There was this one story from like the 1700s, about a temple in Korea that was-"

Micah felt his throat tightening up. His chest hurt. He waved to dismiss the truth spell. Anything to stop her from continuing.

She shook her head, not understanding what had happened. The woman went on with what could have been a lie or the truth. Now, there was no way to know. "Don't worry, though. You've called the right people. I've been hunting vampires since I was thirteen. I know all their weaknesses."

He was mentally pulling himself out of the worst night of his life. He tried to act normal. Tried to make his voice calm. "Such as?"

"Nets!" The woman said with a big toothy grin, pulling out what he assumed was a wadded ball of fishing net from her coat pocket.

He looked at the ball of knots and string in her hand. His memories faded to the background as he focused on what was in front of him.

She leaned in, holding the ball of net up like she was imparting a very important secret. “They love untying knots, and what is a net but a bunch of knots! And, added bonus, it makes them stop moving, so boom! Vampire caught and distracted while you stake em’.” She made a staking jabbing motion with her free hand that, without the stake, looked like something else.

Her wife reached out and put the hand down, stopping the gesture.

Micah paused for a moment, looked at the net, and suddenly the forum name this woman used made complete sense. “Ah, I get it. Net-toss-a. It’s clever.”

The woman’s smile was gone. She glared at him. “That’s my real name. Are you making fun of my name?”

“Darling, don’t,” the one with pink hair said in a whisper, now looking like she was ready to leave.

“No disrespect intended.” Micah got an awkward smile, but he reached his hand forward to offer to shake. “Well, Netossa, I’m pleased to hire you to help me save my daughter.”

She took his hand and shook hard, her smile growing back.

Micah added, “I’m taking a vacation from work to work with both of you.” It was a vacation that Angella would hopefully never know about.

Netossa’s smile faded.

Micah felt like this was the right move. Hire experts. Catra would be safe soon. That thought made him drag some happiness out of his mind despite the memories. Everything that happened ended

up with him here at this time and place, with enough resources to save Catra. So... hadn’t it all been worth it?

All at once, he felt the tiredness of the night hit him. He went back to the coffee, desperate for fortification.

Chapter End Notes

> How could I read this entry and not think of Netossa?
>
> Fishnets: An item used in many [Romani] villages, particularly among the Doms, to protect against attack. Fishnets were dropped over the doors of homes with the knowledge that vampires who sought entrance would be compelled to count all the knots in the net before setting about feeding. This action was similar to the placing of knots in graves to distract the vampires. -The Vampire Encyclopedia by Mathew Bunson

Fledgling

Chapter Summary

> Micah meets a horse, Adora has a dream that gets too real, and Glimmer makes a mistake.

Micah sat in shame in his car, holding the steaming coffee mug his wife had made him. He didn't sleep again. All night, he was plagued by memories as dreams and would wake up and could think about nothing else but getting the hunt started.

The shame came from the deception of his wife. He got ready like normal and acted like he was going to work. His wife had made him coffee and kissed him goodbye, and he had gotten in his car. The windshield had frosted over, so he took the time to defrost it and acted like he was going to work. Instead, he pulled into an alleyway between their neighbors' backyards and waited to see his wife’s car drive as she went to work.

For twenty-something years, their life had been built on a lie that she asked him to keep up. He was not a lying man. It didn't come naturally, and this felt like a sin heaped upon a sin he was already finding difficult to live with. But, the hunters had said they needed to start the hunt at the last fresh point of contact, which meant the house.

Once he saw his wife’s purple sedan drive past the alley, he texted the vampire hunter's wife, whose code name was Spinnerella, that the coast was clear.

He put down his phone and, to his horror, felt more than saw something big driving up the street to his house.

He looked up in the rearview mirror and saw a massive pickup truck with double back wheels, putting what looked like a livestock trailer.

His heart sank, and he threw his car into reverse and backed out to see the hunters parking the trailer in front of his house.

He parked next to the truck and frowned as the two women got out with... He rolled down his window. “A child?”

The girl, dressed in blue and white, with severely sharp-cut hair, didn’t look up from her phone as she said, “I’m not a kid. I’m almost twelve.”

Netossa got a big smile and slapped a hand down on the shoulders of the kid. “Number one best way to find a vamp is to have a virgin ride a virgin horse at the last point of contact. Micah, meet Frosta, our resident virgin.”

The pink-haired wife said, with an apologetic smile, “Our adopted daughter, Frosta.”

The girl shrugged, not much caring how she was referred to.

Netossa went toward the trailer and talked. “Normally, virgin horses are repulsed by vamps, so it takes training to get them to go toward that feeling instead of running away from it. Add a trained virgin rider, and you’ve got a vampire tracking system.”

The horse she pulled out was young, thin, and eager. It had long, thick, well-cared-for hair along its neck. Netossa beamed with pride. “We named him Swifty, after the most famous horse of his bloodline.”

Micah looked between the woman, the horse, and the child. “So we just... follow them?”

Spinnerella smiled softly and responded, “It might take a few days, but they’ll narrow down the places your vampire tends to be. Then we’ll monitor those areas at night while our little Frosta is somewhere safe.”

The girl looked up from her phone and said, “When I become a vampire hunter, my code name will be Vampire’s Bane. I’m going

to specialize in punching them to death.” She said this with all seriousness- the same that Catra would have uttered it with.

Micah’s heart ached for the simplicity of young Catra and Glimmer when the worst trouble either of them got in was fights with bullies at school.

The wife pulled out two other bigger, more mature horses, already saddled up. They would follow Frosta on horseback. He would follow by way of the car and the roads.

He smiled with the same feeling he got when he called someone to fix a bad water heater. He couldn’t fix it himself, but he could find experts who fixed these types of things regularly and rest easy in their competence. The vampire would be dealt with, maybe within the next night. Then started the long slow process of deprogramming his adopted daughter from the vampire manipulation... but that's ok because they still had Razz on retainer, and she was the best.

He looked at the horses and could imagine the HOA complaints that would pile into his mailbox the next day, and he didn’t care. This was what taking care of a family meant, and he would do it, no matter what. Glimmer and Catra would be safe, and this ordeal would be behind them. “Mount up. I’ll follow,” he said with a growing smile. The future looked hopeful.

***

With a day that reminded her of her first years being a vampire, she was not surprised where her dreams took her. They plucked her out of modern time and dropped her right into the wild west, into chaos. Drinking, shooting, gambling chaos. Vampires were drawn to that chaos, and Shadow Weaver was forced to it in a way most vampire sires weren’t.

“You are problematic,” the woman said quietly, whispering under her breath and behind the mask as she stood in the shadow of the dance hall.

Adora was a young vampire, alight with interest and investigation into a world her sire had sought to ensure she couldn't remember. A side effect was that everything she experienced was fresh and new, and she didn't have the instincts of someone who had lived a whole human life. No, her life had artificially started on the basement floor of Shadow Weaver's farmhouse.

Every moment since that one had been a new experience, so in those first few decades, Adora dove into each experience like a toddler with extremely sharp canines and a taste for blood.

"What is problematic?" With the absence of her formal education, Adora fell into just asking what more complicated words meant. Each time, instead of an answer, she was given an enigma.

"Problematic means your god-forsaken hide requires *Foie gras* when what I have is ground beef chuck."

Adora still had no idea what the woman was talking about. This was, on reflection, more to do with the fact that Adora's first language was Dutch, and English had been her father's job to instruct her. He had been too pragmatic. At that moment, however, she didn't have words like 'pragmatic.' All she had was 'hungry' and 'gross.' As in, the first few meals Shadow Weaver brought her were cowboys and 'gross.' No matter how hungry she was, she wouldn't eat them. She grew 'hungry,' and it only took Shadow Weaver a few days to realize that what Adora, the raw, hungry, and human-less vampire needed, was attractive young women.

The feeding problem was solved. The next problem was what they were handling at the moment. Adora, an animal in a world that was ill-designed for her, needed to hunt.

Shadow Weaver had tried to dress Adora in period-appropriate clothing. A dress. A sensible dress, and Adora- the human-memory-less vampire threw a fit that threatened to wake up the respectable neighbors miles away.

The old woman was forced to dress Adora in pants, a button-down shirt, and a sensible jacket. She was forced to look at the fledgling she had been given and decide that this was workable.

Shadow Weaver grabbed Adora's jaw and forced her face to look toward her in the night. She looked between Adora's eyes and declared, "As you feed tonight, remember that I brought you here and trained you. Without me, you are nothing."

In those early years, Adora had no sense of pride. No sense of self to be prideful about. "I am forever yours to command, my sire."

The woman relaxed a fraction.

From Adora's perspective, everything was easier after one of these moments of sublimation.

Her sire gave it a moment of reflection to absorb the gesture before grabbing Adora's shoulder. Her sire dragged her by the jacket to the window of the dance hall. The woman sank into the shadows of the window before pulling Adora to look inside. "Pick a target that you feel drawn to. Ideally, it's someone whose disappearance won't be noticed for a while."

Adora's fangs were already threatening to come out just at the idea of feeding as she looked into the window. There they were on a street in the middle of a cattle trail. A boulevard lined with vices. A bar next to a brothel, next to a bingo hall, next to a lower-stakes poker game. In the last couple of weeks, Adora had come to know the place that would be called The Bloody Third Ward like the back of her hand. Between cattle runs, it was a sleepy place, but when the cowboys roared into town, what they wanted was booze, girls, and entertainment. Adora, on some level, understood this and accepted it.

She looked into the window and tried to produce a match to the requirements of a human girl to whom she was drawn and someone whose disappearance wouldn't be noticed. She was,

instead, completely taken by a woman with pink and purple hair, wearing a light purple dress. “I want that one,” Adora said, falling against the window.

Exhausted by her endeavor to try to find someone, anyone that Adora would actually hunt, Shadow Weaver gave in immediately. “Ok. Sure. She will do. Lead her away from the action. Get her alone outside in the dark, and there you will feed.”

The very thought of it made Adora’s heart pound. Her face flushed. She attributed these signs to being hungry as a vampire because her sire gave her no indication that it was anything else.

In a moment, she was allowed to go into the dance hall, a space that was normally occupied and resurrected to men. Shadow Weaver cautioned her to stay in the shadows. “The less they see of you, the less they’ll notice that you’re different.” Adora assumed she meant that people would notice less she was a vampire. Shadow Weaver meant that people would notice less that she was a woman, dressed and pretending to be a man, entering a male-dominated space.

Adora had no memory of gender dynamics, so she strolled into the place like she owned it.

Inside, there was the distinct smell of fresh cowboy. Weeks on the trail, riding horses and not taking full baths, it was leather and musk, and many people around town said it smelled like money. Adora had no concept of finances, but she could pick up that these men were valuable, but the only thing she cared about was the parasites that sucked out their lifeblood in a different way than her. Prostitutes. Dancers. Women of ill repute. No one expected one of these soiled doves to last long. They were a young lesbian vampire’s perfect victims.

The woman Adora had identified was the most noticeable woman in the room. Pink and purple hair. Plump and well-fed, a rarity but a commodity, and wearing a dress that bespoke money.

Adora felt drawn to her. The woman’s existence tugged at her, and she pulled on that tug.

She did what she had been taught to do. Shadow Weaver used the word ‘seduce,’ but Adora had no frame of reference for that, so she disregarded it. She followed Shadow Weaver’s instructions to the letter.

She came up behind the woman, so the woman wouldn’t immediately see her face and take her for a youth or a woman. She put her hands on the woman’s hips and pulled them together.

The woman had an animal reaction. Less fear and more delighted surprise.

Adora smiled at herself and made her first mistake. Instead of saying or doing anything else, she pulled the woman in to smell her. She smelled her shoulder and moved to the nape of her neck. This produced a visceral reaction in her. Her fangs pushed against the inside of her lip. Her whole body ached to drain the woman now, in front of everyone. No, she would take it slow. She forced her fangs to retreat and ran her lips along the subtle skin of the woman’s neck.

She put her lips to the woman's ear and whispered, “A shame for such a beauty to be here alone.”

She felt the woman shudder under her fingertips.

“You look ravishing,” Adora whispered as her fangs pushed past her lip, protruding from her mouth. This was where she always failed the hunt. She got distracted. She got hungry, and everything happened too fast. “Simply... delectable.” These words came to her easily.

Adora bit her teeth together, feeling the want within her grow. Feeling the desire to bite and feed, regardless of who was watching. “Let me drink in your beauty, won’t you, my dear?”

The woman’s short, pleasantly plump body jolted with electric understanding.

Adora was drunk off it. More distracted by the body than she was by the feeding. This was why she had, for two hundred years, been shit at hunting. It was too easy for her to lose the seduction of the prey with the seduction of the self, and she was completely at a loss to identify that fact, so she was helpless.

What she wanted... was to feed. What she wanted was to rub parts of herself on the thing she desired most. What she wanted was to have all these things together without them being mutually exclusive.

Adora moved her hands the way she had when this happened in real life. She moved away from the waist, down the hips, to the thighs, and toward something that she couldn’t express or understand wanting. Her fangs slid out all too easily.

The woman gasped and twisted out of her arms. She spun to face Adora, ready to chastise her for going too far. She, instead, froze.

Adora smiled. It was the soulless smile of a hungry monster. She reached for the woman, and the woman screamed, the way all of the early women screamed. Except, this one, as Adora reached for her, disappeared. In a flash of purple sparks, her hands remained empty. Her wild smile faded. That wasn’t how it happened in real life.

Adora woke up.

She opened her eyes to her new bedroom, at the cave, with Catra snoring softly beside her and Melig sleeping at their feet. The calmness of the scene was destroyed by a splitting headache and the feeling that her stomach felt like it had rocks in it.

She maneuvered to get out of Catra’s hold without waking her up. Her limbs moved around the cat. She got onto her feet, grabbed her phone out of habit, and went to the little modern adjacent

bathroom and shut the door behind her. She tried to breathe, to calm down, but then she saw her face in the mirror over the sink.

The eyes that looked back at her weren't the soft gray-blue eyes she shared with her brother. They were red. She moved toward the mirror, looking at herself, unable to recognize her own face. Her fangs weren't retracted all the way, and she touched them in horror.

They looked just like Shadow Weaver's...

Was she doomed to the same fate? No. Surely not. She just had to calm down. She closed her eyes and tried to breathe.

She was interrupted by her phone buzzing.

She opened her eyes and looked at it. Glimmer's picture was on the screen. Her heart started pumping hard and fast. The tightness in her stomach got worse as she reached to answer. "Glimmer, is everything ok?"

For a moment, all she heard was Glimmer breathing as if she had just run a mile. Then, she got some air in her and said, "Yeah, I have... a weird question."

Adora's stomach twisted into knots.

"Were you just now dreaming?"

Adora made a small grunting noise that meant yes.

Glimmer breathed for a moment before she asked, "What were you dreaming about, Adora?"

Adora's whole body hurt. Her head throbbed as pain shot down the back of her head. She leaned against the sink. She couldn't think critically, so she answered, "I dreamed about one of my first hunts." Just saying it made her feel like her vampire hunter colleagues were about to burst in, stakes flying, judging her for the sins that weighed on her soul.

“Yeah, that wasn’t your first hunt. That was me.”

Adora blinked. “That’s impossible.”

“Apparently not. You were... Different. You were...”

Adora made a noise, deep in her throat, wordlessly begging Glimmer not to say it. “I’m sorry. I’m so sorry. I didn’t know it was real. I thought it was a memory.”

“It’s ok. No harm, no foul, right?”

Adora didn’t know what that meant. Why would this have anything to do with birds?

Glimmer went on. “Adora, you put me under your influence sixty miles away. That’s insane! How did you do that? With that and the rats last night-”

Adora’s chest felt tight. She had been sure the whole rat thing was a hallucination, but it obviously wasn’t. Glimmer was really there, which meant... She groaned and leaned against the sink.

Glimmer's voice got quiet. Conspiratorial. “Adora, what did you do to yourself, and can I have some? It would make all this resurrection and illusions spell stuff so much easier to have-”

Adora hung up. She shouldn't have hung up, but she did. She couldn't take it. Couldn’t handle it.

Adora felt a gnawing pain in the pit of her stomach. She had scared Glimmer. Glimmer had seen her at her worst. A newly minted vampire, with her humanity magically wiped out. She had been a monster those first few decades. Now, Glimmer had seen her at her worst, and there was no way she could guarantee it wouldn't happen again. There was nothing to say she wouldn’t bite down on Glimmer next time, and- *Shit* ... she was getting turned on. *Fuck* . She leaned over the sink, feeling her stomach churning in a way that made her worried she was going to puke.

The door to the bathroom opened, and Catra yawned. She came in casually and put her arms around Adora's waist. She rested her chin on Adora's shoulder and opened her eyes with a hazy smile. "What are you doing in here, princess?"

Adora couldn't think past the cacophony of her body, but Catra's touch reminded her that she wasn't a monster. She was loved. She was trying to be better. She wasn't the thing that nearly fed on Glimmer in a dream. She was scared, and the last thing she wanted was to be scared in front of her lover, so she deflected. "The meeting with Juliet wasn't a hallucination, was it?"

Catra yawned again and shook her head.

On top of everything else, she was solely responsible for solving the feeding problem, and... she had no ideas. No leads. Her brain was empty because all she saw was her failure. She forced herself to breathe in and said, in a choked whisper, "Catra, we're fucked."

"If you want to be," Catra said as she nuzzled into Adora's neck.

Adora was on edge and nearly wriggled out of the closeness. She felt like she didn't deserve this physical affection. "No, I mean, I don't have an answer. I don't think anyone does. Over a thousand vampires are looking to me to solve a problem and..." She couldn't bring herself to finish.

Catra smiled against Adora's neck. "My poor little vampire." She kissed the sensitive skin there.

That hit a nerve in Adora's body, making all the horrible thoughts vanish from her brain. It reset her. She leaned into it.

Catra kissed her up her neck, then down her shoulder before pulling back, just a hair, and saying, "You and Juliet both think about this wrong."

Adora startled out of her haze. "What?"

“As much of a vampire you are, you’re still a vampire hunter at heart, and so is she. You two can only think about this in the inflexible way you’ve been taught.” She turned Adora around to face her and pressed their bodies together. Catra’s smile was lopsided. Her eyes were half-lidded, and her body confident. Her tattoos peaked from the edges of her oversized t-shirt, and her skin against Adora’s was warm. “Blood, as a commodity, is hard to get and expensive. I’m sure Juliet looked at the going price of pig blood and nearly had a heart attack.”

Adora breathed her lover in and felt the fear and panic disappear in waves. She let herself be swayed back and forth by Catra’s body as if they were about to start dancing again. “And you have a better idea?”

Catra pressed her forehead to Adora’s. “From the perspective of the blood, this is impossible. There’s just too many vampires to make it work at scale, but you know what?”

Adora shook her head no against Catra’s.

“You only need fourteen thousand people a week to feed everyone. One pint each. I can guarantee that there are fourteen thousand sickos worldwide willing to get fed on by a real vampire.”

Adora opened her eyes. She stopped swaying. Slight panic returned. “That’s against the ban.”

Catra pulled her torso back but suggestively pressed her hips into Adora’s. “No. The ban is against non-consensual feeding.” She rocked her hips against Adora’s to make the point. “I just said this feeding would be specifically consensual. They’d have to sign paperwork and shit.”

Adora felt her heart ramping up again, but instead of fear, it was excitement. “Are you sure?”

Catra nodded, smiling wider. “Look, half my ex-girlfriends would jump at the chance. And they’d pay good money for it too.”

Adora reached up, grabbing Catra's face. "Tell me you're not joking. You're serious."

"I'm serious. Not joking. There are probably millions of people out there who would do it. The trick is finding them, and I think I know how to do that too."

Adora put her lips on Catra's suddenly. Urgently.

Catra closed her eyes and moaned deep in her chest.

Adora kissed her, pouring every ounce of thankfulness into that kiss. She forced herself back. "If you can fix this-"

Catra licked her lips, unable to stop smiling. "If I can fix this for you, you are going to screw me senseless with that harness, princess."

At first, all Adora could think of was a horse's harness, and then it hit her- the harness from the sex shop. The thing in the bag. Adora's thoughts got hazy. She smiled. "Yeah, absolutely. Anything you want. If you can do this, I'll rail you for hours."

Catra's smile was gone as her cheeks flushed. Blood came to the surface of her skin, bringing with it heat and the scent of a meal. She was aroused at the idea, which only made Adora lose herself more.

Catra put a hand on Adora's jaw and traced her chin with her thumb. "Well then, get suited up because we have one of my exes to go see."

The weight of the world left Adora's shoulders. She felt something she hadn't felt in a long time. Hope.

***

There was no hiding that something had happened. Glimmer knew that as much when she knocked Bow out of bed.

It had all been so instinctual. She saw Vampire Adora, fangs out, with a smile on her face that reminded Glimmer of the smile Catra got back when she was wilder.

It scared her so bad that she just teleported. She woke up half a mile above her apartment, the sun setting in the distance, and then she started falling back to earth. It had taken her half a second to realize this wasn't a dream. She was really falling, and instinct had taken over. She thought of Bow, teleported again, and landed in the bed. Bow went flying.

They had eaten breakfast in silence. Every attempt Bow made to ask her about what happened, she refused to say anything. After a while, she said, "It was a nightmare." She was sure as hell wouldn't tell him that the nightmare included their lesbian vampire roommate feeling her up. That seemed... too hard to explain. Too complicated. It was no one's fault. Adora didn't know it was a shared dream, and neither did Glimmer. None of their actions had to be blameworthy.

Bow's worry faded as the morning got underway. He fell into the dull trap of reading old hunter reports.

At lunch, they got food from a place Glimmer could teleport to without being seen, and then they went to the forbidden archive. They ate at a little table with two chairs stationed at the front door. Glimmer pulled out the spell book, busied herself reading over the resurrection spell, and then flipped over to the illusion spell to check something. She put the hamburger down and leaned into Bow. "I think I've got it. I can resurrect more than one person. If I also call Adam, he can enhance the overall illusion to keep the uncle-" She flipped back to the resurrection spell and then stopped cold.

Bow glanced between her and the book. "What?"

She blinked as her eyes landed on the note scribbled on the side. "I had the answer the whole time..."

“What answer?” Bow begged.

Glimmer leaned in. “The resurrection spell. It only works on direct blood relatives.”

Bow looked at her. “So?”

Glimmer winced. “Uh- so- The spell can’t resurrect an uncle.”

At that, Bow frowned. “But, you and I saw him. He was a green skeleton.”

Glimmer leaned on the table. “Yeah, I know we both saw him. That’s my point. We wouldn’t have seen him unless he was a direct relative.”

Bow’s brow furrowed, then the information trickled in. His face went soft, and he reached out to her hands and closed the book in front of them. “Glimmer, this isn’t good.”

Glimmer said nothing but watched him.

He swallowed and gathered his courage. “This is digging stuff up that should stay buried... Literally.”

She felt a pit open in her stomach. “Bow, what are you saying?”

“I think we should stop.”

She shook her head. “I’m not tired. I’m fine. I told you, it was just a nightmare.”

He put a hand over her hand. “No, I mean we should stop all of this.”

She looked up at him. Their eyes met. “What... what do you mean?”

He took a breath and added, “After last night and what happened with Adora- and Juliet warning her about breach of contract... I

was ok with all this before, but I think she's right. I think the order made all this stuff forbidden for a reason."

Glimmer sat back, moving away from him slightly. "What? So no resurrection?"

He shook his head. "And, after this morning, no more teleportation."

Glimmer balked at him but shut her mouth. She almost said what she truly felt. She couldn't stop teleporting. She had absorbed it somehow. It was now part of her. She had done it while asleep, which... shouldn't have been possible based on everything she had read.

Bow caressed her hand. "I know I agreed to this, but that was then, and this is now. I think resurrecting people- especially someone we know is a bad person- is a really bad idea, and I think we should stop."

She shook her head and held up the book. "But I've researched it. I made a risk management plan. I have a really good plan!"

He looked at her helplessly. "I know, and I'm really proud of you, but-"

Now, she was desperate. She grabbed the spell book and opened it to show him. "I can raise more than one person. I mean, Skele-dude raised three, right?"

Bow sighed, big and heavy. "I know you've put a lot of thought into this, but... I'm not even sure we should be in here now. It feels wrong."

She went into a panicked rush. Opening the spell book to check something before she said, hypothetically, "Look, I can do the illusion. It's easy. I resurrect Adora's brother and father-" She felt a chill down her spine. Glimmer rattled off the rest without thinking, "- under the illusion that the father is here to teach the brother magic so that he'll go through all the same books he went

through when he was here. And that way, we'll have an ally if things get out of hand." She felt an electric crackle on her fingertips. Her brain interpreted it as static electricity until it suddenly stopped. She went cold.

Bow opened his mouth to say something, but he was cut off by a voice just a few bookshelves away.

"Stop slouching and keep your hands to yourself. These books are one of a kind. Priceless."

Bow froze, looking at Glimmer.

Glimmer's eyes went wide. They were in the forbidden archive. They were the only two people who could have been in that room.

They heard Adam's voice, clear as day, "Yes, uncle."

Bow's eyes went wide. Glimmer's hands closed around the book. Had she looked at the spells one too many times? Had she absorbed both the way she had the teleportation spell? She hadn't said any of the words. She didn't do any of the preparations.

"Shit," Glimmer said under her breath.

Dispelled

Chapter Summary

> Catra makes a deal. Things get interesting for Bow and Glimmer.

The car barely warmed up in the long drive down the dark highways to the metroplex. Melig situated itself on the back of Adora's chair, half on her shoulders, half curled into her neck. Like a living scarf.

Catra seemed distracted. Quiet. She let the phone call out the directions.

It was the quiet that bothered Adora. It gnawed at the back of her mind. Catra was so rarely quiet.

Out of nowhere, Catra put her phone down and said, "Are you ok feeding on someone else tonight?"

Adora startled. "What? Why?" She glanced Catra's way and found her girlfriend staring at her intently in the dark.

As they passed the lights of the freeway, they glittered off Catra's eyes, and for a moment, Adora wondered if humans could have their own influence. Catra's eyes were so mesmerizing.

Catra clicked her tongue and looked back down at her phone. "We're making a deal. You don't show up to a deal without the goods and without being willing to prove the goods are as good as you say they are."

"That was a lot of the word good." Adora hesitated and glanced back at Catra when she could. "Maybe I don't have to say this, but I have not bitten anyone else since I first bit you. Glimmer wanted me to, but I told her-"

“Fucking, Glimmer!” Catra started typing on her phone. “She always does this. Always flirts with whoever I bring home.”

“No, no, no. She stopped when I told her it was... kind of intimate for us.”

Catra stopped typing and instead hit the delete button over and over. “Ok. That makes her out to be a little better.”

A long silence.

Catra broke it. “You... think the biting stuff is intimate? Babe, you do it to cows.”

Adora felt a sting in her chest at the idea that they had not been on the same page about that. She opened her mouth to say something but couldn't. She didn’t want to mess this up. It was her being too sentimental.

Catra talked like it was nothing. “The biting is super hot, and I’ll admit I got a kick out of you being so desperate for it. But the exclusivity couldn’t go on forever.”

Adora flinched at that.

Catra reached out a hand, touching Adora’s knee. “This whole problem about winter feeding, it’s not just the rest of the Horde. Adora, this is your problem too.”

The phone called out for her to exit the highway, so she did. Somewhere in the back of her mind, she had thought of this. It just wasn’t at the forefront yet. Maybe she had pushed the thought aside. There were, after all, more important things going on.

Catra broke the silence again. “I’m solving this problem for you as much as anyone else. Worst case scenario-” She rubbed the bridge of her nose. “Even if this doesn’t work for the whole Horde, at least you’ll have a place you can feed. I hope it works for

everyone. I will do everything I can to make it work for everyone, but Adora- I only really care about you." Catra smiled at her.

Adora caught a glimpse of that smile. Her chest fluttered. The phone told her to make the nearest right turn, and the destination was on the left.

"You alright?"

"I'm fine." Was she fine? She wasn't sure if that was a lie. "I'll bite whoever you want me to, as long as they consent."

Catra's smile slipped to a wide one. "Can I watch?"

Adora's cheeks flushed crimson as she parked the car.

Catra switched modes. Her smile was gone. Her voice got even. Business-like. "One thing. This place isn't exactly the cleanest of businesses. They pay protection money to the local mafia. The local mafia that runs the strip club that we-"

Adora's hands gripped the steering wheel. "The place where you got beat up?" Adora had a visceral memory of the weeks it took for Catra's bruises to fully go away. Her split lip was a reminder every time they kissed for weeks. A reminder of how Adora had failed to protect her. The fluttering chest turned into a driving drumbeat. Her body had gone from young love to desire-for-vengeance.

Catra didn't seem to notice. "So, I won't stay long, and I need you to stay in the reception area and keep an eye out for anyone you might recognize from the Crimson Waist... At least till we call you in to do your little magic trick. If you do recognize anyone, don't do anything. Just send me a text to tell me not to come out. It can be in Dutch. I've been learning."

Desire-for-Vengeance disappeared. Adora turned to her girlfriend. "You... what?"

"Nevermind. It's go time," she said as she opened the door.

Melig jumped down with a small huff the moment Adora opened the door. She stood up and looked upon the destination. She stared at the sign. She looked in the windows. It looked...extremely mundane. “What is this place?”

Catra slammed the car door. “Mystacor Massage and Spa. My ex is the owner of a whole chain of these. They’re amazing. The whole concept is themed massages. A whole room done up like a beach with fake waves, hot lights, and sand. A steam grotto. A vampire massage is right up their alley. Imagine a private room where you can get your snack on with someone who consented and is looking forward to the whole thing.”

Adora looked at the place in wonder. “That does sound amazing.” As she looked, she frowned. “Why does this place need to pay protection money?”

Catra had made her way around the car and hooked her arm around Adora’s. “Babe, you don’t just stand outside businesses and announce their dirty laundry.” Catra pulled her toward the building.

Adora’s brows furrowed. “I thought this was a massage parlor... Not a laundromat.”

Catra laughed, light and free.

Adora’s heartbeat quickened. Catra’s laugh was a balm to the soul.

They walked in, and Catra went straight to the front reception desk. A middle-aged woman, dark hair and put together, turned to address them. Her eyes fell on Catra and stopped cold.

Adora’s eyes got big in recognition. This, without a doubt, was the ex. This woman was twice Catra’s age.

Catra’s smile got wide. “Hey there, Casta. How’s it hanging?”

The woman, Casta, blushed. “In my office now,” she said in a rush, looking around nervously.

Catra followed as the woman ducked into the back room.

Adora didn't go. She stayed put because she had been told to wait and keep watch, despite every inch of her wanting to follow in just to chaperone.

Melig meowed at her from the floor. It was a wordless urging for her to relax.

She turned and sat in one of the four chairs in front of the windows. Melig jumped onto her lap, and she rewarded it by immediately scratching at its favorite spots. The cat was right. She needed to trust Catra.

Inside the office, the moment the door was shut, Casta attacked. Pounced like a fucking cougar.

Catra was caught off guard and went from opening her mouth to start on the pitch to pulling a tongue out of it and prying herself out of the woman's grip. "I'm here for business, not pleasure."

The woman blushed even more at the rejection and pulled back. She pretended she was distracted by putting her hair back in place. "Sorry, I- misread the situation."

Catra wiped the woman off her lips and got back to the pitch. "I have something I think you'd like- that your patrons may like."

Casta rolled her eyes and sat down behind the desk. "You know how many pitches I hear a week?"

Catra leveled her eyes at the woman. "I've got something special."

Back out front, Adora tried to close her eyes. This place was supposed to be soothing, right? It was trying really hard to be soothing. Trying a little too much. The place smelled too strongly

of lavender. The fountain in the corner was too loud. The body harness that Adora had under her clothes itched and pulled in places that made it impossible to ignore. Maybe that was the point. With it on, there was no way she'd forget that it was there, and why.

She heard a door open, and because the relaxation wasn't working, she opened her eyes and looked down the hall. Out of one of the private rooms, a woman stepped out. A strong woman, but not tall. Dark hair. Dark skin. Smiling and flushed like she had just... Adora caught the scent that Catra always had about her after their lovemaking. A musk of sweat and hormones. This woman had just climaxed.

The masseuse smiled, flirted, and said she'd pencil the woman in for another *session* next week.

Adora went very still, trying to pretend not to notice. Trying to not act weird. This wasn't someone she recognized from the club, so- she should just try to make this not incredibly awkward.

Melig, on the other hand, stood at attention in her lap. Its back went curved. The hair on its tail puffed up.

Adora tried to push the cat's back down. Automatically, she spoke quiet Dutch. Baby tones, trying to get the animal to focus on her instead of the other person.

The woman started whistling as she stuck her hands in her pockets and strode toward the exit, which would take her past Adora.

Adora's only goal was to prevent the cat from taking a swipe at her.

What should have happened was that Adora got a handle on the cat, and the woman left without taking note of them. Instead, as the woman got closer, Adora looked up and felt a pull. And it was so easy to tug on that pull, and the moment she did-

It was like she had dropped into a dream. She was somewhere else. A back room somewhere shady. The woman who had been walking toward her was bent over someone in a chair with her fist raised. The place smelled like the club, and Adora thought she had to warn Catra. But then she saw who was in the chair.

Catra was in the chair, tied to it. Smiling like a fiend.

In the physical world, Adora stood up and said, "You... were the one that hurt her. You hurt my girlfriend." Something clicked in Adora's consciousness. The desire-for-vengeance came back full force.

Melig meowed and hissed. Adora didn't notice that the animal had started hissing at her, not the woman.

Adora took a step toward the woman.

Inside the office, Casta's brows furrowed. "A vampire? A real vampire?"

Catra nodded and sat forward on her chair. Just to prove her point, she leaned her head and pulled her shirt a little to the side, revealing the pet bite marks that were still present on her neck. "In the flesh."

Casta's whole countenance changed. She looked Catra over. "So... it feels good when they do it?"

Catra licked her lips and nodded.

Casta raised an eyebrow and tapped her desk.

"I think you could make twice your usual fee. Call it a rejuvenation session. The Bloody Kisses special. You handle all the paperwork, consent forms like you do for your normal session with some important addendums. After sundown, I could fill up every room

you wanted to with a vampire ready and willing to work for free. They're getting paid by the feeding."

Casta's dark eyes dilated. The inner capitalist showing through. Money was the language easiest for everyone to understand. This is what the plan rested on. Any massage parlor owner who was offered that sweet deal would buckle instantly. Casta couldn't hide her eagerness. "What's the catch? What's in it for you?"

Catra sat even further on the edge of the seat. "The only thing I ask is ten percent till I have enough to buy a ring. After that, nothing."

Casta's mouth dropped. She covered her mouth with her hand and sat back. "Oh...Oh, Catra-"

Catra watched, slightly confused at that reaction. Had she said something wrong?

Out front, in the physical world, the woman had the vague vacant stair of Adora's influence, but her eyes followed Adora as she walked closer.

Inside their heads, Adora plunged the both of them into a living nightmare. She didn't know how she knew it, but the woman had been scared of dogs from a young age.

Lonnie's heart pounded against her chest as the blonde morphed into a wolf before her. Bared teeth. Glowing red eyes. Matted fur and large paws. The animal opened its mouth, drooling slobber onto the ground. She had never once in her life dealt with that much terror. She froze. Neither fight nor flight kicked in. The horror before her short-circuited her brain and all it's defense mechanisms.

Inside the office...

Casta put her hand down. “Catra, I know I have no place to step in on this but- how long have you known this girl?”

Catra was confused, so she answered honestly. “We started dating on Halloween.”

“So, a few months.” Casta put her hands together. “And... you’re sure you want to marry her?”

Catra blinked. Sat back. “Well, yeah.”

Casta winced.

Catra’s brow furrowed. “It’s love.”

Casta tilted her head as if asking, “really?” without having to voice anything.

Catra couldn’t help but want to defend this. “I feel like- when she’s with me- we’ve somehow known each other all our lives. I can’t imagine being without her. It’s intense.”

Casta leaned back in her office chair. “Young love can be, but that doesn’t mean it’s time to get married.”

Catra watched the woman, confused.

Casta sighed. “A few months isn’t long enough to get past infatuation. Right now, it’s all dopamine and excitement. All the sex is amazing. You love everything about them. In a word, young love is obsession. Don’t you think-” She put her hands down on the desk. “If she really is a vampire... that’s maybe a little dangerous, and I know you, Catra. You're a thrill seeker. Are you really into her or the danger? If you’re into the danger, that’s not a girl you marry.”

Catra’s mind relaxed. She understood now. This was easy. “She’s not a danger to anyone.”

At that moment, out front, Lonnie was pissing herself as the wolf of her nightmares came closer.

Adora's chest buzzed with adrenaline. Her fangs ached to bite into the woman's neck. She soaked in the pleasure of the drenching of fear. It smelled exquisite. A gamy scent that she had not caught for months. She stepped forward, a predator.

The woman had fallen to the floor whimpering, her pants turning dark at the crotch.

Melig walked between them, turned to Adora, and sat down. The cat coughed at her. It was rough and fast and sharp.

It got Adora's full attention. Looking into the animal's eyes, Adora went stone still. In those eyes, she saw long-suffering disapproval. Adora had become attuned to that look on Adam's face. She stopped instantly. She let go of the mental tether holding the woman in her control. The vision of the wolf faded.

Lonnie scrambled to crawl away, reaching the door, and got to her feet, half falling over, before sprinting and screaming like a mad woman into the night.

Adora didn't notice. Adora, instead, looked at the cat that was... disapproving of her. "I'm sorry. I had a nightmare last night, and... it's been hard to shake off." Adora found herself saying to the cat.

The animal trilled at her and rubbed against her leg, and meowed for her to sit back down. It begged to be scratched again.

In a haze of coming back to herself, Adora did as the cat wanted and sat back down and accepted the animal onto her lap. It was then, and only then, that the reality of what she had done- and what she almost did- came to her in sudden horror. She would have hunted the girl. She would have feasted upon her blood and savored every minute of it. She shook it out of her head. Wanted to get the thought out of her system. "It was just the nightmare

last night," She repeated, more to herself than Melig. "It's got me thinking about how things used to be, and I slipped. It's nothing. It won't happen again." Why was she apologizing and making excuses to the cat?

The door to the office opened.

Adora's eyes snapped back up.

Catra had a gleam in her eye and a playful grin. "Hey, babe. We're ready for your demonstration."

Adora stood up with the cat in her arms, afraid to let go. She walked into the office.

Twenty minutes later, they were leaving. Adora wiped the last bit of blood off her mouth.

"You did beautifully," Catra cooed as she opened the car door for Adora.

Adora was glad Catra had watched. In a way, it still felt intimate despite another person there. The woman had sat down, and Adora approached her from behind. Adora watched Catra watching her the whole time. The older woman had moaned, which made Adora blush just thinking about it.

They piled back into the car. "That was your ex?" Adora blurted out, having held it back this whole time.

Melig jumped in Catra's lap this time. "Yeah. So?"

"She's too old for you!"

Catra laughed hard and loud, to the point that Adora was not sure what was so funny.

When Catra finally stopped laughing, she said, "How old are you?"

Adora blinked. “That’s different.”

“It really isn’t” Catra pulled up her phone. “We’ve got to go back to town and stop by the sex shop. Got to spread the word.”

Adora’s jaw clenched. Yes, she was two hundred... but really, she was still just twenty. That’s how... vampires worked... right? Adora swallowed her pride and started the car.

***

Glimmer watched the drop of Adora’s blood shrivel and turn to rust-like dust on the page of the spell book. She looked up at Bow.

“Shut it off,” He whispered.

She almost did. She really almost did... She winced. “It’s already been done. What if we just-” She went silent as the talking got louder.

The *uncle’s* voice sounded deep, resonant, and confident. “Where shall we start? At the back and go through illusions? Discuss the early history of the Order?”

Glimmer bit her lip.

Bow tensed up for a moment before he let out a breath, and his shoulders fell. He had given in.

Glimmer got up.

Bow got up with her.

She didn’t expect that, but... she was thankful.

They turned the corner just as the other two turned the corner putting them finally face to face.

Glimmer didn’t know what she was expecting. Some part of her brain still expected the green skeleton walking around bare with

bright red spots in the hollows where his eyes should be. Instead, he was just a man. A man that if they had ever seen him in the flesh before, there would have been no question that his man was their father. He had the same build as Adam, just slightly taller. The same color eyes as the twins. The same golden blond hair. A spitting image of the both of them but older, with a goatee. He stopped when he saw them.

Bow and Glimmer looked at the person next to him.

Adam looked... different. A few weeks ago, they had spent three days in an alternative dimension with him. He had been full of life. Happy. Strong. Now, he looked... depressed? It was such a stark contrast to the vibrant man she knew and the person that Bow had developed a ridiculous crush on. The stark difference caused them both to lose their words.

Adam looked up briefly, and there was no recognition in his eyes. Those blue-gray eyes held a palpable sadness. His sword hung on his belt. He wore the same overcoat they had seen him in before. But his eyes were sunken in like he hadn't been sleeping. Do the dead sleep? Glimmer was faced with the possibility that maybe she hadn't done it right. Somehow, something had gone wrong. She almost ended it. She almost cut off the magic right then and there and called a do-over.

The only thing that stopped her was the older man smiling as he saw her and moving forward, offering his hand. "Ah, I didn't know the Order had approved other interested parties to look through the formerly forbidden archive." He shook Bow's hand first. "Keldor Van Helsing at your service."

Bow gave an attempt at seeming interested in the handshake, but his eyes and his attention were on Adam.

Adam wouldn't look up.

The older man turned his attention to Glimmer. His eyes glanced over her hair. There was a spark of interest. He took her hand and

lowered himself to kiss her knuckles. Before his lips touched her skin, he said something in French that sounded inappropriate, the way all French sounded when an older man said it to a younger woman while kissing her hand.

Glimmer blushed, and she felt immediately guilty about that. It was just- he looked so much like Adam and Adora, and the damn hand kiss had been so old-fashioned and smooth, damn it.

After the man came up, he continued to hold her hand and motioned behind him. “And this is my nephew, Adam.”

Glimmer flinched at the word nephew. She then took her hand away from him and turned to Adam.

With what seemed like a monumental effort, Adam looked up at them and forced a half-hearted smile. “It’s good to meet both of you.” His voice was weak, but as he looked at them, there was a moment. He looked a moment too long. Something crossed his face.

As much as she wanted him to remember them, to give him news of Adora- to let him know that they had won the last fight against the man standing in front of her, she couldn’t risk it. *Don’t waste time. Get to the point. No pleasantries* . She forced herself to turn to the man who called himself Keldor. “Mr. Van Helsing, I am in need of your assistance finding something in this archive.”

Keldor, the man, seemed infinitely more graceful than the Skele-dude they fought before. His body moved in languid confident ways and settled into a noble posture with his chest puffed out, one hand behind his back and the other open in invitation. “Why, of course. You have my services for whatever you need, my young lady.”

Damn it. She felt her cheeks flush again and tried to get through it by deflecting. “Is there... something wrong with your companion?”

Keldor looked back at Adam. “Too many sleepless nights doing his job, I’m afraid.”

Adam looked at the man pretending to be his uncle. “Where is Adora? I don’t... I don’t remember where she is.”

Glimmer was going to come up with an excuse. She hadn’t thought of what to say to him about Adora, but she didn’t need to. Keldor stepped in.

“She’s with my brother training. You know as well as I do she has a distinct disdain for the arcane. They both do. More willing to put their faith in steel than in words on a page, as I recall.”

“I don’t remember saying I wanted to learn magic either.”

Glimmer stiffened. Her brain was working to come up with something to say to smooth this out.

Keldor didn’t give her the chance. “Don’t get cold feet now. We’ve got the clearance, and we’ve traveled all this way.”

Adam looked perturbed but didn’t have the energy to do or say anything.

Glimmer rushed in to get to the point before anyone could bring up any other inconsistencies. “Well, Mr. Van Helsing, why don’t you and I look for something, and my companion can take care of yours.”

Bow looked so relieved. He had been holding his breath and now let it out and gave her a look of supreme thanks. It broke Glimmer’s heart. He was worried about Adam.

Bow moved in, putting his arm around Adam’s shoulders and leading him back to the table. “Why don’t we get you to a chair so you can rest.”

Adam mumbled small words of thanks.

Glimmer turned her attention to the man of the hour. The necromancer who didn't know he was a necromancer... or did he? "Do you know where to find information about the catacombs?"

His face passed through surprise, then interest, before settling on a dashing look of mischievousness. "Of course. I know just what you're looking for. Though, I must warn you of the forbidden things in this forbidden archive; you'll lose your job if they find out you've looked at it."

"No one ever has to know, right?"

He smiled wide. "A woman of my own heart. Follow me." He took off at a brisk walk down the row.

She rushed to follow him, but her mind was back on Bow and Adam and what in the world she had done wrong. Maybe it was just a side effect of doing it accidentally.

Keldor stopped a few shelves down and pulled out a book. "The earliest records of the founding of the Order are here." He handed her a leather-bound book with gold lettering on the spine, then turned to her. "To save you time, you can just tell me what you want to know, and I can answer you."

"I think we can find it ourselves."

"It's written in a cipher that took me two years to break."

Her heart sank. She looked up at him, unsure. "We need to know why the catacombs were created in the first place."

He stood up straight and leaned against the shelf. He looked pleased. "It is surprisingly simple." He stroked his goatee."The skulls of vampires don't turn to dust and ash when they die unless they have done something extra to prevent it, and few vampires have the resources for something like that. Within the vampire skull is a very small amount of the dark blood magic that created them. Strung together and put down in tunnels dug along ley lines, the catacombs can have a very simple spell spread over a

large area. Before he descended into necromantic madness, the original founder of the Order came up with the mechanisms to make it work."

Glimmer stared at him. "So... it's a spell. What does the spell do?"

He seemed to enjoy the attention. He seemed to love being smart and having the answers. "It's the reason vampires can't enter homes without invitation."

Again, she didn't know what she was expecting, but that wasn't it. She should have cut the magic right then and there. She had the objective. She had the answer in her hand.

He leaned in. "That's what you're here for, but that's not really what you want to know, is it?"

She bit her lip. There were so many mysteries she could just solve by asking. She sorted through them. Eventually, her dad would teach her magic once he realized Adora was not dangerous. The man before her was a better source for a different line of questioning. The stuff that she had no chance of answering without him specifically. "Why is it so important to the order that the Van Helsing line continued? Was it about the sword?"

He looked at her as if re-appraising. His eyes narrowed. "You've read my diary."

Her heart was beating hard against her breastbone. She set her face to not react.

He leaned in, and his eyes were mesmerizing. "You must have high clearance within the order." He got a devilish grin. "And you read Latin."

"Fluently."

"Come," he said as he turned and walked quickly.

Glimmer followed him, conscious that she was getting further away from Bow.

Keldor suddenly stopped at another shelf as they heard, shelves away, Bow laugh, and Adam laugh weakly along with him. Bow, being Bow, was trying to cheer the guy up.

Keldor tipped a book out of its place. "This is the *Dissertatio de Hominibus Post Mortem Sanguisuga.* I assume you understand the title."

Glimmer nodded and answered as if this was one of her father's tests. "Dissertation on the Bloodsucking dead."

He gave her the same quiet, approving nod her dad would have. "Correct. This forbidden archive has many such manuals, but this one is the only one that really matters to your query." He opened the book, flipped to a page, and held it out to her. "This book was written in 1732. Before then, the Van Helsing family had a fetch. I know from family tradition that it was a cat."

Glimmer forced herself to not react, but her mind went wild. Bow had mentioned it as a joke. Glimmer had even told him she didn't sense anything about it the way she sensed Adora, the catacombs, or anything else.

"And after 1732, there was no more cat. Instead, we had a sword."

Glimmer's brain lit up with understanding. She blinked. "The sword... was the cat?" A few weeks ago, this man called whatever was in the sword a goddess. He had referred to her as The Eye of Ra. Her brain struggled to layer that concept over what she had taken as a stray cat.

His eyes narrowed at her. "Interesting you would use the past tense."

Glimmer flinched.

He dropped the book.

Instinct made her reach out to grab the dropped book, the book that held the rest of the answers.

He grabbed her arm.

Pain shot through her, like what Shadow Weaver had done. The other book fell out of her hands. She tried to stop the magic. It wouldn’t stop. She looked up.

Keldor got close, squeezing her wrist. “The problem about illusions, my dear, is that they can be broken.” He snapped the fingers of his free hand.

Glimmer felt a wave of magic leave her.

Keldor pulled her closer to him, the skin of his face starting to droop and peel off, revealing a green smiling skull. He started laughing out of a hinged green jawbone.

Panic seized her. She screamed Bow’s name.

Bingo

Chapter Summary

> Glimmer gets a lesson in necromancy. Adora and Catra communicate. Micah ignores his better judgment.

Glimmer's scream was cut off by Keldor chanting Latin and casting his hands out to the ground. With each cast, pain shot through her as she felt a voltage drain. Her voice was drowned out by the sound of earth moving and the clanking of what sounded like wood hitting wood. Just beyond them, things were pushing themselves out of the dirt and stone. White hard things appeared. Bones. Moving on their own. Clawing out of the ground and pushing themselves up to standing.

She heard Bow and Adam down the hall, running toward them, and turned back to Keldor.

He jerked her toward him, forcing her to look at him in the sparks of magical light that replaced his eyes. In a near seamless way, from all his practice in ventriloquism weeks back, he said in a high nasally voice, "The Shadow Bitch was right. You are quite useful as a battery! And, you seem to be dabbling in minor resurrection, which also means you show interest in a future career in necromancy. Wonderful. I'll be your mentor. Get your pen and paper ready. First lesson, skeleton summoning. Really useful in a pinch, but very resource heavy. If you don't have a demi-goddess to steal magic from, homemade is-"

She spat a wad of spit onto his green bone face and yelled, "Fuck you!"

What felt like miles away, she heard Bow and Adam on the other side of a horde of skeletons.

Keldor opened his mouth to chant again. He was about to summon more.

She needed to keep him talking. She needed to give Bow and Adam time. “You ass! You’d kill your own son in cold blood?”

He clamped his jaw shut. He leveled his gaze at her, and even though he had lost the ability to emote, he still somehow looked curious. He pulled her back, moving her toward the wall. “He’s not quite alive, though, is he? You made sure of that.”

Glimmer’s jaw clenched and she burned at him.

“Oh, did I hit a sore spot there? Didn’t quite fully comprehend the process did you? Don’t worry. You have plenty of time to observe since I’m never letting you go now that I have you.” His grip on her tightened. He paused. “Also, you’re assuming I care that he and Adora are my progeny. Sure I went through the trouble of making them and then going through all the rituals to make them the best vampire hunters ever born. I dedicated them to the goddess in the blade, the old way our ancestors used to, which- I don’t even know if that’s a good idea. I mean, sure, there's got to be consequences for that, but it’s not my problem, so I don’t give a shit.”

Wow. It was not hard to keep this guy talking.

He kept on. “But I lose myself. They were always just reagents for me. It’s easier to do blood magic to become a necromancer when you have direct blood relatives to experiment on. You should take notes. Have kids first, but don’t have ones you care about. Makes the resulting blood magic too messy. I mean, it's blood magic, it’s always going to be messy, but I mean emotionally. You get attached, and suddenly you don’t want to kill the bastards or drain their lifeforce.” Another uttered a bit of Latin, and a handful of skeletons burst out of the ground to charge.

Glimmer grunted at the pain of that magic being stolen from her.

He prattled on in a wistful voice as if reminiscing. “My brother was so happy at his supposed good fortune, he never stopped to really think about it too hard. He never really looked at his own kids

long enough to think, hey- they kind of look like my brother. But shouldn't we all take a lesson from that? Live life simply. Don't think too much about it. Don't look a gift horse in the mouth, or you'll see your cheating whore of a wife."

Behind them, Bow yelled, and Adam yelled back. They were both hacking at the waves of skeletons coming toward them. A glimpse and Glimmer saw Adam swinging the blade, taking down three skeletons to dust. Bow was taking out two with the leg of a chair. He looked up, and they made eye contact with her before the skeletons swarmed between them.

Keldor clacked his teeth before saying under his breath, "I forgot about that damn sword he had with him. Did you have to summon him in his full hunter gear? Have you no imagination?"

Her arm ached. His grip was too hard, and the magic flowing felt like a constant stream of electricity. She couldn't shut off the flow, but maybe, she could redirect it. "You can't get out of here. We're in the headquarters, and the door is locked." The words rattled off on their own while she wondered if glancing at a spell was enough for her to absorb it. She remembered the spell, remembered the page. A spell for summoning light from the fingertips. It had been marked as "doesn't work." So far, she had done other things he couldn't, so she thought of the spell and diverted some magic to her fingers.

She felt a spark there. A glowing ember of magic in her palm. She could barely contain her excitement. Barely hide it on her face. She was going to out magic a man who studied for a decade. *Fuck this dude.*

He looked up, realized the fighting noises were getting close and spoke a few more words. More skeletons climbed out of the churned ground, and he turned away from the fight toward the wall. "Oh, that's where you're mistaken, wench. I have you and a near limitless supply of magic through you to dig myself out."

Glimmer roared and used the last of her strength to throw her palm and the glowing, burning hot ball of blue flames into his face.

His jaw opened wordlessly as he dodged one way as his other hand swiped to try and divert the path.

For a brief moment, the magic stopped flowing, and the skeletons behind them fell to the ground.

"Fucking bitch!" Keldor screamed high-pitched and nasally.

She looked back. Bow stopped hitting and held the chair leg aloft. Adam had switched his grip on the sword, his eyes on Keldor and Keldor alone.

Glimmer knew that grip. She knew that look in his eyes. She had once seen it in Adora's. She pulled back as far as she could, giving Adam a clear target.

Adam's face was stern. Set in focus. He was angry. Still sad, still not right. Still broken, but with a fire of pure rage behind it. He chucked the sword like a spear the way Adora had in their recent adventure because, sometimes, you had to throw a fucking sword.

The blade soared through the air, a gleaming needle through the throng of skeletons coming back to life from the brief diversion, and cut through the air and hit just above the elbow of Keldor's arm, lopping it off just above the elbow. The maniac screamed, but the control was severed.

Glimmer fell back and cut the magic off. The skeletons slumped into lifeless bone piles.

The man before her was gone, and so was the severed arm. The forbidden archive fell into dead silence, except for Bow's feet on the churned ground, stepping on bones left, dragged out of their deep graves. "Glimmer!" He fell at her side.

She grabbed his shirt and pulled him into a kiss.

He made a noise in his throat but didn't fight her. She pulled back, looked him in the eye, and said, "Did you see me? I threw a light ball at him! I resurrected two people and then made a light ball!"

Bow looked... confused. Adrenaline was still pumping through him. His pupils were constricted. Then, he looked above her eyes, and he frowned.

In that moment of waiting for Bow to explain, she started to feel the first signs of what Catra had dubbed "magic sickness".

Bow reached to the side of her head and pulled her hair forward so she could see.

Her hair was her father's dark color, from root to tip. The moment she saw it, she felt the full sickening feeling in her stomach that had seized her after Shadow Weaver used her. "I'm out of magic, aren't I."

Bow's eyes went wide. "How... how do we get out?"

The sickness permeated every inch of her. It made her nauseous, but she could feel the magical current of the catacombs pulsing just beyond the wall. She didn't even realize she had started scrambling on the floor toward it. She didn't even realize that Bow was surprised, that he was trying to talk to her, that he was confused and maybe scared.

She put her hands on the wall in a wild desperation. There was no thought in her mind, no question of whether this was necessary or reasonable. She didn't even know how she did it, maybe picked it up from the way both Shadow Weaver and Keldor managed to suck magic out of her, but she connected to the current of the skulls, and it started flowing into her. She felt less sick the longer she waited, and when it stopped, she reached out for Bow. "Hand!"

He grabbed her hand without question.

She teleported them both the two feet necessary to end up on the other side of the wall. She landed on her feet, and so did Bow, and once she was there, she started to laugh.

Bow looked at her with a growing frown. “Are you... ok?”

She forced herself to stand up straight, despite still feeling off. She would need to charge in the moonlight for a while, but that could wait. She beamed at him. “We did it! We got the information! I’m a fucking sorceress! And I didn’t need Dad.”

Bow’s shoulders fell as his eyes drifted past her. He finally dropped the chair leg. “Glimmer...”

She turned to him, ready to be showered with praise. “Yeah?”

Bow pointed behind her.

She turned.

The long tunnel of the catacomb stretched out in both directions away from them. The skulls were gone. They had all crumpled to ash and dust on the floor.

Glimmer finally lost her smile. “Oh... That’s bad.” After a moment of thought, a sheepish smile crept back despite her stomach starting to do flips. “But hey, wasn’t that always the goal? Just one less catacomb we have to dismantle later.”

Bow frowned. “I guess.” He took a breath. “And, I guess you found a good fast way to do it.”

“That’s right. All’s well that ends well. This was, one hundred percent, a successful night.” She took a step to leave, and her knee gave out under her.

Bow rushed forward to support her, and they started limping toward the stairs.

It was a long walk up to the roof where they could get some moonlight. “Any chance you could carry me?”

He didn’t hesitate but instead swept her into his arms.

Despite the sickness, she giggled.

He smiled. “I don’t think I’ll ever get used to how brave you are.” His smile faded. “That was scary. Let's... never do anything like that again.”

She hummed a noncommittal response, leaned her head against his shoulder, and tried hard not to throw up.

***

Catra steadied the cat and herself by bracing against the door. Adora was driving strangely. Not fast, but she turned suddenly like she had forgotten the route until the very last moment. She was... probably distracted.

The cat turned its heterochromatic eyes in a big pleading look up at Catra.

Catra sighed. “Ok. Fine. I’ll fix her.”

“You’ll what?” Adora said, not angry, but again, distracted.

“What’s wrong?”

Adora flinched at that. “Nothing. Nothing is wrong.”

“What did I do?”

Adora’s jaw worked, and for a moment, she chewed on her lip before saying, “How in the world did you end up dating that woman? I mean, did you go get a massage? You... don’t seem like the type.” She paused, then tilted her head. “Then again, maybe you do because that didn’t seem like a normal massage parlor.”

Catra petted Melig, trying to calm it. “I needed a job, and Micah contacted a distant relative of his to see if I could work there. He didn’t know it wasn’t a normal massage parlor. I worked the desk. Figured everything out pretty quick, but I needed the money, so I didn’t squeal... though I almost did because I was trying to get the attention of a lady cop at the time.”

Adora had gone stiff in the seat as she pulled the car into one of the few parking spots in the strip mall where the sex shop was. For a moment, she didn’t move. She didn’t turn off the car.

The cat in Catra’s hands was stiff too. On edge. She tried to get it to relax by running fingers down its back. “What? Did I say something?”

Adora turned to her with searching eyes as her hands shut off the car in a practiced motion. “How... many women have you dated?”

Catra hissed at the nails of the cat digging into her jeans, so she moved the cat to the back seat and turned to look Adora in the face, meeting her focus with intensity. “I lost count.”

Adora’s focus never wavered. “Are we talking...five?”

“Oh, wow.” Catra couldn’t help but smile.

Adora looked like she was going pale. “Six?”

Catra looked back at the cat, which was kneading the back seat and settling down for a nap before she opened the door and said, “Higher, babe.”

Adora’s face flashed with mild shock, but she opened the door. She rolled down her window for the cat to get some air, and they both walked toward the building.

Adora put her hands in her pockets and looked up, and a new shade of horror came to her face as she looked into the window. “I’ll just stay outside.”

Catra looked up and understood immediately. Huntara was at the desk. Adora was blushing a little. *Cute.* "Are you embarrassed that she helped you? Don't be. Huntara won't be weird about it. She's a friend. She and I go way back." She went to open the door for Adora.

Adora shook off the cold and stepped in. "Let me guess, she's an ex?"

Ah, the tone. Through the tone, it was obvious Adora was trying to be sarcastic. Implying that it was a ridiculous assertion. Catra just smiled and said, "How did you know?"

She watched Adora's body react to that. A shiver went all the way through her.

Catra, smiling and smug, went past her and straight to the front desk.

Adora stayed behind and sulked against the wall.

Huntara was a seasoned butch who spent half her time in the gym and half running the shop. Her signature was the purple tribal tattoos she had all over her body. No one knew if they were purple by choice or had just faded to that distinct color, and no one was going to ask.

Huntara's eyes flicked up to Adora, and before Catra could stop her, she yelled, "Hey there, Blondie. Still happy with the consultation?"

Adora blushed furiously, muttered a quiet, "Yes, thank you," and tried to duck away to pretend to look at the bondage gear.

Catra leaned on the counter. "Lay off. She's a newbie, and you're making it worse."

Huntara leaned on the counter opposite and focused her attention completely on Catra. "I guess I should instead ask you for the review." She winked. "How was it, Wildcat?"

“Exceptional, but I’m not here to praise your education skills.” She, instinctually, played with the little silver cross necklaces hanging on a display on the countertop. This was flirting. When she had first met Huntara, the woman had warned her that if she caught her stealing anything, she’d punish her in the back storage room. Catra had looked her dead in the eye and stuffed some cheap thing from the counter into her pants. Such was the beginning of a short and intense relationship. “I need to call in that favor you owe me.”

Huntara lifted an eyebrow.

“The night after tomorrow night. Mysticore Spa and Massage. Real honest to god vampires and the bite is out of this world. Better than ecstasy and not illegal.” She stated the price. “Tell anyone who's interested to ask for the Bloody Kisses special.”

Huntara leaned back. Her eyes slid to Adora's reflection in the single dome spy mirror in the corner of the room. “Is this a cosplay thing?” Still looking at Adora. “Because your girl didn’t look like that last time I saw her.” Huntara clarified by pointing at her own eyes and teeth to indicate that yeah, Adora’s eyes were a different color and her fangs were still sticking out a little.

Catra stopped toying with the necklaces, leaned in, and whispered, “No cosplay. She’s the real deal.”

Huntara looked at her, then the reflection of Adora pretending to browse by picking up a pack of nipple clamps, realizing what they were, blushing furiously, and putting them back. Huntara shook her head. “Catra... Are you... pimping out your girlfriend? I know you’re willing to go pretty low, but I didn’t think that low.”

Now Catra raised an eyebrow. “It’s not sex. It’s just biting. And besides, my girl needs to eat, and I’m a fucking provider.”

Huntara rolled her eyes.

Catra felt her heartbeat quicken. The flicker of a pilot light of anger started in her chest. “I am. Or, at least, I’m one now.” She

ran her fingers through her hair, reminding herself to keep calm. She leaned in and whispered, "Just... contact my old circle of fuck buddies. I know half of them would be into it. Give them a good long description of my girl over there."

Huntara looked at her searchingly. "So... this *is* a sexual thing."

"It's not sex. Just sex appeal. I need..." She found the words caught in her throat. She couldn't explain why she needed this. How the idea of Adora going hungry, of her having to break into a barn, or worse, feed on Glimmer as a last resort... those were all unacceptable futures. She settled on, "I need the biggest possible crowd to show up. Adora won't feed on anything but girls, so I need girls for her to live, and- well, if I have to pull the sex appeal card to get them to show up and keep coming back, then that's what I'll do."

At that, Huntara scratched her chin and offered, "Sure. Fine. I'll sell this because I owe you." She pulled back a little. "But if you care about her that much, I'm going to warn you right now that stuff like this... it seems fine in theory, but in practice... I just need assurances that you're not going to go off on some girl I send your way just because you suddenly get a case of *the jealousies* ."

Catra's jaw clenched. The pilot light was back. "I won't even be there. I can't hang around because of..." *Well, because of Lonnie and to a lesser extent Scorpia.* "-my own problems. My being around complicates things, so tell them that if they hate me and never want to see me again, I won't be there, so they have nothing to worry about." She'd ask Glimmer and Bow to stand guard. Surely they could take one night off their quest to support the Horde Lord... and roommate. Besides, Catra had other plans for that night, depending on how things went.

Huntara nodded. "Alright. That I can agree to. I'll make flyers. Hand them out to everyone and tell all my employees to do so too. And, I'll call your old circle and give them the message."

Catra's shoulders relaxed.

They didn't waste time on small talk. Catra thanked her sincerely and showed her thanks (and commitment to this new girl) by not stealing anything.

Catra turned her attention to finding Adora, and she did find her, standing at the leather gear, face red. Shoulders and jaw tight.

Catra stopped short. "What now?"

Adora breathed in and out quickly and turned on her. "I have superhuman hearing, remember?"

Catra blinked at her. "So?"

Adora's voice went quiet, but somehow she managed to sound like she was shouting. "Your circle of fuckbuddies? Half of them would be into it? How many..." for a moment, she looked lost. "How many girls, Catra?"

The pilot's light of anger was gone. What came over her was a blanket of pure calm. This was a conversation she had scripts for. "Does it matter?"

Adora's eyes got wide. She moved back a little. She opened her mouth like she wanted to say something but couldn't find it.

Catra moved in, took Adora's hand, and led her not to the entrance but toward the back. "I didn't mean for you to hear all that."

Adora gripped her hand, maybe half with anger, maybe half with a desire to reconnect. Still in the whispering yell, "Oh, what? Were you expecting me to just chomp on half of every girl you ever slept with without knowing it?" Adora's voice was getting shaky like she was on the verge of crying.

"Yes. I was." Her own voice was level. She pulled Adora to the back employee-only area, right next to the sign that said "No Sex

in the Sex Shop." She pushed the staff door open and pulled Adora into the storage room.

Catra pushed Adora up against the wall, her knees buckling against one of the many storage boxes piled up there.

Adora half fell onto the box, half leaned.

Catra pressed her body against her lover's because she had an instinct that words would only make things worse and not get across the message. Her body might.

Adora's breath caught. She looked confused in the dim light that came through the staff door window.

Catra ran a hand along Adora's thigh.

In a shaking voice, Adora turned her head away and asked, "What are you doing?"

Catra leaned in, kissing Adora's jaw.

Adora caught a whimper in her throat.

Catra closed her eyes, savored the taste of her lover's skin, and whispered, "Are you jealous?"

Adora hesitated a moment but nodded slightly.

This was a good sign. It meant Adora was listening. It meant she was still invested. That was good. Catra had lost good girls like Adora, more often than not, when her history came out. "I like sex, so the moment it was an option, I went for it and never stopped. I left a lot of girls in my wake. Half of them I hurt without realizing it. It took me some time to figure out how people worked about that stuff... I'm sorry. I should have told you the extent of it earlier."

Adora's hands, shaking, moved up to hold Catra's waist.

Catra breathed out slowly, sinking into the feeling that this was an olive branch. A motion of reconciliation.

Adora looked like she was working up to something. When she finally talked, her voice shook. “I just... It caught me off guard... I’m... intimidated.” She moved her hands a little on Catra. “That's a lot to live up to. A lot of ground you’ve covered that I haven’t. I don’t know if I can do it. I don’t know if I can keep you satisfied.” And there it was. The real truth. Adora deflated at that admission, her shoulders slumping a little.

Catra couldn't help but smile. “Totally normal thoughts.”

Adora took a long slow, shaking breath. “Yeah?”

Catra moved to put them face to face, nose to nose. “How can I make you feel better?” Catra slid the hand on Adora’s thigh up to her hip, then her stomach, and under her fingertips, she felt the leather straps, and her brain went off. She had been so carefully doing this, talking it out, just like she had been taught, and the moment she realized that Adora had put on the fucking harness the moment her back was turned... Blood started pumping. Her nipples went taught against her shirt. “Oh, shit.”

Adora’s eyes got wide.

Catra grabbed the bottom of Adora’s shirt and pulled up.

Adora leaned back against the wall, helpless and confused, and let Catra expose her bare chest. Catra practically drooled at the way the leather tightened and pressed Adora’s breasts up and out. The way it looked like it was just barely containing her muscles. This was a good look on her girlfriend, and it was making it hard to think.

Catra breathed heavily. She didn’t let the shirt down. She turned to Adora with what she hoped was a pleading expression. “Babe...”

Adora’s eyebrows knit in confusion.

"You can't expect me to focus on emotional shit with something like this between us." Her other hand went exploring, looking for the bulge that would mean that Adora brought the other part of the ensemble. That she had been a good student of Huntara, and planned for some spontaneous sex. "Did you bring the-" Her hand stopped on Adora's jacket. The dildo was in Adora's inner jacket pocket. "Fuck."

Adora moved her arms, so the jacket fell open, allowing Catra access to pull the thing out.

Catra gulped as she grasped it. "I'm sorry... Can our... conversation wait for like twenty minutes?"

Adora's face lit up in a brightness that was confusing. "Yes. Sure. Actually... that would make me feel better." She hesitated for a moment before saying, "I think- I just need assurances that you still like me, even if... I'm not as mature as the masseuse lady, or as buff as the woman at the counter and... not as experienced as you."

Good girl , Catra thought. *She's communicating!* Catra savored every ounce of what she was about to say. She let every word wilt off her tongue. "Oh, Adora, this is not because I like you."

Adora frowned.

Catra moved in, pressing herself against Adora's nearly bare chest. "It's because I *love* you."

Adora exhaled and leaned her head back against the wall.

At that sign, the tension was gone. Whatever lay unspoken between them, it was moot. What mattered was skin on skin. The hot dripping excitement of getting to do this unexpectedly. All other thoughts left Catra's head, and she went for the button of Adora's pants. What better way to prove to a lover that they could hold your attention by lavishing them with it?

Adora opened her eyes wide. “Are you sure you want to do it right here?”

Catra smiled. “Oh, you’re the one dragging me around town to fuck in alleyways, and you’re going to throw a fit about doing it in a storage room?”

Adora looked a little bit unsure. “What if that lady comes in and finds us?”

Catra licked her lips. “She’ll probably ask to join us.”

Even in the dark, Adora’s chest and neck flushed red.

Catra bent down, kissing at the nape of Adora’s neck to chase that flush. Trying to heighten Adora’s accidental arousal at the suggestion.

Adora moaned into those small kisses and gave way with a whimper.

Catra pulled away to make more room for getting Adora prepped.

Adora watched her and surprised herself as her fangs slid out.

Catra smiled up at her as she started to pull Adora’s jeans down from her hips. “Oh, you’re all desperate for a taste of me, aren’t you?”

Adora bit her lip, and her fang, longer and sharper than she was used to, pierced the skin. Adora flinched at the unexpected pain. Dark thick blood pooled.

Catra fixated on it, thinking of all the times Adora had sucked on her lip back when Lonnie busted it. She wanted to return the favor and, for a moment, ignored the preparation and moved back up to kiss and suck the pain away.

Adora threw one hand into Catra’s shoulder, hard, fast. Her other hand clamped over her own mouth. “Applesauce!”

Catra grunted at the pain from her shoulder, but she froze. Protocol was that everything stopped the moment the word was uttered and stayed stopped till things were figured out. “What happened?”

Adora’s eyes were wide with terror. She didn’t take her hand away from her mouth. “Nothing. I just... I can’t. I’m... overwhelmed.” Her hand didn’t leave Catra’s shoulder. She was shaking, scared, as she pulled her hand away from her mouth and saw the blood. In a rush, she wiped it on a box under her.

Catra, with the dildo in hand, said, “Did I do something wrong?”

“No!” Said too fast, too quickly. Another, slightly calmer. “No. I just... I can’t right now. I can’t explain it.”

Catra pulled back, pulling her shoulder out of Adora’s death grip. She glanced at the blood returning to Adora’s lip in a bead of red liquid, to her hand, then the box. “Ok. A rain check on the love confirmation kinky sex in the back of the sex club.” She slid the dildo back into Adora’s jacket and indicated that this was ok. That stopping was ok. Sure she was frustrated, but this was what trust was built on. Having rules and following them. Catra pulled down Adora’s shirt. She then produced a fresh new unblemished handkerchief from her own jacket and handed it to Adora.

Adora took the cloth, still shaken to the core. “Thanks,” she said as she put it straight to the broken lip.

Adora would have no way of knowing she wasn’t keeping any secrets. The way she reacted. What she had reacted to. Catra’s heart raced as she realized this was how vampires were made.

Sure, the idea that something as simple as kissing Adora could have consequences got her heart pounding. That was normal. Right? Sure, she couldn’t stop thinking about the romanticism of, instead of getting married, the two of them being bound by blood in some fucked up power dynamic forever. That was... normal,

right? It was normal to get excited at the idea of forever. Totally normal.

Adora looked at her strangely. “Are you ok? Your eyes just dilated.”

Catra nodded, even as Casta’s warnings about being a thrill seeker kept smashing up against her brain. She pulled back, offered her hand to her girlfriend... the woman she wanted to make her wife, and maybe the woman she wanted to make more than her wife, and said, through all the inner turmoil of what she had just figured out, “Come on. Let's get out of here. I need some fresh air.” She needed a cold shower, but cold air would do in a pinch.

“Same,” Adora said as she took Catra’s hand.

***

The sun was out, burning off the chill of the night. Micah had, yet again, faked going to work, and while he drank the coffee his wife had made him, he met up with the hunters at their last location and started the search again.

Micah was thinking about his vacation leave and how he had wasted it so far. He was following the three horses, driving slow. The path seemed to be random. His overwhelming thought was that this had more to do with water dowsing than vampire hunting. It was... probably a scam. That was the problem with truth spells. They only worked if the person answering knew what they were saying was a lie. What if these women believed themselves to be vampire hunters, and were themselves being scammed by someone else? He was glad he had not given them any money upfront. They’d probably try to say he owed a fee for the horses. He was thinking this as they reached the outskirts of town, and the lead horse, Swifty, and its rider, an eleven-year-old girl, turned sharply. The horse broke into a brisk trot, and the other two women, on their horses, had to spur them to catch up.

Micah hit the gas a little harder than what he had been creeping at for hours and turned to follow.

The horse trotted, fast and happy, toward a strip mall that held a bridal shop, a baby shop, and finally, a twenty-four-hour sex shop on the corner.

He parked the car just as the pink-haired woman grabbed the reins of their adopted daughter, said something quietly to the other one, and started leading her away. She smiled at Micah as he got out of his car and said, "You and Netossa take care of this while I take Frosta and Swifty for a food break."

Frosta groaned and slumped her shoulders. "I never get to do the fun stuff," she muttered as they trotted away.

Netossa swung off her horse and motioned for him to follow.

He slammed the door of his car and walked toward the building. When he got near her, he asked, "What's going on?"

Netossa shrugged. "Strong scent. Unusually strong. Like, they left some part of themselves here or something. We usually don't see that kind of response unless, you know, they bled." She glanced at the sign and added, "And I'm not surprised by the location. Perfect place to find victims." She pressed forward, right toward the door.

Micah stood, not sure if he should go in or not. It was one thing to lie to your wife about going to work. It was a completely different thing to play hooky by going to a sex shop with another woman.

Netossa looked back, held the door open as she stepped aside, and said, "Well? You comin'?"

His feet moved him. Curiosity was greater than his better judgment. He walked in, then stopped dead still when he realized he wasn't prepared for this at all. In every direction, he was surrounded by things that, at first glance, didn't look like they

belonged there. He wasn't even sure what half of them were, and his head hurt the more he thought about what they could be. The world moved fast without you, and the modern world still occasionally gave him mental shocks like this. It never got any easier.

Netossa walked around him, raising her hand to greet the tired, muscle-bound woman with purple tattoos at the counter. "Hey, Huntara- I've got a question for you."

The woman looked up at Micah, then back to Netossa. "You know me. I'm not here to judge."

Netossa waved her hand in dismissal. "He's a friend from work." She stopped at the counter and put both hands down. "Did anybody bleed here last night?"

Huntara lifted an eyebrow. "Nah. All my usuals were busy." She gave a lopsided smile.

Netossa shook her head and folded her arms. "Ok, then you have anyone show up who was into blood kinks or something?"

Huntara's smile was gone. She looked around, reached under the counter, and said, "I think I have just what you're looking for." She produced a red piece of paper and put it face down on the counter.

"Thanks," Netossa said flippantly, grabbing the paper as she turned to leave.

Micah followed Netossa out. Once the door was shut behind him, he asked, "What is that?"

Netossa flipped over the paper and lowered her head to read it. She clicked her tongue and held out the paper to him.

He squinted to read it.

On the red paper was printed some clip art of vampire fangs and the words “Bloody Kisses Special.” A price. A date. A location.

She smiled. “Bingo.”

Promises

Chapter Summary

> Adora makes a promise to Light Hope. Catra makes a promise to Glimmer.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Catra woke up to a notification on her phone about an email saying that the ring was ready. She still needed to pay it off, but it was finished, and she needed to come by in the next few days to verify that it was what she wanted.

There were pictures. The first one was a picture of it on a little pillow. Looking at it made her brain feel good. The idea of putting that ring on Adora's finger after getting a "yes" made the dopamine flow and her heart flutter. It made her feel all the things that movies said she would feel.

It was bliss. Fucking bliss.

Adora moaned next to her and started to wake up.

Catra rolled over, engulfing Adora in her arms and kissing her shoulder and neck.

Adora smiled, hummed, and put a hand on Catra's hip. "Someone woke up in a good mood," she said with a yawn.

Catra said nothing but slotted their legs together. Put their bodies in the wonderful way they fit so well. She groaned into it.

Before Adora responded, she licked her own lip.

Catra watched that motion with a sense of loss. The lip had healed up. Adora was checking it before succumbing to

temptation.

The bliss became contrasted with a feeling of slight rejection. No matter what Catra did, as long as she was human and Adora was a vampire, they would never have forever. What was marriage to a vampire? A blip in a long and vast timeline. A wedding ring was a friendship bracelet for a temporary lover.

Catra kicked herself for managing to worm herself out of bliss and into ennui.

Adora's eyebrows knit. "Are you ok? I think I just saw you deflate."

Catra didn't respond but tried to bring her attention back to their bodies. Back to the warmth that existed between them. Back to the things she wanted to do to Adora and the things she wanted Adora to do to her.

Adora started to smile. "Hold on, Kitten. I need to go do something before you distract me."

Fuck . Catra loved being called Kitten. She put her lips to the delicate skin of Adora's chest and showed it.

Adora giggled and nudged her back. "I said we have to wait. Also, Melig is here." She motioned her chin to the cat lounging on the pillow above her head.

Melig made a rumbling meow as it heard its name. It rolled over on its back, revealed its belly, and wiggled its paws for attention.

Adora reached up and scratched.

Catra made a whining noise in the back of her throat but forced herself to come to a halt. She forced herself to get off Adora. She moved to the side of the bed, and Adora played with the cat before getting up and getting dressed.

Catra wanted to distract herself with the rest of the images of the ring. It took impulse control to avoid it. She couldn't guarantee that Adora wouldn't see them now that she was awake, so she refrained. It didn't stop her from thinking about it, though. Tomorrow night could pay off a few payments of that ring, half of it, or damn it... the whole thing depending on how good Huntara was at spreading the word.

She needed to ask Glimmer and Bow to be there. She sent Glimmer a text asking for coffee and a moment to talk. She expected a surprise teleport that would scare the cat out of its morning reverie.

She didn't get a surprise teleport. Instead, she got a text back.

(Glim) Can't.

Catra stared at that for a long hard minute before she texted back,

(Catra) What do you mean can't?

Glimmer called.

Catra answered and demanded, "What the fuck happened?"

Glimmer gave a long and shaky sigh. "Last night was exciting. I'm all out of juice, and it's taking longer than I thought to charge up."

"Ok, so what happened?"

Another belabored sigh. "Bow doesn't want me talking about it over the phone because Juliet was paranoid, so he's paranoid too. Can you two meet up with us somewhere tonight?"

"Sure." Catra paused, thinking through, before adding, "I think I figured out a solution to the winter feeding problem. I need you and Bow to act as Adora's bodyguards tomorrow night because... I can't be there. Too many of my exes are going to show up."

It was a testament to their friendship that Glimmer didn't ask questions and accepted this statement at face value. A moment and the sound of Glimmer drinking coffee before she said, "Yeah. Sure. No problem. After last night, we have no reason to be at headquarters searching for anything. Bow is trying to explain things to his dads, but we have everything we need."

"Oh... great." She paused. She knew Glimmer better than anyone. Better than Glimmer's parents. Better than any significant other. "Last night was dangerous, wasn't it?"

Glimmer made a noise in her throat before admitting, "Probably."

"Was it at least exciting?"

"Extremely."

Catra started to smile. "I hope you brought hell."

"I always do," Glimmer said with a hint of a smile coming through in her voice.

The cat made a noise next to her, and Catra reached out and scratched its stomach on instinct. It purred against her hand.

She and Glim set a time and a location to meet. A pub that stayed open late, had food late, so they could have breakfast.

By the time they hung up, Adora had dressed and come out more nervous than before. She looked at Melig and then Catra and said, "I need to get volunteers for tomorrow night, right?"

Catra nodded.

"I don't know how to contact everyone, but maybe Light Hope does."

"So we have to go back down to that cave?"

Adora rubbed her arm. "Yeah. Is that ok?"

Catra shrugged and stood up. “Well, let's get going while the night is young.”

Adora gave her a slight smile.

Catra got dressed fast, making sure to grab the stakes. Could you stake a vampire that was thousands of spiders? And some silverware, which she stuffed into her pockets. Silver still worked, right?

They left, and the cat ran after them, jumping into Catra’s arms for a ride.

Adora led the way to the rock that Lyn had pushed to open the passage to Light Hope.

As the door opened, the cat started wiggling to get out of Catra’s grip, and she put it down. The animal had every hair raised on its back and paced back and forth like a lion in a cage. It meowed in the same sound of alarm it would raise for its kittens. Catra knelt down and petted it, trying to again promise that Adora would be fine.

The cat sat down, appeased but not calm.

It would have to do.

Catra got up, and she and Adora started down the stairs.

As they walked, Adora got visibly stiffer.

Catra did her duty and placed a hand on the small of Adora’s back. “Hey, don’t worry. Remember, you’re the Horde Lord and a badass vampire hunter. They’re supposed to do what you say, and if Lyn isn't scared, you shouldn’t be either.”

At all that, Adora did seem to calm down.

“Besides,” Catra added as an afterthought. “Look what you’ve done accidentally with your newfound power. Just imagine what

you could do if you used it on purpose."

Adora shuddered. "I'd rather not."

After what felt like too long, they reached the same green cavern with the statue that wasn't a statue. The robes were limp on the pedestal. The mask hung loose. All the volume in the woman was gone somewhere else, and everything was resting on some kind of pole.

Adora cleared her throat and took a cautious step forward. "Light Hope? Are you... here?" Her voice echoed on the walls, and disappeared into the cave in what seemed like a never-ending refrain.

The spiders started swarming out of the cracks of the rocks and merging into the center. Adora startled and gulped down her own reaction.

Catra watched with mild amusement as the robes filled in, and the mask turned toward them.

In a mechanical voice that came from nowhere and everywhere, the woman who was thousands of spiders said, "Horde Lord Adora. So good to see you. How may I be of service?"

Adora's voice shook a little, betraying the fear she refused to show otherwise. "Hey, yeah. Good to see you too. Do you know how to contact the rest of the Horde?"

"My communication pathways are fully functional. Would you like to send a message?" Clinical. Straight forward. Emotionless.

Adora relaxed a fraction. "Yeah. I need volunteers for tomorrow night. Contact the members of my clan and Hordak's. I need vampires who are willing to be the first to try out our solution for the winter feeding problem." She gave the address, the time, and other minor details.

Catra's hand mindlessly pulled out her phone, and she took a step back. She had a moment. With Adora distracted, she opened the email from the jeweler. She scrolled through a close-up of the stone then a close-up of the details carved into the band, mesmerized by the level of detail that the jeweler put into it. It was exactly like she asked.

Adora took a step back, which got Catra's attention.

Light Hope said, "I would like to make a request of you as Horde Lord. The same request I made of Prime before his demise."

Catra looked up, and things had changed. The spiders were pouring out of the robes and onto the ground. Her phone got shut off and put up. She pulled out the silverware she had stuffed into her jacket.

Adora held a hand out to her in a motion to stop for a moment.

Catra stayed her hand but didn't stand down. Any sign of threat, and she'd bring hell.

The spiders surged forward onto the floor. A figure emerged from the spiders, and Catra stepped between Adora and the figure.

The person... the figure... was a sculpture made of spiders. It was a woman with a kind face and long braided hair. Small spider legs as eyelashes. Small spiders filled in to make the skin look almost right. She looked like she wore a toga or some other ancient dress. Catra had never seen anything like it and said, "That's the coolest shit I've ever seen."

"It *is* cool," Light Hope said matter-of-factly. The spiders were no longer trying to move the mask and the robes. They were giving themselves completely to the task of rendering this body.

The rendering started to move in a fluid motion. Lifting a hand, smiling a little, and soundlessly laughing.

Catra moved forward. The motion was life-like. Fluid. And it repeated in a loop, like a GIF. “Who is this?”

Light Hope’s voice came out of the throng. “This is Mara, Adora’s sire prime. The one that Lyn mentioned the last time you were both here last.”

At that, Adora got a little closer. “It’s amazing... Is this a memory?”

“Yes. A very old memory.”

Catra looked over the figure. The repeating movement included everything. Body language. The way the fabric moved. The way she smiled, her hair, and how she looked at the viewer. Catra uttered, out of nowhere, “You loved her, didn’t you?” She couldn’t think of another explanation for holding on to a memory like this in such detail for... hundreds of years? Thousands?

Adora froze for a moment at the suggestion.

Light Hope went on mechanically. “I did, at one point, love her. I have not felt the pain of that love and loss in a very long time.”

Adora frowned. “What do you mean you haven’t felt it?”

The spiders dismantled the memory, crawled back into the robes, and turned the mask toward them. “When she disappeared, I became what I am now. Spiders can not feel the pain of grief. Nor can they feel love. I did this to discover what had happened to her without being held back by my emotions. However, I miscalculated. The other vampires will not talk to me. It is either because they fear me, or they fear telling me what happened.” The mask turned sharply to look at Adora. “But as Horde Lord, you can require them to talk to *you.* ”

Adora looked down at the spot where the figure had been, and her hands clenched at her sides. She took a step forward, ignoring her own fear response. “You got the same promise out of Prime? Did he ever bring you any information?”

In a cool and mechanical voice, Light Hope responded, “Negative. He always said that these things take time.”

Catra asked because she had to... because she felt the first flickers of righteous anger against bullies. “How much time did you give him?”

Light Hope turned to her. “Spiders are not great at measuring time. The simple answer is I do not know.”

Catra looked at Adora, silently willing her to read the anger in her eyes. Prime had made promises and broken them. He had manipulated Light Hope, thinking it would never backfire. He thought it was something he could get away with. Catra burned with righteous anger and wanted Adora to see it and do the right thing.

Adora nodded and took another breath before squaring her shoulders. “I promise you, I’ll investigate this. I’ll talk to all the clan leaders and tell you everything they tell me. Send a notice to them all that I want to see them at...” She paused and looked at Catra. “When?”

Catra answered without hesitation. “Tomorrow night, after midnight, after the feeding event. Right here at the cave.” She, Bow, and Glimmer could all be there for backup if needed.

Adora nodded and turned to Light Hope. “Ok. Yes. I want to meet all the clan leads here at the cave after the event tomorrow night. Can you send that message?”

Light Hope went still for a moment. Groups of spiders scurried away from her into the dark crevices of the cavern. “Messages sent. Is there anything else you need?”

Adora let out a breath, smiled, and said, “No, but thank you.”

The figure bowed, artificially, jerkingly, like an automaton. “It is my pleasure to serve.”

As they left, Catra wished they hadn't killed Prime, so she could have a chance to beat the living shit out of him herself.

***

Catra didn't realize how long it had been since she had been around humans till she was sitting with a bottomless plate of hot wings and blue cheese dressing with celery sticks, watching a group of people watch a college football game. This was an indulgence compared to being in the cave, going to a store, or being in a room full of angry vampires. Sure, they were outside on the patio because Glimmer's hair was still half her father's color, and she needed to "charge." It was cold, but there was food. Real food that she didn't have to eat out of a can.

The only thing that made it not perfect was that Glimmer looked like shit. Sunken eyes, like she hadn't slept in a week. Ashen skin, and her eyes were dull. Still, she was in a good mood as she recounted what happened to them and what Mr. Skele-dude said.

Catra ate through her food like a castaway and paid less attention to the story. Her mind focused on the crispness of the skin of the wings and the hot savoriness of the meat.

Glimmer finally stopped talking, and Catra's attention was drawn back as Adora said, "So... with the catacombs under the headquarters destroyed... Does that mean that the invitation thing doesn't work here anymore?"

Glimmer winced. "I don't know. All I know is what Keldor said."

Catra stuffed her face with a crispy hot sauce-covered wing, sucking it off the bone. Even that couldn't distract her from the fact that Glimmer was using the guy's actual name and not "your uncle" or "skele-dude," which they had all used up till now.

Adora shook her head. "This isn't good. Juliet will never approve of dismantling the catacombs if they're protecting people, even if they do it at the expense of others." Her brow furrowed, looking off as that fact churned through her brain.

Catra swallowed and wiped her mouth before interrupting, “Bull shit.”

Everyone at the table turned to her.

“She’ll approve because we can dismantle the catacombs, and not a single vamp will test it probably for a hundred or so years, if ever.” She shrugged. “Vampires are not good at changing. They’re all about tradition. They’re all about not testing the waters and following old prohibitions. All we have to do is keep this hush-hush between Juliet and us, and as long as none of us give up the goods, this isn’t a problem. They get dismantled in secret, and no one cares.”

Bow and Glimmer both stared at her in open astonishment.

Adora started to smile.

Bow leaned back in his chair. “Actually, Catra’s got a good point. We wait for Juliet to come back, tell only her, and- maybe this whole thing will be done.”

Adora’s smile was gone, and she looked away from Catra. Her focus was on Glimmer and Glimmer alone. “But you said you resurrected Adam?”

Glimmer winced. “I mean, technically.”

Adora sat forward, her elbows on the table. “But he was there. My brother was there.” Her red eyes were striking in the dark, reflected against the soft light of the outdoor TV. “Was he ok? Did he say anything?”

Bow pressed his lips together and reached to put his hand over hers. “He didn’t look great, but Glimmer thinks it’s because she messed up the resurrection. She won’t be able to do it again until she’s figured that out.” Bow stopped when Adora lowered her head. In a rush, he added, “He was completely in the illusion of the whole thing when I talked to him, but... He was looking for you.”

Adora exhaled. Melig, sitting at her feet, instantly jumped into her lap and started rubbing against her in an obvious attempt to assuage the grief that had sprung up. Adora's hand went to the cat's fur. "I can't believe he was here, and I missed him," she said quietly.

Glimmer's eyes went straight to the cat. "There's something else you guys need to know. I think that cat is-"

Catra saw it happening before anyone else. She caught the turn in the cat's body. The spring of muscles ready to leap. The claws going outstretched. She saw it in slow motion. She stood up and leaned forward, snatching the cat out of mid-air. It fought her but did not scratch her. It snarled and hissed and snapped at Glimmer.

Glimmer had thrown her chair back, staring wide-eyed at the animal, then Catra.

Catra wrangled the animal in her arms, grabbed a hot wing, and jammed it in its mouth between its teeth.

It grumbled around the meat, but it chewed and went quiet.

"Sorry about that," Catra said as she pushed the animal into Adora's arms. "I think Melig saw something behind you." She turned to Adora. "Hold on to that cat for a moment while I take Glimmer to the bathroom."

Adora, still in shock, grabbed the scruff of Melig's neck and wrapped another arm around it in a protective hold.

Catra turned back, snapped her fingers to Glimmer, and walked off like she meant it.

Glimmer pushed her chair back and, not taking her eyes off the cat, got up to follow.

They didn't go to the bathroom. Catra, instead, took Glimmer to the other side of the patio.

“What the hell was that?” Glimmer asked.

Catra leaned against the wall, specifically blocking the cat’s line of sight to Glimmer. “Let me guess, you figured out the cat is magic.”

Glimmer’s eyes went wide, which only made their lack of sparkle that much more noticeable. “Wait... you knew?”

Catra shrugged. “I’ve seen things. I knew the cat was magic before Bow suggested the whole fetch thing.”

Glimmer got very quiet. “It’s not just a fetch.”

That got Catra’s attention.

Glimmer looked uncomfortable. She looked like she was carefully picking her words and glancing back at the table. “That cat is apparently the goddess that was trapped in the sword.”

Catra’s eyebrows went straight up. “Really?”

Glimmer leaned back to the wall. “Does it understand English?”

“Yeah.”

“So it knew I was about to-”

Catra cut in. “It’s been reluctant to show Adora any magic. Adora has no idea what it is, and I think it wants it that way.” She leaned against the wall on her back and looked up at the moon. “I mean, I imagine that whatever Adora’s ancestors did to trap it in the blade, it probably doesn’t want to have that happen again... so maybe, on some level, it doesn’t want Adora to know what it is.”

Glimmer followed Catra’s lead and leaned back, looking up at the moon. “It’s as good an explanation as anything else... Does it talk?”

“It can only communicate like a cat... Or at least that’s all I’ve seen. Meows. Growling. Trills. It’s kind of cute, actually.”

“Ok. Sure. But... you two have a goddess that’s sharing your bed?” She turned to Catra, her face wracked with concern.

Catra shrugged. “I mean, yeah, but it’s also just a cat.” She hesitated before adding, “It’s acted like nothing but a pet. Adora’s known it all her life, even if she doesn't realize it. I’ll bet that’s why it feels so comfortable and familiar.” She took in a long slow breath. “If it is the thing inside the blade, then it’s like family to her. And damn... damn, would it be comforting to Adora to know she still had her sword with her, just in the form of a cat.” Catra smiled at that. “I’ll keep an eye on it and tell it that we know, but we won’t tell Adora.”

Glimmer nodded. “Ok. That sounds reasonable.”

A long pause lingered between them as they both watched a cloud slowly cover the moon. Glimmer made a small noise in her throat as if she could feel the loss of the light. For a moment, she deflated and said, “What I did was really cool, but having Keldor drain me like that-”

The word drain got Catra’s mind back into a groove. It threw her memories to last night, back to Adora’s broken lip. “Hey, Glim, I need your help.”

Glimmer turned to her, a smug smile on her face. “What? Are you having second thoughts about whoring out your girlfriend?”

Catra let out a frustrated sigh and folded her arms. “Why does everyone assume I’ll have a problem with this? It was my idea, and it’s not sex. It’s just biting!”

Glimmer wouldn't let it go. “It’s really uncharacteristic of you. Usually, when you date, you-”

Catra cut her off by throwing out her hands, shaking them, and sticking them in her pockets. “Focus, Glim. I’m serious about needing help.” With all the gravitas she could manage, she added, “I’ve been tempted.”

The smirk was off Glimmer's face.

Catra got serious and looked at her best friend... her roommate... the closest thing she had to family. "I know how vampires are made, and Adora doesn't know that I know."

Glimmer stared at Catra, searching her face. After a moment, she looked away and uttered, "Fuck."

Catra leaned her head against the wall. She looked at the sky, and she waited.

Finally, Glimmer came out of her thoughts. "You're not thinking about actually doing it, are you?"

Catra sucked on her teeth and made a "maybe" face.

Glimmer looked at the ground. "Ok. I shouldn't be surprised." She paused, then added, "It's dangerous."

Catra tilted her head to one side. "It could be cool, though."

"You would have to die, I think. Isn't that how it works?"

"We all die at some point."

Glimmer groaned and kicked at the gravel-covered ground. "Mom would be so hurt that you couldn't make it to Sunday brunch anymore."

Catra shrugged. "We could meet up at night. We'll call it drunch. Dark brunch. I'll tell her my job makes it impossible to do it during the day, and she'll never fight me on that."

"You wouldn't want to eat the food then."

"I could fake it."

"Dad would go nuts. He might not let you come back."

That made Catra's jaw clench, and she looked away. That was a good point and one she hadn't considered.

Glimmer's shoulders fell as she let out a breath. "The last thing I need is to worry about you going off and doing something like that on a whim."

Catra looked up at her.

Glimmer met her eye. "Promise me you won't."

Catra gave a non-committal noise in response. She was still thinking about it and couldn't give assurances yet. It was asking a lot of her impulse control to do this much.

Glimmer moved in, turning toward her. She grabbed Catra's hand out of her jacket and held it with a pleading expression. "Catra, promise me."

"It's my life. My choice." She didn't pull her hand away.

Glimmer rubbed the back of her hand with her thumbs. Glimmer's brows knit, and her jaw clenched as she reached a decision. "I don't think Adora would ever offer it to you, and I think you should think about that. Stop and really think about why Adora would never even bring it up to you as an option."

Catra pulled her hand out of Glimmer's grip. She leaned in, looking Glimmer in the eye as she said, "I want to marry her." She said it because she thought maybe that would make Glimmer back down. Maybe it would impress upon her what this all meant. Forever isn't forever if one of you is mortal.

Glimmer looked unimpressed. "I assumed."

That caught Catra off guard. "What do you mean you assumed?"

Glimmer waved her hands a little dismissively. "It's this ownership thing of yours. Like, how you feel so damn protective of me when I date. I just lucked out that you like Bow."

“Bow is great,” she admitted easily.

“Yes, he’s wonderful, and you still woke him up in the middle of the night to torment him because you thought that he would somehow take me away from you... the way you think all the people I date will take me away from you, even though you know I’m not leaving. I’m not going anywhere. I mean that.” She stopped, took a few breaths, and said, “Look, It’s just...” She cut off her words and acted like she couldn’t find them again.

“Just what?”

Glimmer took a moment, sighed, and offered, “Are you doing it because you’re in love with her, and you want to commit, or are you doing it because it bothers you that she could leave you?”

Catra felt the pilot light come back. That small flame of anger that could flair into an inferno. She took a few breaths. She ran her fingers through her hair. “It’s not just that.”

Glimmer folded her arms and leaned forward. “You were always quick to jump into a relationship, even when there were serious red flags. You started thinking about marriage when any of them lasted longer than a week.”

Catra huffed.

“With you and Adora dating for what, three months, and with a job? I figured you already had a ring ordered, if not made already.”

That was it. Catra couldn’t keep her tone controlled. Couldn’t lower her voice. “So what if I do?”

Glimmer’s hands clenched. She pressed her lips and glared before saying, “You’re moving too fast. You need to give it time. Forget about ‘forever’. Just, I don’t know, date for like a year first, and then you can think about marriage and then maybe after a few years, you can think about the other thing.”

Catra turned away, hit the wall with her fist, and grumbled. She grumbled because this was a reasonable request. It was simple, completely logical, and Catra hated it. A lot could happen in a year. “I’m going to pay off the ring tomorrow night if I can, and when I do, I’m asking her. We can’t wait. I don’t want to wait.”

“Ok. Fine. Ask her to marry you because that’s not permanent. You can always get a divorce if it doesn't work out.”

The pilot light flared, and Catra focused on breathing to stay calm.

Glimmer moved back a little. “I’m not saying it will fail- I’m just saying it’s ok to move too fast on that because it’s not permanent.”

And that was the problem, wasn’t it? A marriage could be undone, but blood- blood was forever.

Glimmer slowly reached out and took her hand again.

The touch made Catra’s anger fade. Glimmer was being gentle. She was trying to express her concern.

Glimmer closed her eyes, took a breath, and said, “At least- for my sake- promise me you won’t try to become a vampire unless Adora offers to turn you.”

Catra sneered. “You’re just saying that because you think she’ll never offer.”

Glimmer tightened her hold on Catra’s hand. “Yeah. Exactly.”

Catra looked down at their hands. She could rage at Glimmer. She could fight with Glimmer and be unreasonable, but when it all came down to it, Glimmer always cared about her. With that thought, she closed her eyes and tried to let the feelings pass through her. She thought of the way she calmed herself when she approached Razz’s horses. She looked at Glimmer’s hand, and with sadness instead of anger, she grabbed Glimmer’s hand back in a handshake. “Ok. I promise.”

Glimmer let go and pulled Catra into a hug. A big enveloping hug that would last a few more seconds than necessary. “I knew I could count on you,” she said, leaning her head into Catra’s shoulder.

Glimmer knew her too well. She knew this would bring back all the feelings of their childhood together. Being each other's support, each other's emotional backup. It brought up all the promises they made when they were young. Then, letting go of the anger was easy. Catra breathed it out like it was just hot air. She held Glimmer back and closed her eyes. This hug was home. It always had been.

The food, the company of humans, and Glimmer were the three things Catra had to admit she missed. “I can’t wait till this stuff with your dad is all over so we can go back home. I feel like I’m missing half my brain when you’re not around.”

Glimmer let out a long breath and hugged her tighter. “Same.”

Chapter End Notes

> “Mara...A terrible night visitor that crushes or oppresses its victims, normally taking the shape of a beautiful woman... Mara comes from the Anglo-Saxon verb merran (to “crush”), which also provides the root for [the word] nightmare (the nicht mara)... The mara was feared from ancient times, known to enter the room of sleepers and to bring them dreadful dreams... As with the alp, the mara has close associations with vampires through its nocturnal predations and, in some areas, it’s fondness for blood...” - The Vampire Encyclopedia by Mathew Bunson

The Bloody Kisses Special

Chapter Summary

> Everyone thinks they are doing the right thing. They are all wrong.

There was no question. This was Catra's doing. That was all Micah could think while he looked at the red flier with Casta's business listed as the location.

"Who is she to you?" Netossa asked as she wrapped ball after ball of netting.

Micah put down the paper on their coffee table. The duo's apartment building was situated in one of the older parts of the city where the trees had been allowed to grow. It was hard to find. Hard to get to, and it was also, from roof to basement, covered in vampire wards all connected to a big bell out front.

The couple's adopted daughter sat in a bean bag in the corner of their living room with a game controller in her hands and a microphone headset. The screen was taken up by a computer-generated urban hellscape. She was barking out orders into her headset mic. "Take the rear. I'll clear the corridor."

Micah looked back at the woman who would face down the vampire he had not been able to take down. "She's my sister's descendant."

From the kitchen, just a little ways off, Spinnerella leaned back to look at them, leather chest armor in hand while her other hand rubbed the conditioner into it. "A niece?"

Micah nodded, feigning that he had confused the words, but he hadn't. When he came here with Angella, Casta was the only family he could find through the magic he knew. She hadn't asked him questions when he showed up penniless and without documentation. She helped him start a new life here. He owed

her everything, and now... With Catra getting stuck in this vampire's clutches, Casta was in danger, and it was all his fault.

Netossa got his attention and leaned in. "You ok there?"

He shook his head, no. "This is the problem with vampire pets." His hand went to his neck where the woman with the long black hair had marked him. "They lure you into thinking you're safe, and maybe you are, but no one around you is."

Netossa's eyes went to the hand on his neck. For a brief moment, there was a look of recognition.

He pulled his hand down. "I can't let any of them get hurt."

"Then, we need pictures of all three of them," Netossa said casually as she started stuffing nets into various places in her jacket.

Micah looked up. "You don't need pictures. I'll be there. I can identify them."

Spinnerella came in and handed one piece of armor to her wife. "You're still a civilian and- well, here's the thing..." She started trying to say something but turned to her wife instead.

Netossa filled in. "The thing is... When dealing with pets of vampires... There's a chance we'll have to subdue one or both of your daughters."

Spinnerella quickly added, "Not kill them. Just subdue them. In our experience, it's not smart to have parents around. It's sometimes hard to watch." Almost absentmindedly, she glanced up at her daughter while the girl yelled obscenities at her online teammates.

Micah felt empty. Why had he taken all this time off? Why had he followed them around if he was going to be side-lined? "Then what do you expect me to do?"

Netossa shrugged. “Go home to your wife. Act like nothing's wrong, but don’t go to sleep. Stay dressed, and wait for a call from us to tell you to come take your daughters home.”

He was going to protest, but how could he? He had been useless with the magic he had. The vampire had that thing guarding it, and without his magic... he was just a man... a father, worried about his family.

Netossa leaned forward, putting a hand on his shoulder. “It’s ok. We know this is the hardest part, but it’s best to let us have our space to do our job.”

His limbs felt heavy as he reached into his pocket and pulled out his phone to find pictures that would be good enough that there would be no mistaking them. A part of him was relieved that this would all be over by the morning of the next day. His girls, and Casta, would all be safe, and this scourge would be stopped in her tracks.

***

Catra straddled Adora’s latex-covered thighs.

Adora had leaned back and presented herself for Catra’s inspection.

Catra brought up the lipstick and started painting Adora’s lips that dark cherry apple red that everyone thought of when they thought of vampires.

Adora watched her while she worked and said quietly, “Are you sure about this?”

“Don’t talk while I’m putting it on,” Catra muttered as she wiped the edge of Adora’s lip where it had gotten away from her. She would put a sealer on it so the lipstick wouldn’t come off on anyone’s neck.

Adora put her hands on Catra's hips, grabbed her, and asked, more firmly, "Are you sure about this plan?"

Catra startled out of her focus for a moment, focusing on the girl instead of the lips. "Are you not?"

Adora's eyes looked at her through thickened eyelashes, eyeliner, and everything Catra could think of to make her look the part. People would assume the red irises were contacts, and looking at them now if Catra didn't know these were real-

"I don't know. It feels weird."

Catra dove back into touching up the lips. "If you don't like the makeup, we can take it off, but I think-"

"It's not about the makeup. I'm talking about the feeding." Adora looked, for a moment, like she was pained, and her hands moved on Catra's hips like they were unsure. "I'd feel better about it if you stayed."

Catra had focused back on a smudge that looked out of place. "I can't stay." The words were emotionless. Matter of fact.

Adora's fingers gripped her. "What if... you just stayed in the office? Or, in the back hall. Somewhere I could visit you if things got weird."

"You can text me. Or call. I'll answer."

Adora let out air like a deflating tire. She was disappointed, but Catra couldn't change that. Things were how they had to be.

Catra held Adora's chin to keep the movement from changing her view. "Look, you've got Glimmer and Bow. They can do whatever you need. Me... I'll just cause problems if I stay."

Adora pouted.

“Stay like that for a moment.” Catra grabbed the sealer and carefully gave Adora that glossy shine you’d expect from red enamel.

“Will you take Melig with you, at least?”

Catra stopped and sat back to give Adora her full attention.

Adora’s lip twitched. “I get the feeling Melig isn’t comfortable around vampires, and... I don’t exactly want it to see me feeding on people... Is that weird?”

Catra looked at Adora’s eyes, then shook her head. “No. That’s not weird.” It was instinct, Catra was sure. On some level, maybe Adora understood what the cat was, even if it wasn’t consciously. She capped the sealer and added, “Any other requests?”

Adora looked like every blonde vampire in every movie ever made. She looked like she was playing a part, a doll dressed up for the camera. That movie star's face went stern. “Don’t go.” Her hand gripped. “Please... stay.”

At that, Catra pushed herself away. “We’ve been over this.”

Adora held on to her hips, preventing her from sliding off.

Catra got angry. Angry because Adora was begging her to do something she couldn’t do. Angry that of all the times that Adora was willing to play the soldier, the one time Catra needed her to just follow orders, she was refusing. “There is nothing to be scared of.” Catra pushed, forcing Adora’s hands off her hips, and slid off the rest of the way. She stood up, admired her handy work, and grabbed Adora’s leather jacket. She did it half so she could look away. So that Adora wouldn’t see her face and wouldn’t guess what was going on underneath.

Catra couldn’t stay, even if she was hidden away because if she was there, she’d have to know what was happening inside that room. She was angry because Huntara and Glimmer had both been right. This was harder than she thought it would be. It all

seemed fine, but the closer they got to launch... the more her mind was lingering on what exactly she had set up. Well, she couldn't stop it now. They were too far in. The die had been cast. For good or ill, everything rode on tonight and tonight had to be a success.

Catra hardened herself to it. "We're sacrificing comfort for your future." She finished, in her own mind, *so we can have a future together.*

When she turned back, Adora looked away. Her brow furrowed, distinct with freshly shaped eyebrows. "Ok. If that's what you want, I can do it." When she looked back, it was the hard shell of Hero Adora.

For a moment, Catra was transfixed. Something about the way Adora looked when she did that... So sure of herself. So confident. It was already sexy on its own, but with the makeup and the suit- it was damn near mesmerizing. Yet, it was, after all, just a shell- an act. She wondered where Adora pulled that hard shell out of. Was it something beaten into her by years of training? Was it her own way of pushing down her emotions? Putting others first?

Razz would rest easy with job security for a few years with Adora as a patient. That made Catra's chest hurt with a pang. When this was over... when it was all over... she'd find someone to help Adora unpack everything... but now wasn't the time for psychoanalyzing. Catra looked away, stuffed down her ever-present Adora-centered desire, and handed her girlfriend the leather jacket. "This will look great with that latex suit."

Adora took the jacket and stood up to put it on.

Catra looked in the mirror to watch the fine lines of Adora's form as she slid the jacket on. The latex did a beautiful job of outlining Adora's muscles while still giving her the comfort of being fully covered.

"Has anyone shown up yet?" Adora said quietly.

Catra pushed aside the curtains of the staff bathroom. In clear view was the front of the business, where the line started. The line went past the window and out into the parking lot; from there, Catra lost sight. Her brain automatically fell into doing math, taking each person and figuring how much each was worth and her take on it. She saw some familiar faces and let the curtains fall back where they were supposed to be. She'd have to leave out the back entrance to avoid causing a scene. "Oh, a few."

Before she left, she grabbed the lapel of Adora's jacket and pulled her down into a kiss. One hard kiss to pour out all her feelings into. A kiss to hold them both off for a few hours while business had to be done. She pulled away.

Adora was dumbstruck, and her eyes dilated. Every inch of her looked like she wanted more. Hungry in a way only Adora could be.

They had no time to get in a quickie before things started. Catra hated that fact because it would have made them both feel better.

Catra checked her own lips in the mirror. "Ok. The sealer works. Good luck." She patted Adora's chest and turned away. She had to leave fast, or else she'd do something ill-advised.

She left Adora breathless and figured that would probably sell the whole effect better.

On the way out, she grabbed Melig up into her arms, to mild cat protest, said some final words to Glimmer about Adora needing a little extra support, and ducked out the back. She had to weave past the other vampires that had shown up as they were getting ready. Doing their hair. Donning any costumes Casta had insisted they wear.

The cat growled at each one of them till they made it outside.

Bow was in the back alley holding Catra's helmet, getting off her motorcycle. He had offered to get Catra's bike from the apartment, being extra careful to avoid being followed if Micah

was still paying attention. “You never told us where you were going,” he said with a half-hearted smile as he handed her the helmet.

“I’m buying a ring,” Catra said automatically.

Bow’s smile was gone.

The cat stopped grumbling and looked up at her.

Catra looked back down at the cat. “Yeah, I’m going to propose after this.” She looked back up at Bow, expecting a lecture about how she was moving too fast.

Instead, she saw him giving her a soft smile.

That disarmed her. After everyone else... Casta, Huntara, Glimmer... giving her shit about her decisions, to have just one of her people actually... accept a decision she had made... Well, it meant the world to her. It disarmed her. It allowed her to be vulnerable. She swung a leg over her motorcycle and secured the cat goddess in her jacket. “Adora’s not feeling too comfortable about all this. Try to help her calm down. Make sure she knows the feeding doesn’t bother me. Help her do... whatever she needs to do to get through tonight.” It did bother her. But, she had no space to be bothered.

He assured her he would get the message across, all while smiling, and before he said, “Also, congratulations. I’m sure she’ll say yes.”

Catra couldn’t help but smile at that. It was just like Bow to have the exact right thing to say at the exact right moment.

She thanked Bow, and she meant it. She put on her helmet, ensured the cat was secure and started the engine. She had a jeweler to wake up.

***

Adora was ushered into a room that was previously something called the steam grotto. It normally had dry ice smoke, but now, it was full of dry ice smoke and hastily pulled out Halloween decorations. A fake spider web in the corner with a fake spider on it. Black drapes everywhere. A red light in the corner. All, Casta said, for ambiance.

Adora sat down in the chair that was her designated chair for the night. Casta got a stool for the... clients.

They were about to open the doors, and Adora couldn't calm her nerves. She pulled out her phone. She sent a text to Catra in Dutch. Something stupid and simple, saying things were about to start and that she was excited and missing her. She wasn't excited, but she didn't want Catra to think things were bad. Catra did not respond. Not immediately, anyway. She was probably still driving... somewhere.

Adora put her phone in the pocket on the inside of her jacket.

She waited.

She twiddled her thumbs. She picked at her nails. She used her nails to pick at the edge of her jacket. She was absorbed in the texture of the leather when the door opened.

Adora stood up, at attention, before she realized she was supposed to stay seated, or at least, she wasn't given direction as to what to do when her first client walked in.

And oh boy... she was a big bug.

Tall. Broad shoulders... strong, but with a distinctly boyishly handsome female face. White hair. Short cut on the back and sides, longish on top, and... a distinctly familiar smell she couldn't quite place.

"I hope I got the right room. Huntara's instructions weren't very precise," the woman said, with a genuine warmth behind it. She

smiled, and Adora felt a thing. What "thing" she felt, she was not willing to accept at the moment.

Adora had no idea what to respond with, so she motioned for the woman to sit.

The woman sat down on the stool facing Adora, legs spread, her arms resting on her thighs. Carelessly casual. Weirdly direct. “Ok, so... how do we do this?”

The effect that Adora was trying desperately to ignore was stronger up close. Not unlike Huntara, this woman was buff and also had tattoos... or one big tattoo, since it showed up on her neck, and her arms where she had her shirt rolled up, and on her chest where her red silk shirt was half unbuttoned.

Adora felt her cheeks flush. Heart rate increase. *Damn it.* “Can you... turn around?” Anything to avoid doing this face to face... chest to chest... Just thinking about it made things happen inside her. *Damn it!*

The woman gave an awkward laugh, “Sure. Sorry. I’m new to this.” She scratched her neck and pushed herself around to turn her well-muscled back to Adora.

Adora stared at it. The silk highlighted chiseled muscles, and Adora lost her damn mind for a moment as she reached out to just... touch it. Women didn’t have muscles like this in the 1800s. Adora was envious and desirous all at once.

“You know, I felt weird about this before. Huntara called and sold me on it, but oh boy- it’s a little weird knowing you’re dating Catra.”

Adora shrank back. “Yeah, but it’s not a problem, right?”

“Right!” The woman said too quickly, too loudly. “I mean, has she talked about me at all?” The woman said with a wilt of hope tagged at the end.

More awkward than she thought it would be, which is saying something. “I don’t think so.”

“Oh...” The woman’s broad shoulders slumped. Her spine went curved as she lost steam. “I guess it’s ok. I mean... The last time I saw her, it didn’t go well. She texted me beforehand- And you know... I was excited to get a text from her. It had been radio silence since we broke up, and that was hard- and she told me to set the whole thing up... and she said it would make me look badass and make the troops respect me- but oh boy... I was not prepared for what happened.”

Adora was hardly paying attention. She was too busy with logistics. She stood up because if she was going to bite this woman, she couldn't do it sitting down. The woman was too tall. She forced herself to touch the woman’s shoulders. At the contact, she felt a quickening in her blood. “It’s ok. Just relax.” She wasn’t sure if she was telling herself or her client, but both needed it.

The woman did not relax and didn’t stop talking. “I mean, I wanted to make sure she wasn’t really hurt. Like, Lonnie went hard, and I felt bad about it, and maybe you could tell her there are no hard feelings and I’m sorry things got so out of hand and-”

Adora’s brain clicked in with the smell. It was the same smell as the woman she had scared the piss out of before. The smell of the strip club. Adora’s stomach dropped.

It all happened so fast. Faster than last time. Her influence taking over was seamless. Adora didn’t have a moment to catch her breath.

***

Glimmer held up her phone, switched the camera to the one facing her, and ran her fingers through her hair. It was mostly back to her unique purple and pink, but not quite. She needed

one more solid good night to charge, and instead, she was stuck inside.

Specifically, she was stuck in the staff hallway on the other side of the rooms. She and Bow stationed themselves at Adora's door. They settled down in a pair of the most uncomfortable chairs Casta probably had for a boring night of guarding.

She had never spent time around Casta's place of business, and now she was ready to never return. The back of the house wasn't nearly as nice as the front. The paint was messed up. The floors needed to be buffed, and there was a faint smell of what she could only assume was mold. Not Casta's fault. It was the owner of the building's job to do upkeep, but still... She'd rather be up front at the desk, onboarding clients and doing paperwork, than sitting in the back doing nothing, smelling mold.

Like she was summoned, Casta came walking down the hall and stopped right in front of Glimmer. She did not look happy.

"Is something up... aunt? Cousin?" She had never fully understood the relation. Her dad had been noncommittal whenever she asked.

Casta was on edge. "It's your friend Adora. The rest of the vampires are churning through the customers. Every ten minutes, we have a group of happy customers leaving, but your girl has been in there with the same customer for forty-five minutes." Her finger nervously tapped on her own thigh. "Which, I don't mind if she wants to give them more of a show, but I need to know so I can charge appropriately."

Glimmer sighed. "Yeah, sure. We'll talk to her."

Casta turned sharply and left with her heels clicking all the way back down the hall.

Bow got up and turned to the door, and knocked.

Glimmer got up and waited, listening for any response.

Bow looked back at her, his look questioning.

Glimmer's brain ran through what could be on the other side of that door. It could be that Adora was just taking a long time to do it. Nerves could do that to a girl... It could be she was... doing more than biting but that didn't seem right. The chances of them opening the door on a scene of Adora cheating on Catra were... low... she hoped. The other option was that... this was the moment they were there for. Somehow, one of the vampires that had a vendetta against her had gotten into the room and... She shook the thought out of her head and motioned for Bow to open the door.

Bow took a breath and grabbed the door knob. He pushed it open, and the door hit something on the floor.

Glimmer looked down. The serine face, the fresh undercut of white hair, the irezumi tattoo (which Glimmer knew from Catra was a full body scorpion design) peeking out from her shirt. Glimmer blinked down at the woman. It dawned on her brain, with no small amount of terror, that the woman before her was Scorpia. As in... the woman Catra almost proposed to before Adora. As in, the woman who ran the Strip Club and took over after Tongue Lashor was taken in by the authorities. Scorpia... the single most dangerous person in the city, even after all the vampires.

Scorpia herself was a kind person. She was a cinnamon roll. She was goofy and sometimes a little too trusting. She gave great hugs and was known for being loyal to a fault, and Angella had been excited that Catra had latched on to someone so *earnest.*

Glimmer's mother, as a matter of course, did background checks on any girl Catra ended up dating for more than a week. When she got the report about Scorpia, it had been hand delivered by her friend at the FBI. It was a three-inch binder, and the binder wasn't about Scorpia but her mothers.

One of her mothers was the daughter of a prominent yakuza family's big boss. Her other mother was the daughter of a Don straight from Sicily. She was a walking, talking peace treaty between two of the world's most deadly mafias.

The walking-talking peace treaty was not walking or talking but lying motionless on the floor with unfocused eyes.

Glimmer stared at her, and her brain went immediately to where to bury the body. Then, how to get them all out of town as fast as possible. Teleportation would help with that. She... could use whatever she had in the tank to grab Catra. She was already figuring out their new names and mentally settling them down in a cottage on an abandoned island.

Bow knelt down and touched Scorpia's neck. "Oh, thank goodness. She's still alive."

That pulled Glimmer out of her spiral, and she breathed.

He stood back up and looked over the rest of the room. His eyes landed on something. "Adora?"

Glimmer turned to look and found Adora curled into a ball, her head in her hands, knees up.

Bow moved forward to her, hands out, every inch of him the concerned friend. "Are you ok?"

At first, Adora didn't respond. She looked dazed. Her fangs were out. Her eyes were that new unnatural red, wide and focused on a location distant from them. She turned to Bow, but she didn't look at him. She looked through him. "I'm fine. It's just a nightmare. I'll get over it. I just need time."

She had done this once before when they were stuck in limbo. Catra had pulled her out of it by offering to dance. Glimmer said quietly under her breath, "She's dissociating, right?"

Bow gave a tight nod and knelt down. He stopped short of touching her. “What happened to our friend on the floor?” He pointed toward the peace treaty.

Adora’s eyes focused, and she turned toward the woman. “I... I accidentally put her under. And... I saw something. I don’t know... It was bad. Catra was being hurt? And I...”

Glimmer fell onto her knees before Adora. “You didn’t hurt her did you?”

Adora shook her head. “No. No... I just needed a moment to work through this before... before I bite her. I’ll... release her then. It will all work out. I promise.” She wasn’t really talking to them.

Bow and Glimmer exchanged a look. Glimmer moved closer. “Adora... what did you see?”

Adora made a noise. A guttural rejection of talking about it.

Bow moved closer too. “We’re not going to judge.”

Adora covered her face and then said in a rush, “She was hurting Catra- with electricity... and... and I don’t know. Catra liked it?”

Bow turned to Glimmer for an explanation.

Glimmer had to reach into the depths of her memory for all the cursed knowledge that Catra overshared about her girlfriends. She found it and pulled it out in a whisper. “Scorpia is into erotic electrostimulation.”

He winced and turned back to Adora.

Adora started talking like they weren’t there like she wasn’t talking to them. “Does she like that? I can’t do that to her. I can’t hurt her like that... Is that why she likes me? Does she think I’m going to do that to her?” Her voice was getting higher and higher. More insecure.

Glimmer rushed in, putting her arm around Adora's shoulder. "No! That's not how Catra works. She's... interested in whatever the person she's with is interested in. She's into doing whatever you're into. Don't let what she did with other people... scare you. She's just like a kinky chameleon." She would have to punish Catra for abandoning the situation, leaving Glimmer to make that comment to Catra's own girlfriend.

Bow moved in. "It's ok that it bothers you. You should have never seen that. Normal people don't get to see memories of their significant others with other people."

Adora seemed to come back to herself a bit. Her fangs slid in as she focused on Bow. "I can't do this. I can't feed on her exes if this is going to happen every time. I don't... I don't want to see her like that... I don't want to see them hurting her." Her eyes got wide. "Or pleasuring her either!" Her grip on her own knees got tighter.

Glimmer rubbed Adora's back as her mother always did when upset. The words fell out of her mouth, right out of her brain, without passing through her filter first. "Well, it's got to be magic right?"

Adora turned to her, hopeful.

Bow turned to her, concerned.

The thought had popped into her head, and she looked back at her friends eagerly. "I know how to dispel magic. Or at least, I'm starting to. If you can make it happen again, I bet I can stop it."

Bow's look of concern switched to hope. "Yeah! That's a good idea." He turned his attention back to Adora. "Are you ok with trying that?"

Adora looked at the woman on the floor and then nodded slightly. "I'll try anything. I don't want to fail. I don't want to ruin Catra's plan."

That settled it. They would try this out. A little discussion among them came down to... the only way to get Adora to recreate the problem was to recreate the situation. Bow was out as a test dummy, so Glimmer offered to stand in. Or, rather, she offered to sit in.

And yeah, she had wanted to get bit since she found out what Adora was. So she was a little excited even if Adora was probably not going to get to the biting. That was the whole point, right? Still, Glimmer tried to get her heart to stop beating so hard as she put her back to her roommate, that had secretly shared a weird vampiric sex dream?

Adora stood behind her while Bow moved to be inconspicuous in the corner.

Adora let out a long breath and said, “Ok. I’ll just-”

Glimmer felt Adora’s fingers brush her neck, moving her hair away, and that movement sent sparks down her spine. Maybe her skin goosebumped. She couldn't control it.

Adora froze. “I... I can’t do this.” Her fingers moved away.

That motion caused Glimmer to look back to see what the problem was.

Bow moved in. “What’s wrong?”

Adora shook her head. Her fangs had slid out again, and she was folding her arms over herself. “I just can’t. We’ll have to figure out something else.”

Bow, the caring one with so much reserve for empathy, asked, “Are you having flashbacks to how things used to be?”

Adora responded by making a guttural sound in her chest, like an animal being squeezed.

Bow put his arm around her. “It’s ok. You were abused. You were manipulated. This isn’t your fault. It’s not a failing of yours. You’re having a trauma response.”

Adora flinched at that.

Bow added, “I know you have a lot of conditioning to equate feeding with violence, but-”

Out of nowhere, Adora blurted, “It’s not violence. Feeding was... never about violence. It’s...” She stopped and looked full force at Glimmer.

The look in those eyes was terror. Fear. Vulnerability.

Adora looked down at the floor. Defeated, she uttered, “It’s... desire.”

Glimmer let a long, quiet “Oh,” escape her lips.

Adora shook her head and added, “Shadow Weaver only ever sent me after women I found attractive. It... made a groove in my brain. Now, I can’t separate it.” She closed her eyes.

Bow carefully moved away, trying to give her space.

Adora, in a rush said, “It’s stupid. I know it’s stupid. I don’t think the other vampires have that happen at all, but every time I’ve bitten anyone, it made me get all tingly, and I thought that was a vampire thing till I got my memories back, and then I realized what it was, and... and... and when I get turned on now I think of Catra, and right now I’m thinking about how I’m failing her by getting turned on, and I think it causes the whole immersive memories thing to happen and-”

“It’s ok,” Bow said quietly. “Like I said, it’s not your fault. You are not a bad person for getting turned on. It’s just what you’ve been trained to do.”

Adora opened her eyes and looked at him. Her look had a hint of desperation and pleading to him. She wanted him to have the answers.

He managed a smile. “You’ve just got to uncondition yourself, and that takes practice and time. Probably therapy.”

Adora glanced at Glimmer, then at Bow. “And Catra...”

His smile got bigger. “She specifically told me that this doesn’t bother her. She wants you to do anything you need to do to feed. She told me before she left to specifically tell you that.”

Adora looked at him for a moment, evaluating. Then she turned to Glimmer. “Ok...” She clenched her fists and looked away. “Ok. I can do this... for Catra’s sake. To avoid making her idea fail. She wants me to feed... I’ll feed.”

Glimmer turned around, putting her back to Adora to make it easier for both of them. “Alright. I’m ready when you are.”

Adora moved behind her, saying under her breath, as a mantra to herself, “Do this for Catra. Do this for Catra.” Her voice got quieter as she leaned forward.

Glimmer closed her eyes and braced herself as she felt Adora’s breath on her neck. Inside, she couldn’t help her reaction. Blood started pumping. But they were all adults, and Glimmer could handle this. Feelings didn’t have to be acted on. Being turned on didn’t mean anything beyond what it was, a physical reaction to a stimulus, which, she guessed, was the thing that Adora was going to figure out. She choked down the reaction as she tried to remind herself to pay attention to the magic.

Adora was buzzing with magic like a high-volt wire. The current of it was now so easy to identify. Stronger than the catacombs. Stronger than it had been when she saw Adora last. She could dip into it and recharge. But she shouldn’t. Right?

Someone knocked on the customer-side door.

Glimmer called out, “Just a minute! Not done here.” Hopefully, if it was Casta, she’d recognize her voice and leave them alone.

Adora put her fangs just to her neck.

The door banged open. Glimmer opened her eyes just as the door hit Scorpia’s head. Glimmer looked up, and there, standing in the doorway were two women dressed in silver and leather, holding stakes. Their eyes fell on Glimmer, then her neck.

“CODE RED!” The one in front yelled, reaching into her blue leather jacket. She pulled out something and threw it.

As a ball of what looked like string came toward them, reality fell away into darkness, and they were all plunged into a nightmare.

Code Red

Chapter Summary

> Catra gets a ring. Everyone else doesn't have such a good time.

Glimmer saw it all starting to happen in slow motion. The ball of string flew toward them. The hunters take a step in and step right on Scorpia's arm. Glimmer had promised Catra she would guard Adora, and she rose to meet that challenge like the demigoddess she was.

Adora, still bent over, still with her fangs on Glimmer's neck, was close enough to grab. Close enough to connect to, like hooking up to a generator. She would use Adora like a battery, just like everyone had used her.

She kicked out her foot to touch Scorpia's legs with her toes through her shoes.

Bow would be fine. He was too far away to touch, but the hunters weren't after him, and he wasn't the child of two very dangerous families. She loved him, but he wasn't top priority here. She'd come back for him.

Like a burning flame, she sucked the energy out of Adora and poured it into the spell, and she blinked the three of them out of existence for a second.

When they reappeared, they were falling. She intended to get them all on the roof, but she had misjudged. Her insides flipped as she lost gravity for a moment and began to free fall.

She and Adora landed in a pile, and Scorpia... poor Scorpia, landed with a thud on the roof.

It was colder outside than Glimmer remembered. Her breath fogged. Ice felt like it was forming on her eyelashes.

Adora groaned and leaned back. Her breath appeared in the air like the smoke of a train.

The slow motion stopped, and the world fell into its normal pace.

Glimmer looked at Scorpia, but something wasn’t right. Scorpia’s breath wasn't fogging.

Glimmer scrambled on her hands and knees toward Catra’s most dangerous ex. She climbed over the woman’s body to get to her neck. She placed a few fingers on Scorpia’s carotid artery, then went still to feel a pulse.

She felt nothing. Her stomach dropped.

Bow recognized the hunters immediately. Before he knew they were hunters, he knew them as friends of his dads. They would come over for BBQs and occasionally afternoon tea. He remembered when they adopted their little girl, who was what... nearly twelve now?

He saw Glimmer move to act. He had to stop her. This was a misunderstanding.

Netossa, out front, didn’t see him, but Spinnerella did. Her eyes widened with understanding, and he saw her reach forward to grab her wife’s shoulder.

Bow moved to stop Glimmer, to put a halt to everything.

He was too late.

She teleported, and in a blink, he was alone.

He fell onto his knees, knocking the stool Glimmer had been sitting on aside and falling to where the client had once been.

He looked up, expecting to see the hunters, expecting to launch into an explanation about what a mistake this all was.

But the hunters were gone too.

He stared at the empty space they left and, for a moment, was impressed. He didn’t know Glimmer could move that many people.

He got up and ran out into the hallway to make his way through the line of waiting patrons and see if he could find where Glimmer had taken them all. He needed to get to them and explain things before it got out of hand.

The hallway was empty.

He blinked.

The desk where Casta had been all night was also empty. Papers fell off the countertop as if the hand holding them had just disappeared.

There was no line out the door. Everyone was gone... He was alone.

Netossa was out front, ready for action. She had seen the fangs on the neck of the girl in the picture and called a Code Red.

She threw her net right at the beast's forehead and felt her wife’s hand on her shoulder. That was not something she expected. It was a halting motion. A movement telling her to stop.

And then, Netossa saw it. There wasn't just one vampire in here. As the net hit their target’s head and burst open, Netossa looked up to see the room was filled with vampires with their fangs out and their red dead eyes trained on them.

Netossa’s muscles clenched. She threw herself in front of her wife and braced for the fight of her life.

Adora saw nothing. She closed her eyes, trying to prepare for the dip into Glimmer's memories. She didn't know what she would see. Would her power seek out Glimmer's memories of Catra? Would she get a presentation of all their fights? Would it seek the most horrible memories?

She was dimly aware of someone yelling. It made her look up.

She looked up just as something (was it a ball of string?) hit her right between the eyes.

It knocked her head back hard and knocked her off balance. The ball burst and expanded into a wide web of netting above her.

Glimmer was in her arms as she started to fall, and instinct told her to protect Catra's closest friend, so she pulled Glimmer back with her.

Glimmer was limp so Adora held on even tighter as they both fell backward and were enveloped by the net.

Adora let go of Glimmer as the strands fell across her face, and her brain locked in.

Shadow Weaver had always said she was young and thus vulnerable to the obsessions of vampirism. Her sire had been all too fast to point out that Adora didn't have the age and experience to guard her mind against these things. Adora had hoped that with the power of the stone backing her up, that maybe this wouldn't be a problem anymore.

Her vision focused in, and her fingers flew to the nearest knot in the net. She needed... she needed to stop this. She needed to get out. She needed to save Glimmer and Bow and...She couldn't!

Her world narrowed down to the string in front of her. She couldn't hear or see anything else. How many knots were on this

thing? Hundreds? Thousands? They were tight, and her fingernails were barely long enough to catch them. She was stuck.

She could practically hear Shadow Weaver's voice telling her this was punishment for thinking she was above her station. For daring to hope for a future. For having the audacity to want anything for herself. She could hear the woman laughing at her, at her weaknesses, at her hubris for thinking she could be Horde Lord without her sire by her side, and it made her sick.

Adora felt her phone buzz in her pocket. Catra probably texted back. If she could just... get to her phone, she could...

Her brain came back to the knot. The knot was the only thing in existence, and the last thought she could think was, *Fuck* .

***

The wind started to pick up, and Catra had to adjust on her bike to keep from being swept off the road, but her mind was a million miles away. She was slipping the ring onto Adora's finger. She was cutting a cake filled with red cherry cream to look like blood and squishing it into Adora's face as their friends laughed and danced the night away.

She came out of it only as the cat cuddled into her jacket, made a *bruppptt* sound, and looked up at her.

Catra slowed down the motorcycle, parked it along the street, and said, "You chose Adora when she was eleven, right?" She didn't wait for an answer. She already knew the story by heart. "Adora said she kept you... as the sword, on her at all times. She slept with it in the bed next to her in the scabbard. She bathed with it leaning against the tub. She told me she talked to it."

She swung her leg off her bike and opened the jacket a bit to let the cat crawl onto her shoulders, where it felt safest. Where it could keep an eye out. Catra headed down the city's dark, lonely streets, hands stuffed into her pockets from the cold. All the while, she talked. "You know her better than her parents knew

her. You probably know her better than her brother, which is saying a lot."

The cat made a low affirmative grumble.

Catra headed toward the hidden basement workshop of her underground jeweler, but she had a burning question on her mind. "Did Adora ever dream of getting married?"

The cat went still.

Catra elaborated. "I mean, most girls of her era did, right? They had little fantasies of the only big important party they would ever have. Their one shining moment to be a princess before popping out a non-stop stream of kids. Did she ever talk about it?"

The cat looked away, tilted its head, and made a small sharp sound that was coming dangerously close to a 'nope' but curved into the sound of just another meow.

"I want to give her the big fancy wedding she deserves. I don't care if I go bankrupt." A thought slid into the focus of her mind. "Of course, Micah and Angella always said they'd pay for my wedding, as parents of the bride- but I have an inclination that Micah won't be so excited to do that if the bride is a vampire."

The cat lowered its head. Pressed its neck up against Catra's cheek. It was consoling her.

That was cute, but Catra had a point she didn't have that long to make because they were almost there. "But I don't care if they won't pay for it. I'll find a way. I'll beg, borrow and steal till I have everything exactly the way she wants it, and then I'll treat her like a fucking princess."

The cat started to purr as it pressed against her.

Catra felt electric. The cat approved. The fucking cat goddess approved. She could do anything. "I love her," she said as it felt like her chest would burst with happiness. "-and I don't care what

anyone else says. I'm not moving too fast. I want her to know how much she means to me." She started walking down the dark hallway leading to the steel door with a million locks. "I want her to know that she has all of me. My blood, my body, my heart." At the last words, she reached the door and stopped.

The alarm went off inside, triggered by the hidden motion sensor in the hallway. More than likely, the jeweler was scrambling out of bed and checking his surveillance cameras.

She stood, stone still, as he went through all his checks and verifications before starting to unlock all the locks one by one. The half-a-dozen deadbolts slid back with clunks.

The door opened, and a man with light purple hair, curly, and an equally curly goatee popped out his head. His code name was Jewelstar. The city's top underground jeweler and fencer of stolen goods. He already had the loupe over one eye ready for business. He scanned the hallway around Catra, stopped at the cat, and pointed toward it with a questioning look.

Catra shrugged. "What? My name is Catra. I can have a cat sidekick."

He rolled his eyes and stepped aside.

She stepped in.

Jewelstar closed the door and started clunking the deadbolt locks back in place, then waved her to follow him.

As she started down the hallway, her phone buzzed. Adora had texted her in Dutch. She struggled to translate one of the words but figured it out before they reached the next door. Ok. So things were about to start... or rather, they had started a while ago, and she just hadn't seen the text. Adora was... excited. *Great* . *Great* ...

All at once, she was mentally back at the event. Adora's hot mouth was on the hot neck of any of her exes. It made her blood

boil, and she pulled herself back. That's why she was here. She needed to stop thinking about it.

She composed a simple message back in rudimentary Dutch. Simple conversational stuff, but Adora would get the message beyond the message. Her girlfriend was making an effort. Catra was investing in the relationship by trying to learn her lover's language.

Jewelstar got to one of the inner rooms. He opened the door.

Catra had, on many occasions, been to Jewelstar's lair but never in his workshop. To do that, you had to be a paying customer, and up till now, she had always been just a carrier.

It was barely bigger than a closet. Gray machines lined the wall. A grinder. A tumbler. Others she couldn't guess at. There were trays of precious jewels that were probably, all told, worth more than Micah and Angella's house. There was a workbench well-lit in the darkness of the room. He ducked behind it for a moment, pulling a ring box out from some hidden location, and presented it to her under the work light.

The diamond took that light and refracted it across the room in amazing brilliance.

Catra moved to the other side of the table and leaned in to see. Melig, just as curious, leaned forward on Catra's shoulder.

"It's beautiful," Catra said in awe.

He shook it a little, indicating she should take it.

She took it out of the box with reverence. It felt heavy for its size. The details, beautiful in the pictures, were nothing to it in person, with the light highlighting everything. This was more than an engagement ring. It was a work of art. She held it closer to the cat. "See that? She won't be able to say no, right?"

Jewelstar, apparently, assumed she was talking to him. “If she does, you’ll have to sell it back to me for one-third the price you paid.”

She looked up.

He shrugged. “It’s a policy that’s served me well. I can’t take it back just for you, even if I do owe you a favor.”

Catra huffed at him and looked back at the ring. “She’ll say yes. There won’t be any hesitation.” Bow thought so too, and he was so much better at this shit than her.

Jewelstar leaned forward on the table. “How long have you known her?”

Catra sneered at him. “Spare me the warnings. I know what I’m doing.”

He put his hands up and sat back. “I’m just protecting my assets.”

She balked at that. The cat had to adjust to stay on her shoulders. “Don’t worry. I’ll pay in full today.” She pulled out the emergency credit card. It was the one she shared with Glimmer, cosigned by Angella, just in case. Glimmer could lecture her all day about how the emergency card was for emergencies, and Catra had the line of reasoning all figured out that this was an emergency. The moment Catra knelt down and begged Adora to be her wife... everything would be ok. Even Glimmer would forget her anger. She’d forget how cynical she had been too. Besides, Catra would get the money from this event and pay it all off before the end of the month, so no harm, no foul.

Jewelstar, a little surprised, took the card. “Are you sure?” There was a hint of concern in his voice.

The cat meowed, short and curious, turning to Catra as if asking her the same question.

Catra couldn't stand it. Everyone was judging her. “I’m absolutely certain.”

Jewelstar turned the card over in his hand, looking at Catra, before sitting back and grabbing his phone. “As you wish.”

Catra relaxed against the table and looked at the cat goddess on her shoulder. “Look at all I go through to make your Adora an honest woman.”

The cat made a small quiet rumble. A mix of a purr and an unsure growl.

Catra reached up and petted the animal on the head. It leaned into her fingers to force her to scratch its neck. She found herself saying, almost dreamily, “Don’t worry. I’ll treat her right.” Her eyes then fell on watching the charge go through. She felt a thrill that she always felt with large transactions. Kind of haphazardly, and mostly to herself, she said, “I’ll take care of her forever if she’ll have me.”

The cat let out something like a bark before it started coughing like it had a hairball. Catra steadied it on her shoulders as Jewelstar handed her back the card and the ring.

***

Despite the cold, Catra felt warm all over. After getting the ring, she had a few hours to burn, so she indulged the cat a bit. She took it to the big pet box store. Of course, the place was closed, but Adora had taught her a few things about lock picking.

She let the cat goddess try out all the cat toys. She did her duty and shook things that needed to be shaken and threw stuff that needed to be thrown. She watched with growing amusement as the cat goddess tried to chase the mice and gerbils while they were still in their cages.

The time came to leave. The event was probably winding down, and she wanted to get on the road to be there just as everything

closed. She gripped the ring in her pocket. “Time to go, kitty cat. My princess awaits.” She held her jacket open.

The cat tore away from trying to capture the fish in the lower tanks and jumped right in. It had figured out it could rest on Catra’s hip while she closed the jacket. They had worked out where to put the cat’s tail. It hummed as Catra closed the front and settled its head at the top of the buttons. It was smiling as much as a cat could.

Catra made her way toward the door, stopping only to write a note that they had failed inspection because of a faulty lock.

She drove with that overwhelming warmth of the cat sitting in her jacket and the ring in her pocket, and all was right with the world.

Catra parked her bike out front because the line was gone. There were no worries about being seen now. She walked in and found Casta at the desk, messing with her financial software.

Catra walked up to the counter, put her elbows on it, and let the cat out of her coat. “A good haul, I assume?”

Casta snapped to look at her. She pulled out a check and slid it on the countertop toward her. “Your take.”

Catra picked it up, glanced at it, and smiled before folding it and stuffing it in her back pocket. It was more than enough to cover the ring. She felt like the stars were aligning for her and Adora.

Casta leaned in, a little too close. “But...there’s something I need to tell you.”

Catra leaned in as well, confused.

For a moment, Casta looked conflicted. “Your girlfriend has been in that room with her first client for hours. I asked Glimmer and her friend to talk to her, but I haven’t seen them since this whole

thing started.” She drummed her fingers on the counter. “I’ve had girls fall asleep before. The clients aren’t the only ones who get tired.” Another drum of the fingers. “Anyway, they still haven’t come out. I... wanted to warn you before you walked in on something.”

Catra blinked.

Casta tilted her head and wiggled her eyebrows.

Catra shook her head. “You’ve misread the situation. She wouldn’t.”

Casta leaned back. “Also, I nearly had a crisis because a lot of the girls came specifically to see her, so I had to pivot and send them to a different blonde that I was lucky enough showed up. It’s not good policy to over-promise and under-deliver, but I think they left happy.” She turned away, shutting down her computer and grabbing her bag. “Well, I’m leaving before the drama. I’ll contact you about doing this again, maybe next week? Good luck with your confrontation. You know where the keys are. I trust you to lock up before you leave.”

Catra watched Casta leave while feeling numb.

If Bow and Glimmer had disappeared... they would have never left Adora alone. Something was wrong.

In a daze, she turned toward the only client-facing room with a closed door, the last room down the hall.

Melig jumped down from the countertop and followed her, meowing inquisitively.

Catra reached the door and turned the knob. It wasn’t locked, but when she turned to open it, it hit something. Smoke from a smoke machine, chugging away, spilled out into the empty hall.

Melig tried to go in and push past, but it wouldn’t open up enough.

She didn’t hear anything inside aside from soft breathing, which, she guessed, was a good sign that at least someone was alive in there. “Adora?”

She heard a grunt.

That was it. A grunt. Not a sleepy grunt, but a fully awake but unable-to-respond grunt.

“Hold on! I’m coming in!” She pushed on the door hard and found that whatever was holding it closed was soft like someone was lying in front of it. The cat pushed against it, too, not like that did much.

Catra got the door open.

Her first thought was that she was looking at a room filled with bodies. Bow’s body slumped against the wall and the floor on the far side. Scorpia’s body, covered by the bodies of two hunters. Then Glimmer’s body, facing up, eyes rolled back into her head. She was laying next to Adora.

Adora was moving, but only her hands.

Catra walked in slowly, stepping around all the people on the floor. Bow was still breathing. Scorpia was still breathing. The hunters were still breathing. If she had to guess, they were under Adora’s influence, but Bow should have been immune, right? She was not sure what she would have done if she hadn’t seen Glimmer’s chest rising and falling. Alive but out cold. “What happened?”

Adora grunted again.

She was half covered in a net, half draped with unraveled threads. Her fingers were working inhumanly fast. Her eyes were impossibly focused.

Melig gave a long and sorrowful sound and ran over. It started attacking the net covering Adora and Glimmer with its claws. It shredded the net.

As the strings fell away, Adora’s fingers stopped, and her whole body relaxed. She blinked, and her eyes focused as if they hadn’t focused that distance in hours.

Catra moved next to her to cradle her. She pulled Adora up, running her hands through her hair. Softly, she asked, “What happened, baby?”

Adora grabbed her desperately.

Catra expected to be fed on, because Adora was stressed out, and feeding helped. She offered her neck. She was Adora’s pet, right? Her blood was to always be available.

But Adora didn’t feed. Instead, she gripped tight and started to sob into Catra’s shoulder.

Catra didn't ask more questions. Not yet, anyway. Instead, she held her girlfriend and said, “It’s ok. I’m here now. I’ve got you.”

***

Glimmer landed in the passenger seat of Scorpia’s car, her hand still gripping Scorpia’s arm.

Catra had come up with the plan, and it wasn’t bad. Drop Scorpia back into her car, and when she wakes up, she’ll think she fell asleep and dreamed the whole thing... which wasn’t exactly wrong.

Glimmer shivered. For the past two hours, she had been plunged into a nightmare scenario, thinking Scorpia was dead. She had never felt such fear in all her life. The longer she spent awake, the less visceral it all felt, but she hadn’t shaken off the feeling completely.

She did a quick check, making sure Scorpia wasn’t in an uncomfortable position. Not that she could move the big woman without teleporting her again... but it was worth a try.

Once satisfied, she teleported back out of the locked car by focusing on Bow.

She appeared by his side, and he startled for a moment before relaxing and letting out a deep breath. She wasn't sure if he had it better or worse than her. For him, the nightmare had been that he was alone... possibly the only person in the world. He said it felt like days and weeks, even though it was only a few hours.

She put a reassuring hand on his arm, and he put his hand over hers.

She then looked up to see what Catra was doing with Adora.

The wind was too loud in the trees, masking what the lovers were saying to each other. She could just see body language. Catra was keyed in. Angry. Furious, but not with Adora. It was with Micah. Once Adora woke them up, they all concluded that he was the only one who could have set the hunters against them.

Adora looked shaken to the core. She listened to Catra and nodded, but she wasn't listening. She looked like a frightened animal, stressed and on edge.

Catra put her hand on Adora's face, and Adora closed her eyes and leaned into it.

The wind changed directions and got less intense, so they could hear what Catra was saying more clearly. "Glimmer is going to go with me. With the two of us in front of him, he won't come after you again to try to save us, and if he tries anything, Glimmer will just teleport us out."

Adora's face briefly tensed with something before going firm, and she opened her eyes. "I understand." Body language said Adora was unhappy with this, but Catra went on anyway like she didn't see it.

"I'll make him understand. I'll make sure this ends tonight." Catra's other hand was in her jacket pocket, which was odd.

Adora let out a breath and looked down, avoiding Catra's eyes.

Catra went on. "Bow will go with you and Melig. They'll both ensure you're ok so you can have this meeting. Figure out what happened to Mara. Make things right for Light Hope, ok?" Catra's hand moved to run through Adora's hair. It was a reassuring motion. Adora's body language relaxed at the touch.

Adora nodded.

Catra pulled back just a bit. "Are you ok with this?"

Glimmer strained to hear Adora's response. She fully expected her to say, "no", because her body was practically screaming it.

"Whatever you need to do. Don't worry about me. I'll be fine."

Glimmer blinked. Adora was not fine. Adora was one bundle of frayed nerves. She was pretending to be ok. She was pushing all her feelings into a box and pretending they didn't exist. Catra saw this, right? She could see the shaking hands, the nervous movements?

Catra had pulled away from Adora suddenly, aggressively, probably because if she stayed any longer, she'd lose her resolve. More loudly, she said, "Release the little hunter first- the one that threw the net. Do it right when you hit the highway. Count to ten, then release Scorpia and the other hunter."

Adora looked up. "Why stagger it?"

"I want to talk to her, if only briefly. Tell her how she fucked up. Tell her I'm going to make a report directly to Juliet about them."

Melig, the cat, which Glimmer was staying away from, meowed and rubbed on Adora's legs. She bent down and picked up the goddess and fell into scratching its fur as if the motion calmed both of them. "Ok. I can do that."

Catra started to walk away before she stopped. Her hand was still in her pocket, and she turned to Adora. “I have a surprise for you. I’ll meet you back at the cave before sunrise and give it to you, ok?”

Adora looked up and nodded, only half aware. Only half paying attention.

It was then that Glimmer knew Catra had a ring and was going to propose and was probably fighting the urge to do it right then and there. She was almost proud of Catra for holding back. Right now wasn’t the time for it.

Catra turned to her and Bow. “Ok. It's go time. Everyone in their places.”

Bow kissed Glimmer on the cheek, and Glimmer leaned into it before he pulled away and headed to the passenger side seat of Adora’s car.

Catra made haste toward the hunters to give her little speech before they drove off.

Glimmer went to get her car. She got in, and her phone buzzed. Curiosity struck her. An email... From her credit card company... for the emergency card. A notice of a high transaction. Glimmer blinked at it. Balked at it. Her mind flew to Catra’s hand in her pocket, putting the pieces together.

She started the car, her chest burning with the kind of anger only Catra could drag out of her.

They had dragged the two hunters onto the sidewalk laying beside each other outside Casta’s business before Catra locked up.

Catra kneeled at the foot of the one Bow said was named Netossa and waited.

As she heard Adora’s car drive away and hit the access road, Netossa started to moan and move her fingers. She came to suddenly, bolting from laying down to sitting up. She breathed fast, heavy. She felt for her wife, found her, checked her breathing, and then her eyes instantly focused on Catra.

Catra stared back, unwavering. Yes, she lied to Adora. She was never going to give this woman the rundown about why she fucked up. No, there was something else she needed more. Something that didn’t quite fit with the stories that Bow, Glimmer, and Adora gave her about what happened. “You called a Code Red. Why?”

The woman blinked. Startled. Clearly, she was not sure if this was still a nightmare or not. In an unsure tone, she reported, “The target had its fangs on the neck of the client’s daughter.”

Catra’s brows furrowed. “But I wasn’t here.”

“Not you.”

Glimmer pulled the car up behind her.

Netossa pointed to the driver’s seat. “Her.”

Catra stared at the woman with the same numbness that had come over her when Casta left.

Behind her, Glimmer opened the passenger side door.

Catra stepped back slowly as the small flicker of a flame of anger started in her chest.

Netossa, with fear in her eyes, put herself over her wife protectively.

Catra turned her back on the hunters. They weren't the problem anymore. She got into Glimmer’s car and slammed the door.

Glimmer hit the gas. “We need to talk.” Her tone was tinged with anger as she turned and drove out of the parking lot a little too fast. A little too uncontrolled.

Catra felt the pilot light in her chest flair to an inferno. “Yeah, we fucking do.”

Avoiding Collateral Damage

Chapter Summary

> Catra and Glimmer have a discussion. Bow and Melig bond over a mutual error.

Glimmer glanced at Catra and caught the intensity of those mismatched eyes locking in on her in the dark. “No,” she declared emphatically. “No no no. You can’t have a fight with me to get out of the fight I’m trying to have with you.” She grabbed her phone from the drink holder between them in one fluid motion and tossed it into Catra’s lap. “Check the notifications.”

At first, Catra didn’t move. The phone sat precariously on her lap, and then, all at once, she ran her fingers through her hair and picked it up with her other hand.

“Buckle up before you get yourself killed.”

Catra did not buckle up. She moved slowly like she had to focus on doing things through a fog of anger. Glimmer heard it in her breathing. Strained. Tight, like the muscles in Catra’s stomach were all clenched. While Catra started to unlock the phone, with the key lock she wasn’t supposed to know but obviously had memorized, Glimmer asked, “And why the hell are you mad at me?”

Catra’s jaw clenched, grinding her teeth together.

This was a magnificent display of self-control. A testament to a decade of therapy, but also, maybe, a little bit of growing up.

With effort, Catra got out, “I told you... to stop... hitting on my girlfriend.”

“But I didn-”

“The code red was because her fangs were on your neck.” The last word came out as if she spat it. Her thumb flicked, and she reached the notification. She put the phone back in the drink holder more carefully than she had done anything. Slowly... measured, she said, “I have the money to pay it off.”

Glimmer gripped the wheel, losing her own control faster than Catra was losing hers. “I don’t fucking care if you have the money. If you were going to have the money tonight, then you wait till you can buy what is obviously a wedding ring *after* you have the money to pay for it.”

Catra’s hands clenched. Her eyes closed. She sat back, and Glimmer could hear her muttering one of her many anti-anger mantras.

Glimmer sat quietly for a moment, despite her own frustration. They both knew they were quick to anger. It was their weakness, and to avoid mutual catastrophic destruction, they had rules that only existed between them. One rule was, if a fight was imminent, to reduce the collateral damage. This meant if they were holding anything that could break, it had to be put down. If they were in the car, then the car needed to be pulled over.

She slowed the car down, turned on the hazards, and parked on the side of the road.

Catra leaned forward and covered her face with her hands. She raked her fingers down as she said, “My family is borrowed from you. My home. My food. I want one fucking thing that is mine. I want my girlfriend to be mine, and-” Her hands were down as she turned to Glimmer. Her eyes were wide. Teeth clenched. Catra’s whole body was tense. Her fingers curled in, making her fingernails into weapons. “Mine! Adora is mine! My girlfriend! My future wife!” She had lost her composure. Spit had started flying from her lips as she formed words. “And you-” Her hand shot out at Glimmer’s shirt.

It was a sign that Catra had lost her battle between the burning anger in her chest, and all Glimmer could think was that they didn't have time for a fight. Not a real one, anyway. As Catra pulled her toward her, to intimidate her, to scream till her lungs hurt and her throat was sore, and maybe get some of the energy that was building up out in a physical fight, Glimmer grabbed her back and teleported her out of the car.

The night had gotten chilly in the short time they had been in the car, or maybe, it was the instant change in temperature from teleporting from a warm car to a frosty night.

Just like in her nightmare, she misjudged a few feet above where she intended to land, but that was ok. It gave her time to adjust, move, and ensure Catra was beneath her.

All the air in Catra's lungs went right out as she landed, back first, into wet sod. Glimmer landed most of her body weight on Catra's middle and knocked the rest of the air out. She threw her hand over Catra's face and got in close. "No! You are going to listen to me!" Normally, she would have said an 'or else', but Catra had always been immune to threats.

Catra opened her mouth wide and bit down.

Glimmer yelled and sat up, pulling her hand back and shaking it. "Son of a-"

Catra raised her hand to go back to grabbing fabric, to continue yelling.

It happened without her even trying. Like an automatic defense mechanism, maybe brought about by the pain. When things cleared up, she would have to ask her dad about the ability to absorb spells from just watching them, maybe feeling them. She watched Keldor's skeleton summoning spell go off, and hands and arm bones reached out from the soil beneath them and grabbed Catra.

Catra's eyes went wide, not in fear but surprise, as her hands were pulled tight. Her jacket was locked down. One hand grabbed her skull and held it to the earth, while another held her jaw. She could only move her lips, and as she started cussing, another hand laid itself over her mouth so that all she could manage were mumbles.

Glimmer watched as her own anger faded to a kind of horror. There was an uncomfortable pressure in the center of her chest. Both arms hurt, and the pain shot up her neck into her jaw. She felt... short of breath. Lightheaded.

It only stopped when the bones stopped moving when whatever was powering them stopped flowing.

Catra's eyes silently burned at her with rage. She struggled against her bounds and screamed against the bones.

Glimmer winced. She didn't mean to do that. It was an escalation... and an unfair one. Even though she felt a twinge of regret, she rubbed the hand that Catra bit. "Glimmer talking time."

Catra screamed against the bones holding her mouth shut.

Glimmer ignored it. "That card is under my name, and you just used nearly all of the remaining balance. Credit utilization ruins my credit rating!"

Catra grunted and rolled her eyes big.

Glimmer went on. "My mom is co-signed on that card. You didn't know if you would have the money before you bought it, so you could have hurt her too, and that's unacceptable."

Catra seemed to attempt to talk, though it sounded like grumbling and growling, not unlike the sound the cat made when a wing was shoved in its mouth the night before.

Glimmer started adjusting her sleeves. "You broke a rule, and I have every right to hold you accountable."

Catra grunted.

Glimmer raised an eyebrow. “What? Do you want to lose emergency card privileges? What if Adora gets injured and needs emergency pig blood? Hm? What if you suddenly need money for a hotel, or she gets dusted by the sunlight?”

Catra grumbled.

Glimmer glared. “I didn’t think you’d like that. If you want the benefits of my credit rating to take care of emergencies, then go by my fucking rules. You got that?”

Catra stared at her, unblinking, but she made no audible rejections.

Glimmer ran her fingers through her own hair, if only because she had seen Catra do it so much when she was trying to calm herself down. “The thing about Adora- you are being an idiot. I wasn’t flirting with her.” She adjusted her weight to relieve some pressure off Catra’s stomach. “You worked so hard to tell everyone that it didn’t bother you. You told Adora that biting had nothing to do with sex, and maybe that’s true for other vampires or other people, but not Adora, and apparently, not you!”

At that, Catra went still, staring at Glimmer with all her malice.

Glimmer then started rubbing her hand where Catra had bit it. The teeth marks were starting to fade. She’d probably bruise, but nothing had broken skin. “Adora was having problems. Whatever the two of you did that upped her power level... it overwhelmed her, and she saw... visions of you and Scorpia together... Doing stuff.”

The fire burned out of Catra’s eyes, and she stared at Glimmer dumbfounded. This, apparently, was new information to her.

“It freaked her out, and Bow told her that you said you were fine with whatever she needed to do to get through tonight, and I had the idea that vampire influence... it has to be magic, right? And

I've just spent the last few days figuring out how to dispel magic- so I thought I could help- but I needed her to try to make it happen again." She looked down at Catra, holding her hurt hand. "So I had her start to bite me. I never even intended for her to actually do it. The whole time, she didn't want to do it, but she forced herself to, saying she was doing it for you under her breath the whole time."

Catra grunted.

Glimmer's lip twitched, and she moved a finger with intent to move the skeleton, and it made a wave of nausea hit her, but it freed Catra's jaw and lips.

Catra opened her mouth. "You have a fucking crush on her!"

Glimmer stared down at Catra. "Oh my god. Catra, of course I do. Tall buff blonde queen of the vampires? Fuck you!"

Catra growled before barking out, "You had one on Scorpia, Huntara, and all the others."

Glimmer let out a big breath. "Yeah. You know me. I get a crush on everyone. I'm a bisexual disaster, and I have to structure my life around that fact. But Catra, it only lasts six months, if that long. After that, it fades. Why do you think I waited six months before I started dating Bow?"

At that, Catra shut her mouth and blinked.

Glimmer relaxed just a little. This was moving out of fight territory. She sat back, relieving more pressure. "You remember the first few people I dated. Pure disasters. Bundles of red flags. It took me years to realize that I had to slow down and let my brain catch up. I give myself six months, and then I start noticing all the flaws that the crush was hiding. I start to see the red flags, or maybe just the stuff I find annoying." She looked down and realized, with a start, how uncomfortable it must be to be held on the wet ground like that. "I'm sorry for the skeleton hands. I didn't realize I could do that, and I didn't mean to do it to you."

Catra stared at her a moment before asking, “So... you think you’ll stop having a crush on Adora after... six months?”

Glimmer shrugged. “I assume so. I’ve never gotten to test it because you’ve never dated someone for that long.” She looked back down. “I’m not trying to take anything away from you. Catra, you know I would never! Breaking that kind of trust? You know I care about *us* too much. You know that I value our friendship above fleeting feelings like this.”

Catra blinked.

Glimmer’s jaw clenched before she said, “But, you’re the one who said you never wanted me to leave, and if that’s what you want, then you’re going to have to handle my occasional crushes. Just know that I will do absolutely nothing about them, ok?”

Catra chewed on her lip before saying, “Ok.” She looked away as if churning on that thought before saying, “You... think I pressured Adora into this whole feeding thing?”

Glimmer’s lip twitched. “She is still in that crush phase with you, and you’re... her first girlfriend. She has no immunity against it. Even if things make her really uncomfortable, she doesn’t know how to tell you that. Her brain goes into crush mode, and she just says yes. I saw it happen just now. She didn’t want you to leave, but she forced herself to be ok with it. She would, and I can’t stress this enough, do anything you asked her to. Even if she eventually resented you for asking her to do it.”

Then it happened. Catra’s eyes opened wide. The neurons fired. She put two and two together. “If I asked her to marry me now-”

“She’d say yes, no matter what, because she’s running off hormones and anxiety. Her brain is telling her to do anything and everything to keep a hold of you. That, Catra, is why people wait before they get married. Nearly everyone needs time to get over the initial rush to make sure they actually want what they think they want.”

All the anger dropped out of Catra's body. She slumped back into the dirt, looking away as if angry at herself. "Shit. I didn't think of it that way."

Glimmer waved her hand, and the skeleton hands started to move away, one by one. She did it, even though the motion hurt her chest and made her want to puke. "Hell, you're not immune either. I think you managed to bully yourself into this whole stupid situation. Your exes Catra?" She couldn't stop her voice from going up an octave at that. "What the hell were you thinking?"

Catra frowned. "I don't know." There was a desperation in her voice. A confusion that Catra was not used to dealing with. "I wanted it to be a success, and that was all I was thinking. I had to have lots of girls there and... and..." Her words failed her.

They had spent too long apart. They always worked best with someone else to fill in the parts they weren't good at. Glimmer was always better at understanding people, while Catra was always better at cutting through the crap and getting to the point in the most direct way possible. But now that they were synced, Glimmer felt like new pathways had opened up in her brain. She was thinking about things differently. "You realize that the solution for the winter feeding problem doesn't have to be universal, right? Some vampires aren't going to be able to do it, no matter what the answer is. You just need a solution for most of the Horde and then to find smaller solutions for everyone else. Maybe Adora needs time before she can feed on other people. She needs therapy." And then the light went on in her mind. She slapped her forehead. "Catra! It's Razz!"

Now all the skeleton's hands had pulled away and laid down inert in the dirt. Catra made no attempt to get off the ground. She sank into the helplessness of where she was and stared at Glimmer, curious. "What about Razz?"

At this point, Glimmer couldn't hold it in. Couldn't modulate her voice. "Her horses! She's got a whole stable of horses. Enough to keep Adora fed all winter!"

Catra’s mouth fell open.

“Razz is old and blind as a bat. She would never notice if the girl she’s giving therapy sessions to were taking a few pints out of her horses, right?”

Catra grunted in a mystified and a little horrified way. “Oh my god.”

“I’m right! I can’t believe I didn’t think about this sooner.”

Catra gaped for a moment before uttering, “Glimmer... I’m an idiot.”

“No, you're not. You got blinded. You needed a solution for the Horde and lumped Adora in with that, so you didn’t even see your options.” She got up and offered a hand to help Catra up.

Catra grabbed her arm, and they both worked to get her to her feet.

Once Catra was up, she didn’t let go of Glimmer’s arm. She held it and looked at her.

Before they had known each other, they had tackled the world alone. Glimmer had her parents, but they couldn’t be there all the time. Catra had been slashing her way through life, defaulting to violence and anger when life gave her no other tools. Together, they had something they didn’t have apart. That fact was more important than credit cards. More important than... misplaced jealousy.

Catra didn’t let go and, instead, threw an arm around Glimmer’s shoulders and pulled her in for a hug. “Thanks for letting me calm down.”

Glimmer, her face smooshed into Catra’s shoulder, said, “No problem.”

Catra added, after a moment's pause, "I'm sorry for using the card. I guess... my brain kind of shut off, and I was going on autopilot. I needed that ring to make up for all my shitty choices before then... And it was stupid. I should have talked to you about it first... at least. I'll pay it off tomorrow as fast as I can."

Glimmer nodded and pulled her face away. She wanted to look Catra in the eye for this part. "I'm sorry I broke your trust about Adora." She held her gaze, even though Catra looked like she wanted more than anything to talk about anything else. "I didn't know I was crossing a boundary, and you can guarantee I never will again. But," She grabbed Catra's collar and pulled her in. It was a mock mirror of the motion Catra had done to her in the car.

Catra smiled, that sly, knowing smile she was so good at.

"But," Glimmer repeated, "You have to be honest with yourself and with me. If something bothers you, no more pretending it doesn't!"

Catra's shoulders fell. "I promise... I should have said something before it started. I just... I got tunnel vision on the ring, and proposing, and-"

Glimmer smiled and pulled back. "I get it. It's ok." She held out a fist. "Ride or die?"

Catra nodded and met the fist with a bump. "Yeah. Ride or die. Always."

Glimmer turned them both back to the car. "Now, are you ready to shake down my father and get him to stop putting out hits on your girlfriend?"

Catra's jaw set. She nodded firmly.

"Ok. And this time, you are going to buckle up."

They both ran back to the car as if it was a race they started when they were ten.

***

Adora's hand shook, even as she held the steering wheel. She couldn't will the shaking to go away.

The voice returned as if the woman was right there in the car with her. As strong as it had been while she was on the floor, undoing knots. "Your father always told you that shaking hands made vampires salivate."

The voice couldn't be real. There was no way Shadow Weaver knew what her father had told her. Adora glanced at Bow to see if he heard what she was hearing, just on the off chance that she was wrong.

Bow didn't react and petted the cat, causing it to purr like a little engine.

Ok, so the voice *was* in her head. Just in her head. A stress response. She had... let things go too far, maybe. Let herself draw too many people under her influence, and... was still struggling to pull herself out of it. That... might explain it.

The voice, dark and low, in Shadow Weaver's conspiratorial register, said, "It's the fear. They can smell it. But you know that. You smelled the fear of humans before. You've tasted it."

Adora could almost taste the gamy tang of fear on her tongue at the suggestion.

The voice sounded so real. So physical... like it was right behind her. She glanced in the rearview mirror and saw nothing in the back seat.

She just... needed to give herself time to wake up fully. Wait for the magic to clear out. She needed to hide this from Bow unless she wanted him to think she had gone mad.

A shiver went through her as she tried to get a grip on her own mind. She was just... hearing her own thoughts out loud.

“You and Catra got silverware from Angella, right?”

Adora flinched at Bow’s voice, gathered herself, and said absent-mindedly, “Um, yeah.”

Adora felt someone moving up to her ear. Talking low, quiet, as if to avoid having Bow hear her, Shadow Weaver’s voice said, “He’s a nice boy. Very kind. Very sweet. He’s, had what? A few weeks of training? And you’re driving him straight to the lion's den?”

Adora focused very hard on the road, but she couldn’t think of anything but how that was true. Bow was really untested as a hunter. He didn’t have the years of experience he needed to be doing what they were about to do. Bow had, all told, fought two vampires, and both times he was the backup. That... wasn’t enough. Catra could do it because Catra didn’t have any fear to show. Catra also had protection from the marks on her neck... Marks that Adora couldn't bring herself to give Bow... not after tonight... not ever.

Bow smiled at her. Melig curled into his lap, and he ran his fingers through its hair. “I’d prefer it if I had my silver-tipped arrows, but you have stakes in the trunk, right?”

“Catra has stakes in the trunk,” Adora said automatically, maybe a little too quickly.

It felt like something touched her shoulder. She could feel Shadow Weaver’s mask against her ear. “I would hate to imagine what would happen if that poor sweet boy got injured. Or worse, what would happen if he died? That sparkling friend of yours- the damage she could cause with rage. You, of course, will survive anything. You’ve got the power of the most ancient one in you. But him? He’s just a human. Soft and filled with delicious blood, and you’re delivering him to his enemies on a platter.”

She shook her head, silently arguing against it. No no no. Bow would go with her, and she would protect him.

The voice responded. “Yes. You would protect him with your life. That’s the problem, isn’t it? He means something to you, and you’d die protecting him- and what happens if you die? Someone else becomes the Horde Lord, and things return to how they were. Thousands of people will die because of you.”

That made Adora stare at the road in deep thought. It was true. If push came to shove, she’d protect Bow with her life... and that was a problem.

The voice cooed in her ear, “And now you know you can put him under your influence. What if you do that accidentally? All it takes is the wrong command, and he gets hurt. *You* don’t want to be the one that hurts him, do you?”

That thought made Adora’s adrenaline spike. It bothered her immensely that Bow had been affected by her influence. She didn’t know how she had done it. She had theories, but nothing she could prove without asking Bow intrusive private questions about his past. The truth was, it didn’t matter how it was possible, only that it was.

She felt like she was on the verge of making a mistake that felt, for all the world, completely logical.

Unbidden, she felt like she heard Glimmer’s voice loud and clear, *You’re family now, and that means we don’t go running off doing reckless things alone. In this family, we do reckless things together* .

Shadow Weaver’s voice rumbled, “If that’s true, why did they leave you?”

Adora had no response to that. Why were Catra and Glimmer driving off alone to confront Micah, leaving her in the impossible situation of protecting Bow alone?

She found herself saying, out loud, “You know what... Let’s stop by the apartment and get your bow and arrows.”

Bow perked up. “I mean, I’d love that, but haven’t you been trying to stay away?”

She forced a smile at him. “With Glimmer and Catra going to confront Micah...” She turned to him. She hoped her look would be genuine. “I think we’ll be safe. Besides, I won’t go inside. I’ll park a little away.”

Out of the corner of her eye, she saw someone who shouldn’t be there in the back seat. It was unmistakable. Shadow Weaver looked at her with those broken, red, cracked eyes.

Bow leaned toward her a little. “Do we have time?”

Adora blinked, and the vision of Shadow Weaver was gone, which... was a relief. Still, the sight had unnerved her. Her heart was pounding in her chest. “Probably not, but I’m the Horde Lord. I can arrive whenever I want. And...” She calmed down a little in the assurance that what she was going to say wasn’t a lie. “I’d feel more comfortable if you had your weapons with you.”

He readily agreed, and his fingers scratched into Melig’s fur even deeper, causing the whole car to be filled with the animal’s purrs.

The voice whispered, “That cat hates vampires. You don’t want it to see you acting as Horde Lord. What if you had to use the power you have? It will hate you once it sees what you’ve become. What a monster you are.”

Adora felt a stinging in her eyes as she held back tears. This thought had lingered in her for a few days, but she hadn’t verbalized it. Hearing it... struck her hard. She wanted desperately just to be a normal woman with a girlfriend and a cat, living in an apartment with her friends. Someone with a good relationship with her girlfriend’s adoptive parents.

But that was a fantasy. Reality demanded her attention.

Adora focused back on the road. She turned the car around, assuring herself that... she was doing the right thing.

***

Once the car was parked, Bow started to put the cat down.

Adora said, too quickly, “Take Melig in.”

Bow looked up, the cat half hanging out of his hands since it was relaxed and acted like it was boneless. “Really?”

Adora’s smile looked strained. “Yeah. After all this is over, if it wants to stay with us, it will have to get used to the apartment, right? Might as well give it a chance to get familiar.”

Something pinged Bow’s brain as... odd. Adora looked vaguely like a frightened animal forcing itself to stay still. This he attributed to the trauma of the last few hours, and it was to be expected. He figured the best thing he could do was go along with her request. Maybe she needed a moment alone, so he gathered up the cat and bundled it into his arms like gathering up fluid fur. “Ok. Sure.”

The animal leaned into him, purring loudly, its body languid and enjoying the warmth.

He turned toward the parking lot and headed to the stairs.

He looked back occasionally and saw Adora sitting in the car, not moving. Looking forward. His dad’s called it the thousand-yard stare. The blank, unfocused gaze of someone emotionally detached from the horrors around them. It would happen to soldiers in war and to hunters who had seen too much action.

If there was a hunter who had ever seen too much action... it was Adora.

As if reading his mind, the cat gave a little helpless noise of concern.

Bow turned his attention back to the cat as he climbed the stairs. “She’ll be ok. She just needs time to get over what happened. We’ll give her some space.”

The cat climbed him a little to look back at the car, while he reached into his pocket to pull out the key.

The door clicked open, and his senses were hit with a familiar smell that didn't smell much like anything in particular. It was... too quiet, though. He was used to this place having more people in it.

He closed the door, turned on the light, and put the cat down.

The animal backed up against the door, and Bow watched, slightly concerned. "I'm going to be honest. I don't know what to do. Do I pick you up and carry you around? Do I let you explore on your own?"

As if in response, the cat suddenly jumped onto the hallway table and pushed the curtains aside to look out. It then settled down, its tail swishing back and forth as if it was waiting for something.... or worrying about something.

He looked out where the cat looked out and saw, in the distance, the car with Adora still sitting there. "She'll be ok." He petted the cat in one long comforting motion before turning to the rest of the apartment. "You'll like living here with us. We're normally really chill. We have movie nights on Fridays and game nights on Mondays. Glimmer and Catra go to brunch with Angella and Micah on Sunday mornings." He talked while he opened the hallway closet. His bow and arrows were stuffed in the back.

The cat made a small meow in response.

He felt a pang in his chest. "Though, I wonder if things will ever return to normal. With Adora basically taking on the duties of a world leader..." He didn't finish that thought out loud, but internally, he wondered if... without the protection of the catacombs, if the apartment was even safe for her... or them. "I wonder if it might be better for Glimmer and me to move in with you guys into the cave. I wonder if that's allowed. It would be a

little bit of trouble, but it would be worth it." He put the quiver of arrows on his shoulder and picked up the bow.

Absent-mindedly, he mused, "No matter what, Adora is safest when she's with all of us. If Juliet thought that one dedicated hunter bodyguard was enough, then three have to be even better."

The cat started whining.

Bow closed the closet door and looked over. "It's ok. We won't be much long-" Before he could finish, he looked up as the cat's whaling went up an octave.

Bow looked out to see Adora's car, in the distance, inch forward. "Oh, she's probably just adjusting the-"

Then the car took off and disappeared into the night.

The cat's whining turned into a wail.

Bow's shoulders and heart fell. "Oh..."

Ah, Fuck

Chapter Summary

> Bow goes with the flow and learns something new about Melig. Adora is not in a great place, and wouldn't it be a shame if someone took advantage of that. Glimmer and Catra have a heart-to-heart with Micah.

Chapter Notes

> "...She would, and I can't stress this enough, do anything you asked her to. Even if she eventually resented you for asking her to do it."
> -Glimmer, talking to Catra about Adora in the last chapter.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Bow stepped out into the night and shivered as it felt like the world had gotten ten degrees colder. He shifted the cat in his arms to pull the door shut and check that it was locked twice before turning to walk down the stairs. He had taken the time to string his bow so he could put it over his shoulder with his arrows and grabbed his helmet with his free hand.

He took the stairs light-footed and tried to wrangle his helmet on his head while still holding the cat. Melig gripped Bow's arm with its claws through his jacket sleeve.

Bow reached the bottom step and talked because his voice might calm the cat. "It's ok. I have a vehicle. We'll catch up with her." He said it with a smile. "She's just a little freaked out. That's all. She probably got scared I might get hurt or something. She does that a lot."

The cat's claws retracted slightly.

The wind picked up and blew hard across the parking lot, rustling the trees. "I'll have to be extra careful in this weather." A shiver

went through him, and he realized he probably should have gotten more fully dressed for the cold. Still, he walked toward the small area near the road reserved for two-wheeled vehicles. He stopped beside his yellow Vespa.

The cat gave a short snort of indignation.

Bow frowned. "It's a perfectly fine mode of transportation. It can go upward of thirty miles an hour, and it's very economical!" He said, quietly under his breath, "And it doesn't require me to have a motorcycle license to drive. It was a very practical choice!"

The cat opened its mouth wide and gave a long disappointed meow into the wind of the night.

Bow said in a rush, "We can catch up! She's going to be driving on a lot of country roads, and not all of them are paved. There are a lot of turns. She won't be able to go very fast. We'll arrive maybe a few minutes after she does, and then we can help her!"

So the cat calmed down while Bow shifted everything he was carrying so he could get the key out of his pocket. Before he could get it out, an engine rumbled in the distance. Bow looked up to see headlights coming down the road. The street lights illuminated a classic black mustang. He knew that car.

The cat did too. It started trying to climb up on his arm to get a better look.

"Adora! She's coming back!" He said as he swelled with pride.

The headlights turned toward them. For a brief moment, the world was washed away in bright white light before it was gone. Bow struggled to see anything, but he heard Adora's engine blow right past them, taking off in the opposite direction from the cave.

The cat tried to climb out of Bow's hands toward the car and started whaling into the night.

Bow held the cat tighter, more secure as he blinked his eyes. His vision came back just enough for him to see the red lights of Adora's car disappear in a turn. "Oh..." His shoulders fell. "I don't know where she's going now. If she gets on the highway... I don't think I can follow on my scooter."

The animal started squirming out of his arms.

He struggled with it, determined not to lose the pet and his friend in one night.

It twisted its body and pushed strong legs off his middle, digging back claws into Bow's bare midriff.

Bow yelped at the pain, but his hand reached out on instinct as the cat jumped free. He grabbed fur blindly. Though... the fur wasn't near the ground where he thought it would be. It was... almost at shoulder height. He blinked. His eyesight was coming back a little in the dark, and he saw his hand attached to... a giant cat?

He didn't have time to process that before the creature's back legs coiled and sprung.

Bow's grip tightened on instinct, and he was swung onto the creature's back, where he gripped for dear life with both hands.

The cat?... Lioness? Started following the car.

He should have been shocked, but Bow had learned to accept a lot of things that shouldn't make sense in the last few months, so he just said, "I guess this works," as loud as he could to make sure the thing could hear him, while he gripped it's... her? scruff, thankful he had taken the time to grab his helmet.

***

A little while earlier...

Adora slowed down and turned down the country road that would get her the most direct path to the cave. It was gravel surrounded on both sides by barbed wire fencing that would have normally kept the cows in. Cows that were right now herded into a barn, warm and safe from vampires looking for a snack.

This bothered her more than she thought it would. She was hungry. She had built up a hunger for the Bloody Kisses special, thinking she'd have more than she ever wanted to eat, and then been denied anything. It was bad enough to face the clan leads but to face them hungry...

Something flickered in her peripheral vision, and she looked into the rearview mirror.

Her sire sat in the back seat looking out the window. How many times had Shadow Weaver sat in that seat, looking that exact way while she had Adora drive her around for errands? This... this was just a reflection of her memory... augmented by leftover magic. Still, Shadow Weaver's voice rumbled in the car as if she were really there. "If you're hungry, you should eat something."

Adora focused on the road.

She could hear Shadow Weaver's deep and disappointed sigh before the vision said, "Just go back to town and find someone. It's not that hard. You don't even need an invitation now."

Adora hit the gas, determined to get to the cave as fast as possible, as a grand "fuck you" to the memory of Shadow Weaver.

When she looked back in the mirror, the vision was gone, and she let out a sigh of relief, then looked forward.

Something was in the road between the headlights.

Adora hit the brakes.

The car started to slide.

The headlights illuminated the thing. It was a person.

Adora swerved and thought she saw her girlfriend's outline for a brief moment.

The car stopped on the dirt road, and Adora found herself gripping the wheel and breathing fast and shallow.

Did she hit someone? Was it Catra?

Through the adrenaline that was making it hard to think, she unbuckled, opened the door, and got out.

The only sound in the night was the thrum of the idling car. Her boots crunched the dead grass on the side of the road as she looked around. “Hello? Is anyone there?” She looked back and saw someone standing in the road, illuminated in the red brake lights.

“Hey, 'Dora,” Catra’s voice called out over the night.

Adora let out a long breath, relief washing over her as she rushed to the back of the car.

Catra stood stiff in the road, just out of the range of the red brake lights. It made her difficult to see, as she was washed out in red and otherwise half in the darkness of the night.

Adora approached cautiously. “What are you doing here? Did Glimmer drop you off?”

Catra’s voice was unmistakable. It had the right tone. The right huskiness. But the way she said, “Of course,” as a response made Adora pause.

“Is... something wrong?” Adora moved forward and reached out to take Catra’s hand. It was a comforting gesture for both of them. She desperately wanted to just relax in the simple comfort of physical contact with her lover.

Catra shifted back further into the darkness of the night, moving her hand to be just out of reach. “Nothing’s wrong.”

Adora froze and blinked at the wind kicked up the dust and blew it into her eyes. She breathed some of it in and coughed into her jacket before turning back.

Catra didn’t react to the dust at all.

Adora felt weird in her stomach. “Why did she drop you off in the middle of the road?”

Catra tilted her head slowly. “Oh, Adora. You know why. She wanted to avoid what happened the last time she teleported into your car. Didn’t she end up straddling you?”

Adora swallowed the rest of the dust in her mouth and throat and focused on Catra. Her girlfriend was mad. Not in a rage and burn down the city kind of mad, but a slow simmer of smoldering fury. The kind of anger that Catra could linger in. Glimmer had always said this was when Catra got the worst. The hardest to deal with.

For a moment, Adora forgot about the Horde. Forgot about the Order. The only thing in existence was her girlfriend, stewing about something. “Is everything ok?”

“Just hunky dory.” Catra’s tone was mocking. She shifted back, moving away slightly.

Adora, on instinct, moved forward, then stopped herself. She wanted to fix things, but to fix them, she needed to know what had happened. “I guess this means you and her took care of Micah?”

“Oh, yeah. He was a pushover.”

Adora couldn’t place the look Catra gave her through the light of the red brake lights.

“That’s... good, right?” *Then what’s wrong?* She wanted to ask. *What did I do to make you mad?*

“That’s good, but not perfect.” She took a step forward, leaning in and cocking her head to Adora.

It was a weird gesture that Adora wasn’t prepared for. She stiffened up. “Are you going to come with me to the meeting?”

“I could,” Catra said noncommittally.

That tone made Adora’s stomach churn. She smoothed down her jacket to have something to do with her hands. “I could use you. Bow is... he’s not in the car. I left him at the apartment because... I didn’t want him to get hurt.” This was hard to say. Hard to admit. Now that she said it out loud, it sounded like a stupid thing to do.

Catra tilted her head the other way, unnervingly slow, before she said, “The clan leads can wait. Making them wait is a power move, anyway. It will do nothing but earn you *respect* .” She narrowed her eyes as she said the last word.

Adora squirmed under that scrutiny. She didn't know what was going on. She didn’t know how to react. “But... You were the one that wanted to answer Light Hope’s question as soon as possible.”

Catra licked her lips. Her eyes were unnervingly focused. Unblinking. “We’ve got to take care of something else tonight. Something more important.”

Adora took a half step back, not sure what she was feeling. Not sure how to soothe herself. “What could possibly be more urgent than that?”

She was unnerved by the smile that Catra gave her. It grew slowly on her face. “The hunters attacked you without provocation. Without going through the proper channels. You followed all their stupid rules. Played the good girl. You were the good little pet vampire, and they came after you anyway. That won’t stand. You

have to make a statement. Make sure nothing like that ever happens again."

Adora nearly shriveled under that gaze. Catra wasn't letting up. Wasn't releasing her from that hold. She was still angry, and Adora was still lost as to why. "We can talk to them tomorrow night and get that all cleared up."

Catra shook her head, again, too slowly. Again with those focused unblinking eyes. "No. We're past the point of talking. And no, it can't wait. If you wait, you'll lose every advantage you have."

Adora shook her head and shrank back. "I don't know what you're trying to say."

"If we go now, you'll have the element of surprise on your side. Show up, and give the hunters that good old-fashioned thrashing they deserve."

Adora snapped up at that, locking into Catra's eyes. Then, she understood. "You're angry at them rejecting you. I get it. It's not fair, and they deserve something but please-" She moved forward again, her voice cracking as she tried to reach her girlfriend. "Please come with me, and we'll deal with them tomorrow."

Catra moved back, one shoulder jerking back to avoid Adora's touch. The girl tilted her head slightly, still with that unnerving smile. "What? Getting scared?"

"No! I just-"

Catra narrowed her eyes, and the smile turned lopsided. "What's wrong? Aren't you going to defend my honor?"

"I... want to, but..." Adora stopped talking and stood there in the growing cold. The wind started to pick up around them, sending a wave of dust between them. She blocked her mouth and eyes from the dust with her jacket, then looked up at Catra.

Catra, with nerves of steel, hadn't reacted to the dust at all. She was still staring, still unblinking. Still focused in a way that seemed wholly unnatural.

Adora faced her again. She understood now. "You're not angry at the hunters... You're angry at me for not standing up for you."

Catra hummed to herself and stood up straight. "Finally. She's starting to get it. Not as dumb as people say you are, are you?"

Adora winced at that. Hurt by the tone. Glimmer was right. When Catra got like this, she could be downright mean.

Catra went on casually. "Glimmer destroyed the catacombs and broke the invitation magic that was protecting them in the process. Nothing is stopping you from just waltzing right into the building that your family's money built."

Adora turned slightly toward the car, grabbing her own arms. Closing off. Insecure. "You're also angry at me for not standing up for myself, aren't you?"

Catra lifted her eyebrows and cocked her head to one side. "Oh, I don't know. What makes you say that?" She said it in the lightest mocking tone, like talking to a child.

Adora's stomach felt tight. This was as bad as dealing with Shadow Weaver. That thought made her shiver. "One vampire against the hunter headquarters is suicide."

Catra clicked her tongue, then laughed and leaned back. "Oh, 'Dora. Making excuses. What other vampire has the power that you have now? None. Prime never had what you have. Your sire had magic, but she couldn't conjure a swarm of rats or put more than one person under her influence. Besides, you have me, right? I'm a force of nature, right?" She winked.

Adora shivered at that wink.

"Don't you love me?"

Adora answered automatically and honestly, through the anxiety brewing in her stomach. “I do.”

“Do you love me more than the Order?”

Did it all come down to Catra just needing assurances? Maybe to test if this was all worth it? Adora’s hands fell to her sides. She knew what was coming but couldn’t stop it. “You know I do.”

Catra’s smile grew, showing teeth that, in the weird red light and half-dark, looked too sharp. Looked fang-like. “Then go on, defend my honor, show them who's boss, or else I go back to someone who can stand up for me.”

Adora’s chest hurt.

Catra’s eyes glittered like she was enjoying it. “Scorpia’s still free, right?” As she said it, she cocked an eyebrow in Adora's direction.

Adora’s hands started shaking, but not out of fear. Indignity. Her muscles felt tight. No matter how it made her stomach churn. How her brain screamed with panic at the idea. The idea of losing Catra’s respect was infinitely worse. “We... won’t hurt anyone.”

“Of course not. I mean, not really.” Catra said smoothly, calmly.

“Just... show up and scare them.” Adora’s leg had begun to shake as she talked, making her voice quiver. She tried to stop it by shifting her weight.

Catra’s smile grew into a wide Cheshire smile. “Show them not to mess with you. One big shock and awe campaign, so they’ll leave us in peace. Show me that you’re not afraid to stand up for us.”

Adora closed her eyes tight. She would do almost anything to end this fight. She wanted... needed her Catra. She nodded.

Catra never dropped the eerie smile. “Let's get going. We don’t have all night.”

Adora didn’t look up as she moved to get back in the car.

When she got in, Catra was already sitting in the passenger seat with her seatbelt on.

Adora hadn’t heard the passenger side door open or close. She was shocked at how fast Catra had gotten buckled, especially when it usually took a few reminders. Adora pushed those thoughts out of her mind. She could relax now. Catra was finally with her, and that’s what mattered. No matter what they were doing, she could handle it as long as they were together. Catra had stood with her when she stood against the Horde at the last meeting. The least she could do is stand with Catra against... the Order. Her stomach felt like it had rocks in it. She closed the door, pushed down the clutch, and eased the gas to turn the car around with a three-point turn.

Catra’s voice nearly purred as she said in that raspy, husky voice, “Good girl. I knew you’d do the right thing.”

Adora swallowed, uncomfortable with the way those words made her feel sick.

***

“So, how are we going to stop my dad?” Glimmer asked as she turned the car into her parent’s neighborhood.

Catra shrugged. “I don’t know. I thought you could teleport him to a tower or something and hold him there till he gave it up.”

Glimmer let out a sigh. “I don’t think that’s going to be the long-term strategy we need.”

Catra tapped her nail against the armrest on the door. “Well, then, I’m out of ideas.”

“Just... ask him why this matters so much.”

Catra’s jaw clenched.

Glimmer added, “This is dad we’re talking about. The guy you could always call to come pick you up from a party, and he’d show up with painkillers and chilled bottled water and never breathe a word of it to mom.”

Catra’s jaw unclenched a little.

“The guy who set up a monthly hangout with you and him so you could bond. Didn’t he always get your favorite ice cream?”

Catra leaned against the window, all the fight slowly melting out of her.

“The guy who pulled you aside and gave you tips when he realized you had your first crush and had no idea what to do with yourself.”

Catra grumbled.

“He taught you how to tie your bow tie for prom. He bought you your first guitar and taught you the basics, right?” Glimmer slowed down the car. “Just remember, he’s not an unreasonable man. He loves you, and he’s worried about you. Just try to understand why he’s doing this and... make him feel heard, and I wonder if you can’t talk some sense into him after he gets his concerns out.”

The house that had been her haven in her youth appeared as Glimmer turned the car down the cul de sac where Micha and Angella’s house sat.

Micah’s car was in the driveway, idling. Micah looked up from his phone when Glimmer parked the car next to him.

His hair was disheveled like he hadn’t washed it in too long and hadn’t been at home long enough to brush it. There were bags under his eyes. His body looked like it had been carrying a worry for too long. The moment he made eye contact with her, the worry faded. He looked so damn happy as he opened the door.

Catra opened her door along with him, meaning to jump into the fight. Meaning to berate him for trying to kill her girlfriend.

Instead, she was pulled into a hug. Glimmer's reminders flooded her brain, and instead of fighting him, she sank into it, taking the simple pleasure of having an adult that cared for her, even if how he cared was a problem.

He squeezed her hard as he whispered, "You're ok. You're both ok." He then looked up past her and pulled back. "But.. where are the hunters?"

Glimmer slammed her door shut and answered, "They're fine. Hopefully, they're going home and rethinking some of their decisions."

He turned to Catra, a new look of confusion on his face. "Then you... you came here willingly?"

Catra had wanted to yell at him. Wanted to goad him into fighting her. Anything to take out the anger... but now, she couldn't muster it. She was still angry at his actions, but she couldn't make herself fight the closest thing she had to a good father. Instead, she said, "Yeah. We came willingly because we figured it was the only way you'd stop."

The happiness of the moment faded in his eyes. A weariness took over. "Then the vampire is still out there."

Catra pulled herself out of his hold by stepping back. "Yeah. And fucking traumatized, no thanks to you."

Glimmer came up behind her and cleared her throat a little.

Catra grumbled but took the note. She straightened her back and looked Micah in the eye. "I want to know what's your damage."

Glimmer elbowed Catra in the side.

Catra growled but added, “I mean, we want to hear your side of things.” She stuck her hands in her jacket pockets, her fingers grasping the ring and its box. “And then, I want you to hear my side of things. You got that?”

Micah pulled back a little, glanced at Glimmer, then looked back at her and nodded. “Ok. That seems fair.” He then looked down at the ground. “Before I continue, I need you both to know that this must be kept secret from Angella for her protection.”

Catra raised an eyebrow at him.

Glimmer grabbed Catra’s arm, hugged it, and answered for both of them. “Absolutely. Right Catra?”

Catra snorted but didn’t say no.

Micah nodded and looked beyond them. “I was a teenager. I lived and worked at a Buddhist temple in Korea in the mountains. I was training to become a priest. The temple was over a thousand years old when I went there. It was home to some shrines that had been there thousands of years before the temple was built. I was put in charge of those shrines. I slept in a room off the building where they were housed. I’d clean and maintain them. One of my first tasks was learning the rituals to keep what was in one of those shrines contained.”

Catra let out a breath. “What does this have to do with vampires?”

Glimmer squeezed her arm.

Micah stood back and cupped his hands as if holding a bird. “It was a boring life, and one night, we had a traveler visit the temple. She was foreign and exotic. I was asked to show her around, so I did. She took an immediate interest in me.” He opened his palm.

Glimmer gasped as a glowing ram made of light leaped out of her father’s palm and into the air. It rose and dissipated above them in a flash of yellow, glittering sparks.

Catra watched it but then leveled her gaze on Micah. “What was her name?”

“She asked me to call her Light Spinner because of tricks like these. She started teaching me magic. She said I had talent she had never seen before. I quickly mastered the stuff she showed me. She kept visiting every night. We would meet in private.” His hands fell to his sides. “I had some inclination of what she was. She only showed up at night. She never went into any of the buildings. But she was kind to me, and I thought there was no way she could be the terrible monstrous thing it seemed like she was.” He blushed a little. “I was thirteen and had the attention and interest of an older woman. I was infatuated.”

Catra felt Glimmer's grip on her arm loosen a little.

“She told me I was too good to waste in the monastic life. She offered me immortality. A chance to live forever, study magic, and follow her as her protégé.” He looked defeated. Deflated. “I was enamored with the romantic idea of forever. Of being whisked away from my boring life to live... with her.”

Catra flinched at the mention of forever. “Adora’s different. She doesn't want to turn me.”

He sighed. “Light Spinner didn’t really want to turn me either. If she did, I’d be a vampire because I wouldn't have stopped her. She made a big show of leaving to ask her leader for permission to turn me. Before she left, she...” He reached up to cup his neck to cover an old wound that still hurt. “She marked me as her pet. Told me it would protect me from evil things. I can’t tell you what it was like to have a woman like that put her lips on my neck. I would have done anything for her.”

Catra sneered. “That is completely different-”

He gently put up a hand to tell her to stop.

She went quiet.

“She was gone for months. Came back on a rainy night. She knocked on the storm cover of the window in the room where I slept and, distraught, begged to be let inside.”

Glimmer’s grip tightened. “Oh, dad...”

“I invited her in because I was young and stupid... I wasn’t thinking about what she was. I was thinking she was uncomfortable and that she sounded like she was on the verge of crying. I helped her get dry and warm, and then she told me her request had been denied. That she would have to leave soon and wanted to see me one more time before she went away forever.” He looked at the ground. “And I was heartbroken. I cried in her arms until I fell asleep. When I awoke...” His hands clenched into fists, and he shook his head as if trying to shake the memory. “The mark did what she said it would. It protected me... but no one else. My invitation had opened up the whole place to her.” His face twisted in remembered grief and pain. “The shrines were destroyed, plundered. The one shrine I was supposed to protect. The one I was told to never bleed on because what it contained was too evil to let loose again... it was gone and in the hands of a vampire who knew magic. I thought I had doomed the world. I couldn’t sleep for decades. I still have nightmares about it.” He shivered.

Catra keyed in. What were the odds that there were two vampire sorceresses with names like Light Spinner... Shadow Weaver.

Micah went on talking, not noticing her. “When a vampire makes you their pet, their target isn’t you. The con, the target, is about what they can get through you. For me, it was the damned crystal in the shrine. Light Spinner was never interested in me as a person. I was targeted, specifically, because of where I slept.” He hesitated as he looked at her.

Catra focused on him as a single word sent off neurons in her brain. “The crystal she stole. What did it look like?”

Micah’s body language changed. His face lost the pain of remembering. Instead, he furrowed his brow and studied her like he did when she was little when she said or did something that was unexpected. He had always been the first to trust her instinct. He didn’t hesitate. “Green. Three points.”

Glimmer pulled away from Catra’s side so she could give Catra a look that begged for an explanation.

Catra ignored Glimmer and looked at Micah with the focus of a cat on a mouse. Her hand clinched around the ring in her pocket. “What was it? Why did Light Spinner want it so badly?”

Micah blinked and quickly said, “There isn’t a word for it in Korean. They called it an evil spirit, but it was a bloodthirsty deity bound to the crystal through the sacrifice of someone it had infected. In simple modern terms, it was supposed to be a...” He stopped for a moment and looked her straight in the eye. “A vampire god.”

Catra’s hand unclenched. She recontextualized that night in the cave with Lynn leading Adora to put her bloodied hand on a green three-pointed crystal. The crystal that seemed to give Adora amazing powers out of nowhere. The one that also made her so powerful, she was having a problem keeping the power in check. “Ah, fuck.”

Chapter End Notes

> "**Gods, Vampire**: Dreadful deities of merciless bloodthirstiness, beings that possess distinctly vampire-like characteristics. Like death itself, the vampire god is found in the earliest, blackest, and most dreadful memories of humanity. The terror of the night, of blood-drinking divinities, and losing one’s life to an utterly evil creature are found in countries all over the world...They were normally depicted with fangs, red eyes, and an insatiable appetite for blood... The vampire god epitomizes the eternal nature of the undead and the general powerlessness of primitive man to oppose

them. Only a great Hindu or Buddhist saint could hope to defeat such foes, short of divine intervention from a good god or the powers of light...”- The Vampire Encyclopedia by Mathew Bunson

On the cusp of Apocalypse

Chapter Summary

> Adora plays the world's worst game of chicken. Glimmer finally gets a magic lesson from her dad. Catra makes a decision that could have world-ending consequences.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

It was the little things she didn't even know she needed until they were gone. She had never noticed before how often she just... touched Catra. Maybe it was touching her knee as she shifted the car into a different gear or just reaching over to touch a hand. But she noticed them all now because they were all, apparently, off limits.

She would go to shift gears, and Catra would move her knee before Adora could touch it. Catra would adjust in her seat the moment Adora tried to lay a hand on her.

It made Adora's stomach hurt.

Catra's voice cut through the cold and the dark. "If I'm going to be your pet, then you need to be worthy of being my *master* ."

Adora's body reacted to that last word, said that way like it had emphasis. Like it had extra meaning. It had... implications she didn't have the brain capacity to parse out at the moment. She tried to focus on making all the right turns down roads marked "do not enter" and "no trespassing."

The gate to the order's headquarters appeared out of the trees in the light of her headlights. Adora brought the car to a slow stop. Her eyes lingered on her own last name wrought into that iron gate, taunting her.

Catra adjusted in her seat, staring at the name. “I need someone who can keep up with me. Someone that will rise to my challenge.”

Adora shrank back into her jacket in the seat.

Catra shifted away. “It says a lot that you haven’t used our little word yet. Keep that up. We’ll see how far you go.”

It dawned on Adora that the word Catra was talking about was their safe word. This was a test to see how far she would go. To see if she would chicken out and use the word first. That thought made a pit open up in her stomach.

Catra licked her lips and turned toward Adora in the car. “You do this right, baby, and we can take this to the next level. Don’t disappoint me.”

The unspoken threat was that if she didn’t do it right, then... then there would be no next level. She swallowed her concern and tried to focus on... whatever Catra meant by “next level.” Her mind raced with possibilities. What more could there be besides giving Catra her whole heart? Her body? And in this act... her honor as a hunter? She turned to look at Catra to ask for clarification but stopped short.

Catra was no longer in the car.

It took Adora a moment to realize she must have zoned out enough not to hear Catra getting out. Adora opened her door, stood up, and looked around.

Catra was gone.

She heard something she didn’t expect. Bow’s voice.

“Adora! There you are!”

She turned to look down the road where they had come. Bow was standing there with his bow and arrows. Melig stood next to him,

watching her.

“I was worried! I can’t believe you’d run from me like that.” Bow smiled easily. He always did, like forgiveness was just that casual. His arrows were in half disarray in his quiver. He swung the bow off from around his shoulders. Then, his eyes landed on the building behind her, and his smile faded. “What... what are you doing here?”

She froze at that question.

He started to look at her, concern on his face. “You’re not even supposed to know where this place is.”

Adora cleared her throat and called back, “I don’t know what place you’re talking about. I was just... taking a drive to- uh- clear my head.” Adora cringed. Adam had always been the better liar between them.

Bow took a step forward and shook his head. “We shouldn’t be here. Let me take you back to the apartment before anyone sees you. Before you set off the wards.” He gave her a very nervous laugh. “Wouldn't want you setting off the alarm and causing everyone to rush out here with stakes, nets and stuff, right?”

She shrank back into her jacket.

“We can call off whatever is going on with the Horde. I think, maybe, you need to take some time off and... recover.”

Adora desperately wanted to go home... back to the apartment, which was why she wasn’t sure this was real. His being there didn’t make sense. She didn’t see his Vespa.

The cat narrowed its eyes on her.

She blinked at the cat and asked, “How... how did you get here, Bow?”

He scratched his neck. “You will not believe me but your cat-”

The cat hissed and lunged at him with full claws.

He yelped and jumped aside, avoiding the claws. “Ok ok, ok! I’m sorry! Never mind. Sheesh!” While eyeing the cat, he recovered and said, “It doesn’t matter how I got here. The point is, I’m here, and we’re going home.”

Adora rubbed her face. “How... How do I know you’re real?”

Bow looked worried. “Are you... seeing things?”

Adora felt like she couldn't get enough breath in. Or maybe she was hyper ventilating. She tried to slow down. “Maybe...” She looked down at the cat.

Its ears were up and turned toward her. Its eyes focused on her unblinking. Unnatural. Staring into her soul.

She swallowed. “Catra... She's here. She wants me to... teach the Order a lesson.”

Bow’s fingers twitched. “Catra isn’t here. She’s with Glimmer and Micah.”

Adora shook her head. “Glimmer teleported her, and she wanted to come back here because she was angry and-”

“What if I can prove that Catra is with Glimmer?”

She looked up at that.

“Wait. Just wait. I’ll call real quick. You can talk to them.”

Adora focused on Bow. Her heart ached for him to be real.

Bow’s hands checked his back pocket, then his front pocket, and his shoulders fell. “I guess I dropped my phone on the way here.” He glared down at the cat. “It was a rough ride.”

Melig made a small apologetic meow at him.

She started to turn toward the building, her heart fighting against her ribs.

Bow now fumbled to get his weapon back in a ready stance. "Don't! If you do... Adora... I have to stop you. I can't let you do anything to the Order."

She hesitated. She was pretty sure this wasn't really Bow. It wasn't really her cat. If the visions were her inner thoughts, then Bow's vision would be her inner conscience. She didn't want to hurt anyone, and Catra said they wouldn't. She swallowed. If she backed out, she was going to lose the love of her life. Adora shook her head. "I don't have a choice. I have to do this." She started to turn.

The bowstring made a *twang* in the night. Pain coursed through her, mixing with shock. She looked down, expecting an arrow in her chest. Instead turned face-first into an exploding cartridge.

Bow had been real. And he shot her!

Her brain sparked as something hit her face. Lots of little somethings. It didn't really hurt until she saw what they were.

Once, and only once, her sire had used seeds against her. Dropped seeds on the floor and left her there for days. Shadow Weaver told her it was to remind her of her weaknesses and her youth and how that made her vulnerable.

As the seeds hit, she fell to her knees and lost the air in her lungs. She thought no one would ever do this to her again.

From down the road, Bow called out. "I'm sorry! I'm so sorry! It's non-lethal. I had to stop you. You're not yourself right now!"

Adora yelled until her throat hurt. Yelled so hard that her chest ached. She fought against the compulsion as tears blurred her vision.

***

Catra had, in a very short amount of time, given Micah a rough overview of the last few weeks while Glimmer focused on trying to call Bow.

Catra talked about them joining the order, Adora becoming the Horde Lord and banning non-consensual feeding, fighting Adora's necromancer uncle, seeking to free the trapped vampire souls, and then the crystal.

As she talked, he did that thing that, as a child, she had been a complete fool for. He sat down and gave her his complete and undivided attention. He listened. Really listened.

He let her finish, then leaned forward. "I wish I had known. I would hope that... If I had let myself listen to you before, I would have seen that she wasn't like Light Spinner." He breathed and planted his hands on his knees, "I am so sorry that I pushed you away. I was scared, and I shouldn't have let my fear of your getting hurt force me to let you actually get in trouble. I was... I was wrong about Adora. She sounds like a good person." He looked away and shook his head. "I should have known. Angella trusted her, and Angie sees stuff in people I can't."

Catra couldn't help but smile at him. At that moment, she felt a kinship that she couldn't explain. His accepting Adora meant the world to her.

He rubbed his neck, the spot where Shadow Weaver's mark lingered in his thinking. "Creatures like this work by finding a foothold in our physical world. They stick a finger through a crack and slowly burrow their way in. Right now, this vampire god is probably not even here yet, not all the way anyway. But every time your girlfriend uses its power, she draws it a little further in."

That pricked at the back of Catra's mind. "So... let's say she used it to summon a bunch of rats at a diner."

He frowned. "That would be bad."

“And, theoretically, let's say she used the power to put five people under her influence for an hour or so.”

His shoulders fell. “Oh... that’s very bad.”

“So what happens if this thing becomes fully realized?”

Micah looked into her eyes. He never sugar-coated things with her. He knew he didn't have to. “Then we’d have a vampire apocalypse on our hands.”

Catra ran her fingers through her hair. “So... How do we save her and save the world? Or do I have to plan on joining the dark side?”

Micah unexpectedly smiled. “You’re in luck. I was the caretaker of its prison.I trained on how to do the blessings. I memorized the binding spells used to hold it in the crystal.” He looked away, his smile softening. “After all this time trying to hunt her... I might be the only person in existence who could save her. If that’s not dramatic irony, I don’t know what is.”

She could have hugged him. She almost did.

Glimmer interrupted. “He’s not answering!” She looked up from her phone. “He won’t pick up. I’ve left voicemails. I’ve texted him.”

Catra clenched her fists. “He knows his job. He’s the bodyguard on duty. If he’s not answering-”

“Nope.” Glimmer cut in. “Not even going to entertain any of those thoughts.” She grabbed Catra's hand, then hooked her arm with her father. All she said was, “Hold on. I think I can get us there.”

It was still such a wonder what Glimmer could do so casually. Almost inhuman. As the world dissolved in pink and purple sparks, Catra watched Micah’s face for any sign that he was surprised. He wasn’t. He braced for it.

Catra was expecting to land in a car, maybe in the back seat. Maybe they would all tumble onto Bow's lap.

But her feet landed on dirt and leaves. They all three landed right in front of Bow, who just happened to be standing in the middle of a forest and not sitting in a car.

While Glimmer reached for Bow and hugged him, Catra asked, "What happened?"

Bow answered by pointing forward.

Catra turned and saw Adora. She was on her knees, roughing up her latex suit's legs in the gravel of the road. She was grabbing something and putting it into her hand. Tears streamed down her face, making the mascara that Catra had so carefully applied earlier run.

Catra understood what had happened when she looked past her tormented girlfriend and saw the building behind her. Saw where they were. Catra's jaw clenched as she realized the thing inside Adora was using her own insecurities against her. Taunting her with the Order. Poking at her most sensitive and painful thoughts. And then... Bow had to go and make it worse.

Bow was breathing hard and fast. "I had to stop her. It's just seeds. But she was... she was going to do something bad."

Catra felt the pilot light start in her chest. Seeds were torture. Right off the heels of having been locked in with nets, this was a lot to do to one vampire. Just as Catra was about to move forward, about to fix this, when something nudged against Catra's leg. She looked down to find Melig. The cat had clamped onto her jeans, holding her there, keeping her from moving forward.

Micah stepped up. "Seeds are a perfect containment." He turned to Catra and gave her a soft smile. "It's not pleasant, but it's what we need to do right now. I can't guarantee that what I'm about to do won't hurt either. She will... need some care and attention to recover from this."

Melig pawed at her, pleading.

Catra sighed. “Fine. Let's get this done quickly.”

Micah put his palms together, closed his eyes, and started chanting something in Korean. His hands began to glow as he took a step forward.

Adora, teeth gritted, looked up at him approaching. She didn’t look like herself. Her pupils were dilated dark pools surrounded by bloodshot that made her eyes look stark red. She only looked at Micah and those glowing hands, then threw her head back and screamed into the night.

The wind picked up leaves and threw them hard into them. Micah’s progress stopped momentarily before Catra got in front of him. She stood unmoved. She didn’t care if leaves hit her.

“Every time she uses its power,” Micah yelled over the wind, “This gets a little harder.”

Catra pushed forward. He followed.

The clouds above them gathered into large rolling masses that churned the sky. Within the clouds, there were little dots of darting things. Catra heard the roar of it. The sound of thousands of bats above them, swirling and swooping. Screeching and chirping.

The heavens let loose, raining bats on them all.

Catra put up her arms to shield herself and Micah behind her. The animals hit in a whirlwind.

The world was a swirling mass of squeaking, attacking little flying rodents. They nipped at Catra’s flesh and scratched at her. Micah ducked behind her, and she pushed through it. It felt like fighting a hurricane with teeth.

In a woosh, the bats were gone again, swooped back up into the sky, churning the air with their wings.

She looked up at where Adora was.

Adora's hands were no longer busy picking up seeds. The seeds were all gone, apparently eaten up by the swarm.

"Fuck," Catra muttered.

Adora leaned back, and her dilated eyes focused on Micah.

Glimmer ran up beside them. "Hold on! I've got this!" She threw her hands into the dirt and grunted with exertion.

Adora started to get up, but skeleton hands burst through the earth, grabbed her legs and arms, and dragged her back down.

Glimmer grunted in effort.

"No! Stop!" Micah yelled, turning toward his daughter.

Catra grabbed his shoulder. She pulled at him to keep him walking.

Micah fought back. His eyes on Glimmer. "That's a necromancer's spell!" The glow on his hands was fading. He was losing focus.

Glimmer yelled back, "I know!"

Adora screamed, summoning strength, and broke her arm out of a pair of skeleton hands.

Glimmer grunted again, summoning more bones to reach up and grab her, pulling Adora back to her knees. "Hurry up! I can't do this forever!"

Micah shook his head. "You don't understand. It's a *dead* necromancer's spell. Doing that alive, you could give yourself a heart attack!"

Catra stopped pulling him. Glimmer looked up at him in shock.

Nothing breaks concentration like the words "heart attack." Glimmer's magic stopped flowing, and the skeleton hands fell.

Adora pushed herself to stand, laughing as her fangs drew out.

In the courtyard beyond, the big alarm bell started to go off.

Bow, thinking quickly, without even being told, took aim and let an arrow fly at the rope holding the bell, knocking it off, and letting it clang to earth mute, saving the whole building from running out into the night and taking on something they weren't prepared for and accidentally fueling the beginnings of an apocalypse.

Catra gripped Micah's shoulder hard and dragged him forward again.

Adora's eyes narrowed at them. The smile on her face was cruel. She put out her hand to focus.

Catra cursed.

The man she was dragging behind her stopped moving. He fell forward, dragging her down by where she held him. She uttered, "No... Not now, no! You got a job to do, old man!"

It was no use. His eyes rolled up as he slumped to the earth.

Catra only let go of him as his hands lost their glow.

The sound of deafening silence nearly hurt Catra's ears. She looked up past Micah. Glimmer was out cold on her side. Bow had crumpled where he stood.

Melig yowled. Maybe it was too much to expect the cat to go all lioness right now. What was it going to do? Rip Adora to shreds? Neither of them wanted that.

Catra sighed. Ok, she guessed she was doing this alone.

Adora looked drunk or high. She was smiling, staggering. Her smile was lopsided.

Catra turned to face her lover, a vampire god, and the possible merging of the two of them. “Can you wake up our friends?” It was a shot in the dark.

Adora’s smile faded. “Bow shot me!” Her voice sounded different like she was talking on two registers. Like two people were talking at once. She shivered before adding, “And Glimmer used necromancy on me!” Her lips curled back. “And your dad was trying to kill me!”

“He was trying to help, and he’s not my da-”

Adora growled at that, cutting her off. “They’re fine! They’re sleeping. They’ll be safe while you and I give the Order that good old-fashioned thrashing they deserve.” Adora threw an arm out toward the building and pointed. “They will pay for what they did to you. Nothing can stop us now!”

Catra saw this for what it was. The thing inside Adora was trying to up the ante. Force her into a conflict. Require her to draw more energy, thus pulling the thing further into their world.

A chill went up Catra’s spine as she looked back at Glimmer. Glimmer had a plan before. She thought she could dispel Adora’s influence. Maybe she could do it. She just needed time to figure it out.

Melig hissed, raising its back and puffing out its tail as Adora started to turn toward the gate.

“Wait!” Catra called out without a plan, but the moment Adora stopped, she had one. It wasn’t elegant. It wasn’t smart, but it was what she had.

Catra gave Adora a smooth, confident, knowing smile. Her movements became fluid.

Adora's eyes focused on her, away from the building.

Catra let her voice drop into a deeper register. Husky. "Are you sure you don't want to do something else first?" She undid the top button of her shirt, pulling apart the fabric to put herself on display.

She had Adora's full attention now. Adora straightened up. Started to walk toward her. Her tongue licked over her lips, over the sealer that Catra had put on just a few hours ago.

As Adora approached, Catra undid the second button and quietly wished there were a camera outside so there would be recorded evidence of her saving the Order's asses with sex appeal.

Adora's look softened. She moved right in front of Catra, and with a cautious hand, she reached to Catra's jaw.

Catra tilted her head to accept the touch.

The moment her hand touched skin, Adora let out a sigh of what looked like relief. Her hand lingered. She focused on Catra's lips. Now desperate, she said, shaking, "I have passed your test?" Her thumb traced Catra's lower lip. Her eyes watched that movement with a hunger that made Catra's insides flutter. "Do you deem me worthy?"

Catra opened her eyes to look into Adora's.

Adora hesitated for a moment. "-for the next level." She started to breathe heavily. "I think I figured it out. What it could possibly be." She looked Catra deeply in the eye. "I was afraid of turning you before. I didn't want to curse you like I had been cursed."

Catra, despite herself, started to close her eyes and lean into Adora's hand.

Adora breathed in, gritting her teeth like she was holding herself back. “I’m afraid no longer. With this power, I fear nothing.”

Catra let out a breath.

Melig started whining next to her. Started rubbing against her leg, then scratching at it.

Adora hesitated, glancing down at the cat, then back at Catra before she uttered helplessly, “I want you with me forever. I want you by my side. I want you as my queen.” The other voice came forward more as she said, “My pet.”

Catra opened her eyes.

Adora let her fang nick her bottom lip. Blood pooled there, darker and redder than her lipstick. It dripped down her chin. She opened her eyes and locked them on Catra. Helpless, she whispered, “Come with me to eternity, my love.”

Catra’s eyes focused on the blood on her lover’s lip. It made her heart ache. With this... Adora could never leave her. With this, she would always know exactly what they were to each other. Glimmer had made her promise not to do this unless Adora offered and... here she was offering.

“Shit,” Catra muttered as her eyes started to close again, willing and ready for Adora’s bloody kiss.

***

Adora’s influence had been seamless before, but this time it hit Glimmer like a sledgehammer. Because she was looking for it, she could tell it was an illusion spell, but a complicated one. Nothing like what she had made with Keldor and Adam. That had been a single strand of thread stretched too tightly, all too easily cut. This, she could see it, feel it as it overtook them, was a thickly woven tapestry. It was beautiful and horrific. The strands were made of blood and the raw dark energy of fear.

The tapestry spread out and made different scenes, locking people in, and Glimmer caught it in time to avoid being entangled herself. She had her fingers dug into the weave. She gripped and pulled, but she couldn't tear it away.

In a moment, horror struck her. She was stuck there. She wasn't in the illusion, but she couldn't get out, which meant Catra was facing Adora alone. Catra was brave. Catra was loyal. But Catra didn't have much self-control, even at the best of times, and especially not around Adora.

She needed to find a way out, and soon. But she didn't know what to do. She didn't even know how to start. She felt helpless, like a little girl again, and her father came to mind. "Dad!" She yelled with her hands holding the fabric of this illusion. "Dad, I need you! I always did. I was a fool for thinking I could do this alone." She squeezed her eyes shut and gripped the weave. "I needed you when this all started. I wanted to know how it all worked, and when you refused..." She felt tears pricking at the corners of her eyes, then tried to regain herself. She focused. "I messed up. I thought I knew what I was doing, but I don't. Dad! If you can hear me, I need your help!"

A hand reached out of the fabric, grabbed hers, and pulled her in.

She fell forward onto cold hard stone. The only light was the light of a lantern. She looked up.

A boy- a young man looked back. He had her eyes, but his were wide with terror. His hair was up in a knot. But she knew him. She knew him because he looked much like she did at that age. "Dad?"

He put a finger to his mouth to shush her and pointed to the window.

She looked back to see it was open to the night and the rain, and a voice lingered and dragged over the window sill.

“Micah,” the thick dark smooth silk voice of Shadow Weaver called out. “I’m back. I have bad news. Please, let me in.”

That voice sent a cold chill down Glimmer’s spine. She looked back at the boy who was her father. “I know you’re scared, but that woman... I actually staked her after Halloween last year. She’s not really here. It’s a dream.”

“Are you sure?” He begged. His hands were shaking.

For all the times her father had comforted her when she was little, telling her he would take care of the monsters under her bed and checking all the shadows in her room. She owed him this. She got to be the adult comforting him for once. “I’m sure.” She reached out and pulled him into a hug. Her heart ached. He was trembling all over. “It’s ok. You’re safe with me.” She looked around. “It’s just an illusion. We can handle illusions, right, dad?”

He gripped her back tighter. “This is my nightmare,” he said in a small voice. “Every detail- is the horror that I’ve relived my whole life.”

She squeezed him. “It’s ok. We’ve got to get back and save the world.”

He pulled away from her. “I can help you get out of this... I don't think I can leave, though.”

Glimmer frowned. “But I need you to help me. I can’t cast out a vampire god on my own.”

He pulled back all the way. His features hardened, like he was remembering a part of his grown-up self. “Yes, you can. Come with me.” He held out his hand to her.

She took it.

He pulled her to her feet and dragged her deeper into the building, away from the window.

Glimmer stared in wonder at the building her father slept in as a kid. A large inner room lit by lamps and candlelight. It was all thick timber and all worn smooth by age.

He pulled her past a few shrines, all decorated with various trinkets and written out prayers.

Passed all that, tucked away in a corner, was a shrine that looked like no one had touched it in a thousand years. The wood was old and dry. It was a box, locked up and covered on all sides by papers with Korean Hangul written on them. Layers and layers of paper, with the old stuff dry and crumbling under the newer, freshly written text.

The young man took a breath in before saying, "It was my job to refresh the writing." He started to smile. "Those blessings and spells were burned into my memory, so they could appear here in perfect detail." He turned to her, his smile fading. "Can you memorize them just from this?"

Glimmer was already beaming. "I've been accidentally memorizing spells without even trying." She fell to her knees before the shrine and touched the papers. The writing started to glow in pink and purple shimmering light.

The young man started to smile again. "That's really cool."

"I know." She pulled her hand away, and both her hands were glowing with the same light.

He looked between her hands as he got serious again. "You have to hit the vampire really hard with that, or else the thing won't dislodge itself."

Glimmer nodded. "I can do that." She looked down at her hands. "But what do I do afterward? I was kind of relying on you to handle it when it got out."

He looked like he was concentrating. Trying to remember something from a past life. "The stories the old priests used to tell

was that their predecessors couldn't banish it. They had to bind it. To banish it, you need a powerful saint or a..." He stopped and started to smile. "An intervention from a good god, or the powers of light."

Glimmer didn't smile. "We don't have those things."

He frowned. "You're a good god, right?"

She frowned back. "Demigoddess and chaotic neutral at best." Then Glimmer remembered something. She got excited. "Wait! The cat!" Her brain was racing back in time to remember. "Adora had a sword that shot out light like the sun. It was a goddess trapped in the blade. That goddess... What did Keldor call it? The Eye of Ra?"

Young Micah's face turned to shock. "Bastet?"

"No, the Eye of Ra."

He shook his young head. " *The Eye of Ra* is a title. Bastet is the goddess that holds that title. She's... a lioness and sometimes a cat."

"Oh, then yeah, that's her."

He looked at her in shock. "You have an ancient Egyptian goddess that controls the destructive power of the sun as a house pet?"

Glimmer shrugged. "I mean... I guess. It's really Adora and Catra's cat. Not mine."

He pulled back and ran his hands down his face. "I tried a seeking spell to find Catra. It intervened. I nearly got my face ripped to shreds by Bastet!" He shook his head and locked eyes with her. "There's no way we somehow managed to get both a vampire god and the one goddess that could banish it in the same place accidentally. It has to be fate. Destiny!" He grabbed her shoulders, eagerness bubbling over on his features. "What does the illusion look like to you?"

“A woven tapestry.”

He started to smile a smile that looked all too much like hers when she got excited. “Then it will act like a tapestry for you. Pull one strand and watch it unravel! Do it fast, and the thing won’t have time to notice. Hit quick, and hit hard!”

Glimmer nodded while thinking of any other questions she needed.

Without warning, her father said, “Good luck,” and threw himself into her and knocked her out of his section of the tapestry and back into the weave.

She cursed under her breath but grabbed one strand and started pulling with everything she had.

***

Adora leaned in, her eyes half-lidded. Her breathing ragged.

Catra leaned back, letting Adora take her in her arms. Ready to give in and just accept the dark gift.

She really expected Glimmer to wake up then and ruin everything.

She hesitated. Really, any moment, Glimmer was going to wake up and fix things and...

Catra glanced back at her best friend.

Glimmer was still out cold, snoring and drooling from the left side of her mouth onto the dirt.

It would be so much easier for her if Glim woke up right now so she wouldn’t have to make a choice. Wouldn’t be given the time to make a bad one.

Adora’s hand traced Catra’s jaw.

Catra shivered and raised her head up to meet her.

Melig whined and leaned into Catra's leg, scratching her jeans, swatting at Catra's jacket, right at the pocket where Catra had stuffed the ring.

Catra closed her eyes.

What was marriage to a vampire but a blip on the radar? A brief moment in forever?

And yet... And yet...

Catra couldn't believe what she was about to do. "Ah fuck... Applesauce."

That word had a nearly magical effect on Adora. She stopped, froze, and opened her eyes. Proof that Adora was still in there somewhere. Proof that she still had some control.

Catra used the moment to grab Adora's leather jacket hard, rolling her hands into it. "Adora, I want this. I want this so fucking bad you have no idea."

Adora's look got focused. Her dilated pupils constricted a little. She leaned in.

Catra used the jacket to push Adora back. "But I can't do it."

Adora's brows pinched in the middle. She looked hurt. Rejected. She looked pathetic. That broke Catra's heart.

Catra pressed on. She couldn't believe what she was about to say. "I want to do this because it's fucked up, but I've been spending the last decade learning how to stop myself when I want fucked up things." She glanced back at Glimmer. Still asleep. *Fuck* !

Something crossed over Adora's face. The vampire god realized this wasn't going to be the thing that pushed Adora over the brink. Her eyes dilated again, and the thing started to turn her head back toward the building, back toward conflict.

But Catra had a grip on the leather. She pulled Adora and the thing back to face her. She started to smile.

It reared back, surprised. “What are you doing?” It said more in the other voice.

Catra smiled at her. “You’re not walking away from this conversation yet.”

It tried to pull toward the building.

Catra knew how to leverage her own body weight. It wasn’t much, but with the hold she had on Adora’s jacket, she could practically throw her around by messing with her center of gravity.

The thing tried to turn and was jerked back. Then, the look of dawning realization on Adora’s face.

Catra started to laugh and started to pull the thing in. “You thought you were the hunter and I was the prey, didn’t you? Thought you could lure Adora into all this with me? Well, turns out you miscalculated because I’m a Vampire Hunter, mother fucker.”

It growled at her. Grit Adora’s teeth and bared her fangs.

She pulled harder, widening her stance and digging into the dirt as she pull it in. “I’m a once-in-a-generation hunting marvel, and I know something that gives me an edge.”

It sneered at her and, with its own voice, declared, “You worthless brat! What hope do you have against me?”

Catra just smiled wider, wilder. “I bet you can’t hurt me, can you? If you do, Adora will kick you out.”

It roared, snarled, and grabbed her hands to try to pull them off, but Catra’s hands were curled in the leather so tight, it was impossible.

Catra laughed in its face. Hard and loud before jerking her grip and weight to throw it nearly off its feet.

The thing struggled to get its footing back and tried to pull back, pull away, but Catra knew how to hold on to someone bucking with leather. Catra started to laugh as she pulled down, acting like a living anchor.

The thing struggled to move toward the building. Tried to take off the jacket, but with the weight, Catra put on it and the latex being grippy- Catra knew a lot about latex and leather. They both gripped. It didn't take much from her to get the two fabrics to lock on.

Catra laughed harder as she heard something move behind her. Someone rustled in the leaves on the ground. The sound of someone coming awake suddenly.

She was laughing too hard for the thing to notice. It was struggling too hard with her, panicking, trying to come up with a new plan.

It didn't even see the beginning sparkles of Glimmer's teleport near it.

Glimmer appeared in full force, already in motion mid-air next to them, her hands glowing purple like Micah's had. She threw her arm out, clocking the thing across Adora's face.

Catra let go of her jacket as Adora was thrown off her feet and slammed into the cold earth onto her back. Adora gasped for breath like the fall had knocked all her air out.

Glimmer landed, heaving, eyes transfixed on something that flew out with that punch. A black wiggling thing.

It took Catra a moment to recognize it. "A snake?"

With a growl, Melig jumped forward with claws outstretched, grasped the snake with everything it had, and clamped its long

body in its jaws.

The forest lit up like it was daylight. Catra and Glimmer both shielded their eyes, but Catra peeked.

The cat was eating the snake, but out of the cat's mouth and eyes shot beams of pure destructive sunlight. The snake wiggled, and struggled, and disintegrated under that onslaught with a pathetic gasp.

When it was gone, the light faded. The cat plopped down and licked its lips before calmly beginning to clean its paws of blood.

Catra glanced up at her best friend.

Glimmer was heaving breath. She was exhausted. She looked like she had been through the rigger.

Catra smiled easily. "Took you long enough to get here. I nearly got turned."

Glimmer rolled her eyes and used her fingers to comb leaves out of her hair. "Oh, come on. Don't tease."

"I did. I nearly let her do it." Catra honestly didn't know if she was lying or not, but she decided it didn't matter.

All at once, Bow and Micah jerked awake on the dirt.

Adora groaned on the ground.

Catra fell to her knees and moved to be by her lover's side. She gathered Adora in her arms and held her there. "Relax. It's over."

Adora looked tired. Exhausted, but her eyes locked on Catra. Her eyes were the bluest blue Catra had ever seen. Her fangs retracted all the way for the first time since she touched the crystal. She looked... like herself again. But she was scared. "What did I do?"

Catra’s arms pulled Adora in. Held her there. “Nothing. You did nothing, baby. You did good.” She brought her hand to Adora’s face.

Adora grabbed her back and held her there as if Catra’s touch was the only tether she had to reality. “But the hunters...”

“They didn’t even know you were here.” Catra started to laugh. She could have kissed Adora right then and there, but instead, she wiped the blood from Adora’s lip with her thumb.

Forever could wait.

Chapter End Notes

*I got my mythology encyclopedia back! YAY

“Bastet: She was usually regarded as the daughter of the sun god Ra... Originally, a lioness goddess symbolizing both the warmth of the sun and the rage of the sun god’s eye, from about 1000 BC Bastet came to be represented as a cat, or a cat-headed woman... Usually a benevolent goddess, Bastet protected humanity from disease and evil spirits. Most importantly, she was a goddess of fertility, sex and love, and enjoyed music and dancing...” - The Ultimate Encyclopedia of Mythology by Arthur Cotterell & Rachel Storm

How hard could it be?

Chapter Summary

> Lyn says something she shouldn’t. Micah hears something he should. Adora gets some therapy.

The Hunter Headquarters sat quiet and peaceful, completely ignorant of the chaos outside, while the Best Friend Squad got themselves up and started getting back into Adora’s Mustang.

Adora tried to get up on her own.

Catra’s insides clenched every time Adora's knees gave out.

“I’m fine,” Adora kept saying as she tried to catch herself before she just gave in and let Catra and Bow help.

The sky had gone from churning whirlpools to nothing. The feeling of stillness permeated the forest. It felt like they were in the eye of a hurricane.

They got into the car, a tired group of exhausted hunters and a dad. Bow, Glimmer, and Micah crammed into the back seat. Catra insisted she was going to drive.

The cat jumped into Adora’s lap, purring and meowing, begging for attention.

Catra watched Adora’s face as she ignored the cat. That made a feeling happen deep in the depths of Catra’s brain. “Hey, Melig’s worried about you,” she said quietly.

Adora snapped out of it for a moment, acted like she saw the cat for the first time, and immediately grabbed it and started scratching it like it was the only comfort she ever had in her whole life.

Bow adjusted in the seat, trying to give Glimmer and Micah more space. “So what now?”

Catra gripped the wheel. “Adora was set up. Lyn did this to her.”

Adora muttered something Catra didn’t hear, but whatever she said, her quiet voice held a tremor.

Glimmer sat forward. “So, we go as a group and confront her! End the threat tonight!”

Bow’s brows pinched in the middle. “You don’t know that she’s guilty. It could have been an accident.”

Glimmer turned on him. “Oh, you think setting Adora up to be the avatar of an evil god is an accident? Who does that by accident?”

Bow’s brows furrowed, his mouth taking on a slight frown as he said in a mildly disapproving tone, “I don’t know, but you’ve done quite a few things by accident recently.”

Glimmer shut her mouth and sat back.

Catra looked away from the fight about to happen in the back seat and turned to look at Adora.

Adora was petting the cat still, but her eyes were focused somewhere between the glove compartment and the windshield. She was muttering to herself.

Catra couldn’t name the feeling she had in her stomach. “Are you ok?” She whispered it so that only Adora and the cat would hear.

“I’m fine,” Adora said automatically, but she didn’t look her way. She went right back to muttering to herself. She lifted a shaking hand and petted the cat’s head.

Catra focused back on the conversation in the back seat just as Micah said, “If you need a confession, I know a truth spell. I only need grit, a flat surface, and uninterrupted time.”

Bow and Glimmer responded with awe and approval, meaning they weren't fighting like Catra thought they would. That was good. It made things easier.

Catra focused back on Adora. "Are you sure you're ok?"

Adora didn't respond. She started tearing at the edge of the car door leather with the nails of one hand while scratching the cat with the other. It was a nervous tick she had developed as a hunter, tearing at the leather armor they were required to wear. But this wasn't the armor. This was the car. She was absentmindedly tearing up her beloved car. The car was decades old and had no other signs of Adora tearing at the leather.

Catra watched that fact while her brain processed what it could mean.

Bow, Glimmer, and Micah had all three fallen into the logistics of getting back to the cave and getting Lyn close enough to have the truth spell cast.

Catra leaned into Adora. "Babe?" She reached out a hand to touch Adora's knee to get her attention.

Adora flinched.

Catra pulled her hand back.

"I'm sorry," Adora said quickly and quietly. "It's not you... It's..." She opened her mouth to say something, then closed it and looked away.

Catra put her hand back on the wheel. The feeling in her stomach was weird. She looked up at the rearview mirror.

Glimmer had that shimmer in her eye that meant she was engaged. "I can teleport us in. We can get the jump on her!"

Bow jumped in, saying something about not wanting to throw all of them into unknown danger instantly.

Then Catra heard what Adora was muttering to herself.

Adora said quietly, “I thought she... he?... was you. It wasn’t you. She... she asked if I loved you... I said yes. Then she asked me if I loved you more than the Order and... I said yes.” She blinked. Her pupils constricted to pinpricks. “I was going to attack the whole order just to prove I loved you.”

Catra moved her hand back, hovering over Adora’s knee, before slowly touching her. This time, Adora didn’t flinch. Catra left her hand there.

Adora didn’t react to the touch but kept talking, repeating things. Muttering to herself.

Catra had seen this before. Sometimes kids in juvie saw something their brain couldn’t process, and they’d just focus on it. It was the brain going into a kind of shock. Processing and reprocessing the thing over and over, hoping the memory would come out different if they just thought about it enough. It never worked. If left that way, they’d do the same thing forever. They’d have nightmares with their brain trying to relive it, trying to fix it. They’d be in the middle of lunch and have a flashback that would take them back to that moment. Catra knew better than most the signs of PTSD in other people. “I’m going to ask you to do something, and you’re going to hate me for it.” She gave Adora’s knee a firm squeeze to get her attention.

Adora stopped talking and slowly looked up at her as if just realizing for the first time that Catra was there. The look on her face was one of absolute terror.

Catra talked slowly so the message would get through the cortisol and adrenaline still coursing through Adora’s brain. “I’m going to ask you to sit this one out.”

The talking died down in the back seat. They went silent.

Adora’s eyes misted. “What?” Her voice cracked.

Catra held Adora's knee a little tighter. "Before we do anything else, we're getting you somewhere safe. I'm going to leave Bow to be your bodyguard." She glanced up at him to see if he was okay with this.

He sat up and nodded firmly.

"No no no no." Adora shook her head. "I can do this. I've trained my whole life for this. I've just got a case of the shakes. That's all. It always happens after a really bad hunt."

Catra let out a slow breath to keep herself calm. "I'm going to call Razz. See if she'll let you stay at the ranch for a while. You'll like it. She has horses you can feed on and take care of."

"I am fine!" Adora's free hand wrapped into a fist. "I can do this. I was born to do this. It's what I am. I'm a Van Helsing! We don't sit these things out."

"I know." Catra turned to look at her. Adora's hair was a mess. It still had leaves and dirt on one side. A bruise was starting to show up where Glimmer had clocked her with her hard right hook. "And that's why I'm asking you to sit this out."

"I'm fine. I just had a bad night. I won't let you do this alone."

Catra tilted her head toward the back seat. "I won't be alone. I'll have my family with me; we're one hell of a group."

Both Glimmer and Micah sat up a little.

Adora closed her mouth, sitting back, still on edge.

Catra ran her thumb over the back of Adora's hand.

"You can't cut me out of this," Adora whispered as she pulled the cat into her face.

"You don't always need to be the one throwing yourself at danger, Adora." Catra leaned in. "Do you remember when we fought

Prime? You told me to stand down. Get behind Glimmer and Bow because I was hurt. Well, I'm doing the same thing to you. This isn't about ability. It's about safety."

The only sound in the car was Adora's soft sobs into the cat's fur.

The sobs only made Catra's thoughts solidify on this. "I'm going to call Razz. Let her know what you are. Tell her what happened. You'll take care of the horses, clean stables, and help that old woman bake pies you can't eat. You will do that, and she will help you through this."

Adora shook her head and tried to respond but couldn't.

Catra pressed on. "I'm doing this because everyone else in your life took safety away from you. They made you fight, hunt, or feed when you were traumatized, and Adora, I'm not going to do that. I won't be that person because that's what Shadow Weaver would have done. That's what your father would have done."

Adora's hand found Catra's and held on. She squeezed as she cried, the cat as her only shield.

Catra held on and pulled her phone out with her other hand. Just like every other time in her life, Razz answered immediately and brightly, as if she hadn't just woken up in the middle of the night. As if the woman never slept. It made Catra's heart swell to hear the old woman's voice. After the pleasantries, she asked, with Adora sobbing silently, holding her hand, "Hey, Razz- I have a favor to ask."

***

Adora was safe with Bow at Razz's. The old lady took her in with open arms.

The feeling in Catra's stomach went away as she felt, for all the world, like she was dropping Adora off at the safest place she could. A place that was Catra's safe place too. She'd even stay in Catra's old room.

Bow promised not to leave her side. Catra made Adora promise to take care of Melig. Adora had gripped the cat close to her chest, and the darn thing let her. It even smiled and purred as if being clutched there was the best place in the world.

Knowing that Adora was nestled safely between Razz, Bow, and the cat, Catra marched back to the car with Glimmer and Micah and turned her thoughts and the car toward the cave.

They had only a few hours till sunrise and had no idea what they were getting into.

The scenarios ran through her brain while she drove. The best-case scenario was that the clan leads were still there. Lyn was among them, and they were able to walk in and have a chat. Micah casts the spell then they get down to business.

A slightly less good scenario is they get there, and the clan leads would be there, but Lyn would be gone. But then again, they wouldn't need the truth spell if that happened. They'd know everything from the traitor turning tail and running. The hunt would start from that moment.

There was one more scenario. The worst possible scenario. They get there, Lyn and the clan leads are still there, and then it turns out the clan leads were in on the plot the whole time. When they least expect it, AMBUSH!

It wasn't until she was standing in the middle of the throne room with the Clan leads bundled together in the middle of the floor, bound and gagged, with Hordak moving and trying to talk, his eyes wide with alarm at her specifically, that she realized she had failed to account for the worst worst case scenario. A super ambush.

With a snap from somewhere deep in the room, the rest of the torches lit and illuminated the one thing Catra hadn't planned on. A hundred or so vampires came out of the shadows around them. They were surrounded. They were outnumbered.

“Fuck,” Catra said flatly as Micah approached her side.

“I’ll warn you not to talk like that in front of your new Horde Lord.” Lyn’s voice echoed through the room.

Catra lifted her head up to the throne up the stairs. The one that was, by all rights, Adora’s.

Lyn lounged on the stone throne, kicking her feet like a teenager. “Don’t you know? Pets are supposed to kneel before their masters.”

Catra’s hand went for the stake tucked into her jacket next to her phone.

With impressive reflexes for an old man, Micah grabbed her arm and pulled it back. “We kneel.” With that, he started to go to his knees.

Catra nearly pulled away. She nearly threw a fit, but he winked at her, so she went with it.

They kneeled.

Lyn cackled with delight. She kicked her feet one more time and swung them to sit up. “Well, well, well. At least we have someone who knows how to treat their new master.”

Catra almost got up to end this woman, but Micah’s hand held her. She turned to question him but stopped when she saw his other hand.

He had knelt with one hand on her and one hand on the ground next to his foot. From one angle, it looked like he was just touching the ground, but from her angle, she could see him scratching a circle into the grit.

Pride flooded her. He was still going with the plan, and now she just had to figure out how to use it.

Lyn tapped her nails on the stone, humming, before she let her voice reverberate around the cave. “Welcome to the new Horde. The Evil Horde.” She looked smug. “Evil Lyn’s Horde. If you can’t tell from the name, I'm in control now.” She waved a hand around the room. “These are my loyal supporters. These are all the ones that hated Adora’s plan only to feed *consensually* .” She said that last word with such disdain it looked like she was tasting something sour. “They are the only true vampires left. The only vampires who want to be what we truly are supposed to be. Killers. Predators. The dominant species. They are the true believers that came to my aid when they saw the signs that the vampire god was returning! Adora made it easy to seize power by asking all the clan leads to be here the same night she lost herself to it.”

Catra’s jaw clenched.

Lyn shifted, sitting forward and leaning on her knees. “Let me guess- I have some experience with this- Your master killed herself instead of letting the thing inside of her out, didn’t she?”

That pulled a memory out of the back of Catra’s brain. It made her look at the wall of the cave behind Lyn. The massive stone wall was flicked with the small flicker of thousands of spider eyes against the light of the torches.

Lyn sat back. “I thought so. Her type always does.”

Catra’s heartbeat kicked into high gear. All her neurons started firing, fueled by adrenaline.

Lyn laughed a deep and disquieting laugh before she focused on Catra again. “The real question is, did she manage to take out any of the hunters while she was at it?” A hesitant pause.

Catra said nothing.

Lyn shrugged. “I guess it doesn’t matter. I mean, I was hoping, with her connections and her deal with the hunters, that they would be ground zero for the apocalypse, but I’m sure Adora’s

overwhelming sense of duty prevented her from actually hurting anyone. What a shame.” Lyn gave out a long and dramatic sigh. “But the past is the past. Let's talk about the future.” Lyn’s face crossed with grim amusement. “How long does a human last without food? Without water? I know some caverns in this cave where I could drop you. The only person who will hear your cries would be that tool of a woman in the basement, and she’s never truly cared about anyone except her dear Mara.”

Catra glanced past her to the wall. The wall shimmered in recognition of the name as thousands of spiders moved.

Now she needed to do her part and get Lyn to get closer. Time to lie. “We came because we want to be turned.” Time to lie super hard. She threw in a grave tone. A tone full of exhaustion. “It’s all I’ve ever wanted.”

Lyn leveled her gaze on her, then stood up. She started walking down the stairs, making a show of every step. “Oh really?”

“We’re kneeling. We didn’t come in force. All we want is what we’re owed as pets.” Micah’s hand on her arm tightened, but he didn’t stop her.

Lyn started to smile as she got closer. “Did Adora refuse to do it even with all the power coursing through her? She could have turned you into quite the vampire with all that.”

Catra grit her teeth before getting out, “She’s gone. She doesn’t matter anymore. Like you said, she was weak, so... let's talk about the future.”

Lyn raised an eyebrow, still a smug smile on her face. She came close. “So all that lovey-dovey stuff was, what? An Act? To get turned?”

Catra lowered her head in mock shame. This was the lure.

Lyn stepped up close. She reached down to touch Catra’s chin and lifted her face.

This was the hook.

The woman hummed before she said, “If I turn you, you’ll crave blood. Human blood.” She paused, waiting for a response. She raised an eyebrow. Interested. “The first few nights are always the worst. I’ve seen whole villages taken out by a newly turned vampire unleashed.”

Catra stared back, resolute.

“Oh! You don’t care what happens to other people? You just want your sweet little immortality.” Lyn smiled widely. “You’re exactly the kind of person I want in my Evil Horde. How about this?” She leaned in, tilted her head to the side. Lyn licked her lips around her fangs. “Pledge yourself to me. Be my fledgling.” Her eyes dipped down, taking Catra in. “And I can show you the ropes.” Those words dripped off her tongue.

Catra opened her mouth slowly. She hesitated. She drew the moment out till-

‘Now!” Micah bellowed. In a rush of motion, he swept up the sigil into a glowing ball of magic and tossed it at the woman’s face along with some dirt.

The woman staggered back, spitting and trying to get the dirt out of her face. “You wretched thing! I’ll have you thrown off the deepest cavern in this place!”

The vampires around them started to surge in.

“Did you cause Mara’s death?” Catra asked it as fast as she could before they were tackled and taken out.

Lyn flinched, still reeling back. She opened her mouth, then struggled to close it. She fought against the impulse and then, with horror, realized she couldn't. “Yes.”

The vampires around them stopped moving. They looked at the woman who was supposed to be their leader. A line had been

crossed. They weren't sure how they felt about it.

The lights of spider eyes shimmered on the wall behind them and went still.

Catra couldn't suppress the wide wild smile on her face now. "How did you do it? How did you take down Mara?"

Lyn looked startled, but the magic was working, and she couldn't stop herself. "Mara was a waste of the vampire bloodline. She only wanted to use its power to protect others. She always said it was the true purpose of vampire magic. Her head was full of ideas that blood should be given *willingly* and only be taken unwillingly from those she deemed aggressors. She was weak." Again, she tried to hold herself back, but the spell won. "I found the spell to summon the vampire god and convinced Mara that it was something else. A tool she could use to do her little good deeds with."

The specks of firelight reflection started to move together on the wall behind Lyn. They gathered into a shimmering mass.

Micah looked up just as the ghostly white frozen mask of Light Hope appeared between the rocks. Small legs carried it to the center of the undulating mass of spiders. His eyes went wide. His mouth dropped.

Catra grabbed his hand, steading him for the final takedown.

Lyn clenched her fists and threw them to her side. Her eyes burned at Catra, and she stopped trying to hold herself back. "She used the power freely, and in the stupid way she would have, to save people. She saved whole villages from armies. She protected humans! She denied her vampire heritage. Oh, how I loved watching that evil take her over. I loved watching her struggle to try to contain it. It made her crave blood like a fledgling, and she very nearly ate the people who saw her as their protector."

The crowd of true believers collectively stepped back, eyes on the mass growing behind Lyn.

Catra moved forward with Micah in hand, pushing Lyn back. “So you tricked her? You lied to her. Why?”

“To take the clan from her,” Lyn replied easily. She moved around the clan leads toward the stairs, back first. “She could have saved herself. She could have embraced it and become Horde Lord, but it overwhelmed her, and instead of accepting the honor of being the avatar of the vampire god, she ran and sacrificed herself to contain it.” A look of pure disgust on her face. “And she got the humans to help her do it.”

Catra turned to her jacket pocket, where her phone had been on this whole time, with Glimmer on the other end of the line. “Glim, can you teleport a dozen people?”

Glimmer scoffed on speakerphone. “Maybe?”

Micah leaned in. “I can help you. Just aim for me first.”

Lyn looked between them. “What the hell is going on here?”

Catra pointed to the wall of spiders looming over Lyn. “ *That* is happening.”

Lyn slowly turned to look where Catra was pointing. Her body went stiff.

Catra grabbed Micah and dove for the bound clan leads while yelling, “Now!”

Lyn, face going pale, turned toward the mass of spiders and screamed as they engulfed her.

A flash of purple sparks and Glimmer was next to her dad. He grabbed her hand and whispered something before Glimmer reached out and touched Hordak on the shoulder as he leaned back into the others.

They blinked out of existence, then landed slowly, softly, onto the ground outside the cave.

The night was calm except for the screams of the Evil Horde echoing from inside and then going silent.

“I did it,” Glimmer said, hair as dark as her father’s from tip to root, as her knees gave out, and Micah caught her. “How did I do that?”

Micah beamed. “I can teach you how to do it yourself next time. It’s all about magic efficiency theory and-”

“I feel like I'm going to throw up,” Glimmer said as her complexion went gray.

“That does happen sometimes,” Micah said as his smile faded.

Catra’s heart swelled with love for her adoptive family. She wouldn’t have done this with anyone else. Leave it to Micah and Glimmer to dive head first into the vampire den and end a bitch.

Hordak mumbled against his gag and shook his hands toward her.

Catra started to rip the rope apart. “You ok?”

He nodded. Once his hands were free, he took the gag off, then started working on the rope on his feet while Catra turned to the next clan lead. But the next one was the big hairy one. Grizzlor. She hesitated.

Grizzlor’s shoulders fell. He held his tied-up hands out for her, pleading.

Hordak paused and offered, “I know he’s uncouth, but I suggest you give him a chance. He is, after all, bound with us and not currently one of the ones screaming in there.” He pointed toward the cave. “Lyn gave us all a choice, and he chose our fate.”

Catra sighed and undid Grizzlor’s hands.

Grizzlor ripped the gag off his mouth and breathed heavily while Hordak turned his attention to freeing the others.

Catra sat back on her knees.

Grizzlor looked at her, then down at the ground. He slumped. "I'm a vampire of my word. I promised that if the winter feeding problem could be fixed..." He hesitated. He shook his head. "Tonight, I was going to let the real Horde Lord know that she had the fielty of me and my clan."

The rest of the clan leads murmured in agreement against their gags.

Catra was awed by it, but she wouldn't let this pity party last forever. Catra leaned in and touched his shoulder. "That's decent of you. I'll tell her."

He looked up at her, full of shock. "She's alive?"

"A little roughed up, but yeah, alive and safe."

He blinked in shock. "But how?"

Catra nodded toward Micah and Glimmer. "I have a badass family. They always pull through in a pinch."

***

They always pull through in a pinch.

That thought bounced around Catra's head as she parked the car at Angella and Micah's house and opened the door. She had to get up for Micah to get out of Adora's two-door Mustang. It gave her a moment face to face with the man.

He climbed out and gave her an awkward smile. "Well, I guess this is the end of the adventure. I will have to drink a lot of coffee to get through the day tomorrow." He stopped, looked at the sky at the coming sun, and winced. "Today. I'll need a lot of coffee to get through today."

"I can get you something stronger than coffee if you need it."

He cringed. “Oh. No. I’m fine. Good old caffeine will do. I’ll take a nap at lunch.” He pulled back. “I want you to know that if you or Adora need anything, I’m here for both of you.”

“I’m going to ask her to marry me.”

His eyebrows went up. “Oh!” He blinked, then smiled. “Yeah, well, Angella said that might happen.”

Glimmer, bad as she was feeling, snickered from the passenger seat.

Catra kicked the car. “Yeah yeah yeah. I’m so fucking predictable. Soooo *emotional* .”

Micah shook his head. “That’s not a bad thing. And, just so you know, I think it’s too early, but-”

This time, she didn’t let him finish. “Glimmer already convinced me to wait. One year.”

Now a genuine smile on the old man’s face. “Oh, Good for her, and good for you! I’m proud.”

Catra winced.

His smile was gone. “What? What did I do?”

“There is a high chance that once I propose, Adora will...” She hesitated, and she so rarely hesitated.

“Will what?” He had leaned in. All ears on her. Giving her his full attention.

“She will probably be dumb about it and demand that she get your permission... as my...”

His eyebrows went up slightly.

“As my...” She was going to say it. She would finally utter the word she knew he had been waiting to hear for over a decade.

Looking at him, she couldn’t say it because she knew what he would do. He’d be dumb about it, but he deserved this. After everything he had done, after standing next to her and saving her girlfriend... She closed her eyes and just got it out. “As my father.” When she opened her eyes, he was beaming. That look caused a new burning sensation in her chest. Not anger, but pride. Pride that he felt so fucking tickled.

“Sure, sure, sure.” He said it too fast. A little rushed. “Absolutely. When it happens, we’ll set something up. A dinner after sunset, fully understanding she won’t be able to eat. And I’ll take her aside and give her the space to ask. Of course, I’ll approve. Just let me know. Whenever you need it.”

She hugged him.

It might have been the first hug she ever initiated with him. That was on her. Her damage made it hard to do this usually, but today it felt easy.

He startled at first but cautiously put his arms around her and hugged back. After a moment, he said, choked up, “I’m sorry for taking so long to listen to you. If I had gotten involved earlier-”

She shook her head, pressing into his chest. “You thought you were doing the right thing. Adora even... she respected you for worrying about me. She even said if she were in your shoes-”

He didn’t let her finish. He hugged her tighter. “The point is, we got there eventually.”

She squeezed him harder, half so she’d be sure he wouldn't see the tears forming in her eyes. “Yeah.”

She was thinking about that hug, and all it meant, on the drive back. She was thinking about what it meant to acknowledge Micah had taken the empty space in her life that was dad-shaped and all that entailed. She would have to get him something really

nice for Father's Day. Was she going to have to start calling Angella mother? Maybe she could call her stepmother. Her brain reeled with the possibilities.

She was pulled out of her thoughts by the small faint sound of Bow's voice on the phone.

"It took a bit for her to go to sleep, even with the magic that happens with the sun," Bow's said.

Catra came out of her thoughts and hit Glimmer in the thigh. "Speakerphone?"

Glimmer pulled the phone away from her ear and hit the speaker before she asked, "What was the deal? Is she ok?"

Bow hesitated. "She's fine. I mean, she's messed up, actually- like this is going to take a while for her to unpack, but... She and I were talking and..."

A long pause.

Catra felt the itch in her palms. "And what?"

Bow let out a long breath. "She and I were talking about the report. The one I'm supposed to send to the Order. What to include. What not to include, and the further we got- the more scared she got."

Catra gripped the steering wheel.

"Between us, we couldn't figure out how they would respond to the truth."

"We can lie," Glimmer said as she leaned forward.

Bow's voice got quiet but urgent. "I don't think we can. I'm not sure we should. We're supposed to make reports daily. If I turn in a report today saying nothing happened... Adora and I agree that lying implies that we think we did something wrong, and we don't

think we did. But if we hide it and Juliet finds out, we lose her as an ally." He paused, taking a deep breath like he was trying to calm down. "We need to maintain her trust and do what we said we would do when we were hired, even if it means the rest of the Order of the Gray Skull declares Adora public-enemy-number-one till Juliet can come back and get a hold of the situation. Adora agreed with me on that one."

"Of course, *she* would." Catra snapped. "It might cause a panic. The last thing I need is a few hundred vampire hunters trying to off my girlfriend."

"No one knows where she is now," Bow whispered. "She's safe as long as-" He stopped cold, hesitated, and finished, "As long as we don't reveal where she is. If I were a hunter, and I wanted to get at her, and I didn't know where she was, I'd follow you because everyone assumes you'd never-"

Catra grunted just to stop him from talking. Just to stop everything so she could think. Bow and Glimmer sat quietly, waiting for her, which was nice.

The road was open. The light of the sun was starting to illuminate the world. She had been driving to Razz's ranch, ready to get in bed with her lover, but... now she wasn't sure. She was so rarely not sure about things.

Glimmer turned to her.

She felt Glimmer's gaze on her. Judging her. Seeing if she was going to do what old Catra would do. Throw caution to the wind and go fuck her girlfriend now that the world was safe. She desperately wanted to do that.

Catra's shoulders fell. "How long till Juliet gets back?"

"A few weeks," Bow answered immediately.

Catra put the clutch down and eased on the brakes as they reached a stop sign. If she turned right, she'd head to Razz's. If

she turned left... they'd go back to the apartment. "So, you're asking me to leave her alone for a few weeks."

Bow sighed. "Not alone. I'll stay. No one knows where I am either, and she needs someone to protect her during the day."

Catra pulled the car to a stop and turned to look at Glimmer.

Glimmer tilted her head silently asking Catra what she was going to do.

They all sat on the line, quiet for a moment.

Catra stared back at Glimmer. "A few weeks without your boyfriend. Can you handle that?"

Glimmer lifted an eyebrow. "I can handle a few weeks apart if it means everyone's alive and safe. Can you?"

Catra closed her eyes and sat back against the seat. She took in a breath.

What she wanted was to scratch an itch. She wanted her reward for saving the world. She wanted the girl.

But she also wanted the girl to be safe.

And now, they were all finally safe. Adora was where she needed to be to get some therapy. Maybe... Maybe a few weeks of focused therapy would be good for her.

She let out the breath and said, matter of factly, "The two of us are probably going to be dealing with a lot of angry or curious hunters stopping by. They'll be watching us like hawks."

Glimmer leaned back into the seat. "Yeah."

Catra put her hands back on the wheel. "I guess we can spend the next few weeks drinking red wine and alternating between Rom coms and action flicks."

Even with her sunken eyes and ashen complexion, Glimmer started to smile. “Yeah.”

Catra took a long breath, sat back, and turned the wheel to the left. “Ok. We can do this. How hard could it be?”

Netflix and Chill

Chapter Summary

> We find out exactly what everyone has been dealing with during the break.

Chapter Notes

> This chapter contains some smut. If that's not your thing, I understand. Skip it if you feel like it, but please come back and read the aftermath in the last two pages. :D

Glimmer woke up reaching for the empty side of the bed. She caught herself, then pulled her hand back. It had just been a dream. She shook it off. She'd feel better after coffee.

She found Catra lying on the couch, staring at the TV which was on the public broadcasting station. Some average-looking guy was looking at the camera and talking about the Eiffel Tower.

Catra's eyes were bloodshot. She lay on her stomach, arm hanging off the couch, face turned to the side in the exact same position Glimmer had left her in when she had gone to bed.

Glimmer put her hands on her hips, channeling her mother. "Did you sleep at all?"

Catra grunted.

That wasn't an answer. "You could at least sleep in your bed."

Catra moved her face to press into the cushion. Mumbling into it she said, "It smells like *her* ."

Glimmer's stance relaxed a fraction and sat on the couch next to Catra, touching her back and her hair. It had the sticky texture of oil. "How long has it been since you showered?"

Catra grunted. “Can’t. Reminds me of *her* .”

Glimmer rolled her eyes. “Look, we’re running out of food. I don’t want to give them the chance to get either one of us alone, so we have to go together.”

Catra grunted again.

“I don’t mind if you wear sweatpants and ratty t-shirts, but you have to at least smell normal.”

Catra started a groan and let it go long and hard against the cushion before she stopped and said, “I don’t want to.”

“You have to. If you don’t get up, I’m going to teleport you into the bathroom. Turn the shower on myself, and I won’t wait for it to warm up.”

Catra let out a long breath. “Fine, but we’re getting mac and cheese. The stuff in the blue box that’s neon orange.”

Concessions had to be made. “Ok. Fine.” She stood up and moved aside.

Catra pushed herself up, languishing, acting like it was the hardest thing in the world. As she did, she let off the distinct smell of corn chips.

“Getting out will make you feel better.”

“Suck a dick.”

Glimmer glared.

Catra pushed herself up to sit and looked Glimmer in the eye. Her face softened. “I’m sorry. I don’t know why I said that.”

“You’re grumpy, and when you get grumpy you get mean, but apology accepted. Get a shower, get dressed, and I’ll make coffee. It’s going to have to suffice for breakfast. That's all we have.”

Catra held out her hand.

Glimmer, on instinct, grabbed it to help her up.

Catra got to standing and then collapsed onto Glimmer's shoulder.

Glimmer hugged her back. She wanted to say something comforting. *Don't worry, this is almost over* , except there was no way for her to know that was true. *I'm so proud of you for getting this far* , except it sounded cheap. But, she really was proud of her. Impulse control had never been Catra's strong point, but this whole month, she hadn't once suggested breaking the no-contact rule.

In the end, she decided what Catra needed was a hug and not platitudes.

Catra nuzzled her head into Glimmer's shoulder. After a moment, Catra mumbled, "The grocery store should be good. There's nothing there that will remind me of her. She doesn't eat food."

***

Catra was frozen at the meat counter an hour later, staring at a display of bloody steaks, her shoulders slumped in defeat. Her hair was wet. Newly washed. She smelled of the rose-scented body wash that was technically Glimmer's, but Catra used it freely whenever she wanted.

Glimmer came up to Catra's side, the cold from the refrigeration enveloping her, her nose full of the robust smell of freshly butchered meat. Earthy, slightly metallic, with the faint scent of blood and the faintest hint of salt. She should have known better than this.

The meat counter was a long half-tube of glass, gleaming under the bright fluorescent lights. Under that glass, there were rows upon rows of unnaturally bright red steaks.

Catra pointed weakly. “They remind me of her eyes when she’s all fangs out.”

“I know.”

“Also, the cow blood. That reminds me of her, too.”

Glimmer put an arm around Catra’s shoulders, leading her away from the steaks and toward the blue boxes of macaroni and cheese.

Down the aisle, something darted away just as they entered. Whenever they got out of the apartment, it was the same thing no matter where they went. There were probably half a dozen hunters in that grocery store, pretending to be shopping. Making notes and reports about their movements.

Glimmer never stopped noticing them, but she ceased to care. There had been a van parked in their parking lot every other day. If they left the house, they were tailed by a blue car, then a red one, then a black one. It was why they had spent most of the last few weeks in the apartment, eating through whatever they had in the kitchen. They were lucky though. Bow had stocked up their small pantry with two weeks of emergency food because of course, he did.

The only contact they had with their other halves was indirect. Micah would talk to Razz to get updates, and then he'd relay the information in a random way, and always in some kind of code.

Bow and Adora were fine. Adora was progressing in therapy, and Bow was brushing up on his baking skills helping an old woman make pies for all the kids that came to the ranch for therapy during the day. Adora had taken well to the horses after a disaster of a first week- but now they liked her and let her brush them in the early morning before the sun came up. It was, apparently, her favorite thing.

When Glimmer relayed the message, it was the thought that Adora was doing well that kept Catra going. Glimmer didn’t want

to lie to her, but maybe she didn’t mention how hard the therapy had been initially. Sure, Catra knew that would happen. She knew better than anyone what it felt like to have someone make you question your own thought processes.

But now, Glimmer didn’t have to hold as much back. Adora wasn’t having as many nightmares. She was... unpacking emotional baggage. Learning to be more aware of her body’s feedback instead of ignoring it.

But it wasn’t enough to know she was doing okay. Catra wanted to see her.

Glimmer wanted to see Bow.

It really wasn’t more complicated than that.

They got a week's worth of frozen and premade meals and a half dozen boxes of macaroni.

Catra had stuck her hands in her sweatpants pockets, and her flip flops (which she put on despite the cold outside) slapped the floor at every forced step as she followed Glimmer around the grocery store.

Glimmer paid with the debit card, which all their combined expenses came out of. The first of the month passed, and they had all still gotten their salary, so they weren’t fired... at least not yet, so they at least had money to cover all this.

Glimmer pushed the cart and led Catra back to the car in the parking lot when someone called out, “Hey!”

Catra’s flip-flops came to a harsh clap stop against the ground.

Catra and Glimmer turned around to see the woman Bow called Netossa standing there without her wife.

The woman didn’t flinch or shy away, even from the death stare that Catra gave her. Glimmer got a little excited that it was the most alive Catra had looked in at least a week.

Catra spat to the side, licked her teeth, and said, “What the fuck do *you* want?” Her voice came out raspy.

Netossa relaxed a little. “I have a letter for you.” The letter in question was readily produced out of her jacket. She held out, offering it to them. “It’s from Juliet.”

Catra’s eyes lingered down, a sense of weariness taking over, then back up as her countenance grew hard again. “You expect us to trust you?” Catra wasn’t jumping to fight but wasn’t backing down either. Her hands might have been in her pockets, but she was focused.

Glimmer moved forward to get between them just in case. “We know the Order has been following us. If you think this is going to lead you to Adora, you can just-”

Netossa interrupted her, calm, direct, “I don’t give a shit about where the vampire is. I don’t-" She hesitated. She looked away. Her shoulders fell. She spoke more softly. “I don’t blame her for what happened. Others do, but the report...” She suddenly looked into Catra’s eyes directly. “If I were her, I would have done the same thing. The stakes were too high for anything else.” She moved the letter in her fingers, considering it. “We’re all taught to do the stuff that ensures success. Anything we can do to make the odds in our favor, we do it. She and I... We’re dedicated to the cause. Maybe a little too much.” She held the letter out. “It put my family in danger. And you saved them, and I didn’t even know it.” Her voice became weak, on the verge of losing it. “We’re all lucky she had you two... Both of you.” Another pause. “I’m lucky she had you two.”

Catra’s shoulders slumped as her eyes fell on the letter, but she didn’t move forward.

Glimmer figured if this was a trap, she could teleport out of it. She moved forward to take the letter, then rushed back to Catra's side.

Netossa, still not looking at them, declared, "I don't know if you get the daily briefings. There's been a full ninety-nine percent drop in attacks." She snapped her fingers. "Just like that. Overnight. Right after your confrontation with Evil Lyn." She turned away, sticking her hands in her pockets. "I never thought I'd be here saying this, but thank you."

Catra didn't move as Netossa walked away briskly and without preamble or explanation.

Glimmer opened the letter. "Juliet is coming in tonight. She wants us to pick her up at the airport." She read the last of the letter. "She wants me to teleport to prove I can do it."

Catra turned to her, face scrunching up. "What?"

Glimmer reacted by grabbing her and teleporting.

Their TV dinners would be fine in the trunk of the car on a night like tonight.

When the sparkles faded, she and Catra were standing in the pickup area of the airport.

Juliet, bag in hand, stopped walking to avoid running into them. "Oh, good to see you both."

Glimmer and Catra stared at her, not sure what to do with that cheery tone.

Juliet smiled knowingly. "Can I get a teleport to my office?"

Glimmer, without thinking, grabbed her, and they were gone.

A little while later, Catra and Glimmer sat in Juliet's office, waiting for their boss to come back in.

The office was a testament to the enduring legacy of the hunt against the undead, which made sense, but now that Glimmer thought about it, Adora would probably be offended. Dark oak paneling adorned the walls, intricately carved telling tales of epic battles against supernatural foes. Tattered tapestries hung at uneven intervals depicting valiant vampire hunters wielding swords.

Juliet's desk was a massive ornately carved mahogany focal point of the room. The finish on the top was worn down smooth with years of use. It was covered with ancient texts, leather-bound journals, and faded maps of, what she realized with a start, were the catacombs.

Behind the desk was a cabinet displaying an assortment of weapons that were meticulously maintained. Silver bullets. Wooden stakes and an array of crossbows leaned against the shelves.

The place smelled of old oiled wood with the faint herbal undertones of the bundles of anti-vampiric plants that were stashed around the room.

"Adora would love this," Catra said out of nowhere. Then she slumped into the aged leather armchair. "Too bad she'd never be able to come in." Catra looked tired. Exhausted.

Glimmer felt a pang of sadness for her closest friend. They were, most likely, waiting to get fired. Glimmer would bounce back. She had a great resume. But Catra... This had been the longest job she had ever had.

As much as losing the job would be a frustration for Glimmer, for Catra, it was the loss of the only job that had ever actually fit her.

So the slump of Catra's shoulders and that look of world-weariness hurt Glimmer all the more.

Juliet opened the door, and Glimmer looked back.

A few hunters were in the hall staring with shock as Juliet ignored them and shut the door behind her with a heavy clunk.

Juliet had a slight smile accentuated by perfect black lipstick. "Sorry to keep you two waiting."

Catra didn't respond. She just looked at her toes in her flip-flops, wiggling them, waiting for the other shoe to drop.

Juliet walked around the desk, sat down, and leaned forward on her elbows. "I've read Bow's report probably a dozen times. I've verified the things it said independently. I had to be sure before I did anything."

Catra's eyes leveled on Juliet. Her hair still drying. Her shirt still stained. "Just get it over with."

"I'm going to give you both a test." Juliet leaned back in the chair.

Catra's eyes drifted back down to her toes. Her fingers laced together. She got that same casual, bored look whenever any authority figure tried to get her in trouble.

"What you've both done is enough to fire you. Breach of contract. Knowing that, do you have any regrets about what you did?"

Glimmer opened her mouth but shut it just as fast, suddenly not sure.

Catra filled in the silence. "No."

Glimmer sat back. "Yeah. I agree. No."

Juliet smiled. "That was the correct answer."

Catra looked up.

Juliet didn't stop smiling. "Once, when I was new to the Order, something really bad happened. I won't go into the details, but I

broke protocol. It was bad. When I got back, my supervisor asked me one question. If I had to do it all over again, would I? I didn't hesitate. I said that I would have absolutely done it again because, at the time, I thought it was the right thing to do." She shrugged. "He said, but it went badly, wouldn't you want to change what you did? And I said, given what I knew and what was at stake, I took what looked to be the lesser of two evils and that I would always take, what I considered to be in the moment, the lesser of two evils." A breath. "He gave me a promotion to Force Captain and told me, in no uncertain terms, that we are at heart an organization that tries to protect people. If the rules get in the way of that mission, then they're not useful."

Glimmer scooted to the edge of her seat. "What are you implying?"

Catra stared but didn't move.

Juliet shrugged. "At the end of the day, I return from a near-world-ending crisis to find another near-world-ending crisis completely averted. The only sign of collateral damage is my warning bell out front, and it will be a devil to replace, though I suspect I can contact your father to get the ward re-done." She tilted her head toward Glimmer. "You think he'd be up for that?"

"Probably," Glimmer said, not really sure if he would.

Juliet smiled warmly. "The point is, as much of this organization is decrying the fact that you broke protocol, when it comes down to it, the two of you, with some help, took down a vampire god and somehow managed to get rid of the internal threat that caused it along with a hundred or so of the worst vampires we had on record." Her smile got bigger. "And I need the two of you to secretly go cross country and decommission the catacombs. That means you both need higher-level clearance."

Glimmer sat back. "Oh, my god. You're going to promote us."

Catra sat up.

Juliet smiled wide. “Yes.”

“Holy shit,” Catra muttered.

Juliet pointed to Glimmer. “If you’ll take it, I’m promoting you to Force Captain. Bow will also be promoted.” She pointed to Catra. “But for you, I’m going to do something special.”

Catra’s brows furrowed.

“With the new winter feeding plan, I need someone to spearhead an effort to convert some of my hunters to vampire bodyguards. I want hunters stationed at these feeding events to prevent what happened the last time. That’s not an easy task, and I need someone who the vampires trust, who's a strong enough leader to keep the hunters in line.”

“I can do it,” Catra said without hesitation.

Juliet tilted her head the other way toward Catra. “Also, the last month has demonstrated that I have a control problem. I need a second in command to keep things orderly when I leave.” Juliet’s smile faded. “I had you on a conditional contract. The conditions have been met, so I’m moving you to a permanent contract. I’m also asking if, for a significant raise, you’d be my second in command.”

Glimmer could have squealed.

Catra didn’t react. She looked at the desk. Then at Juliet. “What about Adora? You haven’t said anything about her.”

“I’m not going to promote her for doing what she did. I’m not going to fire her, either. Some here are ready to stake me over that, but they didn’t know that I knew, vaguely, what she had done, and I let her do it.” Juliet shrugged. “That’s my choice as the head of this organization, and the council agrees with me.” She looked Catra directly in the eye. “You have a problem with that choice?”

Catra shook her head. “No.”

“Do you feel like you want to be my second in command and support me in similarly ill-advised choices?”

“Yes.” Catra blinked and sat up a little straighter. “Yes, ma’am.”

Juliet’s smile spread on her face like a sunny day. “Ok. Well, good. I already announced that you had agreed, so I’m glad you actually did. I really wanted to see the looks on their faces when they find out that the people they’ve been tormenting for weeks are their supervisors and can technically fire them.” Her smile turned smug. “It will make all the wrong kind of people leave, and all the right kind of people stay.”

***

Catra left that meeting reeling.

She insisted they teleport back to the grocery to get their food, and she jumped in to buy a single long-stem red rose.

Once they drove home, Catra opened her bedroom for the first time in a week and got dressed in something nice. Something different, like she was getting ready for a date. A black silk blouse that she could unbutton as low as she wanted. A pair of well-fitted, high-quality tailored trousers, charcoal gray. In the mirror, they made her hips and butt look stunning, and stunning was what she was going for.

Glimmer waited for her impatiently, walking back and forth in their living room.

Once Catra came out, Glimmer stopped and held out her hand. “You ready to go get our missing halves?”

Catra took her hand firmly. “You know it.”

Then, Glimmer hesitated.

“What?”

“Should I aim for Bow or Adora?”

“They should be in the same place.”

“Yeah, but... We’ll be surprising them.”

Of the two of them, they would both be surprised, but Bow was just a dude and wouldn’t have any vampiric powers to get out of hand. “Aim for Bow, but not right on top of him, please.”

Glimmer’s face got determined as she gave a nod of understanding. Closed her eyes and held Catra’s hand hard.

Catra felt a swell of pride for Glimmer. She had been teleporting all night and looked like she could keep going. The lessons with Micah were really paying off.

They landed outside, in the dark, on the ground, in the cold.

A quick glance around and Catra pinpointed where they were. Razz’s ranch. Good sign. Right outside the indoor riding arena.

Glimmer found Bow huddled against the barn door and smothered him in hugs and kisses before he could say anything.

Catra looked away, giving them their moment before she asked the important question. “Adora?”

Bow absorbed the affection from Glimmer but looked at Catra in the dark. “She’s in the stables, but...”

Catra fingered the long stem rose, rotating it in her grip. The newly promoted second in command of the Order came to the forefront of her brain. “What’s her status?”

Bow frowned. His shoulders fell. “Physically fine, but mentally, not great.”

Catra’s brain focused in. She opened the arena door and went in. She didn’t need to hear any more to know she needed to find her lover.

The lights were all on, turning the riding area into a weird approximation of daylight. The stables were a little ways off.

The place had the unmistakable musky slightly sweet odor of horses mixed with the earthy scent of hay and straw. It all took her back at least a decade to when she first showed up. When she first started learning how to interact with other people through horses. Learning the unspoken rules of social engagement by learning how to build trust with an animal large enough to destroy you.

She reached the door to the stables with its distinct smell of wood and leather and tack. She stopped and listened.

The horses gave out high-pitched whinnies and snorts of alarm. Hooves clattered against the ground with sharp, rapid beats, followed by the quick skittering sounds of something scurrying across the ground, rustling hay. Then, the distinct sound of Melig hissing and spitting. Growling and throwing claws. Through the chaos, she heard sobbing.

Gripping the rose, Catra pushed the door open.

Rats. Rats everywhere. Squeaking and chattering, scrambling and scattering as Melig dove like the vengeance of a goddess toward them.

In the corner, curled up and covering her face, was Adora.

Catra’s hands fell. Her heart broke to see the woman she loved like this. She walked toward her.

The rats moved out of her way. Melig started to run past her, stopped, saw her, meowed hopelessly, and then took up the hunt again.

“I thought therapy was supposed to fix me,” Adora said between sobs as she looked up.

Catra stopped in her tracks.

Adora was dressed in Razz’s leftovers. Old jeans. Beat up boots. An old button-down shirt worn down at the elbow and covered in dust. Her hair was half up, half down. The overall effect would have been adorable, but when she looked up, her face was covered in blood. It dripped out of her eyes freely.

Catra had studied under George and Lance harder than she had ever studied in school. She memorized everything because it had relevance to her life now. Bloody tears, or Haemolacria, happened more often with the very powerful undead. Often the old, but occasionally, the young made incredibly well. The theory was that great power caused a strain on the blood vessels in the tear ducts. The kind of strain that, for humans, meant something was severely broken. For vampires, it was a sign of things working as intended, but maybe a little harder than usual. Despite herself, Catra stared at that and could only think of Shadow Weaver. That old crone had said she designed Adora to be powerful, and there, bleeding from her tear ducts, was proof of it. Adora must have known it. Must have remembered it from her training. The moment it showed up, she must have been overwhelmed with the idea of being a thing created. The idea of being something designed by someone so horrible as Shadow Weaver... and not being able to stop it. That woman had used everything she had to turn Adora into the perfect vessel for power and nothing else.

Adora’s eyes softened when she saw Catra. She buried her head in her hands again, and between sobs, she said, “Therapy has just shown me all the ways I’m broken!” Her voice cracked. Her lungs gave out as she fell back into sobbing.

That was all Catra needed to understand. Her own body relaxed. She moved forward. She moved to stand next to Adora.

Adora raised her knees and hugged them like a child. “Razz tried to teach me how to relax. I tried to meditate, but every time I do, this happens!”

Catra let out a long, slow breath as she leaned against the wall and slid down it to sit beside her lover. The ring, and its box, were in her back pocket and hurt a little as she hit the floor, but she acted like nothing happened. “You summon rats every time?”

“Once, it was a wolf. The other night, the whole building was full of bats.”

Catra’s eyebrows raised. She leaned her head against the wall. “That’s... kind of cool.”

“It’s not cool!” Despite her protest, she shifted herself to lean on Catra’s shoulder. It was a moment before she could say, “That thing... it unlocked something in me that I can’t lock back up. This isn’t the worst of it. I keep accidentally putting the horses under my influence. I accidentally put Bow under like six times this last week.”

Catra smiled to herself. “Really? What did you make him do?”

Adora’s blood-stained and tear-stained face shot up. Horror. Indignation. “Nothing! It was accidental! I was trying to focus on my breathing. I let him go immediately.” Adora held Catra’s arm as if she were grasping for a port in a storm. Grasping for home.

Catra moved the rose toward Adora.

Adora paused. She took the rose and clasped it to her chest, crumpling in.

Catra felt a slow, steady warmth in her chest. Her hips. Her knees. She could help with this. She had been there once before herself. “Therapy does help, but it’s not immediate. There are stages.”

Adora made a guttural sound of disbelief but snuggled in.

“The first step is realizing what’s wrong. Recognizing the stuff you gotta work on.” Melig ran past them, chasing half a dozen rats. “Razz can only help with your thoughts. She can’t help with the new powers. You need a mentor. A real one. Not like Shadow Bitch.”

Adora started to look up. She wiped the blood from her eyes.

Catra met her look. Unflinching. “What about Hordak?”

Adora frowned. “He’s never developed anything other than vaporizing. Which I think I can do now, too. I accidentally phased through a door last night.”

Catra couldn’t help but smile. “So, you need someone older, more powerful?”

Adora tilted her head.

Catra had the answer. This was easy. “Light Hope. If anyone can teach you that stuff, it’s her.”

Adora wiped her face again on her other unbuttoned sleeve. “You think she’d do that?”

“Absolutely. Because of you, she got her revenge. She’s been asking me and Glimmer how you’re doing with spider webs. We haven’t figured out how to... You know... respond. The first week, Glimmer tried to move the webs into a reply and got it all over her fingers, then her hair.”

And out of nowhere, Adora laughed. It was the hard laugh of someone who had been too lost to crying. Someone who had not laughed in a long time.

Catra beamed, the plan falling into place. “We can go to the cave and talk to her. I’m sure she’ll be more than happy to help.”

Adora’s laughing slowly subsided, and she leaned on Catra’s shoulder.

Melig ran the other way, chasing a significantly smaller number of rats.

Adora relaxed. “I guess things worked out with Juliet?”

“I got a promotion.”

“Really?” Adora’s voice went up an octave.

“She thought I handled things really well. I’m her second in command. Bow and Glimmer are Force Captains.”

“That’s great.” A pause. “Did I get fired?”

“Not yet, but I’m thinking you need some stress leave. Maybe another month. Maybe a year.”

Adora went very still for a moment. “Really?”

Catra moved to put her arm around her girlfriend. “Yeah. I think it would be best if you weren’t doing anything in particular but working on whatever issues you’ve got to deal with. You agree?”

Adora nodded. She cuddled in.

The horses settled down.

Melig came back in, licking its lips. It plopped next to them, purring, fat and happy, a little cat smile on its face.

Catra reached out and scratched its belly. “You can help get Melig accustomed to all the gifts its cat grandfather has been buying. That dude is going to spoil this cat rotten. Top-of-the-line cat bed. Gold-plated drinking and food bowls. If he knew Melig was slumming it as a barn rat catcher, he'd probably have a panic attack.” She turned to see if Adora thought this was funny.

But Adora was lying in wait for her and kissed her the moment she turned.

Warmth flooded Catra's body. She felt like she was floating as their lips met. The soft touch made every inch of her feel electrified.

The kiss lingered. Adora poured herself into it. She pulled back a little, forcing Catra to move forward, desperate for more. Adora looked up at her, eyes half-lidded. Desperation, hope, and love emanating from her. "I missed you."

"I missed you, too," Catra said in a rush, wanting to kiss her more. It was the connection. The physical comfort of a simple kiss that pulled at her whole body. Her whole self. Her arms wrapped around her lover. She leaned her head on her. "This last month was hard. Harder than I will ever admit to you or anyone."

Adora smiled a little. "You mean you like me?"

Catra smiled back. She knew where this was going, and her heart felt light to see it.

Adora started to smile big. "How embarrassing for you?"

Catra laughed, grabbed her, and the two fell laughing, wrestling playfully onto the straw-covered floor.

Things were going to be ok. They just needed to stay together. Catra decided, at that moment, that come hell or high water, they wouldn't be separated again.

***

Bow and Glimmer got dressed up when they returned to the apartment. It was cute. Catra didn't even know Bow had a suit in his closet, one with an appropriate high middle that allowed his abs to breathe.

Glimmer got dressed in something frilly and utterly sparkling.

"Are you sure it's ok that we go out?" Glimmer asked quietly as Catra was practically pushing them out the door.

“Yes. It’s fine. Adora and I need time to chill.”

Bow, cleaned up from the farm, glowing from his normal skincare products and moisturizer, smiled softly at her and gave her a quiet, “Thank you, Catra. We really needed this.”

He was assuming a lot. Like the two of them, Adora and Catra, staying home was some kind of sacrifice. Catra’s heart had been aching for something domestic and simple since the beginning of all this, and she would finally have it. It didn’t matter what happened. She and Adora could do nothing but cuddle on the couch for hours, and that would be good. It would be great. It would be amazing even. But she gave Bow a smile that pretended like this was such a hardship. “No problem. Now go have fun,” as she pushed them out the door.

Once she closed it, she heard them giggling at each other like schoolchildren let loose for the summer. Both of them had done the majority of the emotional heavy lifting for Adora and her this last month, and fuck it, they deserved a break. A night out.

Glimmer indicated they wouldn't be back till after sunrise, with a wink, when this whole thing started, and that gave Catra hope that they would have the time for Adora to relax or something...

She locked the door and turned to see her little family. Adora, her cat. The rose on the coffee table in front of them.

Catra slid onto the couch beside Adora, grabbed the remote, and threw out a few ideas. “You feel like watching the next movie on Bow’s list for you, or do you feel like something uncomplicated like a home improvement show?”

Just the question made Adora relax visibly. Catra had carefully washed the bloody tears off her face when they first arrived, and she was already looking visibly less distressed.

Adora threw out, “Maybe Netflix?”

Catra couldn’t help but smile, but she hit the Netflix button on the remote of their new TV. “That’s a streaming service. Not a choice.”

Adora sat up a little on the couch, leaning into Catra. She frowned a little. Shook her head. “How about a baking show? Razz made a lot of pies while I was there. It was relaxing. I helped her gather cactus apples one night for a cactus apple pie. That was less relaxing.”

Catra laughed, suddenly and openly, at the visual of Adora picking fruit off a cactus in the middle of the cold night. They were well past the date they were in season, and Razz was probably just stretching to find some activity to pull Adora in to get her to talk.

Adora wanted to watch baking, so they’d watch baking.

She picked the Great British Bake Off and put the remote down.

Adora relaxed into Catra’s side as the show started with its calming music and bright, sunny visuals.

Catra put her arm around Adora's shoulders and couldn’t stop smiling.

Ten minutes in, the show was getting neglected as Adora’s lips found Catra’s again.

It started as a test. Just a light kiss. A suck on the bottom lip. Then, hands were touching jaws and hips.

Communication happened in many ways, but they both fell easily into the simple communication of bodies.

Catra paused for a moment to poke at Melig on the couch and mutter “Scram,” under her breath.

The ancient goddess pretending to be a household cat got up, grumbled, but went to the bedroom where Micah’s cat bed gift was.

When Catra came back, Adora was reaching out for a connection, the kind of connection that Bow and Glimmer couldn't give to either of them. That all-encompassing physical sensation of knowing that you wanted someone and that they wanted you back in that hungry, devastating way that only lovers can have.

It happened so fast. Adora started to lay down. Catra was on top of her. Their kissing accelerated from soft, tender kisses to something desperate. Catra planted her hands on Adora's hips and let her lips slide down Adora's neck.

Adora's eyes rolled up. She threw back her head and moaned while her fingers ran through Catra's hair.

Catra knew immediately what she wanted. This time apart had only made the desire stronger. She wanted to give. She wanted to prove herself to her lover by being selfless. She wanted to serve.

While Adora gasped, Catra unbuttoned the old jeans and slipped them off Adora's waist.

Catra's inside prickled with the visual. Everything in her rumbled to life. Feelings that had laid dormant while she wallowed in self-pity on the couch burst forth. She kissed Adora's stomach. She licked her skin. Her hands grabbed for her thighs, her butt. She grabbed for everything.

Adora was lost in bliss to it. Gasping and desperate.

She was already so wet that her jeans were musty, and she never wore underwear.

The sight was enough to make Catra's loins hurt. "Oh, you're gorgeous," she uttered before pulling Adora's pants off her knees, easily slipping them past the rest of the leg.

Adora's breath caught. She was flushed from stomach to forehead. Her pale skin showed off how absolutely turned on she was. How utterly lost she was.

“You’re beautiful, princess.” Catra’s hands ran up Adora’s legs. Owning. Desiring. Grabbing for what she wanted.

“Catra...” eked out of Adora’s mouth, a helpless appeal.

Catra moved like water between Adora’s knees, pushing her legs aside and opening her. The center of her pink glistening self was laid bare.

“I love you,” Catra breathed as she leaned in, then let her tongue and her lips do their own talking.

Adora clenched up, grabbing Catra’s head, almost to stop her, but not quite. A sign to slow down, so Catra did. She pulled back, massaging the sensitive skin around her inner thigh. Working in and working up to the center.

Soon, Adora’s head had lulled back. Her panting had become fast but paced. She wasn’t tense anymore.

As Catra’s tongue glided over her, Adora turned into a puddle of jelly on the couch. Languid and relaxed, lost in the feeling of it.

They lost track of time. The show had moved on to the next stage of the competition, and neither of them was paying any attention. Adora’s breathing became ragged. Catra’s movement became more focused. More disciplined. It surprised them both when Adora gasped, grunted, and grabbed the back of Catra’s head, and her whole body shivered.

Catra soaked it in and kept going.

The shock of it hit Adora’s body like lightning. Everything tensed up again. Her eyes shot open, and she looked at Catra in what could have been horror.

Catra answered that quiet panic with action. She closed her eyes slowly, meaningfully, and just kept going.

Adora fell back, grunting again.

Catra savored the sounds Adora made. The small signs of exhaustion. The complete act of giving herself over. Her own body felt warm and alive. That midpoint between excitement and release. She could live in this feeling forever.

As Adora crested a second time, released a gasp of desperate, helpless appeal, and fell back, Catra felt a rush of dopamine, which gave her the urge to keep going.

Adora came again well into the next episode, well past when either of them had any idea who was winning and who was the underdog. Catra finally detached, crawled up, and desperately kissed Adora on the mouth, letting the rest of their bodies connect, and entwine.

Adora melted into it. She was so tired she could barely lift a hand to touch Catra's back.

Catra laid down on the couch next to her, half on her, half hanging off the edge, and she didn't care. They both breathed heavily. They were both spent in their own way.

After a moment, Adora swallowed. Her mouth was dry.

Catra acted automatically. She moved her hair away from her neck and held her head back. An open invitation to satiate yet another of her lover's thirsts.

Adora's eyes focused on her. She got very still. She seemed to force herself to look into Catra's eyes. "I want to."

"Take it."

"I don't really want to hurt you right now."

"You don't have to." When Catra opened her eyes, Adora's fangs had slid out. Her eyes had gone red with animal hunger.

Adora moved a little to change their positioning. She was breathing slowly, deeply. Her eyes focused on Catra's neck. "She

always warned me about obsession."

Catra didn't need her to explain who "she" was. She knew who in Adora's life would have given such a warning.

Adora closed her eyes. She licked her lips as if they were dry and needed wetting. When she opened her eyes again, they were still red but clear, and she stared at Catra. "I always thought she was exaggerating, but-" Her eyes closed. She went in, mouth first, lips first, to kiss Catra's neck.

Catra closed her eyes at the feeling of it.

Adora pulled back slightly. Her voice was gruff. Desperate again, but in the way of holding herself back. "-You're all I can think about. You're the only person I want to taste."

Catra gasped at the sudden pain of the teeth sinking into her. That pain and pressure of the bite faded as a wave of pleasure flowed. She moaned. She relaxed. She let her lover take whatever she wanted.

Adora detached with the wet sound of saliva and blood. She was breathing heavily as if she hadn't gotten enough oxygen while feeding. "Are you ok?" Her voice was unsure. A little desperate.

"I'm fine," Catra slurred, blissed out. Drunk off the chemical explosion happening inside her still. It had been too long. She was a lightweight again. Desperate for even the smallest bite.

Blood dripped from the sides of Adora's mouth. Her look took on a general countenance of concern as she pulled back. "I'll get you disinfectant and bandages, ok?"

Catra only managed a positive-sounding groan as she laid back on the couch and savored the last waves of pleasure.

Adora got up, took one step, and flinched and hissed. She grabbed her foot and hopped around.

Catra pulled herself out of the bliss for a moment. Forced herself to focus on her girlfriend. “Are you ok?”

Adora breathed in and out quickly, hopping on one leg before gently putting it down. “Yeah. I just stepped on something.” She bent down.

“What is it?” Catra was still reeling from the residuals of the bite. She wasn’t thinking about what could have been on the floor. What could have fallen out of her back pocket.

A moment of silence before Adora said, “A box.”

A box. The thought wormed through Catra’s hazy brain before it hit her cerebral cortex. Catra’s eyes shot open. “Adora, no!”

Too late. The box was already open in Adora’s hands.

Adora’s body went stiff. Her eyes were wide. Her mouth opened in awe.

The ring glittered with what little light was coming from the TV.

Catra didn’t blink. She started to sit up. “Adora...”

Adora shut her mouth. She was breathing deeply. Hard.

Catra sat up. Sat forward. “You weren’t supposed to see that yet. I promised Glimmer and Micah I would wait at least a year.”

The breathing slowed. Adora closed the box. She stared at nothing as a smug smile slowly slid across her face. “Sure.” A deep breath. A slow breath. She turned around to look at Catra. “I didn’t see it.” She put it down on the coffee table. The smile on her face was big. Unwieldy.

It was an infectious smile. Catra couldn’t help but beam back.

Adora stumbled back a little, caught herself, and pretended like it was on purpose instead of fumbling over her own feet. “I'll get

that bandage. I didn’t see anything.” She waved her hands for exaggeration, but she was still smiling like a fool as she headed to the bathroom, pantsless.

Catra couldn’t help laughing. Couldn’t stop the feeling of overwhelming joy bubbling up from within her.

Adora reached the bathroom, blood still on her face, fangs still out, and she turned back and, with that stupid smile, asked, “Really? Me? Are you sure? I’m a vampire. A monster...” The last word was said with a slight inflection, implying it was partially a joke, and partially not.

“Yes, you idiot, I don’t care,” Catra said between laughing. She grabbed the throw pillow and threw it hard at her lover, who dodged it and disappeared into the bathroom.

A moment later, with the sounds of their first aid kit being broken into and ravaged, Adora was humming the wedding march.

Catra laid back, defeated, thwarted, and utterly and completely happy.

Chaotic Neutral

Chapter Summary

> Catra and Adora are getting married, and Glimmer is doing her best to support her friends, even if it means breaking a few state and natural laws.

"What do you mean you don't know what you're going to wear?" Bow's voice cracked.

"Oh... I was thinking I'd wear this." Adora gestured down at herself, indicating she would wear her everyday sports compression top, moisture-wicking pants, and boots. Unsure if she also meant she would wear her leather jacket, which was hanging up in the hallway closet.

They had all gathered in the living room, having breakfast, drinking coffee, on this night before the big day. Catra pushed eggs around on her plate, and ignored the bacon, and sat back on the couch. Adora sat back, Melig on one side of her, the cat laid out to make as much physical contact with her warm leg as possible, a low rumble purr.

The apartment had been weird the last few weeks. Not the actual apartment itself. No, that was super cozy. Bow had gone overboard with the fall and Halloween decorations. Fake spider webs. Pumpkins everywhere. Little bats with fangs posted around the house in various places you weren't expecting. Adora would never tell Bow directly, but she low-key thought the cartoon bats with fangs were offensive. Catra thought it was funny.

No, it wasn't the apartment itself. It was the vibe in the apartment. It was hard for Glimmer to put a finger on it, but if she had to guess, it was Adora. Not the usual oddness that would have marked Adora's nervousness before a wedding. Everyone expected her to be planning everything down to the very last detail. Having lists. Having a set schedule. No, the weirdness was

that none of that happened. It was hard to get her to think about the wedding at all.

Bow rubbed his face before saying in the nicest tone he could, "You can't just wear your normal clothes. Catra will be dressed up. Glimmer and I will be dressed up. Everyone will be dressed up."

Catra draped her legs over Adora's. Their fingers entwined. This was what kept happening instead of wedding planning. The two of them blissing out about each other. These little physical displays of connectedness and affection were only getting worse the closer they got to the event.

Catra's mouth slid into a wide smile. "You'd be hot in a dress. Something with a low back."

It looked like that statement hit Adora with everything Catra had, and for a moment, Adora was out of breath and blushing. Eventually, she said, "Ok. Sounds good."

Glimmer caught herself from spitting out her coffee.

Bow stared at her. Furrowed his brow. In a voice very gentle, "Adora, you don't have a dress. We would have to go get that-" He glanced at his watch more for dramatic effect than to actually check the time, "-tonight. We'd have to do that instead of all the fun stuff I planned. Are you sure?"

Adora wasn't looking at him. Her eyes fixed on Catra. Her thumb rubbed the top of Catra's knuckles as if she was about to slip the ring on right now. "Yes, I'm sure. If it's what Catra wants, then it's what I want."

Bow blinked, sat back, and inclined his head toward Glimmer. "I guess while you and Catra are having a bachelorette party- we'll be buying a wedding dress."

Bow planned a fun night for Adora's last night as a single woman. Fun for Adora, anyway. Working out at a 24-hour gym, an activity he and Adora started doing after she came back from Razz's that

first time. She liked working out. It helped her calm down. Then, they were going to play miniature golf. They all knew how much Adora liked games. But no, all that was out of the window now.

Glimmer and Bow sighed collectively, watching their friends get lost in each other.

They left their friends in the living room to get ready. They headed to the back room in mutual confusion.

"It's ok. I think they're enamored by the fact that they're getting married. It's good. It's healthy," Glimmer said when they got back in their bedroom, door shut, getting ready for their various adventures.

Bow gave her a nod. "Yeah. I agree. It's temporary. It will all be over tomorrow night."

He didn't notice when Glimmer grabbed her black combat boots and a pair of black yoga pants. "I know. It's just... I miss my best friend."

Bow frowned at her and missed the fact that she slipped on a black blouse with poofy shoulders as well. Maybe he didn't think her dressing in all black was odd for a girl's night out with Catra. He could have assumed they were going to a goth bar or a rock concert. Both would have been good options.

"These last few months, Catra has barely noticed me at all. When I started dating you, she freaked out thinking I would abandon her. Well, now, she's the one neglecting me, and honestly, I thought I would be okay with it but... but..." Tears started to well up in her eyes. "But this whole thing goes both ways. I miss her and she's still living here."

Bow engulfed her in one of his medicinal hugs. "It's ok. It's ok to miss your best friend." He pulled away and tilted his head toward her. "Once the wedding passes, the two of them will realize nothing has changed, and everything will return to normal."

Half an hour later, in the car, Catra said, “Things won’t exactly return to normal. Adora wants us both to live in the cave for a while.”

Glimmer’s black fingerless gloved hands gripped the steering wheel. Anger rose in her stomach. Indignation at the sudden breaking of an unspoken contract. “What?”

“Don’t worry. We’ll visit often.”

“As in, the two of you are going to dump your rent on us?”

“No. We’ll still pay the rent. We plan on coming back, but it’s... it’s complicated.”

It wasn’t complicated. After all the bullshit that Catra pulled, being clingy and jealous of Bow, it was hypocritical for her to up and leave so easily. “How come neither of you mentioned this before?”

Catra didn’t seem to pick up on the tone. And if she did, it didn’t bother her. “It must have slipped my mind with all the wedding stuff.”

“Wedding stuff?” Glimmer asked with her tone now getting out of hand. “What wedding stuff? I’ve been making all the decisions for the two of you.” She added an extra bite to the next words. “By the way, your colors are scarlet and black. Adora’s are white and gold. The cake is almond with a raspberry cream filling because I thought it would be more like blood to sell the whole theme. I sent out the invitations and hand fucking wrote them myself while you and Adora were off saying sweet nothings in each other's ears.”

Catra waited a moment before saying calmly, “Thank you. I appreciate that. If you hadn’t done it, it wouldn’t have gotten done, and Adora and I would be saying our vows to an empty room.”

Glimmer took a breath and took a left turn, taking them down one of the long dark roads. “I’m sorry I got angry. I’m not as resentful as I sound right now. I’m just... shocked.” She waited a beat before saying, “I feel like I’m losing you.”

Catra turned toward the window and let out a long slow breath. “Hm,” was all she said.

Glimmer’s heart broke a little. Was she not even going to address it? She parked the car on the side of the road outside the oldest cemetery in their small little city. High stone walls surrounded it, and it had a spindly wrought iron gate that looked too thin to hold up.

Glimmer opened her door, and they both got out.

Catra moved around the car, straight at her.

Glimmer froze up against the car as Catra grabbed her face and leaned in. “Nothing changes between us, Glim. You look after me, and I look after you, got that?”

She nodded. Tears pricked at her eyes.

Catra’s look softened. “Adora is being selfish for once. It’s been hard to get her to be selfish about anything. She always puts everyone else's needs first, and finally, she asked me for something that she wants so I want to give it to her.”

Glimmer forced herself to breathe in deep. She forced herself to relax. “Ok.”

Catra didn’t back off. She stared at her with those intense mismatched eyes. “We’re still going to the Netherlands, all together, as a group. You and I are still going to clear those European catacombs, and that’s going to take some time. A month or so. We still have time together. It’s just that when we get back, Adora thinks it’s best for her and I to have some time alone to fuck.”

Glimmer's shoulders fell. The tender moment between best friends tainted by Catra's complete lack of anxiety. "Oh my god. Is this about you two boning like rabbits?"

Catra nodded one short nod and backed off, letting go of her face.

Glimmer peeled herself off the car. "Is she still hung up about what we can hear through the walls?"

"Of course she is. She's from the early eighteen hundreds. If she could, she'd fuck in a padded room with the lights off with a blindfold and fully clothed."

"Stop! Stop." Glimmer was smiling now.

Catra was smiling, too, feeding off her. "Let her get it out of her system, and we'll come back and be normal roommates, and maybe she won't care anymore."

"We can't hear anything unless that bed hits the wall," Glimmer said as she turned to the back of the car and popped the trunk lid.

"I've told her that, but she doesn't believe me." Catra came up next to her and accepted the shovel and a flashlight without question.

Glimmer got her own shovel and flashlight and a black kitchen trash bag. She slammed the lid down and turned toward the cemetery. "Are we still going to have movie night?"

"Absolutely."

Glimmer grabbed Catra's shoulder and, in a blink, teleported them both onto the other side of the wall. Catra went with it in stride.

The cemetery wasn't that scary during the day. It was pretty open, with some large gnarled ancient oaks. But at night, with the moon in the position it was, and no one around, it felt like they had stepped right into a gothic novel. The wind blew just enough to make the wrought-iron gate creak in the worst possible way. An

uneasiness grew in Glimmer's stomach. She took a bracing breath and started walking. “You’re still coming to Sunday brunch with mom?”

Catra followed her but gave a strange hesitation on answering that question. “Maybe.”

Glimmer made a noise in her throat, meant to say she didn’t like that answer. “Girls night out? Just the two of us. Every month like always?”

“Absolutely.”

Glimmer felt warmer. She hadn’t acknowledged the anxiety she felt about the prospect of losing Catra. But, the separation was temporary. They’d still be in contact, but maybe Adora would be more relaxed about getting her physical needs met, which was good. It also meant that Catra and Adora would be breaking public decency laws less, which was good for the whole town.

She gained a spring back in her step while she led the way through the winding path.

The grave they were looking for was on the far end of the cemetery. A plot that was dug thirty years before the cemetery was founded. She stopped at the small, simple stone. The name was illegible from weathering. Two hundred years of water damage, freezing damage, and children with crayons and paper.

Catra stopped, flipping her shovel to the earth and resting her food on the shovel’s shoulder. “Are you one hundred percent sure this is the one?”

“I did a seeking spell last month. I had to lie to Dad about what it was for, but he helped me set it up. He never gets his spells wrong.”

Catra picked at her teeth with her tongue, then looked down at the grave. She shook her head. “I wish we had known earlier. Would have helped Adora get through her grieving process.”

Glimmer turned off the flashlight. “Hopefully, she’ll get to talk to him instead.” She flipped her shovel over, sticking the spade tip to the ground.

In silence, they both started digging.

They hit the box faster than they expected, the sound of the shovel hitting wood echoing through the cemetery with a hollow thud that reverberated off the stone walls. The wood crumbled easily under the shovel’s weight. The air carried the musty scent of long past decay, a mixture of aged wood and the faint lingering earthiness of decomposed matter.

Catra turned on the flashlight. As they peered into the cavity, the light filtered through the cracks in the box to reveal a scene frozen in time. Nestled amongst the dusty remnants lay a skull and bones sitting among the rotted-through age-appropriate clothes of a vampire hunter, still with the leather armor on. The skull still bore a full head of hair, its strands as dusty as everything else in the confined space, but the color was still vibrant blond.

A shiver went through Glimmer’s whole body, and she stepped back.

Catra leaned in closer, bringing the flashlight in. “Looks like him.” With her face smeared in dirt, she turned to Glimmer. “So why do we need the bones anyway?”

Glimmer put the shovel down next to the grave and started to take off her gloves. They had done their job to make sure she didn’t get any blisters with the shoveling. “I thought back to what happened with Skele-dude. I asked myself, why was he a skeleton and Shadow Weaver and Adam weren’t. Well, it’s because they were full illusions. They didn’t have real bodies. But Keldor did. Why would he make sure he had a body and not make himself an illusion?” She shrugged. “There’s got to be something to that.”

“So... Adora’s brother is going to be an animated skeleton walking around?” Catra said it in a tone that indicated this wasn’t such a

bad thing, but it might require some explanation for some of the guests. Most notably, Angella.

Glimmer tilted her head. “Well, sort of. I can make flesh out of magic for him, and kind of-” She made a motion with both of her hands as if plugging an extension cord into another extension cord. “-hook all the new flesh up together. As long as I can provide a steady current of magic, then he’ll keep chugging along. The moment the magic runs out, my hair goes black, I pass out, and he turns into a pile of bones.”

Catra blinked at her. “You were going to run the risk of Adora’s brother turning into a pile of bones at my wedding?”

Glimmer blinked back. “I am going to do the resurrection as close to the ceremony as possible, hopefully so he’ll be able to be at the reception.”

“But he’s still turning into a pile of bones at some point?”

Glimmer winced. “Yeah. I figure I can have Bow keep track of my hair, and when it starts turning dark, we’ll get Adam out of there, get him to stand in a trash bag, and cut the magic off out of view. We have access to an empty catacomb where we can stash him for the night so we can go back and enjoy the party.”

Catra smiled so big it looked eerie in the moonlight like she found this infinitely amusing. “Glimmer, I love you. Never change, ok?”

Glimmer blushed and staggered back out a little bit. As a distraction, she looked back down at the bones, and the same shiver went down her spine. “Can you bag him up? It freaks me out.”

Catra’s smile turned sly. “Aw, are you squeamish?”

“A little.” Glimmer threw her the trash bag.

Catra caught it without even looking. She knelt down, grabbed a handful, and stuffed it into the bag. “You're the one that’s going

to have to use these later.”

She knew that. It was hard to explain. Dealing with bones in a bag was a hell of a lot easier to conceptualize than taking the bones out of the grave. “He’s your future brother-in-law. It feels like he'll be less angry at you desecrating his resting spot” Glimmer turned away and decided she’d rather keep an eye out for a security guard.

Catra ended up stuffing the last of the bones, the skull with the hair falling off in clumps, in the bag just as a flashlight beamed out across the graveyard, and Glimmer grabbed Catra’s shoulder to pull her out of the hole they dug. The shovels and flashlights were left as Glimmer and Catra sprinted back toward the car.

With one quick teleport past the wall, Glimmer landed them inside the car, facing the right direction, and they both started laughing the way they’d laugh in the old days when they did shit like this.

Glimmer’s chest felt warm. It felt good to laugh. It felt good to hang out with Catra again.

Catra put the bag of bones in the back seat and told Adam to hold on.

Glimmer started the car and drove to her parents' house, where they were going to stay the night because Adora insisted that it was bad luck for them to see each other before the wedding, and she didn’t want to invite any misfortune. Adam would have to stay the night in the trunk, but... it would be worth it.

***

The next night, the night of the wedding...

Glimmer was the only bridesmaid and the maid of honor, and instead of helping she was alone in a room at the Order of the Gray Skull’s headquarters with a bag of bones, a folded suit, a book of spells, and the crushing expectation that she was to produce one of the bride’s brothers for the ceremony.

From the moment Catra proposed (to an Adora who was clearly pretending to be surprised but cried bloody tears regardless), Glimmer started trying to figure out how to bring Adam back so he could give Adora away, like he wanted before everything went bad the last time. She spent a year trying to understand the spell without her dad's help. A year studying in secret, trying to apply her father's lessons, only to find that they didn't fit. General magic and dark magic were too different. A year, and she didn't understand how she had failed the last time. Why did Keldor come out perfect, and Adam came out sickly? Bringing Adam back wrong would be a disaster in more than one way. There was a slight risk of raising a skeleton and only a skeleton (again, not terrible, but would require more suspension of disbelief from the guests), or... worse, raising the body without the soul attached, making a zombie. Glimmer had little panic attacks thinking about what evil she would have wrought summoning a zombie in the middle of a wedding.

The book's version of minor resurrection only worked with full illusions. There had to be some adjustment Keldor made to it in order to raise himself physically but... she couldn't see it. She couldn't figure out the puzzle.

Her heart was pounding. Her breathing was shallow. She was starting to sweat in the armpits of the dress she was supposed to stand next to Catra in. *Fuck. FUCK!*

She pulled out the bag that held the papers with dots of Adora's blood on them. She asked for a dozen in case she messed up a few times. She opened it, and pulled out one square piece of paper with a single dot of dried dark blood.

This was it. This was go time. She was going to try to bring back Adam, and if it messed up, she'd start over. But it sure would be easier if she had help. That thought made her pause.

Her father couldn't help. He wouldn't help.

She could call Keldor... the one person who knew how to do exactly what she was trying to do. Keldor wouldn’t be trustworthy enough. He could get out of illusions too easily. He held no affection for his biological children, so he wouldn't be motivated by family ties. He would try to wrench control of her power and bring himself back as a lich, sucking her power like a leach. She would be the battery that fueled a new terror brought back into the world by her own hands.

No, Keldor was not an option.

She was limited in who she could call with the blood she had, but among that short list, there was someone who could help and who might actually do it. Someone who at least asked permission to use Glimmer’s magic reserve. Someone who could be bargained with.

No pain, no gain. Fortune favors the bold. Glimmer activated the spell and watched the drop of Adora’s blood shrivel and turn to rust-like dust.

From behind her, she heard a low silky voice say, “Hm.... interesting. I must admit, I thought it would take you longer to speak with me.”

Glimmer didn’t look back. She didn’t want to face what she was doing. She wanted this to be over as fast as possible. “I need help.”

“Of course you do.”

The woman smelled like burning leaves as she moved closer. She leaned in, and said in a breathy voice, “I see you have a bag of bones there and a minor resurrection spell open on the table.”

“I don’t want to do it wrong. Everyone is counting on me.” She looked back, meeting the woman’s cracked, disfigured eyes. “I’m willing to make a deal with you to get this done.”

The woman had a silk mask that covered half her face, hiding her non-retractable fangs. Her eyes narrowed. “What is the occasion?” She half sat on the table and opened the bag with fingernails so sharp they were like claws.

“A wedding.”

Shadow Weaver lifted an eyebrow. “This is the vampire hunter boy I killed. I assume then that the wedding is Adora’s?”

Glimmer didn’t respond.

The woman made a sound deep in her throat. “So she and the little laundromat girl are making it official? Going to stop living in sin while she slums it?”

Glimmer’s jaw clenched.

“And Adora is still Horde Lord, or else she’d be dead.” She opened the bag and sighed. “What a shame.” As if talking to herself, she muttered, “I warned her about obsession, and now, it seems, she’s letting it get the better of her. Well, that’s fine. She’ll figure out her mistake eventually.”

Glimmer’s whole body reacted to that. Heat and anger. “Hey, that’s my best friend you're talking about. I brought you here, and I can make you go back!”

There was a smile in the woman's voice. “Don’t be rash. You need me to make the fairy tale ending happen for your dear friends, right?”

Glimmer backed down a little.

Shadow Weaver started to open the bag. “I will help you, but I have demands.” She grabbed Adam’s skull and held it up, looking into it like she was meeting his eyes. A clump of blond hair fell onto the bag. “I will help you with his resurrection.” She turned to Glimmer, still holding the skull as if she was in a play of Hamlet.

“If it works, then you bring me back again, and together we work on making it permanent.”

Glimmer’s throat went dry.

“And once his return to the living is permanent, we make my minor resurrection permanent as well.”

Glimmer felt sick to her stomach.

Shadow Weaver put the skull down on top of the bag, facing Glimmer. “It’s not a terrible deal. One life for a life. I help you get mostly there, and you return the favor. I’ll give you this too. Once I’m alive, I’ll leave. Your friends won’t even have to know it happened. Adora can rest easy thinking her sire is still dead. I go back to studying magic. Re-gathering the massive amount of reagents that Adora burned out of short-sighted anger. And you-” She moved in close. Her hand raised, touching Glimmer’s jaw.

Glimmer didn’t flinch. She always faced her mistakes head-on.

“You get to visit me whenever you want. I’ll take you on as my apprentice. Really, it’s a win-win. You obviously have talent that is in need of development, and no one is giving you what you need, and I need someone on this side of the divide to facilitate my return.” She withdrew her hand, sat back on the table, lounging.

Glimmer was breathing hard and shallow. Looking the woman in the eyes and trying to decide if she could afford to say no. If she could afford to change the agreement. She narrowed her eyes. “You promise never to bother Adora ever again?”

“Of course.” This was said so casually, so easily, that it rang false.

Glimmer chewed the inside of her cheek. She had to make a decision, and she was never one to hesitate. “Alright. I agree to your terms.”

The woman smiled, “Then let's get to work.”

Glimmer's hands shook. There was nothing in the known world that would convince her to bring Shadow Weaver back again. She would use this woman and her selfishness to get what she wanted and break their deal, call it payback for the two hundred years of abuse that she put Adora through, and be done with it. She could be shrewd. She could be conniving.

As Shadow Weaver started to pull out bones and put them in their places on the table, Glimmer resolved to double-cross her.

Half an hour later, Shadow Weaver was gone, dismissed back to whatever hell she had come from, and Glimmer had Adam's living hand, pulling him through the halls of the Order of the Grayskull's Headquarters.

He had so many questions. She couldn't answer them all. She was running late, and she needed to get him to Adora.

"It's a wedding?" He asked, his voice cracking. "She's getting married? To Catra?"

"Yes."

A smile crossed his face, almost wistful. "That's wonderful."

Glimmer stopped him in front of the door where Catra was getting ready. "Before you see Adora, there's one thing you have to do." Still holding onto his hand, she knocked.

Her mother answered in a sing-song voice, "Who's there?"

Glimmer said, "Catra's future brother-in-law."

The door opened almost immediately.

Catra came out dressed in a red jacket, gray pants with a gold stripe, and a white jacket with gold trim on her shoulder. Her hair was up, but still gorgeous and fluffy. Glimmer's breath caught. Her best friend looked like a prince from a fairy tale. Catra had always been one to change up her wardrobe, dressing in outfits to suit

the occasion, but never had she looked this dashing. Her mismatched eyes landed on Adam.

"Oh, good job Glim!" Catra said as she hit Glimmer's shoulder, then she reached out to Adam, grabbing both his shoulders. "I'm sorry this came so late, and I apologize for planning the wedding first, but Adora insisted I ask. Do I have your permission to marry your sister?"

Adam seemed a bit out of breath. A little overwhelmed. "Of course! I wholeheartedly give you my permission."

They hugged.

Angella, sitting on a chair inside the room with a brush in her hand, dabbed tears out of her eyes.

Glimmer started to feel a pain in her chest. She interpreted it as just a feeling, based on the sappy nature of what she was seeing, but as she grabbed Adam's arm, pulling him away to go see Adora, the pain did not go away.

Shadow Weaver told her there was no way to get rid of the risks of dark magic. There were things they could do to mitigate it. Keeping the magic flow low was a great start. Summoning skeletons was a high-flow activity. Dangerous no matter how or when it was done. Keldor had nothing to worry about when he did it last time. A dead body was in no danger of further death, but her? She was living, breathing, and with a heart that could give out. With something like a minor resurrection, as long as she could keep the flow constant and low, there was only a low-level chance of some minor physical damage. Nothing she couldn't heal from. She just needed to take a break from dark magic for a while.

Of course, she didn't tell Glimmer how to do that. Just let her know what needed to be done.

She was dancing with death to give Adora one last chance to talk to her brother.

She found Adora’s room, knocked, and handed him off, distracted by the pain that wasn’t going away.

She stood out in the hall and only heard snippets of the siblings talking in Dutch. She could only see a sliver inside where the door hadn't been shut completely. Adora sounded so incredibly happy. Adam sounded so supportive.

Then, she heard the cat.

Melig perked up and ran over to Adam’s feet and started purring and rubbing up against him.

This whole time, with that cat living in the apartment, while it never outright hated her, it never really warmed up to her the way it was apparently warming up to Adam instantly.

He reached down, picked it up, and said in English, “Is this yours?”

Glimmer swallowed. The pain in her chest was growing. Going down her arm. This whole time, she thought the problem was going to be running out of magic, not having a heart attack.

She gripped her chest.

Adora laughed and told him how they found the cat in a cave, and it's been theirs ever since.

He said the words, “I always wanted a cat.” The irony. He spent most of his life hanging around that particular creature without knowing it.

Glimmer had to stop thinking about irony. Her heart had begun to beat in slow motions, pumping hard but not pumping often. This whole experiment was going to fail because the pain was getting too much.

Without thinking, acting on self-preservation, she reached for the door and opened it.

Adora saw her face, and her smile was gone. “Glimmer, are you ok?”

No. No, she was not. She was probably on the verge of death. “Hey, I hate to cut this short, but I think this is too much for me.”

Adam turned around with the cat, worry on his face. “Ok. Just give me one more minute.” He turned back to Adora, said something quiet in Dutch, and kissed her cheek.

As he turned toward the door, Adora started to cry bloody tears that were quickly wiped away by one of her vampire attendants. At least someone was being careful about getting blood on the dress.

“I am so sorry,” Glimmer said as she started to close the door.

Adora nodded. “Thank you. This is more than enough. More than what I thought I would get.”

Glimmer wanted to feel good about that, but she couldn’t. She closed the door all the way. She grabbed Adam and dragged him out into the hallway, with the cat, to a nook where she could at least work in private. She was already out of breath.

He looked at her. Eyes constricted. “Are you ok? You look sickly.” He said this while his hands scratched at the cat in the same unconscious way Adora always did as if there was something instinctual about their connection to this animal.

Melig leaned into the touch, purring harder and louder. Blissed out. Too bad kitty. You’re going to lose this twin in a minute.

Glimmer took a breath. “I don’t think I can keep this up. Something is wrong.” The thing she couldn’t say, Shadow Weaver hadn’t told her something. Had held some information back so that she would be forced to bring the old bat back to find out what had gone wrong.

His back got straight. His jaw set. “I understand. I’m... I’m ready if I need to go, and if this is all I get, I appreciate it, Glimmer.”

He was so brave. In that same selfless way Adora had always been brave, and Glimmer hated it because she understood the trauma behind that response. The way the twins had been taught that their own comfort didn’t matter, that they were at war, and the war came first no matter what. Everyone elses happiness and safety came first.

Tears clouded Glimmer’s vision. She wanted to give them this. This one wedding. This one normal thing in a sea of fucked up lives. And the fact that she couldn't was on her. The magic was too different. Keeping the flow, even if it was small, was unlike anything she had ever had to do before. She should have practiced. She should have tried this a month ago. Through a constricting throat, she said, “I’m going to have to try this again. If we hurry, I can maybe get you back before the wedding without threatening my life. OK?” and damn it, she’d fall right into Shadow Weaver’s trap of calling her back to find out what went wrong. She’d refuse to give Glimmer anything until Glimmer gave her some semblance of a life back. *Fuck.*

He gave her a soft smile. It was Adora’s soft smile. That gentle and understanding look that meant everything was fine. “It’s ok. I got to see my sister happy. I get to know that she’s marrying the love of her life. That’s enough for me. This was more than I could have ever hoped for.”

Glimmer could have cried. She forced herself not to. She closed her eyes, and, heaving, she cut the magic.

The pain stopped. She breathed in relief from the sense of doom flooding her. Her body felt whole. She expected to hear the sound of bones clattering to the ground inside a suit, but when she opened her eyes...

Adam was still standing there, holding the cat. Eyes closed and braced for whatever happened.

Glimmer blinked and blinked again, sure that she was seeing things. He was still there.

She reached for him, to feel him, to prove to herself he was still there. She grabbed his suit. His arms. "But how-" Her eyes fell on the cat.

It looked back at her with heterochromatic eyes that it mimicked from Catra. It gave her what could have only been described as a cat-like smile and slow blinked at her.

Adam cautiously opened one eye. "Everything ok?"

Glimmer held his arms and stared at the cat. Her brain raced to figure out what had happened. Then, she remembered Keldor's whole goal of connecting himself with the sword. That sword whose power actually came from the goddess that was a cat in Adam's arms. She let go of him and stood back. "Yeah. I think... I think you're good. I think-" The cat made a grumbling sound. The rules about Adora knowing anything about what it was, she guessed, extended to the brother. "I think we stabilized it."

The cat purred and stretched and rubbed against Adam.

Glimmer remembered her father talking about her mother.

"...she's still a goddess, and, I guess if a goddess wants to be pregnant, she can be pregnant."

The cat was still a goddess, and, she guessed if a goddess wanted to resurrect one of her favorite humans, she could do that.

She swallowed, wondering if this was ok. Wondering if there were going to be consequences. No time to think about that now. She looked into Adam's eyes and told him, "I actually don't know how long you're going to be here. It might be a while." There were logistics. Bow would have to get another seat on the plane for their trip to the Netherlands. Adam would get to see his family home. When Catra and Adora went to live in the cave for a while, Adam could have their room. Her brain reeled with the sudden

possibility of him having to start a life over again. They'd have to get Scorpia's gang to get him an identity. He'd need a job. Juliet might be interested in the other half of the vampire-hunting twins, but there was very little actual hunting happening these days. Maybe he wouldn't want to be a hunter anyway. There was a soft comfortable life in being something mundane.

Adam was ignorant of all of that. He was just a guy who was going to get to see his sister get married, and now he had a cat that loved him very, very much.

Glimmer walked him back to Adora, told her everything was fine, and walked back, in a daze, to Catra's room to help her get the rest of the way ready. To be her maid of honor.

No one had to know what she had done. No one had to know who she had to bring back to get Adam back. She was going to get out of this reputation intact. Unscathed. No heart attack.

And there she was, not an hour later, standing next to Catra while they waited for the music to start. The doors to the hall opened, and in walked Adora, beautiful, glowing. Her brother just as beautiful, with a suit that matched Adora's white with gold trim colors. Just as glowing. Followed by the cat, unbeknownst to anyone, keeping the brother of the bride from turning into a pile of bones on the walkway.

Micah turned around with everyone else from the front row, then turned around suddenly and looked at her with an expression that meant they were going to have a conversation about this later. That she was in trouble as much as an adult child could be in trouble. Glimmer gave him a sheepish smile that communicated that it was better to ask forgiveness than permission.

Light Hope stood at the front, an emotionless mask and robes hiding thousands of spiders. Gloved hands holding what Glimmer had been told was the ancient tomb of rights for vampire ceremonies.

It was a whole thing. Adora was leading the Horde back to their roots. Back to the ancient code of conduct that Mara had ascribed to. Back to the code that Light Hope had become a vampire under. That the condition was not a curse but a gift to be used to better society. Light Hope had been turned by her community, on purpose, to be the ever-living memory of their culture. She was a priestess, and she served her people, and they gave their blood willingly. Mara had been turned by her community to protect them. There was a purpose to this magic, and Adora was dead set on giving the Horde a purpose. They would be protectors and historians, artists and inventors. Hordak was particularly pleased with that last one. He sat up front with his human... lab partner and looked proud to be a part of it. Adora was telling everyone that they would seek to use their long life and their powers for good.

The whole ceremony, while on the surface more like a modern marriage ceremony, was sprinkled with hints as to this new direction that the Horde Lord was leading them toward. Traditional vampire values. With great power comes great responsibility, yada yada yada. By having Light Hope be the officiant with that book, she was telling the vampire half of the room that Prime's directives were out the window.

For everyone else the wedding on the invitation was described as vampire-themed. This was the only explanation necessary to make people not question why half the room was dressed in outdated clothes and some of them had pointed ears and fangs. Eclectic vampire-themed weddings were not odd enough to even raise comment from the handful of people in the room who didn't know.

Catra's side was full of vampire hunters who had worked closely with her as the second in command. People who respected her. Netossa sat in the second row with her wife and their daughter.

Adora's side was filled with every vampire that could manage to come to observe their Horde Lord's marriage. The clan leads sat

up front, stoic and supportive. Madam Razz sat in the front row, eyes magnified and smiling like a fool.

As Adora approached the stairs, Catra bowed and offered her hand.

Adora took a deep breath as she took her lover's hand and let go of her brothers.

Adam looked like he was going to cry. The cat pushed at him to make him take his seat on the front row of Adora's side. Did he know that a hundred vampires, who all had a reason to hate him, were behind him and staring at him like they were seeing a literal miracle? Glimmer felt a little vindicated. They weren't far off. Being a demigoddess gave her the right to do a minor miracle every once in a while.

Juliet, on Catra's side, raised an eyebrow directly at Glimmer. Disapproving. Disappointed.

Glimmer sighed and added a plus one to her list of expected getting yelled at sessions. Didn't matter. It was worth it.

She focused her attention back on her best. She met Bow's eyes from across the stage, and he looked so proud. He looked so happy. She felt a swelling of love for him in her heart that was still beating. That made everything better.

Light Hope started the ceremony by reading from the book. Something about eternity. Something about how love extends beyond death. A lot was said. Glimmer tuned it out. She was watching the back of Catra's head, her shoulders, and how straight they were. How proud Catra was of her future wife. And Adora, the look on her face of pure bliss. Focus on that. Focus on how happy the couple is. They're the real story here.

Light Hope turned to them to say their vows.

Adora took a deep breath. They had been practicing in secret to memorize their vows. No pieces of paper. "I pledge to love you for

all eternity, as the moon loves the night and the shadows embrace the darkness." She took a breath. A little overcome. "With this immortal bond, I promise to stand by your side through the ages, as we navigate the centuries together."

Glimmer furrowed her brow. Maybe Adora was taking the vampire theme a bit too far with the vows. This was going to be hard to explain to Angella why the vows were so different. Glimmer was planning the argument she would have to make to her mother about why symbolic vows were valid.

Juliet shifted in her seat.

Catra took a deep breath, her shoulders lifting and lowering before she started, "I vow to be your eternal companion, your confidant in the darkest hours and your partner in the dance of everlasting night. With each beat of our immortal hearts, I will cherish and protect you, my beloved, as we share the gift of forever."

Adora's chest raised and lowered as if she was suddenly overwhelmed. Suddenly anxious. She had worked hard to keep control of her anxiety, but this moment was a little too much.

Glimmer braced herself for the door to burst open with rats or bats or for bugs to start appearing out of the shadows and crevices of the room. She had planned a spell for this, just in case. A minor illusion that would, at least, keep people from seeing the swarms until Adora could get ahold of herself.

But Adora had been practicing keeping her powers controlled by calming herself. She closed her eyes and breathed deeply.

Glimmer relaxed as Adora relaxed.

When Adora opened her eyes, they were red. She turned those intense red eyes on Catra. "I offer you my blood, my life, and my undying love." Adora was focused. Intentful. She bit her lip.

To everyone else, it would have looked like a shy lip bite of a woman about to kiss the love of her life. It would have been hard for anyone else to see it other than Catra and Glimmer, but with her fangs, Glimmer saw Adora cut her lip. Blood started pooling on her already red lips.

Catra went focused. Went still.

Glimmer went focused. Went still. Something had happened, but Glimmer wasn't sure what.

Light Hope said, in a voice almost too robotic, "You may now kiss the bride."

Glimmer's heart pounded in her chest as she realized what was happening... what had to be happening. This was the reason that Adora wanted to live in the cave for a few months because there would be a new vampire learning the ropes. Panic shot through her. She glanced at the front row. Adam, happy but a little confused. Her father's face froze in a kind of horror, but he wasn't trying to stop it. Her mother cried for joy because she didn't understand.

Juliet's eyes went wide. Her face pale. She opened her mouth to say something. She started to get up. She knew what was happening. She wouldn't be the leader of an organization of vampire hunters if she didn't, and this... this was against the rules for damn sure. If they had just told Glimmer what was going to happen, she could have planned better. Instead, she acted out of instinct. She only knew one spell that would be fast and effective. Glimmer summoned skeletons at Juliet's feet. They grabbed her, pulling her back and binding her to the chair. A skeleton hand went over her boss's mouth to keep her quiet. The horror of it barely registered, it happened so fast. Glimmer realized, only a half second after it happened, that she summoned skeletons to hold her boss back. Skeletons, which was very against the rules. There would be another yelling session about that.

Pain shot through her arm, and she grunted softly to herself as it hit, but she stayed focused. Stayed standing.

Her dad saw those skeletons and looked at her like if the skeletons didn’t kill her, he would. She was probably grounded from magic for like... twelve lifetimes. Didn’t matter. *Worth it.*

While the assembly watched, with Juliet arrested, Catra leaned in, closed her eyes, kissed her wife, and changed everything forever.

End Notes

Thank you all for sticking with this! Sorry it took me so long to get this chapter out. Wedding chapters are actually a lot harder to write than I thought it would be. And I feel weird posting the last chapter of this fic. I'm going to miss it. I have another part planned in the series, but I will need a break. I've got another project in the works that I need to get out of my system before I return to this (the muse is calling and demands to be fed). However, if you're interested in the next part when it comes out, please follow the series. Thank you again for reading! It's been a wild ride, and I've enjoyed having you all along for the fun. <3

Please drop by the archive and comment to let the author know if you enjoyed their work!